

AN ADULT EPIC FANTASY NOVEL

THE WAR OF THE BURIED SKY



E. R. VEYLAN

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Part I

Chapter 1 — Stone Sang Under the Wall

Ashwall spoke through Kharza Olt's right tusk before dawn.

She stood on the southern parapet with one palm against the frost-cold merlon, listening past the scrape of sentries' boots and the coughs beyond the gate. Ordinary fort-stone carried a single burden downward. This basalt carried two. One pitch sank through the foundations toward the old lava beds. A second, finer note climbed against it from below, close enough to make the mineral veins in both her tusks ache.

"Again," she told the hammerer.

The Mahr sapper struck the merlon with his padded mallet. A blunt note traveled west along the wall. Beneath it ran that upward pitch, too clean to come from a cracked footing.

Kharza moved three paces and marked the stone with kiln chalk. Nine marks already followed her along the parapet. Each lay closer to the next than the last.

Captain Deren watched from under a bearskin hood. He commanded Ashwall for the Tern Crown and had spent the inspection explaining his own fortress to her. "Frost makes basalt complain."

"Frost pulls at the face. This rises through the bed."

"Nothing lies under the bed but mountain."

Something shifted below them. The sensation barely reached her boots, yet her tusks gathered it and gave it back as a pressure behind her eyes. Soldiers along the parapet glanced toward the stair. Human ears had caught nothing. Mahr ears scarcely mattered here. Stone-song entered through bone.

Outside the south gate, a child began crying for water.

The line had formed in darkness: three hundred and twelve people from the ash terraces, according to the tally Kharza had taken herself. Most carried stamped ration tiles issued at villages the Crown had already abandoned. Ashwall's clerks had admitted fifty-six before closing the gate. The rest waited between the outer ditch and a row of black stakes while the eastern horizon turned iron-gray.

Deren followed her gaze. "Their villages have orders to hold."

"Their villages have roofs splitting upward."

"They have stories."

"They have burns on the soles of their feet." Kharza looked down into the yard. Twenty Crown infantry stood beside the ration shed. A dozen Kiln House auxiliaries waited near the north sally port, their ceramic lamellar dull with soot. Her niece Lessa knelt among the admitted refugees, cutting a boot from a swollen ankle.

Steam rose from the leather though no fire burned nearby. "Open the south gate."

Deren's face settled into the patient refusal of a man who possessed written authority. "Ashwall holds stores for six days under siege. The Queen-Regent's instruction permits laborers essential to the defense."

"Then admit everyone who can carry water."

"You know what the instruction means."

Kharza knew. Eleven years earlier she had taught Crown officers how to make an instruction survive shame: replace a village with a category, a hungry person with a capacity, an eviction with a movement of stores. During the War of Three Valleys she had closed two roads to keep a royal column fed. The fighting ended sooner. The families caught beyond those roadblocks had not entered the songs sung at Osra's victory court.

Another pulse entered her tusks. This one carried heat.

She knelt and pressed both hands to the parapet. Far below Ashwall, weight moved across a surface that should not have permitted movement. Two tones pulled against each other. In the lower pitch she recognized the long, branching cadence Mahr fault-readers called antlering: stress dividing around a vast obstruction. The finer pitch climbed through every division without weakening.

Deep Hart.

The buried constellation appeared in old kiln maps as seven white stars set across a horned back. Priests gave it festivals. Terrace keepers watched for its rain pressure. Nobody with sense claimed it spoke. Yet its celestial weight could press through leagues of stone, and ninety-six years without a Great Turning had brought that pressure close enough to bend mines and boil springs.

Kharza rose. "Clear the wall."

Deren's patience vanished. "On whose reading?"

"Mine."

"You lost command in the west because your readings served your politics."

A fair blow needed no answer. After Ashwall's first fractures, Kharza had sent three reports naming fixed-sky pressure. Osra's surveyors revised them into maintenance requests. Kharza then refused a new levy from Olt and surrendered her commission before the Crown could take it. Deren called that politics. Her hearth council called it eleven years late.

She pointed to the chalk marks. "Each interval has narrowed by a hand. When it reaches the stair tower, this face will unload."

"Outward?"

"Up."

The word unsettled him at last.

Below, Lessa shouted. The water in the horse trough had begun to jump in tiny

clear beads. Each bead rose a finger's width, hung, and fell. Horses screamed against their tethers.

Kharza took the parapet steps three at a time. "Hadrin, pull the auxiliaries from the north port. Break the inner ration locks. Lessa, everyone who can walk goes through the kiln cut."

Deren came behind her. "Countermand that."

She crossed the yard without slowing. "You command the fort. I command Olt lives."

"Those stores belong to the Crown."

"Then your clerks may count them while carrying sacks."

At the south gate, guards lowered spear shafts when Kharza approached. Their sergeant wore Vael blue at his collar and fear around his mouth. Beyond him, refugees pressed close to the bars but did not shout. Varkesh people knew how noise could hide a fault's warning.

"Lift it," Kharza said.

"Captain's seal keeps it shut."

She drew her field axe, hooked its back spike through the waxed cord, and pulled. The clay seal snapped from the locking bar. Not a royal seal, merely Deren's, but every soldier in the yard understood the choice.

"Charge me after sunrise," she said. "Lift it now."

The sergeant looked past her. Deren had stopped halfway across the yard. A deep shudder ran through the gatehouse, spraying grit from its joints. He gave one tight nod.

Chains rattled. The gate climbed.

Cold air entered with the smell of sulfur, unwashed wool, and fear. Kharza stepped onto the threshold before the crowd could surge.

"Kiln cut, north side," she called. "No carts. Take water, blankets, children, and anyone who cannot keep pace. Leave iron cookware. It will pull heat. House groups stay together until the split cedar, then follow the white stones downhill."

An old woman raised a cage holding six ember hens. "They're all I have."

"Give the cage to a strong back. It goes."

Rules had to bend where people could see the reason. Otherwise they became another officer's appetite.

Hadrin's auxiliaries formed two lanes. Crown soldiers opened the shed and passed out water skins. Pell Vask, had she been present, would have cursed their distribution: large skins to strong hands, none reserved for medics, no count of children. Kharza corrected what she could while the upward note sharpened.

Lessa caught her arm near the trough. At twenty-two, she had her mother's square jaw and none of Kharza's caution around rank. "The burns aren't fire burns."

Skin's red under the heel, pale at the edges. Pressure injury, maybe."

"How many cannot walk?"

"Eleven. Two litters. We need four more."

"Use shutters from the east barracks."

"That leaves the windows open."

"We're not staying for the weather."

A crack sounded from the wall. Soldiers ducked. Nothing fell. Instead, one basalt block rose half a thumb from its mortar bed.

Deren saw it. "Empty the fort," he ordered.

The yard changed at once. Crown discipline, useless while awaiting permission, found purpose in departure. Stable hands cut traces rather than trying to calm the horses. Clerks carried grain sacks out of the storehouse. Two cooks rolled the copper stockpot toward the gate until Kharza stopped them and sent them for salt packets. Above, sentries abandoned the parapet.

No signal flags went up. The eastern watchtower had leaned enough to jam its pulley.

Kharza climbed onto the ration platform. From there she could see over the ditch to the slope beyond. The refugees entered in a steady file, but their carts blocked the road behind them. A family argued over a wagon loaded with glazed roof tiles. Three goats had tangled their leads around a wheel. Every delay had a name and a face. Every commander's map erased both.

"Cut the goats loose," she called. "Tiles stay. Put food on the gray mule and turn it north."

A man beside the wagon stared at her. "Those tiles are my winter."

"The people who know how to fire them are your next winter. Move."

He looked once at his wife, then began throwing sacks from beneath the tiles.

The fine pitch reached the stair tower.

Kharza felt the contact as a hard tap at the root of her right tusk. "Off the south road!" she shouted. "Against the ditch face. Now!"

People moved because her voice carried old command. That frightened her more than disobedience might have. Hadrún drove the last file sideways. Lessa and four soldiers lifted the litter shutters. Deren ran toward the gatehouse to help the sergeant release the chain.

Ashwall folded.

No tower toppled. The southern curtain rose in three immense sections, each block holding to its neighbors as the buried pressure bent the fortress upward. The parapet became a black ridge against dawn. Foundations tore free with a noise deeper than hearing. Air struck the yard, hot and loaded with powdered mortar.

Kharza hit the ground beside the platform. The deck pitched under her. Grain jars burst. A beam swept over her back close enough to tug her cloak, then smashed into the trough. Water flew upward in a shining sheet and stayed there for one impossible breath.

Through the opened earth below the wall, seven points of white light shone.

They did not resemble fire. Fire consumed edges and threw shadows. These points gave the surrounding stone a depth without illuminating its surface, as if leagues of buried darkness had narrowed into seven distant wounds. The Deep Hart's antler line pressed behind them. Kharza's tusks rang until her teeth hurt.

The suspended water fell hot.

Someone screamed under the gatehouse.

Kharza crawled toward the sound. Dust turned the yard red-gray. One half of the gate arch had lifted; its other half remained planted, twisting the raised gate into a slanted grate. Deren lay beneath a fallen chain drum. The sergeant crouched beside him, pulling at a timber pinned across his thighs.

"Leave me," Deren said.

Kharza wedged her axe under the timber. "You can issue that instruction after we lift."

The sergeant took the other end. Two Olt soldiers joined them. Stone-song flooded Kharza's skull, making balance uncertain, but the load path through the timber stayed simple. She shifted the axe head a hand left.

"Here. On three."

They raised it enough for Deren to drag himself free. Both legs bent where legs should not. Lessa appeared through the dust, assessed him once, and tied splints while he bit his hood.

Beyond the wrecked arch, the last refugees crouched against the ditch face. The upward-curved wall had shielded them from most of the blast. One child bled from the scalp. A Kiln auxiliary lay facedown beside the goat cart. Hadrun turned the body and shook his head.

The eastern tower began to climb.

Kharza listened. The two pitches no longer met under the south wall. Their crossing had shifted north beneath the armory, where forty oil jars sat in racks.

"Leave the grain," she ordered. "Oil next. Roll it clear or break the jars into the ditch. We have perhaps sixty breaths."

Nobody asked how she knew. Soldiers hauled Deren onto a shutter. Refugees who had been denied food moments earlier returned through the gate to help move Crown oil. The tile maker shouldered a jar beside the old woman with the ember hens. Lessa led the injured down the cut.

Kharza entered the armory last. Shelves leaned toward the ceiling. Each clay jar

weighed enough to slow two people. She cut the rack ropes, rolling three into the central aisle, then stopped.

A piece of wall stone protruded from the floor.

It had not fallen there. Smooth basalt had punched upward through the flagging, carrying old mortar on its lower face. Across that mortar ran a pale seven-branched stain, fine as a kiln glaze and cold despite the heat.

Proof could be carried. She wrapped the stone in her cloak, tucked it under one arm, and rolled the last jar with the other.

They cleared the north gate as the armory rose. Oil jars shattered in the ditch rather than among the evacuees. A dark sheet spread across the earth, harmless until the eastern tower split and sparks fell. Flame raced along the ditch behind them.

From the lower switchback, Ashwall looked less destroyed than transformed. Three wall sections curved upward like the rim of a colossal buried bowl. White points faded in the torn foundations as sunrise reached the peaks. The fort had not repelled an army. It had become evidence against the sky the Crown insisted on keeping fixed.

Kharza counted at the split cedar.

Three hundred and sixty-eight refugees. Eighty-one soldiers and workers. Six dead recovered, including Hadrún's auxiliary. Four missing. Deren lived, though Lessa said he might never walk without braces. The stores saved would feed everyone for two days if divided honestly. Ashwall could not be held by any number of troops.

The count did not answer where they would sleep. Morning had exposed the whole lower slope: a shelf of clinker, three goat paths, and no water except what they had carried. Varkesh stood half a day north for an unburdened rider, longer for litters. If the injured remained until carts came, heat might rise through the cut again. If the column moved at once, Deren could bleed out from the shaking.

Kharza divided the problem where everyone could hear. "Twenty soldiers take the fit walkers north. No forced pace. Two people remain with every child separated from a house group. The terrace elders hold their own ration tiles and count distribution beside a Crown clerk."

The ration sergeant frowned. "They can alter the tally."

"So can you. You will watch one another."

She assigned the tile maker to lead a work party downslope. An abandoned charcoal platform stood beyond the white stones, sheltered by an overhang and close to a cold seep Lessa remembered from childhood. Shutters became litter beds. Spear cloaks became shade. The ember hens supplied no eggs that morning, but their owner knew which scrub leaves could be boiled against nausea. Kharza put her beside Lessa rather than treating local knowledge as a thing command

could requisition without respect.

Deren called Kharza over while soldiers lashed a brace around his hips. Sweat had soaked his hair despite the cold. "My report names your destruction of a command seal."

"It should."

"I could name the lives preserved."

"You should do that too."

His mouth tightened. "You always did make confession sound like an inventory."

Eleven years earlier he had served as a standard bearer in her valley army. She remembered a narrow young officer carrying Osra's sunburst through a village whose wells Kharza had ordered guarded for troops. Perhaps he remembered the children driven away from them. Neither memory improved the present.

"An inventory admits what remains unpaid," she said. "A confession can stop at the speaker's relief."

Deren looked toward the curved ruin. "Would you have opened the gate if the wall had stayed standing?"

"Yes."

That answer cost her any shelter his report might have offered. It also left the morning clean enough to build upon.

Before leaving him, she pressed the cold-stained wall fragment into a grain sack and sealed it with three witnesses' clay marks: Deren's sergeant, the terrace elder, and Lessa. A court might discount Kharza's reading. It would have greater difficulty dismissing stone whose broken face still carried the Deep Hart's branching pressure glaze. She ordered two riders by separate roads to warn the terrace villages away from masonry foundations.

A rider came up the cut on a lathered horse while they were tying the dead into cloaks. Vael blue showed beneath road ash. He carried a message tube stamped with the crown sunburst.

Deren lay under blankets near the cedar. "For me?"

The rider looked at Kharza. "For every Crown commander west of the river."

"I resigned that honor."

"Then hear it as a citizen." His voice cracked from cold or haste. "King Ordan died before dawn. The designated heir holds Crown Gate. Queen-Regent Osra has called every royal garrison to bearing obedience."

Around them, the displaced people of the terraces stood with ration sacks taken from a fallen royal fort. No one cheered a king's death. No one knelt for the next command.

Kharza set the wrapped stone on the ground and opened the cloak enough to show the pale antler stain. The rider stared at it. Deren closed his eyes.

“Take that to Varkesh’s hearth council,” Kharza said. “Tell them Ashwall is gone. Tell them why.”

“You should carry it.”

Behind her, the ruin gave one final two-pitched note. The higher tone traveled north beneath the mountains, toward roads, orchards, and the hinge city where a dead king’s successors had begun to divide the sky between them.

Kharza lifted the proof. “I will.”

Chapter 2 — The Orchard Without Stars

The first star-bee struck Sevrin's veil and fell into the pollination bowl.

He caught it before its wings touched the blue paste. The worker gripped his fingertip through the mesh, abdomen pumping, six legs bright with the silver dust of the upper sky. No deformity showed in the wing joints. Its breathing spiracles remained clear. Yet when he lowered it toward the bowl, it twisted hard enough to sting the leather between his fingers.

Across the Rootglass terraces, twelve hundred bees refused with it.

Their flight should have drawn shining loops from hive doors to the leafing frames. Instead, the insects battered themselves against the cedar lattice, recoiled from every dish of upper-sky pollen, and crowded into the dark seams of their boxes. Morning light poured through the translucent soil beneath Sevrin's boots. The orchard trees stood bare above it, their glass-pale roots visible in layers as deep as a house.

"Close the frames," he called.

Workers moved along the terrace. Aeli gardeners lowered shade cloths. Human graft tenders capped the bowls. Two Vennik carpenters turned the hive doors inward by half a finger to keep the panicked workers from spilling onto the path. Nobody waited for a keeper's ceremonial signal. Bees suffocating in ritual order remained dead.

Sevrin carried the fallen worker to a field table. The photosensitive filaments along his temples lifted toward the sun, each thin as new grass and warm where light entered them. Through those filaments, upper constellations usually left a faint geometry across his sight. Cinder Net hung west of noon in its fixed position. Rootglass orcharders had built ninety-six years of leafing schedules around that stubborn certainty.

The worker wanted nothing from it.

Meya, a human graft tender, brought three more bees in a cork cup. "East boxes too."

"Queen line?"

"Second and fifth daughters. The old line hasn't opened."

"Temperature?"

"Within one mark. Humidity two marks low, so we wetted the reed screens."

Sevrin examined the bees. Their feet carried pollen from three separate dishes, all upper-sky strains. Each insect scraped frantically at its own legs as if the silver dust burned.

"Wash them with orchard water," he said. "No oil. Put them in an empty nursery box and keep it dark."

A young Aeli worker beside Meya flinched. "Empty? My daughter's leafing begins today."

"So does mine," Meya said. She touched the green filaments emerging behind one ear. She had paid two months' wages for a place in the scheduled pollination, a rare grant for a human worker. Rootglass's council had only begun admitting non-Aeli leafing research volunteers after Sevrin argued that the orchard's collapse would not honor ancestry when it spread.

Sevrin met the younger worker's eyes. "No person enters the frames until the bees feed willingly."

"What if they don't?"

"Then I will not spend your child to preserve a calendar."

The answer angered her. It also kept her from entering the lattice.

A bell sounded below the terrace, not the clear three-stroke pollination call but a dull iron warning. Irel Saan came up the root stairs with four senior gardeners. At one hundred and twelve she moved without hurry, her white leaf-filaments braided flat under a green work scarf. She had opposed Sevrin's appointment, his coastal methods, his inclusion trials, and nearly every intervention that later kept the lower orchard alive. She had also rebuilt half these terraces after the glass blight. Disagreement did not reduce expertise.

Irel looked at the shuttered frames. "How many refusals?"

"All open colonies."

"Disease?"

"No visible lesions. They reject the pollen itself."

"Upper pollen."

Sevrin heard the accusation before she gave it shape. "That is what the bowls contain."

"Because you forbade the old lower blend."

"The lower blend carries spores from dead comb."

"It carries what their mothers recognized."

One gardener placed a sealed clay tube on the table. A customs mark from the western road crossed its wax. Irel broke it and unrolled a strip of kiln paper. The message contained few words. Ashwall had risen through its foundations before dawn. Refugees survived. A wall fragment showed the Deep Hart's pressure stain. King Ordan had died.

Around the table, workers fell silent in uneven waves as the news passed from mouth to mouth.

Irel tapped the message. "Outer-hinge agitation."

"Pressure can rise without anyone touching a hinge."

"Kharza Olt touched Ashwall."

"She inspected it."

"You know her?"

"Only her reports." Sevrin had read every suppressed survey from Varkesh and told the council he had read three. "If the stone rose before she broke the gate, her hands did not cause the rising."

Irel's gaze settled on him. "You defend quickly for a stranger."

"The sequence defends her."

Below them, bees struck cedar in bursts. The sound resembled dry seeds thrown against a door.

Sevrin opened one hive through its rear service panel. Warm resin air reached him. Workers clustered in the comb's inner alleys, leaving the honey rims untended. A few had packed their leg baskets with dark pollen, nearly black, though no dark blend had entered Rootglass in twenty years.

He scraped one grain onto a lens stone.

Light from above passed through it without silvering. A buried constellation had marked the grain from below.

Irel saw his face change. "What?"

"Bring the queen-hive record."

Her hand closed over the service panel. "Answer me first."

He offered her the lens. She bent over it, then turned the stone toward the glowing roots. In light rising through Rootglass, the grain opened into seven tiny branches.

Deep Hart again.

Not the constellation's full pressure, merely a trace carried through soil, flower, and bee. Rootglass flowers had begun answering a sky no worker could see from the surface.

Irel closed the panel. "Outer agitation has crossed the root bed."

"Or accumulated pressure has."

"You keep making a grammatical difference into a political one."

"Causality deserves grammar."

She almost smiled. Three years ago she would have. Since then, Neris shipments had grown while inland comb yields fell, and every council meeting had taught both of them how evidence could become a weapon before it became a remedy.

A runner arrived from the queen terrace. "Senior Gardener, the old box opened. Workers came out without the queen."

Irel moved before Sevrin did.

They descended beneath the pollination frames, through passages made green by light filtered across Rootglass soil. The queen-hive occupied a stone chamber whose walls held stable temperature across all seasons. Its cedar box stood on a low platform surrounded by water channels and copper ant guards. Workers poured from the entrance, not flying, only walking in a thick stream toward the darkest wall.

Sevrin knelt outside their path. The insects carried no upper pollen. Their bodies shone with a dim blue dust drawn from stored comb.

A hive keeper lifted the rear pane. "Queen alive. Feeding attendants present. She won't cross the brood band."

Inside, the queen moved across old comb with her long abdomen curled away from the newly prepared cells. The cells had been brushed with silver pollen according to schedule. At their border she stopped as if facing flame.

"Remove the new comb," Sevrin said.

Irel blocked the keeper's hand. "If we disturb the queen now, we may lose the line."

"If we leave the irritant, she may stop laying."

"Or she may accept it after shade."

Meya entered behind them carrying the cork cup. "The washed workers settled. They're feeding."

"With what?"

"Nothing yet. They stopped scraping once the silver came off."

That decided the matter for Sevrin. He reached for the brood frame.

Irel caught his wrist. "Your authority covers scheduled leafing, not queen custody."

"Then use yours."

Her fingers tightened. For a moment he thought preservation and rank would become the same command. Then she released him, took the frame tool herself, and cut the silvered comb from its pegs.

The queen uncurled before the frame cleared the box.

Relief moved through the chamber, restrained but unmistakable. A hive keeper covered her face with both hands. Meya sat on the edge of a channel. Sevrin watched attendants feed the queen from old stores and felt no triumph. Rootglass possessed enough unsilvered comb for perhaps twelve days. After that, every viable colony would face the same refusal.

Irel set the removed frame in a waxed tray. "No one leaves with comb."

"We need an outside comparison."

"We need a living queen."

"I did not ask for her."

"You have asked for pieces of this orchard until I no longer know which piece you mean to save."

The charge reached deeper because he had earned part of it.

Three years earlier, Sevrin had compiled loss figures from Rootglass, Salt Aeli apiaries, and Neris harbor gardens. Neris colonies had gained nineteen measures of silver pollen yield while Rootglass lost twenty-seven and marsh-route hives failed outright. He published the regional decline but removed the enclave columns. Guild unity, he had told himself. Time to verify methods. Protection against Heartland officials eager to close inland grants.

His edited table had allowed Irel to argue that all Aeli shared one manageable decline. It had allowed Neris merchants to continue selling fixed-sky honey as evidence of stability.

Sevrin stood. "Come to the record room."

Irel studied him, then told the keepers to seal the chamber and double the water guards. "Meya, no one enters or removes the queen-hive without my spoken leave. Not council script. Mine."

They climbed alone.

The record room occupied a low house grown between two orchard trunks. Its shelves held bark ledgers, glass slates, and wax rubbings from dead comb. Sevrin unlocked his coastal chest. He took out the complete Neris tables and laid them under the window.

Irel read in silence.

Her leaf-filaments remained braided, but the unbound tips angled toward the columns as if they could gather truth from ink. When she reached Sevrin's published totals, she placed one page beside another.

"You removed nineteen measures of gain."

"Yes."

"Rootglass funded that survey."

"Yes."

"You let me say the loss fell evenly."

"I let everyone say it."

"That enlarges the cowardice. It does not distribute it."

He accepted the blow without answer.

Outside, horses entered the upper court. Tack bells carried the clipped rhythm of royal couriers rather than orchard wagons. Irel rolled the complete tables and put them inside her coat.

"Those are mine," Sevrin said.

“The figures belong to every worker whose failed comb paid for them.”

He could not dispute that without repeating his crime.

Osra’s envoy waited beneath the grafting arch with six mounted guards and a clerk. Lady Ven Ardel wore travel dust over Heartland red. Her courtesy extended first to Irel, whose office controlled the hives, then to Sevrin, whose title impressed cities.

“King Ordan’s death grieves the Queen-Regent,” Ven Ardel said. “Until succession settles, she offers royal protection to Rootglass. Twenty riders for the western road, grain guarantees, and sealed recognition of the orchard council’s custody.”

Meya and the other workers had gathered beyond the arch. They heard every offered benefit.

Irel asked, “In exchange?”

“Neutrality. No pollinators, pollen records, or orchard personnel supplied to armed hinge claimants. Rootglass closes its western gate to Kharza Olt and any force acting through her.”

“You crossed a failed orchard to offer us protection from an orc in Varkesh,” Sevrin said. “What protects us from the failure?”

Ven Ardel’s clerk opened a folio. “Royal surveys find no systemic threat to the upper season. Ashwall suffered deferred foundation repair.”

“Your surveyors reached it after dawn?”

“The Crown has prior records.”

Irel’s eyes shifted toward Sevrin. Prior records. The phrase covered edits made by men in offices and by starwardens in record rooms.

Ven Ardel continued. “Agitation at any outer sky hinge could endanger this orchard. Her Grace intends to secure the Crown Hinge and prevent unauthorized movement. Rootglass has more reason than most to value restraint.”

That reason held weight. A full Great Turning performed after ninety-six years of pressure could tear migration paths apart. Sevrin had argued against reckless motion himself. Osra offered armed protection for a policy Irel already favored, and she did so while royal roads still functioned.

“What grain?” Meya called from the workers.

The envoy looked displeased at the interruption, but answered. “Heartland rye and white barley.”

“Enough for paid hands or council households?”

“Distribution would remain an orchard matter.”

Rootglass’s internal divisions entered the offer exactly where Osra needed them. Council families could preserve hive stores and assign grain downward. Laborers might gain food or merely another promise accounted above their heads.

Sevrin said, "Name the term if the queen refuses upper pollen."

Ven Ardel did not blink. "The queen-hive remains under orchard custody."

"That names possession, not remedy."

"My authority concerns political security."

"Bees have declined to separate the subjects."

A few workers laughed, tired and sharp. Irel silenced them with a glance.

She addressed the envoy. "Rootglass will deliberate. Your riders remain outside the lower terraces. No guard enters a hive chamber."

Ven Ardel bowed. "The Queen-Regent asks an answer by sunset."

The envoy's clerk left a written schedule on the grafting table. Sevrin read it while the horses moved away. Grain would arrive in three allotments, each released after Rootglass certified that no hive material had crossed the western road. The last allotment required a royal inspector inside the archive. Protection had acquired a measuring spoon before the council had accepted it.

Meya read over his shoulder. "Second shipment after six days. We have flour for four."

"Five if the council opens its winter bins."

A senior gardener behind them said, "Those bins preserve spring graft stock."

"Hungry workers will burn graft stock for cooking wood," Meya replied. "Preservation has to include the hands."

Sevrin looked across the listening crowd. Rootglass contained Aeli families who traced service through eleven leafings, human tenants with no council vote, Salt Aeli merchants stranded by road closures, and Vennik builders hired for one repair season who had stayed for nine. Osra's neutrality term treated them as one orchard when enforcement helped the Crown, then let local rank divide the grain.

He turned the schedule over and wrote the colony refusal count on its blank back. Beside it he added the stored-comb estimate and the delayed leafings. "Copy both sides," he told the archive apprentice. "Post one at every wage kitchen."

The senior gardener objected. "Council has not verified those numbers."

"Workers watched the frames close. Concealment cannot make the pollination private again."

His own words tasted deservedly bitter. Meya heard the irony and gave him no comfort from it.

After the royal party withdrew to the guest house, council gardeners crowded the grafting arch. Some wanted the grain. Others feared giving Osra control of the western road. One demanded Sevrin explain why he had mentioned the queen's refusal in public.

Irel raised both hands. "The queen moves now."

Silence followed.

"Where?" Sevrin asked.

"Not where an envoy can seize her, nor where a frightened starwarden can decide a sample matters more than a lineage."

"I asked for comb."

"You concealed a region. Forgive me if scale no longer reassures."

Before noon, Irel's keepers emptied the queen chamber through a root passage known to senior gardeners. Sevrin did not see the destination. He watched workers carry ordinary repair baskets uphill while one basket's bearers matched their pace too carefully. He could have followed. Doing so would turn disagreement into pursuit and queen custody into a contest of stealth.

Instead, he returned to the removed silvered frame.

The sample comb held enough evidence: rejected cells, upper pollen, traces of the dark seven-branched grain, and fresh queen scent proving the frame had come from the old line. He cut a piece no larger than his palm. The remaining comb stayed sealed in Rootglass's archive.

Meya found him wrapping the sample in damp cloth. "Is that theft?"

"Yes."

"Good. I dislike professional uncertainty."

He looked at her new filaments. "Your leafing?"

"Delayed. My daughter's too. We'll be angry when there's time." She handed him a narrow travel case. "Cork lining. Keeps comb from sweating. Bring it back if the road doesn't eat you."

Sevrin placed the sample inside. "I am going to Varkesh."

"Kharza?"

"Ashwall's stone. If its stain matches this pollen, the failure crosses peoples and regions. Osra's survey language will not survive both."

"Will your Neris figures survive?"

Irel stood in the record-house doorway, hands empty. The complete tables no longer showed beneath her coat.

Sevrin faced her. "Publish them."

"I intend to."

"Include my edits."

"I intend that too."

His standing at Rootglass might not survive the disclosure. That consequence belonged far below the losses he had hidden.

Irel glanced at the case. "I could stop you."

“Yes.”

“The queen stays with me.”

“Yes.”

“If you bring soldiers back, the western gate closes.”

“I am bringing evidence outward, not an army inward.”

For all their anger, they still shared enough language to hear the distinction.

At the western gate, Sevrin took a work mule, two water skins, and no orchard banner. Behind him, shade cloths covered the pollination frames before the sun reached its height. Rootglass glowed underfoot without answering the upper constellations. Somewhere among its luminous roots, Irel guarded the queen-hive from a Crown offering safety without remedy.

The road west ran toward volcanic smoke. Sevrin fastened the sample comb against his ribs and left the orchard before Osra’s envoy received an answer.

Chapter 3 — A Crown Marshal at the Gate

King Ordan entered Vael Tern feet first.

The bier bearers had turned him on the final slope so his crownless head would pass beneath Crown Gate before the closed eyes of the city. Maela Ruun watched from the gatehouse stair, counting witnesses. Twelve royal guards. Two physicians. One priest from the river court. Pell Vask beside the inner winch, holding a ration slate rather than mourning cloth. Above them, archers lined the wall in full view of Osra's envoy waiting beyond bow range.

"Open one leaf," Maela ordered.

The gate crew released the western door. It moved just wide enough for the bier and its escort, denying any mounted rush. A cold wind came through with Ordan, carrying river mist and the smell of the preserving herbs packed around his body.

No crowd waited inside. Maela had cleared the gate court before dawn. Grief did not require seventy thousand people to trample one another beneath a murder rumor.

Ordan's physician stopped at the white line painted across the stones. "Crown Marshal, King Ordan Ruun died in his sleep before the first bell yesterday. No wound, no poison sign, no restraint mark. The body remained in our custody from death to gate."

Maela looked at each named witness. "You affirm that account?"

They did. The river priest's voice shook.

She descended and laid two fingers against Ordan's wrist. Cold skin. No pageant could make the fact larger. He had designated her successor four years ago, after deciding his collateral cousins loved the harvest provinces more than the whole realm. He had not married. He had not called Maela daughter. Political law had placed her in his line, and political law could remove her.

"Carry him to the east chapel," she said. "No public viewing until the physicians issue their written finding. Twelve city witnesses remain with him, chosen by lot from six wards."

One royal guard stiffened. "A king lies under royal witness."

"A dead king lies in a city Osra has threatened. We will not give either side an unwitnessed body."

Pell scratched a note onto her slate. Two fingers were missing from her right hand, lost to a pulley years before Maela met her. She held chalk between thumb and remaining fingers with the same exact pressure she used on winch lines, accounts, and inconvenient officials.

The bier moved toward the chapel.

Outside the half-open gate, Osra's envoy raised a red staff. "The

Queen-Regent's demand must be heard before the sun reaches the southern tower."

Maela answered from under the arch. "It will be heard at council. Your escort remains outside."

"My person bears truce."

"Your person bears twenty cavalry."

"Protection on an uncertain road."

"Then they can protect it from there."

She closed the gate leaf.

Pell waited until the locking beams dropped. "You have acquired a kingdom and begun by insulting its aunt."

"Ordan's aunt by marriage."

"Excellent. Correct the genealogy while she marches."

Maela almost smiled. Pell had once known how to draw laughter from her in rooms where rank had been left with their boots. Their intimacy ended two winters ago without betrayal and without repair. Pell said Maela carried the citadel to bed. Maela answered that Pell brought three ledgers. Both had been accurate.

"What does the slate say?" Maela asked.

"That dead kings continue not to eat, which helps less than expected." Pell turned it around. "Sixty-one thousand four hundred residents. Eight thousand six hundred refugees registered inside the outer walls. Seventy thousand mouths before garrison animals. Flour for twenty-three days at siege ration if every noble kitchen turns over its private stores. Sixteen if they don't."

"They will."

"Your confidence lacks a search schedule."

"Write one."

"I did. The council will call it confiscation."

"The council may spell it while unloading sacks."

Pell's large dark eyes narrowed with professional approval. "Cistern capacity holds thirty-one days if lower seepage stays stable. It has not. South basin dropped a thumb overnight."

"Leak?"

"No wet wall. The water went somewhere below."

Beneath them, a faint tremor passed through Crown Gate. Iron leaves hummed against their pins. Pell felt it through the winch housing and placed her left palm on the stone.

"That again?" Maela asked.

“Third time since midnight. Not cart traffic.”

The royal chamber below the citadel had also sounded twice during the night, but only Maela and Ordan’s dead seal-keeper knew that. Exclusion had trained her to recognize danger privately.

“Council first,” she said. “Bring every ration figure.”

The Hall of Confluences faced three rivers through narrow windows. By the time Maela entered, twenty-three councillors had arranged themselves according to what they hoped the succession would preserve. Old royal families occupied the sun side. Ward speakers stood near the doors. Guild representatives clustered around the central water clock. Jorren Taal, her scout captain, waited by a map of the western roads.

Osra’s envoy stood alone inside the witness rail. Lady Caren Dane, a distant niece with no military command, wore Heartland red and carried a document bound in white cord.

Maela did not sit on the king’s raised chair. She took her place at the marshal’s map table.

“Read,” she said.

Caren broke the document cord. “By authority of Osra Dane, Queen-Regent of the Tern Heartland and protector of continuity during royal vacancy: Vael Tern shall admit the Regent’s household guard, transfer custody of Crown Hinge, recognize temporary suspension of succession designation, and prepare the city for lawful inquiry. Crown Marshal Maela Ruun shall retain rank upon giving immediate obedience.”

A councillor asked, “If she refuses?”

“Her Grace will secure the hinge against unlawful seizure.”

“How?” Pell said from the public benches. “With polite cavalry?”

Caren ignored her. “The Regent also bears news from Varkesh. Ashwall failed after insubordination by former general Kharza Olt. Outer agitators may attempt further disturbance.”

Jorren leaned toward Maela. “Western beacons went dark before midnight. No confirmation.”

Maela addressed the envoy. “Ordan designated me under the Witnessed Succession Act. What lawful basis suspends it?”

“A vacancy with disputed hinge safety.”

“Disputed by whom?”

“The Regent’s survey court.”

“Not present in this city.”

“Which is why Crown Hinge custody must transfer.”

The argument curved neatly back to Osra. Maela had used such curves while

excluding Mahr petitioners from lower chambers: access required recognized standing, and standing required records kept behind the inaccessible door. At the time she called it lawful defense against sabotage.

Councillor Hesn rose from the sun side. "We should admit a small inspection party. Refusal makes us look guilty."

"To whom?" asked a dock-ward speaker. "The army traveling behind it?"

Caren's face did not change. That answered enough.

Maela turned to Jorren. "Road report."

"Three thousand infantry left Dane Cross yesterday. Engineers following. Cavalry screens on both banks. More banners assembling north."

The chamber stirred.

Osra had begun marching before her demand reached the gate.

Maela set both palms on the map table. Authority pulled every eye toward her and therefore threatened to make every other witness decorative. "We verify the hinge before we answer. Six council observers."

A royal cousin objected. "The lower chamber admits only the sovereign or designated heir."

"Then the designated heir will admit witnesses."

"Can you?"

Maela drew the royal bearing seal from beneath her breastplate.

It fit in her palm, a disk of river gold cut with four unequal arcs. Ordan had given it to her when he named her. She had used it to open petition rooms, archive doors, and the chamber where generations of kings claimed they alone could hear the world's bearing. Every use had affirmed both her legitimacy and someone else's exclusion.

The ward speakers chose observers: Pell for the Vennik caravan houses, Jorren for the garrison, a Mahr mason named Vorda from the south ward, an Aeli instrument maker called Thaen, the river priest, and Councillor Hesn for the royal families. Caren demanded to join. Maela refused until the city completed its own inspection.

They descended through the citadel.

Lower corridors narrowed as if the fortress wanted to ration access by body width. Old reliefs showed human kings placing hands over carved constellations while smaller figures stood behind them carrying ropes, bowls, and tuning staffs. Their faces had been chiseled smooth. Maela had passed those walls for six years without asking why only the king retained features.

At the final door, four stone arcs surrounded a circular hollow. The royal bearing seal entered at the center. Warmth traveled through Maela's fingers. She turned the disk until its unequal cuts aligned with the arcs.

The door withdrew downward without sound.

Pell crouched beside the opening. "No counterweight noise."

"It moves through bearing pressure," Maela said.

"That sentence means nobody let my people inspect it."

"Yes."

Pell glanced up at the admission. They had argued about this door when they still shared rooms. Maela had defended law. Pell had asked who maintained a miracle after the authorized person died inside it. Neither had persuaded the other.

The chamber beyond formed a vast circular gallery around a central shaft. Far below, Crown Hinge crossed the chasm in four black arms. They resembled natural ridges until the eye followed their impossible symmetry. Upper light entered through crystal conduits in the ceiling. A deeper blue glowed beneath the arms, not reflection but the buried sky seen through miles of open dark.

Maela stepped to the brass sighting rail.

Four needles should have pointed to one mark cut under Ordan's reign. The northern needle stood half a hand east. The western sat lower than its rest. Fine white dust gathered beneath both bearings.

Thaen unfolded a lens. Vorda pressed an ear to the floor. Pell walked the circumference counting paces and anchor sockets. None touched the hinge itself.

"Misalignment," Thaen said. "Recent enough that dust hasn't compacted."

Vorda lifted her head. "Stone pushes upward under the north arm."

Councillor Hesn gripped the rail. "Can Osra correct it?"

Maela looked at the royal seal still warm in her hand. "The seal opens this room. It does not supply four missing kinds of labor."

"How do you know four?" Pell asked.

The wall reliefs here had suffered worse erasure. Four sets of hands remained around every old bearing scene, while words beneath them had been cut down to royal titles. Maela had no answer she trusted.

"I know one person cannot realign that weight," she said.

A grinding pulse crossed the gallery. The northern needle moved another hair east. Pell seized the rail. Thaen's leaf-filaments flattened against his temples. Vorda gasped and covered one tusk.

Below, a field of unfamiliar stars shifted behind the hinge arm.

Jorren whispered, "Has it always looked that close?"

"No," Maela said.

Their inspection lasted another quarter hour. Pell marked empty anchor sockets sized for portable tackle. Vorda found old scoring where stone had once carried resonance. Thaen collected white dust without naming its source. The priest copied

every needle position. Hesn stopped arguing for immediate admission of Osra's surveyors.

When they returned to the hall, Lady Caren stood ready with Osra's document.

Maela placed the observers' preliminary record on the witness rail. "Crown Hinge is misaligned. The city will not transfer it to a force that marched before making its claim."

Caren's voice cooled. "Then you assert the throne?"

"I assert the gate."

"The Regent recognizes no distinction."

"She may learn one outside these walls."

Caren rolled Osra's demand closed. "Your refusal makes you a usurper in arms."

"Your army made me in arms. The title remains yours."

By sunset, red signal fires answered along the northern road. Osra's advance companies would reach the outer farms within days.

Maela issued evacuation orders before the council could turn fear into ceremony. Children without household protection, patients who could travel, and refugees with sponsors outside the siege ring received first passage south by river. No general emptying could succeed with roads already screened. Pell estimated six thousand places if barges returned instead of fleeing after one trip.

The first quay list failed within an hour. Two royal households entered thirty-one servants as dependents while a fever ward received six places. A dock clerk erased three refugee names when their sponsors could not produce city seals. By the time Maela reached Blue River Quay, families had packed the steps and soldiers were holding a passage too narrow for litters.

She climbed onto a mooring block. "No departure until the list is read again."

Groans answered her. A barge master pointed at the falling river. "Wait for speeches and I lose the south channel."

"Then help us finish quickly."

Pell stood at a cargo scale beneath the awning, comparing bodies and baggage against the barge's safe draft. "We have forty-seven seats manufactured by servants who appear to be carrying more jewelry than service skills."

A nobleman pushed through the crowd. "My household has royal travel privilege."

"Your household can row," Maela said. "One able adult attendant per child or patient. The rest join ward defense or apply under public criteria."

"You would separate families?"

"You separated servants from their own families when you called them dependents."

The exchange drew anger from his retainers and approval from people who did not need another reason to resent the sun-side wards. Maela ordered the quay witnesses expanded: one clerk from each river ward, two refugee representatives selected by the camp kitchens, and a Vennik load assessor with authority to reject dangerous baggage. Every removed name had to remain visible beside the reason for removal. No clean ledger would hide the contest beneath it.

A woman from the fever ward approached carrying a boy whose breathing rasped. Her place had disappeared from the first list. Maela put her aboard without invoking rank, using the restored medical criterion while the witnesses watched. The distinction mattered. Mercy granted by a ruler vanished with the ruler; a public rule could outlive gratitude.

The barge master called draft marks as passengers boarded. Pell shifted three sacks of dried beans forward, moved a trunk ashore, and sent twelve unaccompanied children to the center benches under two ward nurses. When the hull finally lifted free, every name remained posted on the awning wall.

Only then did Maela authorize departure. Oars took the current. People on the quay watched until the blue sail passed the south chain tower, because nobody trusted a promised route until a vessel had traveled it.

Jorren arrived with a scout report while the next list went up. Osra's cavalry had purchased fodder from northern farms at triple price and seized what farmers refused to sell. Her engineers marked camp ground outside bow range. She had not yet closed the southern river.

"She wants the city to see that obedience still has a road," Maela said.

"For now," Jorren replied.

Maela ordered farm families inside before dusk, grain stacks burned only if seizure became certain, and every well beyond the wall covered rather than poisoned. A besieger might inherit the water later, but refugees used those roads first. Military denial without a civilian clock merely renamed cruelty.

"Limited evacuation means choosing," Pell said in the quartermaster's room. Ledgers covered every chair. "Choosing means someone will accuse us of pricing lives."

"We are pricing capacity. Publish the criteria."

"You say that now."

Maela accepted the accusation beneath the words. Years ago Pell had altered a ration ledger during a winter campaign. Maela knew only that the change saved soldiers; Pell had never told her whom it cost. Their trust had developed a locked room neither dared force.

"I need you west," Maela said.

Pell stopped writing. "You need me here."

"I need someone who can read those empty sockets. Ashwall's survivors may

have proof, and Kharza Olt has standing among the Kiln Houses.”

“Standing enough to be blamed for losing a fort.”

“Then reach her before Osra’s account does.” Maela set a writ on the desk. “Find Kharza. Find an Aeli witness if the Rootglass reports are true. Bring me a claim to bearing authority that does not begin and end with this seal.”

Pell stared at the writ. “You are sending your quartermaster away from seventy thousand people at the opening of a siege.”

“I am sending the only person I trust to count what the Crown erased.”

“That is almost an apology for the door.”

“Do not improve it.”

Pell took the writ with her left hand. “Nim can hold the city stores for four days. After that, your noble kitchens start lying.”

“Search them on the third.”

“Now you’re learning romance.”

The old humor hurt cleanly. Pell packed chalk, pulley tables, two compact scales, and no court clothes. She also took the city’s west-road ration stamps, each impressed through one edge so villages could distinguish her authority from Osra’s requisitions. Maela added a blank witness book and signed only its first page; what followed had to belong to the people Pell found.

At Crown Gate before midnight, Maela watched her ride west through the single opened leaf. Southbound evacuation barges moved below, each carrying names copied in public at the quay. North of the city, Osra’s signal fires multiplied.

Maela kept the royal bearing seal in her closed hand until its edges marked her skin. Then she returned it beneath her breastplate, ordered Crown Gate barred, and prepared Vael Tern to defend a hinge no dynasty had ever taught it to share.

Chapter 4 — The Reed Orcs Answer

Aruk Venn stepped from one council barge to the next while both decks moved apart.

A pole's width of brown water opened beneath him. He landed on wet planks, caught the mast stay, and waited for the barges to strike together again. Reedwater war speakers shouted approval from three vessels. The fish-mothers on the nursery scow did not look up. Anyone raised in the eastern marsh learned early that applause did not keep a boat level.

"Lash them wider," Aruk told the deck crews. "Osra's people brought horses. We will not have one kick us into agreement."

Ropes tightened across the floating council. Seven barges formed a broken circle around open water, each representing a channel confederacy whose boundaries changed with floods. No raised chair marked Aruk's office. As war speaker for the season, he stood on whichever deck held the current without sinking.

His two silver caps felt cool over his tusks. Reed Mahr wore them for ceremony, fishing, battle, and sleep. Upland Kiln Houses called that a refusal of stone-song. Reedwater people considered constant resonance a poor bargain when mud, drowned timber, shell banks, and shifting clay all complained at once. Silver reduced the noise to pressure he could choose to hear.

This morning, something pressed through the caps.

The pulse came from beneath the nursery scow, slow enough to mistake for a barge settling under load. Aruk watched the waterline. It stayed level. Beyond the council ring, reed islands leaned west although the wind came east.

"War Speaker," called Darsa Pell from the Eel Mouth delegation. "Your guests have reached the chain."

Osra's envoys approached in a broad ferry roofed against rain. Their six horses stood blindfolded between wicker partitions. Reed pilots controlled the poles. Heartland soldiers kept their hands away from weapons, having received good advice from somebody.

On the opposite channel, another skiff came fast under a black-clay pennant. A young Kiln House courier knelt in its bow with a sealed tube against his chest.

Both offers had timed themselves for the same tide.

Aruk ordered both parties held at separate chains until the ordinary reports finished. Osra could wait. So could Kharza Olt. Neither would vote on how many Reed children had coughed blood after last month's salt tide.

Channel speakers gave their accounts. North Net had lost two nursery ponds when clear water rose beneath the mud and left a white crust. Eel Mouth's rice fish

carried lesions. Three human villages wanted permission to move house platforms into Mahr-administered channels rather than pay a Tern landlord twice for flooded ground. A Salt Aeli trading family had abandoned a winter quay, taking two grain contracts with them. None of these matters fit cleanly inside the royal language of autonomy.

When the seventh report ended, Aruk raised an open palm. "Bring the red ferry."

Osra's delegation entered without horses. Councillor Bel Dane, the Regent's cousin, wore marsh boots too new to bend. Beside him came a surveyor from Neris and a Reed-born human clerk named Sal Marrow whom Aruk knew from flood court. Osra had chosen at least one person capable of hearing local terms without translation.

Bel bowed to the barge circle. "The Queen-Regent recognizes the Reed Confederacy as a sovereign marsh partner during the present vacancy."

Darsa called, "Which Reed Confederacy?"

The envoy hesitated.

Seven speakers waited.

Sal Marrow murmured in his ear. Bel corrected himself. "The channel confederacies assembled under seasonal defense covenant."

"Better," Aruk said. "Continue before the tide changes your education."

Osra offered what the old Crown had refused for thirty years: recognized marsh courts over fishing, house platforms, and internal tolls; an end to royal appointment of channel reeves; three years of subsidized salt exchange from Neris; engineers for the failing east levee; and payment for four thousand soldiers under Reed officers.

No demand required conversion to Heartland command. That absence mattered.

Aruk asked for the written articles. Sal passed them across a plank. Reed law used knotted cord beside text, allowing boat crews who did not read court script to verify quantities and durations. Osra's document carried cords for money and grain but none for autonomy.

"Words without knots drift," said Old Ter Venn from the Pike Channel barge.

Bel frowned. "The Regent's seal binds the text."

"Her seal does not bind our children."

Aruk handed the articles back. "Knot every term before sunset. Add that Reed officers retain command and marsh courts judge crimes committed here by allied troops."

"The campaign cannot function under divided military law."

"It will function elsewhere, then."

Bel looked around the barges and understood that no palace authority could

make this floating floor hold him. "I will refer the command term."

"You will answer it."

Rain began in thin strokes. The nursery scow bumped the council barge, though its mooring poles stood firm.

The Neris surveyor opened a map. "Salt relief requires stable roads and stable seasons. Unauthorized disturbance at Ember Hinge could drive a surge through Reedwater. Her Grace intends to secure Crown Hinge against rival claimants."

"Did fixed seasons preserve our nursery ponds?" Darsa asked.

"The last salt rise came from outer agitation near Varkesh."

"Before or after Ashwall?" Aruk said.

The surveyor paused. News had traveled faster through marsh traders than official reports. "The timing remains under review."

"Then your cause has no timing."

Bel stepped in. "Kharza Olt has already destroyed one royal defense through insubordination. She now asks regional leaders to defy lawful continuity."

"Does she?" Aruk turned toward the black-clay skiff. "Bring her words."

The courier climbed aboard. He had one tusk chipped at the tip from kiln labor and ash packed into the seams of his lamellar. He offered Kharza's tube to Aruk with both hands.

The message described Ashwall's upward collapse, the Deep Hart stain, the refugees saved, and King Ordan's death. Its final lines asked every Mahr defense house to assemble under General Kharza Olt's emergency field authority and deny Osra access to the outer hinges.

Aruk read those lines twice.

"Who witnessed the wording?" he asked.

"Varkesh hearth council received it this morning," the courier said. "General Olt spoke before them."

"Did the council grant her field authority?"

"They are debating."

"Yet she used it."

The courier's jaw tightened. "There is no time to build command from reeds."

A murmur moved across the barges. Kiln Houses often used reeds to mean temporary things. In the marsh, properly woven reed walls outlasted stone foundations because they yielded without surrendering shape.

Aruk held up the letter. "Kharza asks us to escape royal command by entering hers."

"She asks Mahr to stand together."

“Which Mahr? My people have stood for three generations against upland toll collectors who shared our tusks and called that kinship enough.”

Bel Dane allowed himself a small smile. Aruk turned on him.

“Do not enjoy this. Osra offers sovereignty because she needs boats. Her husband’s house denied it while they had bridges.”

The smile disappeared.

Aruk gave Kharza’s courier food and a dry cloak, then ordered both delegations off the council ring while the speakers deliberated. No outsider would watch dissent and later mistake it for weakness.

Arguments began before the ferries cleared the chain.

Eel Mouth favored Osra. Subsidized salt could save fish nurseries if deliveries came before winter. Pike Channel distrusted every Crown article and proposed armed neutrality. North Net wanted Kharza’s evidence inspected before any soldiers left. Two smaller confederacies feared that refusing Osra would let Heartland cavalry close their dryland markets. The fish-mothers opposed all marching until the nursery scow’s strange movement had been explained.

Aruk listened without announcing his preference. A war speaker who began by speaking could reduce seven judgments to echoes.

At midday, the nursery master beckoned him aboard. Her name was Vesa, a human woman whose family had managed spawning reeds under three different channel covenants. She lifted a wicker lid. Inside, young silverfin circled the trough against the natural current.

“They started west at dawn,” she said. “All six tanks.”

“Salt measure?”

“High, not enough to turn them.”

A Mahr dredger crouched beside the scow’s central post. “Something knocks below. Not driftwood.”

Aruk knelt and set his uncapped palm to the post. Wood transmitted confused taps. He touched one silver cap. Cultural choice did not require deafness when evidence demanded hearing.

He twisted the left cap free.

Bare tusk met the wet air. Stone-song surged through it from far under the mud, broad and branching. Reedwater carried little exposed rock, but ancient shellstone lay beneath its channels. That buried bed sang under pressure moving west to east. A higher note crossed it from below.

The sensation made his eyes water.

He replaced the cap before pain clouded measure. “Not boats,” he said.

Vesa watched him. “Hinge?”

“I do not know.”

“Will you tell the council that?”

“Yes.”

Certainty offered command an easy posture. Limits required more strength to state.

Back on the central barge, Aruk reported exactly what he had heard. Kharza’s warning gained weight. Osra’s salt promise gained urgency. Neither decided the alliance by itself.

Old Ter asked, “If the Crown fixed the sky for Heartland grain, why march to help it?”

“Because Osra offers us the authority her realm denied,” Darsa said. “We can bind that offer while she needs us.”

“And after?”

“After, four thousand trained soldiers come home under Reed officers.”

A younger speaker from Low Rush pointed toward the nursery scow. “If Kharza opens Ember Hinge, our water may worsen.”

“If Osra locks Crown Hinge, pressure may worsen anyway,” said North Net.

Every path carried an injury. Aruk distrusted leaders who called that indecision rather than the substance of rule.

He asked each delegation to state what would make its preferred choice wrong. Eel Mouth said Osra’s alliance failed if autonomy remained unknotted. Pike Channel said neutrality failed if either army seized marsh routes without resistance. North Net said Kharza’s call failed because it placed one former royal general above local councils. Low Rush said any campaign failed if Reed troops burned civilian boats or nurseries.

That final condition held the circle.

Reed warfare had grown from channel defense. Boats carried fighters, but also nets, families, seed jars, and the platforms on which houses survived flood. Burning civilian craft did not merely kill passengers. It erased shelter and harvest together. Heartland commanders called such boats supply vessels when they wanted them targeted.

Aruk stood as afternoon rain thickened. “I propose alliance with Osra under five knots. Sovereign marsh courts. Reed command over Reed soldiers. Salt delivery measured at our quays. Withdrawal if Crown troops seize channel homes. Absolute refusal of orders to burn civilian dwellings, nursery reeds, refugee craft, or unarmed food boats.”

Darsa asked, “Who judges civilian use when fighters hide among them?”

“Reed officers on the water. Not a distant siege marshal.”

Old Ter said, “And Kharza?”

“We send her the truth. Her evidence names danger. Her authority does not

bind us. If she wants partnership, she can write without borrowing a dead king's voice."

Votes in the Reed Confederacy did not use raised hands. Each channel placed a carved float in open water: green for assent, white for refusal, black for delay. Current could separate them but not change their colors.

Five green floats entered the circle. Pike Channel cast white. North Net cast black until the autonomy cords returned.

They waited.

Near sunset, Sal Marrow poled back alone with revised articles. Every promise carried a matching knot cord. Osra accepted Reed command and marsh jurisdiction. Her clause concerning military necessity tried to weaken the protection for civilian craft. Aruk crossed out six words. Sal read the change and said, "Bel will object."

"Bel is already riding toward dry land."

"Osra may reject it."

"Then our soldiers remain here."

Sal tied the corrected cord herself.

North Net replaced its black float with green. The decision passed six channels to one, with Pike's dissent entered beside it rather than hidden under unanimity.

All night, the marsh fleet prepared. Four thousand Reed soldiers did not emerge from a horn call. Fish crews shifted nets to feed the departing companies. Armorers checked silver caps and shell-lamellar ties. Human, Mahr, Aeli, and Vennik households contracted replacement labor for poles, levees, and nursery watches. Each channel named its own officers. Aruk held seasonal coordination, not ownership of their obedience.

Pike Channel's white vote became the first test of that distinction. Old Ter refused to contribute fighters, yet Osra's article assessed grain from every channel receiving salt relief. Darsa demanded Pike either pay or surrender its share. Younger officers muttered that dissent without cost amounted to shelter behind other people's shields.

Aruk called them to a lamp-lit deck beside the loading quay. "Pike receives no campaign salt until it contributes campaign grain," he ruled. "Its ordinary winter allotment remains untouched. We do not starve a channel for voting against war."

Darsa folded her arms. "Then the rest carry more."

"Yes. Put that burden beside the vote where everyone can read it."

Old Ter studied him through the rain. "You could compel us under seasonal defense law."

"I could, if an enemy had entered Reedwater. We are leaving Reedwater to enforce a treaty. Different water, different rule."

The judgment satisfied nobody. That gave it a chance of remaining law rather than favor.

Aruk spent the next hours at the provision floats. A campaign barge needed shallow draft, six days of dried fish, three poles for every two used, spare reed mats, water clay, lamp oil, and room for wounded bodies on return. Heartland paymasters had sent silver based on four thousand spear carriers. The actual force included dredgers, cooks, medics, ferrymen, armor repairers, and nursery-trained water readers. Aruk made Sal Marrow add those workers to the paid rolls rather than letting Osra receive their labor under the word support.

At the third float, he found two bound men sitting under guard. One came from a Mahr fishing household, the other from a human rice village. Both had cut open a campaign grain sack and hidden meal in their boots.

"Desertion theft," their officer said. "War law permits hand marking."

Aruk looked at the meal, then at the two pairs of boots. "Who eats at home?"

The human man answered first. "My mother and three girls. We gave our dry bin to the levy."

The Mahr fisher said nothing until Aruk waited. "My husband's platform took water. He has six children there, two ours."

Aruk ordered the grain restored, the men released from the campaign roll, and their households entered among those replacing absent marsh labor. Their channel lost two paid places and had to name volunteers openly.

The officer objected. "They stole."

"They did. Mark the debt against their first restored catch, not their hands. A soldier forced to march after choosing family will desert farther from home and cost us more."

"Osra's army flogs for less."

"Then remember whose officers command this fleet."

By the time the eastern horizon paled, the seven provision floats carried public tallies. Four thousand soldiers had names, channels, officers, food shares, and households to which pay would return. The number no longer floated free of the people sustaining it.

At dawn, he met Kharza's courier on the outer platform.

"Tell General Olt we sail under our own covenant," he said. "Tell her Ashwall's stain will be examined by our dredgers. Tell her the silver caps do not make us deaf."

The courier accepted the reply. "You choose Osra knowing the pressure is real."

"I choose a treaty my people can enforce while every offered remedy remains uncertain."

"She will call you enemy."

“She may. I will not call myself her subordinate to make the disagreement easier.”

War barges entered the east channel in disciplined pairs. Their prows bore silver-cap emblems, fish marks, family knots, and no royal sunburst. Osra had gained four thousand soldiers. The Reed Confederacy had gained written autonomy and a line its soldiers could refuse to cross.

Aruk’s command barge passed the nursery scow last. Vesa held up a jar containing three of the west-swimming silverfin. He had ordered water samples taken at every confluence on the march, with duplicate jars sent home by independent traders. If salt changed behind the fleet, Osra’s surveyors would not own the record. If nothing changed, Aruk would say that too.

Darsa joined him at the bow. “Pike watches our empty channels. You trust a dissenting vote with our rear.”

“I trust Ter to want Reedwater intact more than he wants me embarrassed.”

“And Kharza?”

“Kharza wants Varkesh intact. That may bring us against each other before it brings us agreement.”

Ahead, the channel narrowed between reed walls tall enough to hide scouts. Aruk ordered outriders into light skiffs and kept the heavy barges centered. Alliance did not relieve him of guarding against Osra’s enemies, Osra’s friends, or opportunists belonging to neither. Each evening, the water readers would publish their salt jars beside the ration tallies. A treaty earned trust only while ordinary boat crews could measure its promises.

Under Aruk’s capped tusks, shellstone continued its troubled song as the fleet sailed toward war.

Chapter 5 — The Road Out of Varkesh

Pell Vask reached Varkesh while the hearth council argued over which wall should receive Kharza's blood.

The city had no execution square. Kiln Houses settled grave crimes before ancestor kilns, where an object chosen by the condemned entered the fire and the person, if death followed judgment, did not. Outsiders often called that softness. Pell had seen royal courts kill people between breakfast and lunch because a scaffold stood ready.

She pushed through the packed kiln hall with Maela's writ under her coat and road mud above both knees. At the center, Kharza Olt stood unbound beside a basalt fragment wrapped in grain cloth. Forty councillors occupied clay benches around her. Refugees from Ashwall filled the aisles. A Crown officer lay on a shutter near the rear, both legs splinted.

A councillor with red-glazed tusk rings struck the speaking bowl. "You broke a command seal, abandoned a royal defense, took Crown stores, and now bring soldiers to this hall."

"Eighty-one surviving soldiers brought themselves," Kharza said.

"You held their obedience."

"I used it."

Pell recognized the dangerous shape of the answer. Kharza refused innocence because guilt had become easier to command than complexity.

Another councillor rose. "Ashwall guarded the west road. Osra's cavalry may now enter without a siege."

"The outwork cannot guard anything," called a woman from the refugee benches. "Unless you teach curved walls to fire arrows upward."

The speaking bowl rang again.

Pell climbed onto an empty fuel bin. Height mattered in human courts. Among Mahr, being the smallest person in a room merely encouraged others to underestimate how far her voice could carry.

"Quartermaster Pell Vask, under writ from Crown Marshal Maela Ruun." She held up the document. "Before you execute the only witness who can read your broken wall, the city that owns Crown Hinge requests her help."

The red-ringed councillor looked her over. "Vael Tern claims authority here?"

"Vael Tern requests. Osra claims. I walked two days to preserve the grammatical difference."

Dry laughter moved around the benches.

Kharza regarded Pell without amusement. "Maela holds Crown Gate?"

"For now. Osra's army has started north and west. The hinge under Vael sits out of true."

That silenced the room more effectively than the bowl.

Pell handed the writ to a clerk rather than directly to the senior councillor. The clerk read it aloud. Maela asked Varkesh for Kharza's evidence, an Aeli ecological witness, and any surviving records concerning shared bearing work. She offered no pardon. Good. A pardon from Vael would imply lawful authority over Varkesh's judgment.

The council called three Ashwall witnesses.

Captain Deren spoke first from his shutter. "I ordered the gate kept shut. General Olt broke my seal before the main uplift. That act violated my command and saved the people outside. She then ordered full evacuation before I did."

"Did her evacuation cause the loss?"

"No. The stone moved from below."

A terrace elder displayed the witness marks on the grain sack. Lessa Olt described pressure burns and the timing of the collapse. None softened Kharza's seizure of stores. Pell appreciated that. Evidence made poor shelter when trimmed to fit the person presenting it.

The basalt fragment came free of its cloth. A pale branching stain crossed the broken mortar. Mahr councillors leaned forward; several tusks vibrated audibly.

Pell took one of her compact scales from her pack. "May I?"

Kharza nodded.

The fragment weighed two measures more than its displacement suggested. Pell balanced it against iron pieces, then shifted the tray. Weight changed slightly when the seven-branched stain faced down.

A Vennik bridgewright beside the kiln whispered a caravan oath.

"Not enough to move a wall," Pell said. "Enough to prove direction."

The council withdrew behind clay screens for deliberation. Pell sat beside Kharza on the fuel bin.

They did not deliberate quietly. Clay screens preserved custom, not sound. One councillor argued that losing Ashwall completed a pattern begun in the Three Valleys: Kharza seized authority, civilians paid, and afterward she named necessity. Another replied that killing the reader who warned them would turn accountability into self-harm. Refugees demanded standing to testify about the gate. Crown veterans demanded standing to speak for the outwork. Every speaker had suffered enough to believe suffering granted the final word.

Pell left the fuel bin and found the clerk who had read Maela's writ. "What penalties exist between release and execution?"

"Hearth bond. Command bar. Property firing. Exile."

"Which preserves her ability to inspect Ember Hinge?"

"Hearth bond, if the council names the work. Command bar would forbid her from leading armed travel."

"Could the bond prohibit levies without prohibiting self-defense?"

The clerk considered. "If a hearth accepts responsibility."

"Olt will be accused of sheltering its own."

"Yes."

"Can Ashwall's refugees serve as a second hearth?"

"They have no registered kiln."

Pell pointed at the ration platform outside, where displaced terrace families had set three cooking fires around salvaged grain jars. "They have fire, shared stores, and witnesses. Your ancestors managed before registration forms."

The clerk's mouth twitched. "You enjoy insulting archives while asking them for help."

"I enjoy making them confess they were invented by people."

Together they drafted a bond that assigned Kharza a specific task, denied her unilateral levy authority, preserved the refugees' claim against seized stores, and required public accounting of the wall fragment. Pell sent it behind the screens without attaching Maela's seal. Varkesh needed a local answer, not a more polite external command.

A terrace man approached while they waited. He had owned the wagon of roof tiles at Ashwall. "If she had not ordered us away, my family would be under that wall."

"Then you favor release."

"I favor remembering she left our valley wells guarded for Crown soldiers eleven years ago. My sister's boy died walking to the next spring."

Pell looked toward Kharza. "Have you told the council?"

"They know the campaign. They do not know his name."

"Do you want it entered?"

The man gave the name. Pell wrote it in the witness book beneath Maela's signature, not as a charge resolved by Ashwall's rescue but as a debt that rescue did not purchase away. When she showed Kharza, the general read without defending herself.

"You saved him by not commanding me," Kharza said to the man.

"I saved my children by obeying quickly. Do not turn that into your reform."

He returned to the refugee benches. Kharza watched him go.

Pell sat beside her again. "You resigned Crown command," Pell said.

"Yes."

"Yet your letter to Reedwater names emergency field authority."

Kharza's jaw hardened. "You have read it."

"Aruk's reply reached the south post before I did. Marsh couriers understand roads better than maps."

"I needed troops."

"You needed consent and wrote yourself command instead."

"Maela sent you to recruit me, not correct me."

"Maela sent me to count what the Crown erased. You remain visible."

Kharza turned toward her fully. Pell felt the old general's attention settle like a load test. "What do you want?"

"Mutual audit. Every ration transfer public to the party. Every military order names objective and expected civilian cost. Any expert may stop work inside their discipline until the objection receives a hearing."

"That creates four commanders for ten people."

"No. It creates brakes. You can still choose the cliff afterward, but you must hear the wheels complain."

Before Kharza answered, a commotion rose at the outer doors. An Aeli man entered with road dust on his black hair and living green filaments along his temples. He carried a narrow cork case against his ribs.

"Sevrin Ael of Rootglass," he told the door guards. "I need the Ashwall stone."

Pell climbed down. "You and everyone else."

Sevrin saw the fragment and stopped. He opened his case on the floor beside it. Inside lay a sample comb wrapped in damp cloth. Silver pollen filled half the cells. Dark grains patterned the wax in seven tiny branches.

The resemblance did not require priesthood.

"Queen line?" Pell asked.

"Fresh scent from the old queen-hive. Irel retains the queen. Every open colony refused upper pollen."

Kharza crouched across from him. They looked at each other for the first time over evidence neither people could claim alone.

"Ashwall rose before any hinge work," Kharza said.

"Rootglass turned toward buried influence before your wall failed," Sevrin replied. "Pressure crosses the regions."

"Or damage from old royal handling crosses them."

"Possible. Not established."

Their disagreement began with honest limits. Pell considered that promising.

The council returned at midday. Kharza would not be executed. Varkesh released her under hearth bond to investigate Ember Hinge, with three conditions: she carried no Varkesh levy without a new vote; Ashwall's stores remained charged against the council's relief account rather than erased as emergency seizure; and she returned the stone or a witnessed record of its loss.

Kharza accepted each term.

In the archive beneath the kiln hall, Pell spread Maela's copied wall sketches beside old Varkesh bearing fragments. Most texts had suffered water, censorship, or pious simplification. Kings appeared large. Everyone doing actual work appeared small.

She ignored rank and counted repeated objects.

Every surviving scene placed tusked readers at stone ridges. Pollen bowls and winged marks appeared near a second group. Rope teams occupied sockets matching Pell's measurements from Crown Hinge. A fourth group stood inside a circle of open hands. Royal copies labeled those figures witnesses, but older fragments showed them holding route maps and casualty sticks.

"Four labors," Pell said.

Sevrin traced a pollen mark without touching it. "Living transfer."

Kharza indicated the tusked figures. "Stress reading."

"Distributed load," Pell said, tapping the sockets. "And people witnessing where the load goes."

"Priests?" Lessa asked.

"Perhaps. Or affected regions. The record has scraped away the useful nouns."

They did not know whether the four groups held equal power, whether all were required at every hinge, or whether the diagrams recorded ritual rather than function. Pell wrote uncertainty beside every claim. A neat reconstruction could become another royal lie if nobody preserved its gaps.

Ember Hinge offered the nearest test. It lay under the volcanic crossing east of Varkesh, beyond Ember Ford. Kharza could read its stressed stone. Sevrin's sample provided living pollen. Pell could build a load frame from caravan tackle. Varkesh's hearth witnesses could supply a public record, though not authority over everyone affected.

Lessa packed medical rolls while they debated party size. "I am coming."

Kharza said, "No."

"Excellent demonstration of the new audit." Lessa tied shut a case of splints. "Objection: your ten-person party has no medic. Evidence: Deren would have bled out while you argued with a beam. Remedy: me."

"You are my niece."

"That affects promotion, not arterial skill."

Pell raised her left hand. "Medic's objection sustained."

Kharza glared at both of them, then laughed once without pleasure. "I begin to understand the cliff."

They chose twelve travelers: Kharza, Lessa, four Olt auxiliaries selected by the hearth council, Sevrin, Pell, two Vennik tackle workers, a terrace witness, and a human guide who knew the Cinder Plain wells. No one called it an army. Their food covered five days, water three if heat stayed seasonal, and no one believed it would.

Equipment caused the first practical quarrel. Kharza wanted a second weapons cart; Pell wanted its axle under water casks and iron weights. Sevrin refused to let the sample ride beside kiln oil. Lessa demanded room for two empty litters, arguing that a party which packed only for the healthy had already chosen whom to abandon.

They settled it in the yard with scales. One weapons chest stayed. Water gained the axle. Comb traveled in a sling under Sevrin's coat, medical rolls occupied the driest cart box, and the empty litter poles served as side braces until needed. Pell entered each decision with the person who had objected and the reason the group accepted or refused it. Mutual audit began before trust, which suited her. Trust often arrived late and expected clean bedding.

Pell posted the first audit on the kiln hall door. Kharza held field command for defense and route decisions. Sevrin controlled hive material. Lessa controlled triage. Pell controlled counterweights and ration measures. Any stop order and its resolution entered the witness book Maela had given her.

A scout arrived before the ink dried. Osra's riders had crossed the west causeway and were closing the royal road behind them. Another company moved toward the ford.

The party left Varkesh through the ash gate at dusk. Kharza carried the sealed wall fragment. Sevrin guarded his sample comb. Lessa led two pack mules. Pell walked beside a cart loaded with rope, iron weights, and more trust than its axles had yet earned.

Ahead, Ember Ford cut across a red horizon. Behind them, Osra's cavalry closed the western road.

Chapter 6 — Beneath Two Noons

At midday, Sevrin cast two shadows.

One stretched east from his boots, thin and dark beneath the upper sun. The other leaned west, fainter but edged in blue, thrown by heat rising through the Cinder Plain from the buried sky. Between them, the glassy grit had softened enough to take his footprints and keep them shining after he moved on.

“Cover your filaments,” Lessa called.

Sevrin pulled the shade scarf lower. His leafing threads pressed against the cloth, hungry for light that now arrived from opposite directions. Upper radiance offered the familiar geometry of Cinder Net. The buried influence entered as a pressure without pattern, making every filament tug toward the ground.

Ahead, Kharza walked beside the lead mule. She kept the party moving in fifty-minute intervals, ten minutes of shade, no deviation. Their guide had promised a covered well by noon. They found its stone curb split open and the water hot enough to blister a hand.

Pell lowered a thermometer wire into it. “Drinkable after cooling. Poisonously inconvenient before.”

“How long?” Kharza asked.

“Two hours in shallow pans, one if we spend shade cloth.”

“We have water until evening.”

“Under one noon,” Sevrin said.

Kharza glanced at the paired shadows. “We march to the cedar station.”

“That station appears on a map copied before the lower heat reached the surface.”

“So does every other shelter.”

The argument had repeated since dawn in different forms. Kharza measured danger by arrival time. Sevrin measured it by what arrived with them. Pell measured wheel grease and water. Lessa measured urine color, pulse, and the quality of lies people told when close to collapse.

They filled four pans and left two Olt auxiliaries under an awning to cool the water, with orders to follow at dusk. Distributed command had begun by splitting twelve travelers into fewer.

The Cinder Plain climbed in long black shelves toward Ember Ford. No trees stood beyond thorn scrub. Old lava ribs crossed the road at angles that forced carts into narrow cuts. Heat shimmer revealed distant objects twice, one surface image above and a darker echo below. Sevrin understood why caravan songs called this country a place beneath two noons, though no song had described the lower light burning through boot soles.

Near the second lava cut, they found the refugees.

Thirty-seven carts jammed the road. Families from three western terrace villages had loaded grain jars, kiln molds, bedding, and winter seed. Ashwall's warning riders had sent them east, away from rising foundations. Osra's cavalry on the western causeway had turned them south. A heat fissure now blocked their front wheels.

The crack measured less than a pace across, but red light moved far below it. One wagon had slipped its left wheel into the opening. The axle rested on stone. A mule hung in its harness, hind legs kicking above the glow.

Kharza stopped the party. "How many fit fighters?"

A terrace elder counted fourteen.

"Cavalry?"

"Six riders passed north an hour ago. They saw us."

Kharza looked east. Ember Ford lay a day and a half away if they kept pace. Osra's riders could reach it sooner. "Cut the mule free. Burn what cannot cross. People walk."

Cries rose from the wagon owner. "That cart holds seed plates for five villages."

"People first."

"Without the plates, we plant one season blind."

Sevrin examined the cargo. Each clay plate held rows of seeds embedded in ash according to terrace height. The families could walk away, yet the next harvest's knowledge would remain over the fissure. A commander could call that property. An orchard keeper knew dormant life carried its own civilians.

"We can lift the wheel," Pell said.

"With twelve people and enemy scouts behind us?" Kharza asked.

"With a portable counterweight and six people. Four if your soldiers follow instructions."

Pell's two Vennik workers unloaded a folded tripod from the tackle cart. The legs consisted of short ironwood sections joined by sleeve pins. They set one foot on each side of the fissure and braced the third upslope. A rope cradle went under the trapped axle. Instead of pulling directly, Pell hung three water casks from a traveling arm and slid them outward a hand at a time.

"Why spend water?" Lessa asked.

"Because weight doesn't care whether we drink it later."

The arm lowered. The axle rose.

Sevrin watched load travel through wood and rope with the clarity of a branching root: cargo pressing down, water answering at distance, the tripod feet dividing both burdens into stable ground. No single body had to overpower the wagon. Pell controlled movement by changing where weight belonged.

The mule screamed. Kharza cut its tangled left trace, letting it drop onto a shelf below the road rather than into the fissure. Lessa slid down with a rope and covered the animal's eyes while the wheel cleared.

"Forward half a pace," Pell called.

Refugees pushed. The cart rolled free. One tripod foot cracked the road crust, but Pell shifted the hanging casks inward before it sank. The whole operation took eleven minutes.

Kharza looked at the recovered seed plates. "Every cart gets eleven?"

"No," Pell said. "Every cart gets assessed."

The next six crossed by plank. Three surrendered iron stoves to reduce load. One held a feverish woman who could not walk; the party used the counterweight again. By then Sevrin could see dust moving on the western ridge.

Scouts.

Kharza sent two auxiliaries upslope and ordered the remaining carts into the cut where cavalry could not surround them. She wanted her original party moving east once the vulnerable wagons crossed. Sevrin counted the refugee children filling skins from a brackish seep. Twenty-three. The convoy's rear still lay exposed on open ground.

"If we leave, the scouts mark them for the vanguard," he said.

"If we stay, the vanguard takes the ford first."

"They may already hold it."

"Then every hour matters more."

"To whom?"

Kharza's right tusk twitched, catching some vibration he could not feel. "To Varkesh when pressure breaks Ember Hinge."

"And these people when cavalry takes their grain?"

"I saved refugees at Ashwall."

"That does not purchase the next group."

Her face closed. Sevrin regretted the shape but not the truth. Good acts could become credentials for later neglect.

Pell stood between them, tightening a tripod pin. "Audit. Objective one: reach Ember Ford before Osra fortifies it. Objective two: deliver civilians beyond cavalry capture. Available capacity: twelve travelers, now ten until the water pair returns. Proposal?"

Sevrin said, "Escort the convoy to the basalt teeth. The road narrows there and splits toward three villages. Scouts cannot follow every branch."

"Cost," Kharza said.

"Half a day."

“More. Carts move at two-thirds our pace.”

Lessa climbed back from the mule shelf. “Cost of leaving: wounded and children captured, supplies requisitioned, fourteen potential fighters forced into Osra’s labor train.”

Kharza looked at the ridge dust. “We escort them.”

No thanks followed. The decision changed their danger; gratitude would not change it back.

They moved the convoy in three groups. Empty carts went first to test each crossing. Laden wagons followed under Pell’s marked weight limits. Walkers held the sides, cloth wrapped around feet against heated grit. Sevrin distributed the orchard water he carried for the sample comb, then reduced the comb case’s cooling wrap to one damp layer. Evidence mattered only if living people survived its transport.

The scouts appeared at sunset.

Eight Heartland riders paced the southern ridge, staying beyond bow range. Their leader carried no banner. Kharza placed the Olt auxiliaries where silhouettes suggested twice their number and forbade anyone from loosing arrows first.

A rider called down, “Royal road. Convoy submits to inspection.”

The terrace elder answered before Kharza could. “Which royal?”

“Queen-Regent Osra Dane secures these routes against looting.”

Pell murmured, “Convenient. They inspect food into their saddlebags.”

Kharza called, “The road remains open. Approach unarmed with two witnesses.”

The riders conferred. They did not descend. Their task likely involved counting and delay rather than combat.

Sevrin studied the ridge vegetation. Dry thorn heads leaned toward the riders, though evening wind blew away from them. Beneath the ground, lower radiance drew plant tissue down and east. He took a pinch of pollen from the sample’s outer wrapping, not from the comb itself, and dusted it across a thorn branch.

The grains brightened blue.

Star-bees were absent, but pollen still answered celestial pressure. The glow ran along the plant’s downward-leaning fibers and revealed a line where crust had separated from deeper rock. A fault crossed beneath the riders.

He told Kharza.

She listened through her tusks at the road edge. “Thin shelf. No deliberate break. It could throw them into the fissure.”

“We do not need to break it.” Sevrin pointed at the blue line. “They do not know we won’t.”

Kharza raised her voice. “Your ridge carries open sky-shear. Move off the pale seam before your horses feel it.”

One mount was already stamping. The rider looked down and saw the blue pollen trace. Scouts withdrew twenty paces at once.

Pell climbed onto a cart wheel. "Inspection remains available. Two unarmed witnesses. We'll even show you our ration deficit."

No one accepted.

The riders changed tactics after dark. Two circled north and set fire to a patch of thorn above the road. Wind drove smoke down into the cut, blinding mule teams while the remaining scouts rushed the rear cart. They wanted draft animals, not bodies. A convoy without animals would block the road until the vanguard arrived.

Sevrin heard harness bells clash behind him. He turned through smoke and found a rider dragging at the lead of a seed wagon. The terrace driver clung to the bridle. Neither could see the cart's right wheel approaching a shallow side fissure.

"Wheel right!" Sevrin shouted.

Smoke swallowed the warning. He ran alongside, caught the cart rail, and felt lower heat pouring through the crack. Pollen in the comb case warmed against his ribs. He opened the case long enough to brush blue dust across the rail. Its glow outlined the axle and the approaching break.

The rider saw it and hauled his horse away. Kharza came out of the smoke on foot, not pursuing the saddle but cutting the stolen lead rope. She slapped the mule's flank toward stable ground. The cart missed the fissure by half a wheel.

An arrow struck its grain box. Another hit an Olt auxiliary in the upper right arm, punching through ceramic lamellar at a cord gap. Lessa pulled him behind the wheel, snapped the shaft short, and ordered two refugees to hold pressure around the point. The injury cost them one fighter and required removal under clean light.

Pell's voice rose from the front. "Brake teams, release on my count. Three, two, now."

The first six carts rolled downhill together. Their mass tightened a long drag rope she had run through rear axles during the afternoon. Vennik tackle workers threw the free loop around a basalt spur. The convoy swung across the road, making a temporary wall of wagons with people sheltered on the inside. Horses could not charge the narrow ends without entering spear reach.

Kharza placed four archers behind the grain boxes. "Aim at road, not riders. Show the distance."

Arrows struck in a line before the scouts. One mount reared. The attackers withdrew into smoke, carrying no mule and leaving no body that either side could turn into a grievance larger than the raid.

Fire continued along the thorn patch. Sevrin organized cloth screens and water sparingly, wetting them from the brackish seep rather than drinking stores. Refugee children crawled beneath the wagons away from sparks. Terrace workers beat out embers where they landed on seed cloth. For half an hour, protecting the

convoy meant fighting weather created by enemy hands rather than meeting weapons.

When the wind shifted, the plain emerged blackened and the scouts had gone. Lessa removed the arrow from the auxiliary. It had missed bone but torn muscle. She bound his right arm to his chest and placed him on a cart, changing the party's future fighting count in Pell's book.

Kharza inspected the wagon wall. "You rigged one rope through thirty-seven carts."

"Thirty-four," Pell said. "Three had rotten rear pins. A linked load can hold where individual brakes fail, provided nobody decides independence during the downhill part."

Sevrin touched the comb case. Heat had dried one edge of its cloth. He used a mouthful from his own ration to wet it.

Kharza noticed. "Will it survive the ford?"

"If I stop opening it to save carts."

"You revealed the fault. That saved more than the cart."

"So did your refusal to chase."

The exchange did not erase their argument over pace. It established that both could recognize restraint in the other, a smaller growth than trust and perhaps more useful on a dangerous road.

Under cover of darkness, the convoy reached the basalt teeth. Black pillars rose on either side of the road, forcing riders into single file. Three village tracks branched beyond. Kharza assigned terrace fighters to each group and gave them chalk copies of the fault warnings. Pell transferred one water cask and a spare axle pin. Lessa left fever tincture with the woman's daughter.

The elder wanted Kharza to take six fighters east. "You need hands at the ford."

"So do your carts."

"They can choose."

Kharza asked them openly. Three joined the party, all people whose households had already gone north. The others stayed. Her force grew by consent rather than the assumption that shared tusks supplied an enlistment roll.

They rested two hours among the pillars. Sevrin did not sleep. His filaments ached under the scarf, pulling downward whenever the buried light strengthened. Kharza sat apart with the wall fragment between her boots. The argument over pace remained between them, unresolved but altered by her decision.

Before dawn, the two auxiliaries from the hot well caught up with four cooled skins. They had seen torch lines on the west road: infantry and wagons moving toward Ember Ford.

The party left the refugees and forced the pace east.

Day six burned through their sandals. The extra terrace fighters carried little water, so rations tightened. Pell measured half-cups at each halt and wrote her own name first beside the reduction. Kharza rotated the lead every hour. Lessa inspected feet without waiting for complaints. Sevrin's mule began to stumble when lower heat softened the road; he walked and gave the saddle to a limping tackle worker.

By the afternoon of Day seven, volcanic ridges closed around them. Stone-song became audible even to Sevrin as a vibration in his jaw. The upper sun stood white above the pass. Beneath a split in the earth, blue-gold radiance climbed until the road showed two sets of every shadow.

Then Ember Hinge appeared.

It crossed the chasm beyond the ford, a black stone arc broad as a city avenue, half buried in red cliffs. Natural ridges fed into it from four directions. Heat plumed through gaps beneath its span. On the far bank, the river had withdrawn from one channel and boiled in another.

Kharza stopped at the overlook. Her tusks hummed against the sound rising from the hinge.

"How long?" Sevrin asked.

"Not long enough." The hinge's lower radiance pulsed through the soles of their boots.

Below, red tents formed ordered lines on the upper ford. Earthworks cut the eastern approach. Cavalry pickets held the road they should have reached first. Osra's vanguard had arrived during the half day they spent protecting the refugees.

Pell counted tents, shovel teams, and supply carts. "At least nine hundred visible. More behind the ridge."

She passed Sevrin the small lens from her scale case. Through it, he saw how the vanguard had used the terrain. Infantry held the upper channel where the ford stones remained dry. Engineers drove stakes along the boiling branch, forcing any western attack toward a strip of soft gravel. Horse lines stood behind a low lava wall with saddles kept on. Their supply carts had been parked outward, ready to withdraw if the hinge shifted rather than committed to a permanent defense.

"They fear the ground too," Sevrin said.

"Fear with shovels still makes fortifications," Kharza answered.

Three work gangs wore no military colors. Captured road laborers, perhaps, or local people compelled by requisition. Kharza marked their position separately from the spear companies. Pell noted two unfinished trenches and a stack of unplaced timber. Delay had not made attack impossible, only more expensive and more likely to catch civilians between objectives.

A group of displaced families huddled on a gravel island between the boiling

channel and the enemy bank. Riders had driven them off the road but not admitted them through the works.

Kharza looked from the fortifications to Sevrin. No accusation entered her face. The earlier choice remained right and had still cost them the ford.

“Camp below the western shelf,” she ordered. “No fires. Pell, find load points. Sevrin, keep the comb alive. Lessa, count the island people. At dusk we map a way through.”

They descended toward Ember Ford behind schedule, beneath two noons, with Osra’s vanguard already digging into the ground they needed to move.

Chapter 7 — The Battle of Ember Ford

Kharza listened to Ember Hinge through the soles of dead men's boots.

The boots lay in a row beneath the western shelf, seven pairs recovered from a burned ford station. Their owners had been road guards before Osra's vanguard arrived. Lessa had covered the bodies with sailcloth but left the footwear outside so living people could use it. Each sole carried a different thickness of river grit. Kharza set her bare tusks against the iron nails in turn, tracing vibration from the ground without exposing her face above the shelf.

Every pair gave her the same warning.

Pressure converged beneath the upper channel, where Osra's infantry held dry stones and three rows of earthworks. A lower stress line crossed toward the gravel island where twenty-nine refugees waited among steaming pools. Between them ran Ember Hinge, its black arc buried under the eastern cliff, pulling heat upward against the river's weight.

Behind Kharza, Pell whispered counts. "Eleven hundred enemy by cook fires. Two hundred engineers or laborers. Cavalry near two hundred, but only half can deploy on this bank. Six scorpions, all facing west."

"Relief?" Kharza asked.

"Late."

Before leaving Varkesh, the hearth council had promised no levy. It had not prohibited households from following. All night, small groups reached the shelf: kiln workers carrying ceramic shields, terrace guards, former Crown soldiers from Ashwall, families seeking people trapped at the ford. By the lowest count, Kharza had four hundred and eighty-two able fighters. Most had never fought together. Another hundred and forty workers could move rope, litters, water, and earth.

Enough to begin a battle. Not enough to pretend command could repair every failure in it.

Sevrin lay beside her at the overlook, his leaf-filaments wrapped in dark cloth. "The island's eastern pool widened since dusk."

Kharza felt that too. "At sunrise, the heat line reaches their shelter."

"Then the rescue cannot wait for relief."

"We strike before dawn."

Pell slid down from the rock. "Before dawn means no upper pollen response."

"After dawn means cooked civilians."

Sevrin touched the case under his coat. "First light reaches the hinge face before it reaches this shelf. I can work with that."

None of them knew what work meant. Fragmentary records gave four repeated

labors but no surviving sequence. Kharza could read stress, Pell could distribute load, Sevrin carried living pollen, and the terrace witness had brought Maela's open-handed record. Improvisation at a structure holding two skies should have sounded like madness. Waiting promised a result they could already measure.

Kharza crawled back beneath cover.

A charcoal map filled the ground under the shelf. She had asked each group to mark what it would accept rather than arranging them as interchangeable blocks. Kiln shield crews could hold heat longer but moved slowly. Terrace archers knew crosswinds. Former Crown soldiers understood the vanguard's horn calls and would not wear royal colors. Refugee families demanded the island rescue remain an objective, not a reward after victory.

Kharza placed four stones on the map.

"Objective one: open a path to the island before sunrise. Objective two: deny the enemy the upper ford. Objective three: reach Ember Hinge with all four labors. We do not pursue east of the red cliff. We do not attack the labor camp. Any group that loses its objective withdraws to the western shelf, not into the river."

Hadrin's sister Mar Olt commanded the ceramic shields. "Who controls the crossing?"

"You do until the first trench. Then Captain Sorn's former garrison takes it."

Sorn frowned. "Divided command at the contact line?"

"Transferred command at a marked line. Your soldiers know trenches. Hers know heat."

"What do you command?"

"The hinge approach. I also decide general withdrawal."

Lessa tied a white cloth around her upper arm. "Medical stop remains mine. If I close a route for litters, no commander reopens it without my word."

Several veterans looked displeased. Kharza said, "Entered and accepted."

Pell took the forward stone. "My tackle teams own the western winches, bridge ropes, and anything hanging from them. If someone cuts a marked blue cord, I will survive long enough to explain why they should not."

A little laughter released breath without reducing danger.

Sevrin said, "No one handles the sample pollen barehanded. If I fall, Meya's case goes to Pell. Do not pour it into the river."

"Why not?" asked a terrace archer.

"Because I do not know what it will do."

Honest uncertainty traveled around the map. People nodded more readily than they had at false reassurance.

Kharza assigned the island rescue to Lessa, twelve swimmers from ford families, and thirty shield bearers under a human ferryman named Udan. Their route

crossed the lower channel on a guide rope Pell would anchor upstream. The main assault would hit the first trench at the same time, forcing Osra's archers to divide.

"What if they shoot the island?" Udan asked.

"Then Sorn sounds their own advance horn from the north cut. Their reserve will move before officers correct the signal."

Sorn rubbed his beard. "Once. They won't trust it twice."

"Once reaches the first rope."

Kharza looked at every face around the map. "Refusals?"

An old kiln fighter declined the assault because his vision failed in darkness. Kharza put him with the casualty runners. Two Crown veterans refused Sorn's leadership over an old pay dispute; they joined Mar's shields. A terrace company insisted on keeping its own archer. None of these choices shattered the plan. They made its actual shape visible.

The attack began while the upper sky remained black.

Pell's tackle crews rolled three empty carts down the western approach. Enemy sentries heard wheels and launched fire bolts. The carts burned brightly, revealing range markers and drawing the first scorpion shots. Behind them, Mar's shield line entered the lower river under wet hides.

Kharza moved with Sorn's trench group through the north cut. Water reached her thighs, then fell abruptly around a ridge of hot stone. Ahead, enemy stakes angled across the ford. Vennik workers slid hooks around them and pulled from the side rather than forward. The first stake came free without exposing anyone to the firing lane.

A horn sounded from the eastern works.

Sorn answered with the captured advance call.

Osra's reserve moved toward the north cut, exactly as hoped, crowding its own archers for several breaths. Terrace bows struck the scorpion crews. Mar's shields reached the first trench and tipped wet clay jars into it, turning packed ash to sucking mud.

Then the defenders understood.

Arrows came down. Ceramic shields cracked under iron heads. A bolt from the nearest scorpion passed through two overlapping hides and drove a fighter backward into the channel. Kharza dragged him by his harness until a casualty runner took hold. She did not look for the wound. Lessa's people owned that knowledge now.

"Stake clear!" Pell called from behind.

The guide rope shot across the lower channel on a weighted arrow. Udan's swimmers caught it from behind a gravel spur and hauled the thicker line after it. Enemy archers turned toward the island.

Kharza rose above the north ridge. "Sorn. Now."

Former Crown soldiers charged the first trench in Osra's drill cadence. Defenders saw familiar footwork under mismatched armor and hesitated. That moment carried the attackers over the lip.

Kharza struck a spear aside with her axe haft. The soldier behind it wore Heartland red and looked seventeen. She hit his helmet rim, not his throat. He fell into mud. A second infantrywoman drove at Kharza's ribs. Ceramic lamellar caught the point; force bruised bone beneath. Kharza hooked the spear, pulled the woman off balance, and shoved her toward Sorn's prisoners.

"Take surrender!" she shouted. "Keep moving!"

Victory at the trench could consume them if fighters stopped to kill or strip armor. Their objective lay beyond it.

Across the lower channel, Lessa's rescue line entered the water. Shields held upstream against floating debris. Refugees tied children into loops and sent them hand over hand. Steam concealed half the crossing.

Enemy cavalry began moving along the eastern bank.

Pell saw them first. She changed the western winch angle, attaching two loaded carts to the guide rope through a side pulley. When the current dragged the rescue line downstream, the carts rolled uphill against chocks and absorbed the force. A portable counterweight built for one wagon now held twenty-nine civilians against a boiling river.

Kharza reached the second earthwork.

Here the vanguard commander had placed Mahr mercenaries from Tern's city guilds, not Kiln fighters. Their tusks carried leather guards against heat grit. An officer called for Kharza to yield in trade Mahr, using a formal city dialect.

"You lost Crown rank," he said. "Do not spend our lives pretending to recover it."

"I am not recovering it."

"Then why do they follow you?"

A question too accurate for the space between spear points.

"Ask them if we live through this."

He attacked. Kharza caught his blade on her axe head. Stone-song made every impact ring through her tusks, cluttering the deeper stress she needed. She shifted left, drove her shoulder into him, and rolled both of them down the earthwork. He lost his weapon. Kharza pinned him with one knee.

"Your company can withdraw east," she said. "No pursuit beyond the cliff."

"You promise for all of them?"

"No. I state the order in public. You decide whether it carries enough weight."

He looked at Mar's shields, Sorn's mixed veterans, and the terrace archers

covering their own people rather than aiming for easy bodies. Then he shouted withdrawal to his company.

Not all obeyed. Most did. A gap opened in the second work.

Sunlight touched Ember Hinge.

Sevrin ran through the gap with Pell and the terrace witness. Two tackle workers carried the tripod in sections. Four Olt auxiliaries guarded them. Kharza followed, trying to hear beneath combat.

The hinge approach descended between red cliffs. Old sockets lined the road, each cut for beams far larger than Pell's field tackle. A relief wall showed winged marks worn nearly smooth. Beside them, open hands surrounded a map basin. Heat poured from cracks in pulses that matched Kharza's heartbeat only when she stopped running.

"Here," she said at the third socket. "Load crosses under this point."

Pell dropped to measure it. "The tripod won't span."

"Use the cliff anchors."

"Those are thirty paces apart."

"Then distribute farther."

Pell looked once at the terrain and began issuing orders. Ropes ran from old anchors through portable pulleys, across the hinge approach, and back to captured supply carts above. Water casks hung from the returning lines. The arrangement did not try to move Ember Hinge by muscle. It prepared somewhere for the load to travel if movement began.

Sevrin opened the sample comb.

Upper light silvered half its cells. Blue radiance rose through the dark grains in the other half. His leaf-filaments lifted under the scarf, drawing paired lines across his face. He pressed a wax strip into the worn wing marks. Bees were absent. Living pollen still entered the stone, carrying the trace of a colony that had refused the fixed sky.

The terrace witness, a potter named Esha, set Maela's book in the map basin. "What do I say?"

"Who bears the change," Pell answered.

"We do not know the change."

"Then name who stands in reach of harm."

Esha began with the island refugees, the assault groups, the defenders, and the road laborers. She named Varkesh terraces, Rootglass hives, Reedwater nurseries, and Vael Tern behind its gate. The list granted no magical purity. It made concealment harder.

Kharza set both tusks against the third socket.

Stone-song entered her skull.

Ember Hinge carried more than a fault. Its black arc joined upper heat to the Deep Hart's rain pressure below. Ninety-six years of fixed bearing had twisted those forces past each other until their contact sang in two pitches. Ashwall's warning, enlarged beyond endurance.

She followed the lower tone along the hinge arm. It divided beneath the ford, rose under the island, and gathered below the old socket. The higher pitch resisted from above. A full release would tear the banks apart.

"We need a smaller path," she said.

Pell tightened a line. "How small?"

Kharza had no surviving measure. Along the socket rim, mineral polish ended at a short arc between two chisel marks. Not proof of method. Only wear.

"This arc," she said. "No farther."

Pell marked the rope travel corresponding to it. "If the blue knots reach the pulley, we dump the casks and stop load transfer."

"Can that stop stone?"

"No. It can stop us helping it move."

A horn blared above. Enemy cavalry had reached the southern bank.

Kharza kept her tusks to the socket. "Begin."

Pell's teams released the first cart. Weight moved through ropes into the cliff anchors. Sevrin pressed pollen deeper into the relief. Esha continued naming costs and witnesses. Kharza sang against the lower pitch.

Mahr stone-song used the body as a tuning chamber. Breath entered low, crossed the jaw, and left through tusk resonance into rock. It did not command stone. It offered a matching path, the way a hand on a vibrating rope could reveal where strain wanted to travel.

Her first note vanished inside Ember Hinge.

She changed pitch. Heat climbed her throat. The hinge answered through both tusks, a force strong enough to blur sight.

Above, battle rolled backward toward them.

Osra's cavalry found a shallow crossing downstream and struck the shield crews from the side. Mar formed a clay wall around the rescue line. Horses refused steaming water until riders covered their eyes. Then they came through.

Lessa had moved the triage point under the western shelf. Wounded from both sides lay there, separated by need rather than colors. The Olt auxiliary shot the previous night held bandages with his uninjured left hand. When a cavalry bolt struck the shelter awning, Lessa ordered litters into the abandoned first trench, using enemy earthwork as medical cover.

Udan sent the last three children across the guide rope. Their mother refused to follow until an elderly enemy laborer trapped on the island entered a loop beside

her. Rescue expanded because someone at risk had authority to name another person.

At the hinge, Pell's first blue knot moved toward the pulley.

"Quarter load," she called.

Kharza found the matching pitch. Deep Hart pressure surged beneath her song. Rain wanted ascent, not creation, moisture drawn from lower stone and western air. Upper heat held it down. She angled her voice along the polished arc.

The hinge shifted too quickly.

Rope snapped taut. One supply cart lifted onto two wheels. A Vennik worker cut a water cask loose before it pulled him into the anchor. The cask fell and burst, its weight leaving the system. Motion slowed.

"Hold there!" Pell shouted.

Holding required a counterforce none of them possessed. Kharza changed note again, trying to feed pressure sideways. Pain entered the root of her left tusk.

Not a crack. Not yet. A warning bright enough to empty her lungs.

She stopped singing.

Ember Hinge settled back. The blue knot retreated. Above, enemy infantry cheered, mistaking the failed movement for victory or sensing only that the earth had ceased to sway.

Sevrin sagged against the relief wall. Pollen had blackened his fingertips through cloth. "The grains responded. They paired, then separated when you stopped."

Pell checked the ropes. "One anchor shifted. Cart two lost a wheel. We can reset once."

Esha's voice shook. "Do witnesses matter if no court authorized us?"

Kharza lifted her face from the socket. "They matter to what we become after."

A runner stumbled down from the ford. Mar's shields had lost the southern edge. Sorn held the second trench with fewer than a hundred. The island stood empty, but cavalry could cut the western retreat within minutes.

The sensible military order called for withdrawal. They had rescued the civilians. The hinge attempt had failed. Another minute risked encirclement.

Kharza looked at the polished arc. Failure had not returned the stone fully to its prior position. A thread of cold moisture now darkened the socket beyond the first mark.

"How far did it move?" she asked.

Pell measured rope against her chalk scale. "Less than the arc. Perhaps a degree."

"Can we limit it exactly?"

"Only by shedding load at the mark."

Sevrin studied the comb. "The paired pollen held while the stone moved. It separated when movement reversed."

Esha closed the witness book around a clean page. "Then name the intended bearing before we begin. Everyone hears the limit."

Not authority inherited from a king. A bounded action stated before those who would bear it.

Kharza sent the runner back. "Tell Mar and Sorn: hold until three horn calls. Then withdraw west whether the ground moves or not."

"What about you?"

"The same order."

She turned to Pell. "Set one degree."

Pell marked the rope at a measured interval and stationed a cutter at every hanging cask. Sevrin divided the remaining pollen across both wing marks. Esha stood where retreating fighters could hear her and read the intended movement, the stop mark, the named regions, and the absence of certainty.

Kharza placed her tusks against Ember Hinge again.

This time she did not try to overpower both pitches. She sang the difference between them.

The note entered through her chest and narrowed along her jaw. Lower rain pressure rose. Upper heat shifted east. Ropes took load across the cliff anchors. Pollen shone silver and blue in one living band.

The first marked cask dropped.

Ember Hinge moved.

Stone rolled beneath stone with no wheel and no axle, a sacred geological bearing older than every road above it. The black arc turned through the measured span. River water climbed one bank and left another. Heat fissures narrowed. Deep Hart's seven white points appeared far below the chasm.

Pain split Kharza's left tusk from root toward tip.

She heard the fracture inside her skull. Her song broke into blood and breath. Instinct demanded she pull away. If she did, the hinge might settle backward before the stop mark.

Lessa's voice came from somewhere above, shouting three horn calls.

Kharza held contact.

The crack widened. Stone-song entered the fracture directly, too sharp to resemble sound. She tasted iron. Her knees struck the ground, but her right tusk stayed against the socket and carried what her left could no longer hold cleanly.

"Mark!" Pell cried.

Cutters released the remaining casks. Weight crashed into the drainage channel.

Ropes slackened. Sevrin tore the comb strip free. Kharza stopped singing.

Ember Hinge held one degree beyond its old bearing.

For a breath, battle continued from habit. Swords struck shields. Horses fought reins. Archers searched for targets through rising vapor.

Then rain fell on Varkesh.

It began as large cold drops striking hot stone far west of the ford. Steam lifted across the plain. The fall spread east, not created from empty air but released from pressure held beneath the mountains. It reached the river in a gray curtain.

Osra's cavalry lost footing on ash slopes built for dry heat. Sorn's soldiers withdrew at the third horn. Mar's shield crews backed across the ford with rescued civilians inside their formation. Enemy infantry tried to advance and found their own first trench collapsing into mud.

Kharza pulled away from the socket.

Blood ran from her mouth along the pale vein in her left tusk. Lessa reached her, took one look, and wrapped both hands around the base without touching the fracture.

"Do not speak," the medic ordered.

Kharza tried anyway. Pain erased the word.

Lessa bound a padded strap around her jaw and tusk, fixing the cracked side against movement. No cure existed on the battlefield. Stabilization would have to serve.

Pell knelt beside them, soaked by rain and grinning without joy. "Exactly one degree by rope travel. Unless the cliff moved too, in which case our geometry has become political."

Sevrin held up the remnant comb. Half the wax had melted. Enough living pollen remained for proof.

Above the hinge approach, vanguard horns called retreat. Their commander pulled infantry east in ordered groups, covering engineers and wounded. Kharza's forces held the upper ford but obeyed the red-cliff limit. No one pursued into the rain.

The battle had not destroyed Osra's vanguard. It had denied the crossing, rescued the island, and opened Ember Hinge by a measure royal doctrine said should not exist.

Rain made the first accounting difficult. Chalk ran from shield backs. Blood thinned into red fans across gravel. Lessa divided the western station into immediate surgery, stable transport, and dying comfort, with no row for enemy bodies until a former Heartland medic objected that colors did not change pulse. Lessa handed her the red cord and put her in charge of the third row.

Thirty-six coalition fighters had died by the first count. Eleven remained missing

in the channels. Enemy dead visible west of the red cliff numbered forty-two, while seventy-three prisoners or wounded defenders remained in coalition hands. Kharza could not verify losses from the retreating vanguard and forbade anyone from multiplying visible bodies into a heroic claim.

The young soldier she had struck at the first trench woke with a cracked helmet and asked whether he would be executed for serving Osra. Sorn gave him water and pointed toward the red cliff. "Exchange when their officers send names. Work for food until then. No one buys pardon by changing banners tonight."

Udan's swimmers recovered the guide rope and found two bodies tangled near its downstream anchor, one refugee and one shield bearer. The elderly laborer rescued from the island identified six others forced to build earthworks. Pell entered their names separately from enemy troops. Compulsion complicated custody, but it did not make their hunger less measurable.

Mar Olt wanted to press scouts to the eastern ridge while rain blinded the retreat. Kharza wrote her answer on Pell's slate because speech remained impossible: HOLD THE RED CLIFF. COUNT FIRST. Mar read it, looked toward the fading vanguard, and obeyed without surrendering her anger. That obedience mattered precisely because pursuit might have succeeded.

At dusk, Kharza stood with help on the western bank. The rain had cooled heat fissures into smoking seams. Varkesh runners knelt to touch water pooling in old hoofprints. Refugees from the island named those missing and those recovered. Lessa's triage count remained unfinished.

Across the river, enemy rear guards watched from beyond the red cliff. War had withdrawn one ridge, not ended.

Pell entered the bearing in Maela's witness book: one degree; three kinds of skilled labor and public naming visibly present; costs uncertain; Kharza Olt injured at the left tusk; rain released westward; eastern effects not yet measured.

Kharza made her add the defenders' orderly escape and the coalition dead before any line called the action victory.

Her cracked tusk throbbed with every drop striking Ember Hinge. Through the pain, the stone carried a changed note. One pitch had shifted. The other remained.

Royal command had not opened the ford. Shared labor had moved it, and the moved stone held.

Part II

Chapter 8 — What the First Hinge Moved

Rain turned Pell's victory ledger into pulp before she finished the heading.

She tore out the wet page, shoved the witness book under her coat, and watched three supply carts slide sideways into yesterday's first trench. Water ran across Ember Ford in new channels, carrying ash, arrows, and ration bowls together. Fighters who had crossed boiling gravel under fire now lost boots to mud.

"Unload before pulling," Pell shouted. "Weight off the high side first. Prisoner crews get rope, not harness."

A Kiln officer pointed at the eastern camp. "They fought us yesterday."

"Today they sink at the same angle."

Seventy-three captured and wounded enemy remained west of the red cliff. Pell would not put ropes around their shoulders like draft animals, not from delicacy but because panicked people pulled badly and remembered humiliation longer than terms. She paired each prisoner crew with a Vennik tackle worker and a coalition witness. The carts came free one grain sack at a time.

Rain had begun as proof and become weather. Varkesh terraces drank it. Ember Ford could not.

The moved channel ate the lower bank during the morning. Udan's ferrymen shifted guide ropes twice. Pell ordered the western stores moved onto the captured earthwork, then discovered its packed ash walls dissolving. Ceramic shields became floor plates. Scorpion timbers became retaining braces. Every object changed allegiance to gravity before it changed allegiance to politics.

By midmorning, Lessa sent for copper.

Before answering, Pell had to keep the ford connected to food. The western road dropped through three ash gullies, all cut deeper by rain. A messenger reported the first culvert gone and the second holding a lake behind its stone face. If that face failed, water would take the casualty station and every grain cart below it.

Pell rode a captured mule uphill with twelve tackle workers, twenty prisoners who had volunteered for ration credit, and Mar's reserve shield crew. The first gully had widened into a brown torrent. Half the culvert roof lay downstream. On the far side, two wagons from Varkesh waited with flour under soaked hides.

"We bridge here, it washes out," said Nim's former apprentice Dov, one of Pell's Vennik workers.

"We do not bridge the water," Pell said. "We change where it wants to go."

They cut a spill channel through the softer southern bank. Kiln shields lined its mouth while prisoners and coalition workers shoveled behind them. No ancestry

supplied special understanding of water; Dov read grades, a human road mason found the old drain, and a Mahr potter identified clay firm enough to hold stakes. Pell moved among them with her angle string, correcting depth a finger at a time.

The lake behind the second culvert began to tremble.

“Down tools,” she ordered. “High bank.”

Some workers hesitated, seeing only rain. Pell saw the level line climb a weed stem. She dragged one prisoner by his coat as the stone face burst. Water tore through the road, carrying a dead mule and an entire section of wall. Their half-cut spill channel caught the leading surge and bent it away from the casualty station.

One shield worker lost her footing. Dov threw a rope, but the current pulled her under a root shelf. Pell anchored the line around her own waist and used the mule as the counterweight, walking it backward while others hauled. The woman emerged coughing mud, left knee twisted but alive.

After the surge, the road no longer had two banks suitable for wheels. Pell ordered the flour broken into sling loads and sent people across a rope traverse above the water. Every bag gained two witness marks, one from each side, because broken transport routes invited invisible losses whether thieves or rain took them.

A prisoner named Daret refused his ration credit after the crossing. “Your people fed us this morning. Call the work exchange for dry blankets instead.”

Pell amended the list. “Twenty blankets cost more than twenty ration shares.”

“Then twelve blankets, shared.”

She looked at the soaked crews. “Fourteen. The knee injury receives one alone.”

Daret offered his hand. She shook with her left, the one pulley accidents had left complete.

By the time flour reached camp, the rain had altered more than terrain. Enemy and coalition workers had saved the same road under publicly stated terms. That did not dissolve imprisonment or the battle that produced it. It made the next decision less easy to hide inside those categories.

Only then did Pell reach the overhang where Lessa waited for copper.

Kharza sat beneath the stone overhang with a padded strap securing her jaw. The crack in her left tusk ran pale against darker mineral veining, from near the gum toward the outer curve. Rain vibration reached it through the ground. Each heavy drop made her flinch once, then hold still as if pain could become an order she had issued herself.

Pell put a coil of clean copper strip beside Lessa. “Taken from the enemy signal chest. Entered as medical salvage.”

Kharza tried to speak.

Lessa pressed two fingers against her lips. “Write or glare.”

Kharza took the slate. TOO TIGHT STOPS SONG.

"Good," Lessa said. "You are not singing today."

The medic cleaned blood from the crack with boiled water, packed the base in resin-soaked cloth, and wound copper around the tusk without crossing the fracture's open line. Thin braces ran to a leather jaw cup. The work stabilized sideward movement while leaving the tusk exposed enough for examination.

Pell watched Kharza's hands. They remained still until Lessa tightened the final brace. Then the general's left fist closed.

"Pain measure?" Lessa asked.

Kharza held up seven fingers.

"After poppy?"

Five.

"Then you get more, and someone else chairs the dead count."

Kharza wrote: PELL.

"Vindictive," Pell said.

The casualty station occupied the western ford house. Rain drummed on its tile roof. Coalition companies had sent different counts: some omitted missing people, some counted them as dead, and one enthusiastic clerk counted a fighter twice because he had changed units at the first trench. Pell set three columns on a slate wall: confirmed dead, missing, and wounded unable to travel.

By noon, the first two figures held at thirty-eight confirmed coalition dead and nine missing. Two of yesterday's missing had returned from a downstream sandbar; four wounded had died overnight. Enemy dead recovered west of the red cliff numbered forty-six. Their officers sent a truce clerk with names for prisoner exchange but no eastern casualty figure.

Pell did not invent one.

The truce clerk asked to take all seventy-three prisoners east before names were verified. Pell refused. Six wore no soldier's token, and nine gave home addresses inside Vael Tern rather than Osra's Heartland. Conscription, paid service, compelled road labor, and opportunism had mixed in the same retreat. Returning everyone to the nearest red banner would simplify custody at the expense of people who had not chosen that banner.

She set up three interview tables under open awnings. Prisoners could request exchange, neutral release to a named settlement, or continued holding until a claim could be checked. No promise guaranteed approval. Every answer received a witness from among the captives and one from the coalition.

Daret chose exchange because his unit held his brother's pay bond. A human engineer named Osa asked for neutral release; Osra's officers had taken her surveying crew at the west road and assigned them to trenches. Two Mahr guild

soldiers wanted exchange together and refused to explain whether loyalty or fear drove them. Pell recorded the choice without demanding a confession as its price.

By evening, forty-one names were cleared for exchange, seventeen required inquiry, nine wounded could not travel, and six laborers claimed no military status. Osra's clerk accepted only thirty-eight of the cleared names, alleging three had deserted before the battle. Pell kept those three under ordinary prisoner rations rather than handing them over to likely punishment.

"Your mercy shelters deserters," the clerk said.

"My accounting shelters disputes until evidence arrives."

The exchange crossed at the red cliff in rain, equal numbers moving each way. Coalition families recovered nineteen captured scouts and road workers. Nobody called the transaction reconciliation.

Civilian losses required a separate line. One refugee had drowned during rescue. Three forced laborers died in the works. Nine noncombatants suffered serious burns or arrow wounds. Twenty-nine island refugees reached coalition shelter alive, including the elderly laborer carried in the last loop.

"Your heading says losses," Sorn observed.

"It says people."

"Soldiers expect a battle account."

"Then they can read around the civilians."

A Varkesh courier arrived soaked and laughing. Rain had reached the north terraces before midnight. Cisterns overflowed. Dry channels carried water for the first time in eleven years. Farmers were cutting spillways to prevent young soil from washing downhill. The courier brought three jars: old cistern water, fresh rain, and muddy runoff carrying blue mineral specks.

People crowded the ford house to see them.

Pell placed the jars beside the casualty columns. Benefit and cost belonged on the same table.

A second messenger arrived an hour later from the southeastern trade road. Unlike the first, she did not laugh. She wore Reedwater knot cords over a courier's gray coat and carried a sealed water jar crusted white at the lip.

"North Net relay," she said. "Salt climbed two handspans in the west channels at dawn. Nursery gates closed. Three rice-fish ponds lost."

The room quieted.

"Cause established?" Sevrin asked.

"Timing established. Water readers marked the rise after your hinge moved. No storm tide on the coast."

Pell opened the jar under witness. Its salt measure exceeded ordinary nursery water by six marks. The messenger unrolled a cord record naming sample points,

times, and keepers. Aruk's people had prepared independent measurements before joining Osra, expecting exactly the kind of claim one side might later deny.

"Salt surge," somebody said.

The phrase passed through the room.

Kharza entered under Lessa's arm, copper bright around her left tusk. She read the Reed cord and closed her eyes. When she opened them, she wrote on Pell's slate: OUR MOVEMENT?

Sevrin answered carefully. "Likely connected. Not enough to map the path. Deep Hart pressure carries both highland rain and marsh tide force."

Sorn looked at the cheering courier from Varkesh. "So the rain cost three ponds."

"It may cost more," the Reed messenger said. "Or recede. Aruk Venn demands the full bearing record."

"He fights for Osra," Mar Olt said.

"He still has villages."

That ended the easy dismissal.

Before the salt report, three kiln scribes had begun composing a victory broadside. Their draft named Kharza sole opener of Ember Hinge, claimed Osra's vanguard destroyed, and described rain as Varkesh's restored inheritance. Pell found them sheltering under a scorpion awning with forty copies drying on boards.

She took the first sheet. "No."

The oldest scribe bristled. "The hearths need courage."

"They need roads that still exist." Pell pointed to the claims. "Vanguard withdrew. It was not destroyed. Kharza did not act alone. Rain moved with marsh salt. Thirty-eight of ours are dead."

"We can issue losses later."

"Later lets triumph become memory and costs become correction."

"Osra will publish her own lie before our caution crosses one hill."

"Then we should outrun it with facts, not a more attractive lie."

The scribes appealed to Kharza. She read the broadside with her jaw strapped, took the charcoal, and crossed out her own title. Beneath it she wrote the names of Pell, Sevrin, Esha, Mar, Sorn, Udan, Lessa, the tackle crews, and the island witnesses. Then she added Reedwater's salt measure.

The revised sheet no longer fit on one side.

Pell ordered copies posted at Varkesh, the ford, and every road station willing to host one. A separate sheet listed unknowns: eastern bank casualties, full salt reach, rain duration, road stability, and whether Ember Hinge could be moved again without worsening pressure. Uncertainty received space rather than being

left to rumor.

The coalition council met that afternoon inside the captured engineer tent. It had no settled membership. Kharza represented the hearth bond but could barely speak. Sevrin represented only himself and his evidence, not Rootglass. Pell carried Maela's writ and no authority to pledge Vael. Varkesh houses, terrace refugees, former Crown soldiers, ferrymen, medics, and prisoners each claimed some standing. Esha proposed that anyone bearing a recorded cost could speak, while decisions about movement required the four labor groups present.

"Temporary rule," Pell said. "Entered as temporary."

"Everything becomes ancient if a clerk forgets the date," Esha agreed.

Their first question concerned pursuit. Osra's vanguard had retreated toward the Hollow Salt road, destroying two culverts but leaving the red cliff passable. Scouts reported a larger force could return in four days. Holding Ember Ford indefinitely would protect Varkesh and accomplish nothing about the fixed sky.

Sevrin laid a copied map beside the sample comb. "Salt Hinge lies below Hollow Salt. Rootglass records show tide pressure crossing that region. If Ember's movement displaced force east, Salt Hinge may offer a way to measure where it gathered."

"Or moving it doubles the damage," said Udan.

"Yes."

Mar wanted to fortify the ford and wait for Maela. Sorn argued Vael Tern might already be under siege. The Reed messenger demanded no further hinge work until Aruk's water readers received a voice. Varkesh farmers wanted the rain protected before it ran off.

Pell reduced each position to capacities. The coalition could leave three hundred fighters at the ford under Mar, enough to deny a quick return if trenches were rebuilt. Captured stores supported a mobile column for six days. Refugee carts provided transport but not without consent and payment. Sevrin's comb could survive the Hollow Salt road for perhaps ten more days. Kharza required rest and a better brace before any resonance work.

Lessa interrupted. "She requires weeks."

Kharza wrote: WE HAVE DAYS.

"You having fewer days does not grow new tusk."

The council accepted Lessa's medical stop over Kharza's objection. Any Salt Hinge plan would need other Mahr fault-readers, not one injured general treated as an inexhaustible tool.

That decision changed the campaign. Kharza no longer supplied every load herself.

Pell drafted five commitments on a sheet large enough for everyone to see. First, publish measured benefits and injuries together. Second, no region's gain

could erase another region's loss. Third, no hinge movement without locally affected witnesses and all four known labor capacities. Fourth, stop if new measurements exceeded declared limits. Fifth, share original records, not only favorable summaries.

A former Crown officer asked, "Who enforces this?"

"Everyone keeping a copy," Pell said.

"That is not enforcement."

"It is the beginning of evidence. Armies have begun with less."

They voted by named groups rather than one undifferentiated crowd. The decision passed to pursue the Hollow Salt route and seek Salt Hinge, while sending warning messengers to Rootglass, Reedwater, Vael Tern, and every settlement along the projected pressure path. Mar's ford garrison received refusal authority if the mobile column attempted to requisition its stores without account.

No one called the coalition permanent.

At sunset, Aruk's truce party reached the red cliff. He had remained with Osra's larger march and sent Sal Marrow plus two Reed water readers. Pell met them at the line with the original rain and salt records, Esha's witness entry, a copy of the revised broadside, and a sealed shaving of the dark pollen wax.

Sal read the papers beneath an oilcloth. "Aruk asked whether Osra knew the fixed pressure had already reached Reedwater before this battle."

"We cannot answer what she knew," Pell said. "We can show her surveyor blamed Varkesh before timing existed. We can show the nursery fish turned west before Ember moved. We can show today's surge came after."

"So proof of concealment, not proof she caused the surge."

"Correct."

Sal appreciated precision. "He will remain under treaty. The autonomy cords still bind his vote."

Kharza stood a few paces back, rain ticking against her copper wrap. She did not ask Aruk to defect. Instead, she gave Sal a slate message: YOUR WATER READERS MAY INSPECT EMBER HINGE UNDER TRUCE. BRING THEIR OWN MEASURES.

Sal accepted it. "He may answer with soldiers."

Kharza wrote: THEN THEY STOP AT RED CLIFF.

The Reed party departed with proof that Osra's officials had dismissed pressure already troubling the marsh, and with proof that Kharza's victory had harmed it further. Neither side received moral simplicity.

Night settled over a flooded camp. Pell moved the witness book to a waxed chest and posted duplicate cost sheets under three separate roofs. Rain continued west. Salt continued east. The road toward Hollow Salt had washed out in two places before the coalition took its first step.

She assigned one courier to each copy rather than trusting a single heroic rider. One went toward Varkesh, one toward the marsh relay, and one south around Osra's patrols for Vael Tern. If any message vanished, the surviving versions would show both what had been learned and who had benefited from silence.

Pell entered the campaign's new destination beneath the casualty count: Salt Hinge, by way of Sul Venn, with costs published before claims of victory.

Chapter 9 — The City of Capped Tusks

Sul Venn's gate clerk refused Kharza entry because her copper wrap had no civic color.

Rain ran from the brim of his blue felt hat. Behind him, the city climbed a salt-white hill in close tiers of brick, canvas, kiln tile, and carved shellstone. Nearly every Mahr adult passing through the arch wore tusk caps. Blue glass marked water guilds. Green ceramic marked advocates. Black iron marked people who declined guild arbitration. Children wore paint until their tusks finished growing. No single custom explained the city, which appeared to be the custom's purpose.

Kharza touched the brace around her cracked left tusk. "It is medical."

"Medical copper takes a white cord inside Sul Venn," the clerk said. "Uncorded metal signifies an unsworn signal cap. Those are permitted, but you register the resonance it conceals."

"It conceals pain."

"Then white cord."

Lessa stepped forward with visible impatience. "If your cord catches the fracture, she bleeds into the street."

The clerk examined the wrap without touching. "Tie at the jaw cup. Three loops, loose enough for two fingers."

He supplied the cord himself.

Kharza submitted because independent law became meaningless if obeyed only when convenient. Around her, coalition fighters queued by household and profession rather than following her through as a general's body. Sul Venn admitted three hundred travelers under temporary passage, kept the rest in a rain camp outside the north wall, and forbade weapons longer than a forearm in the market tiers.

Mar Olt objected. "Osra's agents entered yesterday with swords."

"They entered through the east military yard under diplomatic bond," the clerk said. "You may use that yard if you accept the same hostage terms."

Kharza asked, "What hostage terms?"

"Two senior officers remain under city comfort until every weapon leaves."

Mar preferred the rain camp.

Inside, stone-song changed beneath Kharza's feet. Sul Venn stood over capped wells drilled into the Hollow Salt shelf. Thousands of small resonances entered the streets through metal, glass, and ceramic tusk coverings. Some damped vibration. Others filtered it by pitch. The result resembled a city speaking through closed doors, each resident deciding what to hear.

A human baker argued prices with a Salt Aeli carter under striped awnings. Vennik pulley houses operated freight lifts between tiers. Mahr veterans sold cap fittings beside apprentices who had never served any army. Shrine keepers maintained public silence courts where caps came off by consent. Kharza's childhood elders had called Sul Venn rootless because no ancestor kiln governed it. The city had roots. They simply crossed.

Pell found lodging in a caravan court whose floor drains still worked. Sevrin carried the comb remnant to a cool cellar. Lessa took Kharza to a capwright licensed for medical metal.

The capwright, Yara Sen, wore one tusk bare and one enclosed in red porcelain. She unwound the rain-dark copper strip, inspected the crack through a lens, and clicked her tongue.

"Battle wrapping. Effective for getting off a battlefield. Bad for sleeping."

"Can you make it bear song?" Kharza asked.

"No."

"Can anyone?"

"Anyone promising that wants your title more than your health." Yara fitted narrow copper bridges on either side of the fracture and secured them to the jaw cup. "Resonance enters the crack. Copper spreads some vibration, not damage. If you sing hard again, this may split through the gum."

Kharza held still while Yara tied the required white cord. Pain moved with each knot.

A voice behind her said, "She always asks whether the weapon can return to service before asking what remains of the body."

Kharza knew the voice.

Doru Ash stood in the workshop doorway. Eleven years ago he had commanded a valley company under her. Now gray touched his scalp and both tusks wore matte black caps. His right leg ended below the knee in a saltwood brace.

"Doru," she said.

"General."

The title carried no honor.

He had not been at Ashwall. He had been at Nar Pass, where Kharza centralized five local companies under one field plan and ordered a night advance before valley guides agreed the snow bridges could bear it. The assault took the pass. A shelf collapse took sixty-three soldiers and two shepherd households below.

"I did not know you lived here," she said.

"You did not ask where we went after discharge."

Yara left them the workshop without pretending work needed her elsewhere.

Doru looked at the copper bridges. "I hear you saved terrace people."

"Yes."

"And opened Ember Hinge."

"With others."

"Already correcting the song."

"I am trying to correct the record."

"Records did not carry my company down Nar Pass."

"No."

He waited for an explanation. Kharza had given him one after the collapse: scouts reported Crown cavalry behind them, delay risked encirclement, the pass secured the western flank. Every statement had been true. Truth arranged around command could still hide the person who chose.

"I overruled your valley guides," she said. "I moved the companies before the snow test finished. I counted the pass as decisive and treated local refusals as delay. The dead belong in my victory account."

Doru's jaw shifted under black caps. "Do they belong to you?"

Kharza understood the trap. Guilt could centralize the dead as completely as glory.

"No. Their names belong to their households. The decision belongs in my account."

"Better." He did not say enough. "Treaty court sits at second bell. Half the veterans' gallery wants you expelled. The other half wants your army to buy winter lodging."

"I am asking passage, not troops."

"Then say that before your followers begin calling our streets a route."

Sul Venn's treaty court occupied an open cistern whose water had receded years earlier. Galleries descended toward a tiled basin. Advocates in green caps sat at four tables. No throne or senior bench stood at the bottom. Petitioners occupied the lowest point, where every gallery could look down on them.

Kharza entered with Pell, Sevrin, Esha, a Varkesh hearth delegate, two refugee witnesses, and the Reedwater salt record. Osra's delegation already waited opposite. Councillor Bel Dane had exchanged his marsh boots for polished city shoes. Beside him stood a Mahr officer from Tern's urban guilds and three Sul Venn merchants seeking restored royal contracts.

The chief advocate struck a glass rod against the basin. "Petition: transit through South Hollow Gate onto the protected salt route. Petitioners will state benefit, named cost, bearer of cost, and remedy offered. A benefit without a loser named enters as advertisement and receives no judgment."

Pell whispered, "I like them."

Bel Dane presented first. Osra offered amnesty to all Sul Venn citizens who had

supplied Kharza before the battle, recognition of city tolls, and military protection for the Hollow Salt caravans. In return, Sul Venn would deny coalition transit and allow a Crown observation post at South Hollow Gate.

The chief advocate asked, "Benefit?"

"Trade continuity and freedom from prosecution."

"Named cost?"

"Temporary restriction on one armed column."

"Bearer?"

"Kharza Olt's coalition."

"Your post occupies gate land."

Bel glanced at his clerk. "The city bears limited land use."

"Your protection draws retaliation."

"The city may bear increased military attention."

"Your amnesty presumes an offense."

Silence caught him.

A green-capped advocate said, "Name who loses legal standing by accepting forgiveness for an act our law did not prohibit."

Bel attempted to describe jurisdictional uncertainty. The glass rod struck once.

"Advertisement," the chief advocate said. "Revise before judgment."

Kharza's turn came.

Pell read the measured facts from Ember Ford: rain in Varkesh, salt rise in Reedwater, known dead, unknown eastern effects, road damage, one controlled degree of movement. Sevrin described why Salt Hinge might reveal the displaced pressure path and why further movement might worsen it. Esha read the coalition's temporary commitments.

The chief advocate looked at Kharza. "Benefit sought?"

"Access to Hollow Salt and records concerning Salt Hinge. A chance to measure pressure and prevent greater structural failure."

"What costs are named?"

"Our armed passage consumes road capacity, food, water, and city attention. It may draw Osra's vanguard. Any future hinge work may shift harm toward regions we have not yet measured."

"Bearer?"

"Sul Venn households along the route, independent caravans delayed by us, settlements near Hollow Salt, Reedwater if salt pressure increases, and our own wounded."

"Remedy?"

“Pay tolls at published rate. Limit armed transit to three hundred at a time. Buy supplies without requisition. Accept Sul Venn observers with stop authority over city roads. Publish all measurements. No promise beyond our capacity.”

A merchant in the gallery called, “You forgot the veterans who must watch you command again.”

The chief advocate let the interruption stand. “Add or dispute.”

Kharza looked toward Doru and the black-capped gallery. “Add the political cost of legitimizing my command after Nar Pass and the War of Three Valleys.”

Bel Dane rose. “The Queen-Regent offers the general personal amnesty for every disputed campaign action if she dissolves her force and submits the Ember record. No city must bear that history.”

The offer struck exactly where he intended. Osra could absorb Kharza’s guilt into royal pardon, making Crown authority the solution to violence conducted under Crown authority.

Mar Olt shouted from the gallery, “She needs no human pardon.”

Doru answered, “The dead need more than Mahr pride.”

Voices rose around the cistern.

The glass rod rang twice. “General Olt will answer.”

Kharza faced Bel. “Does amnesty restore Nar Pass households?”

“No legal act can.”

“Does it publish Osra’s orders to centralize the valley companies?”

“The campaign archive can be reviewed under Crown seal.”

“By whom?”

“Authorized court officers.”

“So the Crown pardons the conduct, keeps the records, and decides who may read the bargain.”

Bel spread his hands. “It ends grievance as a weapon against present necessity.”

“No. It ends my exposure while preserving hers.”

Kharza turned to the galleries. Her left tusk throbbed under copper and white cord. “I accepted central command because it made victory faster. I continued using it when local commanders named costs my plan did not carry. At Nar Pass, Doru Ash’s guides refused the snow shelf. I overruled them. We took the pass. Sixty-three soldiers and two shepherd households died in the collapse. Osra praised the decision. I accepted praise and kept command.”

No one moved.

“In the south valley, I guarded wells for Crown columns and sent families to the next spring. A child died on that road. At Ashwall, I broke a seal and saved people.

One act does not purchase the others away. I refuse Osra's amnesty because she has no right to close accounts held by those who paid them."

Doru removed his right black cap.

The gesture exposed pale mineral veining, not forgiveness. Other veterans kept theirs on.

Bel said, "Confession does not make your march safe."

"Correct." Kharza faced the advocates again. "That is why Sul Venn's observers may stop our use of Sul Venn roads. They may not command our military choices elsewhere. We ask passage under conditions, not loyalty in either direction."

The court recessed for public questions.

For two hours, Kharza answered people who had served under her, profited from royal road security, lost trade to Osra's patrols, or feared another hinge movement. A Vennik freight master demanded compensation if coalition carts displaced salt cargo. Pell proposed alternating road windows and posted axle weights. A Salt Aeli navigator asked whether Sevrin spoke for Rootglass. He said no. A human widow from Nar Pass asked Kharza for her husband's last order. Kharza remembered the company but not the man's final moments. She refused to invent dignity for him.

Outside the cistern, rainwater entered street drains and flowed toward capped wells. Yara Sen checked Kharza's wrap during recess. "Your gum is bleeding."

The recess also exposed what the formal petition had missed. A line of market porters waited under the cistern awning with tally boards. Their representative, a young Mahr woman wearing one blue-glass cap and one bare tusk, showed how three hundred armed travelers would occupy every licensed lodging court near South Hollow Gate. Caravan crews arriving behind them would sleep outside the walls or pay double on upper tiers.

"You named road capacity," she said. "Not room capacity."

Kharza looked toward Pell.

"My omission," Pell said. "We counted carts and meals, not beds."

The porter shook her head. "Your army omits it. My back carries the correction."

They revised the petition before judgment. Coalition companies would camp outside after each road segment unless storm warnings required shelter. Lodging courts reserved half their rooms for ordinary caravans. Fighters paid the same bath and drainage fees as merchants. Sul Venn households could refuse billets without losing supply contracts.

A second group brought a harder claim. Capwright apprentices expected military demand for copper and iron to raise medical fitting prices. Kharza's visible brace had already sent three wounded veterans to Yara's workshop asking whether they too needed reinforcement.

"Do they?" Kharza asked Yara.

“Two need examination. One needs someone to stop selling fear.”

Pell proposed a ceiling on coalition purchases. Yara rejected it because fixed prices could empty shops. The capwright guild instead required separate medical and military inventories, with coalition armor metal bought only after local repair quotas had been filled. Kharza accepted the delay even though replacement shield ties mattered on the salt road.

Doru watched the amendments enter. “You would not have paused a valley column for lodging or cap prices.”

“No.”

“What changed?”

“People here can stop the road.”

“So virtue followed leverage.”

“At first. Practice may teach it to arrive earlier.”

He considered that answer longer than a promise of personal transformation. Sul Venn did not require Kharza to become pure before using its streets. It required institutions strong enough to limit her while she remained capable of old habits.

“I have not sung.”

“You have spoken for two hours. Bodies do not respect the distinction between military and political strain.”

She tightened the jaw cup and ordered Kharza to answer the remaining questions seated.

Osra’s Mahr officer approached while Yara worked. He had withdrawn from the second earthwork at Ember Ford. “You kept the red-cliff limit,” he said.

“Yes.”

“Bel’s draft report says weather forced our retreat.”

“Rain contributed.”

“He omits your pursuit order.”

“Then enter your own witness.”

“If I do, Osra calls it enemy aid.”

Kharza pointed toward the open cistern. “Sul Venn protects testimony under treaty court.”

The officer looked at the watching advocates. Before the recess ended, he submitted a sealed statement confirming coalition restraint and his company’s negotiated withdrawal. He did not change sides.

At sunset, colored lamps appeared around the basin. Sul Venn rendered judgment in four parts.

Osra’s amnesty offer failed because it imposed a legal debt on city acts not previously criminal and concealed the archive determining the pardon. Her

protection post failed because the delegation had not named civilian retaliation as a bearer cost. Toll recognition remained acceptable but supplied no reason to exclude other petitioners.

Kharza's coalition received conditional passage through South Hollow Gate and the Hollow Salt route. Only three hundred armed travelers could enter each road section at once. City markets set transparent prices. No requisition applied. Sul Venn would send nine observers: three road assessors, two water readers, two treaty advocates, one veteran selected by the black-cap gallery, and one rotating caravan witness. Any three could stop transit on city-maintained sections for an unrecorded cost or breached weight limit.

Sul Venn sent no troops.

The distinction disappointed Mar and relieved half the gallery. Kharza accepted it publicly.

Doru received the veterans' observer place. "I am not joining your command," he told her.

"You should not."

"I may stop your road."

"If the condition applies."

"I will decide whether it applies."

"With two others."

His mouth moved near a smile. "Still listening for the edge of your authority."

"Yes."

At South Hollow Gate on Day twelve, the city lifted three white bars from the road. Beyond lay a descending shelf of salt stone, pale under evening cloud. Farther south, the earth opened into the Hollow Salt desert and the buried route toward its hinge.

Coalition companies passed in groups under public axle limits. Merchants kept alternate road windows. Pell posted payment copies at both gates. Sevrin's comb traveled in a city-inspected cool box. Lessa rode beside Kharza to enforce rest. Doru and eight observers wore Sul Venn gray, no coalition insignia.

At the first checkpoint, Doru stopped Mar's weapons cart for exceeding its declared weight by two spear bundles. Mar argued the excess meant little on dry stone. A road assessor pointed to a hairline crack along the culvert lip. The spears came off and traveled by hand. Kharza did not intervene. Conditional passage became real at the first inconvenience.

Bel Dane watched from the east wall with Osra's rejected amnesty rolled under his arm.

Kharza crossed the gate without a cheer. Sul Venn had opened a road, not offered absolution. Its observers followed because every promised benefit required

a named cost, and because confession without enforceable limits would merely give old command a humbler voice.

Behind them, the city closed its military yard to both armies. Ahead, Hollow Salt received the coalition under conditions neither Kharza nor Osra controlled alone.

Chapter 10 — Down the Hollow Stair

The courier reached Maela while six soldiers were carrying the west granary door off its hinges.

He came through the drizzle with salt dried white across his boots and Pell Vask's oilskin tube tied under his coat. Behind him, Vael Tern's lower market moved uphill by handcart: sacks of rye, lamp crocks, dismantled millstones, three cages of indignant geese. The western farms had burned their surplus rather than leave it to Osra's cavalry. Every useful room inside the second wall now had to become a storehouse, an infirmary, or a place to sleep.

Maela broke Pell's wax with her thumbnail. The message named the dead at Ember Ford, the rain over Varkesh, and the salt surge advancing through Reedwater. Pell had put the costs before the victory. That made the account easier to trust and harder to celebrate.

At the foot of the page she had drawn a route: Sul Venn, Hollow Salt, Salt Hinge. Beside it stood a request in her compressed quartermaster's hand.

Find what the crown buried below its own stairs. Send copies by separate roads.

"Marshal?" Jorren asked.

Maela watched masons fit raw plank over the granary doorway. Beyond the western roofs, signal smoke marked three more of Osra's companies crossing the Wheatwater. By tomorrow they could close the road. By the day after, a courier might need a boat or a grave.

"Put the royal stores under ward captains," she said. "No palace clerk may countermand them without my signature. Tell the council I am inspecting the lower foundations."

Jorren glanced at the tube. Rain tracked down the old scar beside his mouth. "Are you?"

"No. I am inspecting a lie."

They entered the citadel through a postern crowded with flour porters. Maela took only Jorren and two hinge engineers, Dasa Mor and young Fenn Cor. Four people could descend quietly. More would turn secrecy into rumor before she had anything worth spreading.

The Hollow Stair began behind the dead king's map room. A bronze door filled the inner wall, plain except for four shallow handprints worn almost smooth. Maela had passed it every week for six years. Ordan had called the lower chambers ceremonial storage and told her the keys had been lost during his grandfather's reign.

No keyhole marked the bronze.

She pressed the royal bearing seal into a depression concealed inside the lowest

handprint. The seal warmed against her palm. Lines of dull green light traveled through the door, not decoration but pressure paths, each bending toward the other three handprints. Stone shifted somewhere below with a sound too large for the narrow room.

The bronze opened a finger's width and stopped.

Fenn set his shoulder against it. Dasa caught his belt before the pressure could pitch him into the gap.

"Not swollen," Dasa said. She crouched and slid a bone gauge beneath the door. "The lower jamb has climbed half an inch."

"Stone does not climb," Jorren said.

"Ashwall did," Maela answered.

They rigged a screw jack from the map room's shutter bar and two chair legs. The work lacked dignity and preserved their fingers. As Dasa turned the screw, the bronze gave in short complaints. Warm air escaped from below carrying salt, old paper, and a faint mineral sting that set Maela's teeth aching.

The gap widened enough for them to pass sideways. Maela went first.

Steps curved down around a shaft whose bottom their lamps could not find. Every ninth tread bore a different mark: a tusk pressed into clay, a branching leaf, a Vennik house knot, seven river strokes. Later masons had chiseled crowns across them. The cuts had not erased the older signs. They had merely made every landing look wounded.

Maela counted doors as she descended. The first opened onto shelves of tax rolls. The second held rusted counterweight chains thick as her wrist. The third had jammed inward, its lintel bowed beneath pressure from the buried sky. Fenn tapped the stone and listened with his cheek near the surface.

"It is carrying load from deeper down," he said. "If the pressure climbs again, this stair could shear away from the shaft."

"How long?"

He looked offended by the question because stone did not keep campaign hours. "Until it doesn't."

That answer belonged in every fortress manual ever written.

They descended faster. At the thirty-fourth landing they found fresh lamp smoke on the ceiling.

Jorren drew his sword. Maela raised one hand, listening. A pen scratched beyond a cedar door. Someone coughed, muttered about margins, and moved a stool.

She knocked.

"Unless the upper city has fallen," a man's voice called, "you may wait until I finish this line."

"The upper city is preparing to be surrounded."

The pen stopped.

Brother Caldryn opened the door with ink on three fingers and a salt-gray beard tucked into his belt. He wore no order's badge. His room held a cot, a brazier, six water jars, and stacks of clay rubbings tied with blue thread. A narrow passage continued behind him into darkness.

Caldryn looked at the bearing seal in Maela's hand. His expression held no reverence. "So Ordan died."

"You knew?"

"I knew he would never come down here while breathing." Caldryn stepped aside. "His father appointed me guardian of records he did not wish to read. His son made the appointment permanent by forgetting me."

Dasa stared at the water jars. "You live here?"

"I work here. Living requires better air."

Maela entered. On the desk lay a clay tablet impressed with columns in four scripts. A royal copy rested beside it. Someone had scraped whole lines from the newer clay before firing.

Pell's request tightened in her mind. "How many?"

"Compact tablets? Nine complete, fourteen fragments, and three royal revisions pretending to precede their own source." Caldryn folded a damp cloth over the tablet. "You have no right to them."

"I have the seal."

"That opens a door. Rights require witnesses."

The words struck with the force of a formal challenge. Maela could have arrested him. She could have ordered Jorren to search the room and invoked emergency custody. Every excluded petitioner she had turned away from Crown Hinge had heard some polished version of those powers.

"Then witness this," she said. "Osra Dane is closing a siege ring around seventy thousand people. Another coalition has moved Ember Hinge without royal command. The movement brought rain to Varkesh and salt into Reedwater. They are going to Salt Hinge because the buried pressure will not wait for our laws. I need to know whom those laws erased."

Caldryn studied her as if comparing a damaged copy against an original. "Need has excused most erasures."

He drew a folded list from beneath the damp cloth. It named petitions Maela remembered refusing: a Mahr hearth council seeking access after a mine collapse, Salt Aeli navigators asking to compare tide bearings, a Vennik house offering to weigh the Crown Hinge chains. Beside each petition a palace clerk had written competence acknowledged; standing denied. Maela recognized her own signature on two.

"Those decisions protected a dangerous chamber during unrest," she said, and heard how readily the old defense arrived.

"Did danger make their measurements false?"

"No."

"Did your signature make the pressure smaller?"

"No." The second answer cost more. She took the list without hiding the names beneath her hand. "Put this among the copies. If I ask strangers to trust my warning, they should know what I helped refuse."

Dasa made another rubbing while Caldryn watched Maela rather than the page. The stair groaned below them, carrying the buried sky's answer through every royal alteration.

"What would satisfy you?"

"Copies sent beyond your control. The originals carried to the old court under Hollow Salt. Your seal stays with you."

Jorren shifted by the door. "Taking the originals toward two armies is not safekeeping."

"Leaving them under a dynasty that denied their existence has not served."

A low concussion rolled through the shaft. Dust sifted from the ceiling. One water jar clicked against another.

Fenn hurried into the passage and returned pale. "The third landing has shifted again. We should leave."

Caldryn reached for his lamp. "Then help me pack."

Beyond his chamber, the archive narrowed into a rock-cut vault. Nine dark tablets stood upright in felted cradles, each as long as Maela's forearm and twice as heavy. Their surfaces held columns divided by lines that crossed rather than ranked one another. She recognized court Ternic along one edge. The other marks belonged to peoples royal charters usually named only as labor suppliers.

She did not ask Caldryn to translate. A hurried answer would become a weapon before it became knowledge.

They wrapped the Compact tablets in felt, then fitted them into two saltwood cases. Dasa took rubbings while Maela copied the visible Ternic lines onto thin dispatch paper. Some clauses concerned witness counts and mapped losses. Others referred to bearers without granting the crown first place. One scraped passage on the royal version remained whole on the older clay, but the script used an archaic legal hand she could not confidently parse.

"Who taught you to preserve these?" Maela asked.

"A Salt Aeli jurist whose name the palace catalogue records as a cleaning expense. A Mahr mason who entered by the load shaft. Two Vennik copyists paid to falsify weights and determined to leave honest numbers somewhere." Caldryn

tied the first case shut. "Guardianship has always looked less orderly from below."

Another tremor struck. The lamp flames leaned toward the shaft. From above came the grind of bronze forced against stone.

"The outer door is moving," Dasa said.

Maela divided her copies into six packets. One for Pell by the Hollow Salt courier road. One for Sul Venn's public treaty hall. One for the Neris coast. One for the Reed Confederacy, despite Aruk's alliance with Osra. One for the Vael council. The last she put inside her coat.

"Jorren, take Caldryn and the cases to the salt drain."

He frowned. "The salt drain exits beyond the southern vineyards."

"Which remain open for perhaps three hours. Choose six scouts, no uniforms. Get him onto the Hollow Stair caravan route."

Caldryn tightened his beard knot. "I need no escort."

"You need people who know which bridges still exist." Maela handed him the packet for Pell. "Give Quartermaster Vask the originals only in a witnessed place. Keep one case with you if the company divides."

"And you?"

"I go up."

The archivist's gaze went to the royal bearing seal. "To defend the right that kept you out of this room?"

"To defend the people above it. The right can answer for itself when they are no longer under siege."

They climbed together as far as the landing with the counterweight chains. There the shaft divided: the main stair curled toward the citadel, while a low service tunnel descended toward the old salt drains. Jorren shouldered one case. Fenn took the other despite his engineer's soft hands. Caldryn carried the rubbing satchel beneath his coat.

Maela wanted to give Jorren an order that would guarantee his return. Six years of command had taught her how often such orders merely disguised prayer.

"Three days," she said. "If the southern road closes, do not try to come back through it."

"I know what a ring looks like, Marshal."

"So do I. That is why I dislike finding you on its wrong side."

He gave her the brief smile of a scout already measuring distance. Then he followed Caldryn down into the dark.

Maela climbed with Dasa. They squeezed through the bronze door moments before the lower jamb rose again. The screw jack split, flinging one chair leg across the map room. Bronze struck bronze behind them and sealed the Hollow Stair without waiting for the royal seal.

Outside, bells sounded from the western tower. Not alarm. Withdrawal.

Maela ran to the battlement. Across the Wheatwater, Osra's cavalry had reached the north road. Engineers drove stakes for the first siege earthworks while infantry columns extended south through the harvested fields. The ring lacked less than a mile.

At the granary, ward captains were already issuing rye by household rather than rank. Maela handed the Neris packet to the salt-stained courier and the Sul Venn copy to a fishwife whose boat would leave by the eastern culvert. She sent the Reedwater packet with a marsh trader who spat at the royal wax before hiding it under her tunic.

Six copies departed by six routes. None carried enough to command a hinge. Together they carried enough to make concealment harder.

On the southern road, three riders emerged from the vineyard mist around a low cart. Caldryn sat beside the cases, his lamp extinguished at last. Jorren looked back once toward the wall, then led them down the Hollow Salt road before Osra's final companies closed it.

Maela fastened the royal bearing seal beneath her cuirass and resumed command of the surface. By sunset Vael Tern stood encircled, but the old originals had passed beyond the crown's reach.

Chapter 11 — The Compact Under Salt

Pell knew the old bearing court had been built by Vennik before she saw a single house knot.

The entrance tried to kill anyone taller than a loaded mule.

Kharza struck her brow on the lintel despite three warnings. Sevrin folded himself through with the careful resentment of a man entering somebody else's practical joke. Pell ducked, stepped over the drainage groove, and found the foothold cut where a short mason carrying forty pounds would need it.

"An ancestor had standards," she said.

"An ancestor had enemies with horns," Kharza muttered, touching the copper wrap on her cracked left tusk.

Beyond the entrance, the passage opened into a chamber beneath Hollow Salt. Four banks of seats descended toward a floor of black stone. Salt crystals coated the walls in pale fans, but the benches remained dry. Grooves converged at the center around a circular bearing table. Every groove had once held colored clay. Someone had gouged out three colors and left the royal blue.

Caldrin waited beside two saltwood cases. His escort looked exhausted enough to sleep standing. Jorren Taal clasped Pell's wrist, gave her Maela's sealed copy, and accepted a canteen before beginning the return journey to Vael Tern. He had less than a day to reach a culvert before Osra's patrols learned it existed.

"Tell her the rye count is still a lie if the ward captains don't weigh the sacks themselves," Pell said.

"She will be delighted by the affection in your message."

"Affection is expensive. That advice is free."

Jorren left with Fenn and four scouts. Caldrin watched them vanish into the passage before he opened either case.

Sul Venn had sent three observers: Ral Olt, a capped-tusk ceramicist who had fought against Kharza in the Three Valleys; Tei Vask, no relation Pell could prove within four generations; and Saan Rel, a Salt Aeli navigator with her leaf-filaments shaved close. They stood in separate seating banks by choice. The coalition's own witnesses filled the fourth: Lessa with her medical roll, Vennik haulers, two refugee delegates, and captains from the ford.

Pell counted thirty-one people, four exits, seven lamps, two suspect ceiling seams, and one archive that could alter a war if nobody dropped it.

Caldrin laid the first of the Compact tablets on the bearing table.

"This court predates the Tern dynasty by three centuries," he said. "It was repaired after the Inversion and used during the first lawful exchanges. The language crosses four scripts because no translation held priority."

"Then give us all four," Kharza said.

"I intend to. It will take hours."

"Osra's outriders were half a day behind me," Caldryn's scout said. "You have fewer."

Pell took the royal copy from Maela's packet and set it beside the original clay. "Then begin with what somebody scraped away."

Caldryn's mouth tightened in approval. He dampened a square of charcoal paper, pressed it over the oldest tablet, and rolled a felt cylinder across the impressions. Raised characters appeared in black. Tei read the Vennik column. Ral sounded out old Mahr court marks. Saan translated the Aeli branching script. Caldryn supplied river Ternic.

The four readings did not match word for word. They matched in structure.

Each hinge required four equal traditions of bearing: stress heard in stone, celestial pollen carried by living colonies, loads divided through measured counterweights, and consequences witnessed by those who would endure them. No king appeared in the subject of the clause. No ancestry received permanent command. The older language treated each people as a practice, not a blood destiny; a trained bearer could serve across traditions, but no ruler could merge all authority into one office.

Kharza bent over the Mahr column. "This mark means hearths, plural. Not Mahr as a single nation."

Ral's silver-capped tusks flashed when he turned. "Convenient to remember plurality after you commanded three valleys as one field."

"It would be more convenient to forget."

Pell put one missing finger against the clay margin. "Argue after we know what we are arguing over."

They continued.

A second tablet carried a cost map. Not a painted territory chart, as Pell had expected, but a ledger of gains and losses linked to bearing marks. One degree toward the Cinder Net lengthened Heartland grain warmth by eleven days while pushing brine farther into eastern reed beds. A contrary degree restored upland rain at the price of colder Neris currents. Every benefit named the households expected to lose, the stores owed to them, and the point at which witnesses could halt further movement.

Sul Venn's treaty custom had preserved a piece of this law. Every promised gain required a named cost because the first bearers had understood that weather could only travel, never multiply.

The following lines described payment before motion, not afterward. Grain moved to the coast before a colder current reduced fishing. Reed cuttings moved inland before brine entered nursery channels. The court appointed counters from

communities receiving the benefit and communities bearing the loss, and either set could demand a new weighing when stores failed to arrive. Pell read the columns twice. No king had been trusted to compensate his own advantage from memory.

Tei tapped a sequence of house knots. "These weights are indexed to households, not provinces."

"Because provinces do not go hungry," said the refugee delegate from Ashwall. "People do."

One of Kharza's captains objected that no army could wait for every village to approve weather. Saan answered that the Compact required representation and thresholds, not unanimity. Ral pointed to an emergency clause permitting temporary movement when a hinge threatened immediate collapse, provided the bearers published the debt and stopped at the first stable bearing.

Pell thought of Ember Ford. They had met the danger and ignored the debt until rain and salt forced it into view. "We used the emergency power without knowing its terms."

"We saved people," Kharza said.

"Yes. We also spent Reedwater's fields without asking. Both statements fit in one ledger."

The general's copper-wrapped tusk twitched against pain. "Then what do we owe?"

Pell began a list on fresh paper: freshwater carts, seed reeds, salt physicians, ferry priority for displaced marsh households. The coalition did not have enough of any item. Naming the deficit did not fill it, but it kept victory from consuming the evidence of who had paid.

Caldrin turned the tablet to its final register. A series of witness marks had been pressed by fingers, tusks, filament combs, and weighted cords. Not decoration. Receipts.

"Copy every mark," Pell told Tei. "If descendants can be charged for an old command, they can also inherit proof that consent once existed."

Kharza looked at Pell. "Ember Ford."

"The rain and the salt surge fit this table." Pell followed the old columns with a charcoal nub. "Not perfectly. Pressure has accumulated for ninety-six years. But close enough to prove the movement transferred load rather than releasing it."

Sevrin had gone still across the table.

His leaf-filaments caught the lamplight in copper-green threads. He touched a line in the coastal column without speaking.

Pell marked the gesture and kept listening.

The royal revisions began two reigns after the First Compact. Their clay looked

cleaner. Their language did not. Public witnesses became royal witnesses, then appointed witnesses, then servants of the crown. Compensation tables vanished. The four practices became four labors under one commander. Later copies reduced even that phrase to ceremonial participation.

Caldrin turned the third tablet so a long scraped hollow faced the court. "The palace catalogue calls this damage from salt rot."

"Salt does not use a chisel," Tei said.

"No. Kings employ people for that."

Ral read the surviving Mahr margin aloud. "No bearer shall claim a whole people in the bearing." His gaze moved to Kharza. "You arrived with Kiln troops and a royal command history. Which part of that sentence troubles you?"

"All of it, because you are using it badly." Kharza straightened. Pain tightened her mouth as the copper wrap pulled against the tusk crack. "I can read stress. I can command soldiers who consent to my command. I cannot stand here as the Mahr bearer while Reed fleets fight for Osra and Sul Venn sends observers instead of troops. If this court requires one orc to make every Mahr answer, then this court has learned nothing from its own wall."

Lessa crossed her arms. "Say what you are offering instead."

"Kiln House authority for the forces that elected me. No claim over Ral. No claim over Aruk. No silence imposed on Mahr who refuse the hinge."

The refusal cost Kharza something Pell could see in the way she planted both feet. Her old command had promised simplicity. Every quartermaster knew simplicity often meant somebody else's burden had disappeared from the page.

Ral touched his capped tusk, then nodded once. "I will witness that limit."

Caldrin added the statement to fresh clay.

A rumble passed through the court floor. Salt dust drifted from the eastern benches. Pell glanced at the ceiling seam she disliked most. It had widened by the thickness of a knife blade.

"Move the cases under the west arch," she said.

Nobody moved.

"That was not a philosophical contribution. Tei, take the near handle. Lessa, clear the center."

The room obeyed quartermaster tone before anyone remembered to object. They shifted the tablets into the more stable arch and moved witnesses away from the eastern wall. Pell set two haulers to brace the narrow exit with bench planks. The buried sky pressed upward through miles of salt, patient as debt.

When she returned to the table, Sevrin still watched the coastal figures.

"What do you recognize?" Pell asked.

"A variation."

“That word means nothing without a number.”

His jaw hardened. “The table predicts a reduction in star-bee flight along Neris after a prolonged fixed period. Three seasons of widening loss, followed by apparent stability.”

Saan Rel stepped down from the Aeli bank. “Neris hives have reported stable yields.”

“They reported what I certified.”

Silence spread through the court, not empty but occupied by everyone recalculating him.

Pell placed the charcoal nub on the table before she snapped it. “What did you certify?”

Sevrin looked first at Saan, then Kharza. He did not seek Pell's mercy. That at least saved time.

“Three years ago I combined inland and coastal pollination figures. Rootglass losses made the guild total look catastrophic. Neris merchants threatened to withdraw feed stores if the report caused a harbor closure. I separated the ledgers and published the stronger coastal yield.”

“You hid Rootglass?” Lessa asked.

“I hid unequal failure. I believed a united guild could protect the queen-hive until the next leafing.”

Saan's shaved scalp showed the flush beneath her skin. “Neris did not remain strong. Dockside hives failed first. We were told poor keepers had contaminated them.”

Sevrin closed his eyes. “I know.”

“How many colonies?” Pell asked.

“Forty-seven recorded. Likely sixty.”

“Likely is not a number you get to bury twice.”

The ceiling cracked.

A slab dropped over the eastern seats and shattered three benches. Salt blasted across the court. Pell hit the floor as the bearing table jumped beneath her hands. Someone screamed in the passage. The braced exit folded inward, snapping both planks.

Darkness followed. One lamp remained, rolling in a groove.

Pell crawled toward it and stopped it with her left palm. “Names,” she shouted. “Answer by seating bank.”

Voices came through dust. Mahr bank, six standing, one pinned. Aeli bank, five standing, Saan cut but moving. Vennik bank, all present. Coalition witnesses, two missing near the exit.

Kharza's stone-song rose below ordinary hearing. Pell felt it through her teeth and the clay floor. The general pressed her wrapped tusk near the west arch, listening past pain.

"Load is crossing from east to north," Kharza said. "We have minutes before the passage closes."

Sevrin knelt beside the surviving lamp. His leaf-filaments tilted, not toward light but toward a draft leaking under the fallen slab. "Air behind that wall. Perhaps another gallery."

"Perhaps does not move rock." Ral was already digging around the pinned observer.

"No, but it tells us where not to suffocate."

Pell took inventory. Two case handles. Three intact bench rails. One chain embedded in the bearing floor. Twelve able lifters close enough to hear her. She sent Lessa to the wounded, Kharza and Ral to choose the cut, Sevrin and Saan to track airflow, and Tei to strip the counterweight chain from its salt-packed groove.

Nobody asked who had authorized her.

They worked by practices the kings had reduced to symbols. Kharza marked two fracture lines and refused a third where the stone-song doubled. Sevrin held a filament above each crack until he found the cold thread of air. Vennik haulers made an A-frame from bench rails and ran chain through the case handles as makeshift pulleys. Caldryn kept the tablets wrapped while dictating their order to a refugee boy, in case clay broke and memory had to carry what survived.

The pinned observer belonged to Sul Venn, a potter named Menn Olt. The slab trapped her left leg above the ankle. Lessa slid folded felt beneath the stone and warned that lifting too fast would tear the limb.

"Three counts," Pell said. "Raise one hand's breadth. Hold. Lessa clears. Then raise again."

Kharza braced the A-frame with her shoulder. Sevrin took a line beside Saan. Old Caldryn wound rope around both forearms. Four peoples, Pell thought, and pushed the thought away before it made labor into a mural.

They lifted.

The chain bit into saltwood. The frame bowed. Menn came free with her boot crushed and blood running dark through Lessa's packing. As soon as they lowered the slab, a second crack traveled across the ceiling.

"North wall now," Kharza said.

Ral drove a ceramic wedge into the fracture she had marked. Two Kiln soldiers hammered with tablet cradles after Caldryn swore at them and handed over a less important bench leg. Salt split along the cut. Cold air struck Pell's face.

The missing coalition witnesses were in the blocked entrance passage. Their shouts came faintly through stone. Pell could not open both routes before the

ceiling failed.

"Names?" she called.

"Bera Venn and Colt Dane," someone answered.

Pell fixed the names in memory. Then a fist struck from the far side of the north wall.

Osra's outriders had found the adjacent gallery.

A spearhead punched through the opening. Ral knocked it aside with his silver tusk cap. Kharza caught the shaft and dragged the soldier against the gap hard enough to disarm him.

"Enemy gallery," Tei said.

"Still a gallery," Pell answered. "Widen it."

More blows came from beyond. Sevrin kicked the surviving lamp into the breach, plunging the other side into confusion. Kharza's soldiers broke the lower salt blocks while Sul Venn observers held shields over them. When the hole reached shoulder width, Pell sent the wounded first.

Osra's engineers attacked from the dark. They were human and Mahr, wearing salt veils and siege leather. Their objective had not been slaughter; they carried pry bars, packing straw, and royal evidence sacks. They wanted the archive.

Pell looped a counterweight rope around the first sack-bearer's knees and pulled. Saan struck his wrist with a lamp hook. Ral shouted safe-conduct terms in old court Mahr while Kharza ordered her soldiers not to pursue beyond the gallery bend. The court roof began falling in slabs before either side could win.

Evacuation imposed its own truce. Osra's engineers withdrew toward their shaft with two wounded. Pell's people carried Menn, the Compact tablets, and their own injured in the opposite direction. Bera and Colt remained behind the collapsed entrance. Pell heard their pounding cease as the central ceiling came down.

The force of it drove everyone to their knees. Salt air roared through the gallery. The old court disappeared behind white dust, taking its royal-blue groove and its gouged-out colors together.

They emerged an hour later through a sink cut beneath the desert crust. Sunset made Hollow Salt look briefly flooded with copper. Osra's riders watched from a ridge too distant to charge before darkness. Kharza formed a rear guard without claiming the Sul Venn observers. Sevrin walked apart, his face gray with dust.

Pell opened both cases. Eight complete tablets had survived. The ninth had cracked across one corner without losing script. Caldrin put his hands over them, then moved his hands away.

"Custody?" he asked.

"Mine until Vael Tern," Pell said. "Copies begin tonight. Sul Venn gets a set. Neris gets the coastal figures. Reedwater gets the degree costs. Every coalition

company gets the clause limiting sole command.”

Caldrin nodded. “Witnesses?”

Pell looked across the survivors: Kharza, who had refused to impersonate a whole people; Ral, who still did not follow her; Saan, whose coast had paid for Sevrin's quiet; Lessa tending Menn's ruined leg; Tei counting the dead.

“All of them,” she said.

Sevrin approached before anyone called him. “My figures go out under my name.”

“They do,” Pell said. “You will also explain them to every orchard council that asks.”

“I will.”

Trust had not returned. Authority had changed. The Compact tablets lay in Pell's wagon under four separate seals, and by midnight the coalition possessed a lawful claim to Salt Hinge that no crown had granted and no single bearer could own.

Chapter 12 — Osra's Harvest Ledger

Osra placed the last blue marker on the campaign map at dawn.

The southern vineyards lay beneath it. Tavan Roe's engineers had closed the final road with a ditch, an earth bank, and six linked watch posts. Vael Tern now stood inside a complete ring: three rivers, two armies, seventy thousand mouths, no open farm.

Rain hissed against the command pavilion. It had come west from Ember Hinge across country that should have remained dry for another month. The sound drew younger officers to the tent edge. They treated altered weather as wonder because none of them had watched wonder empty a granary.

"Count the ring," Osra said.

Her clerks read the columns. Eighteen thousand Heartland infantry, five thousand cavalry, four thousand Reed soldiers under Aruk Venn, two thousand engineers, two thousand support and medical workers. Thirty-one thousand at campaign beginning, though sick animals and flooded roads had already reduced what could move on any given hour. The numbers mattered more than banners. An army that admired itself starved as efficiently as a city.

Tavan leaned over the northern approach. "Crown Marshal Ruun pulled the ward stores behind the second wall. She also moved families out of the river quarter."

Before answering, Osra walked the wet perimeter with her marshal. The ring had to function as a settlement before it could defeat one. Heartland infantry dug runoff trenches uphill from their sleeping pits. Reed cooks had rejected the army's iron cauldrons and suspended broad clay pans between barges, boiling millet without wasting scarce wood. Vennik teamsters in royal service rebuilt a collapsed wagon ramp while cursing every officer who had placed tents across the drainage line. Nobody shared a culture of war. They shared mud, consumption, and the fact that bad orders reached all tents eventually.

At the north hospital, a surgeon showed Osra six cases of marsh ague acquired before the siege began. The medical stores carried fever bark for eleven days at current use. Support workers had already cut doses for camp followers to preserve soldiers.

"Reverse that," Osra said. "Ill laundresses spread fever through five companies. An ill spearman spreads it through one bed."

The surgeon stared, then amended his slate.

Farther east, cavalry horses chewed their third day of reduced fodder. A remount officer proposed stripping the last standing hay from two villages inside the ring. Osra refused. Those households had accepted royal occupation under written payment. Breaking the terms would deliver recruits to Maela and still leave the horses hungry next week. She ordered river oats purchased from Aruk's barges

at his named rate.

The tour consumed an hour and corrected nine failures no battle map showed. When Osra returned to the pavilion, her hem carried the same clay as a laborer's boots. She trusted the ring more for having found its weaknesses.

"Toward the inner districts?"

"Toward old flood shelters. She is preparing for bombardment and a breach."

"She is preparing to make prudence resemble legitimacy." Osra removed two cavalry markers from the west and set them beside the salt road. "Send them after the archivist's party."

"They missed the closing by hours."

"Then they can continue toward Hollow Salt."

Tavan's face did not change, but she pressed one finger on the map where the salt road divided among sinkholes. "Pursuit costs fodder. We have reports that Kharza's coalition intends Salt Hinge."

"That is why pursuit has value."

Osra dismissed the officers at first bell. She kept Tavan, Aruk's empty chair, and a cedar box brought from the royal famine archive. The box had traveled under her own bedroll from the Heartland. Its lock opened with an ordinary brass key. Some of the most dangerous records in a kingdom needed no magic because shame guarded them well enough.

Inside lay the original ledger of the Ash Famine.

The cover bore smoke stains from a granary riot forty-two years earlier. Osra had been sixteen. She remembered standing in a ration line with soot in her hair while a clerk announced that the day's barley had gone to soldiers guarding the northern mills. Her mother had traded a silver comb for two handfuls of black peas. Her younger brother had eaten half, vomited during the night, and stopped asking for water before dawn.

The ledger gave him one line.

House Dane, west ward: one male child, wasting fever, unconfirmed.

No name. No correction.

Osra turned the pages. The original tables compared Heartland grain with deaths beyond it. That comparison had been removed from every public copy. When the fixed Cinder Net warmed the central fields, grain yields recovered within four seasons. During the same years, salt storms stripped Varkesh terraces, winter currents failed along Neris, and Reedwater nurseries soured. The gains had not cured the realm. They had moved its hunger until the capital could stop seeing it.

She knew this. She had always known enough of it to avoid asking for the whole table.

A loose page preserved distributions from the famine's worst winter. South

Granary received eight hundred wagons under guard. The eastern wards received two hundred and thirteen after spoilage. Varkesh sent kiln grain and took royal debt notes later declared invalid. Reedwater delivered smoked fish while its own nursery islands lost seed stores to a surge. The crown had survived through assistance from regions the official history described as dependents.

Osra followed signatures down the margin. Her father's appeared beside an emergency requisition. So did the mark of Aruk's predecessor, pressed in silver-black ink. A Rootglass caravan had delivered bee-wax candles to keep mills running through ash-dark days. The famine she remembered as Heartland endurance had depended on a realm acting without the equal law its rulers had already hollowed out.

Memory resisted the figures. She could still see neighbors breaking a bakery shutter, a soldier losing two teeth to a thrown paving stone, her mother dividing peas with a sewing needle so neither child could accuse her of favor. Those things remained true. So did the wagons. Trauma did not become false when evidence widened around it. It became less obedient.

Tavan read one entry upside down. "The outer provinces fed us."

"They fed the capital because the roads still answered the crown."

"Or because hungry people understood other hungry people."

Osra's first instinct reached for rank. She suppressed it. "Motives do not move wagons. Orders, contracts, animals, and passable roads do."

"Then preserve all four next time you tell this story."

Osra turned another page. A ruler could admit complexity in private and still face a public that demanded one cause, one culprit, one prevention. Yet the ledger refused her preferred simplicity line by line.

Tavan stood across the campaign desk. "Why bring that here?"

"Because Maela believes change has no memory."

"I asked why you brought the original."

Osra looked at the line naming her brother only by sex and symptom. "Copies become arguments. Originals remain evidence."

"Evidence for whom?"

The question carried no insolence. Tavan had served her for nineteen years and still believed exact answers prevented poor orders.

"For the ruler who survives long enough to read it."

Outside, teams hauled the first stone throwers onto the western bank. Men shouted as a wheel sank in mud. Osra closed the ledger before rain spray reached it.

A siege clerk entered with Vael's projected consumption. Maela had burned outer surplus, brought livestock inside, and shifted royal rye to ward captains. At

full ration, the city could last thirty-seven days. At reduction, perhaps fifty-three. Disease would shorten either estimate once wells crowded.

Tavan waited until the clerk left. "We should open civilian passage before we announce terms."

"Maela would move soldiers in family clothes."

"Then inspect the columns. We have five thousand cavalry. We can separate weapons from bedding."

"Five thousand cavalry require fodder. Inspections require guards. Refugees require roads through our stores."

"They also require food if they remain inside."

Osra rested both palms on the closed ledger. "The siege succeeds because the city consumes its confidence. A broad passage tells Maela she can preserve both her defiance and her people."

"A passage tells the wards our quarrel concerns the hinge, not their children."

"Our quarrel concerns whether their children inherit a country capable of feeding them."

Tavan glanced toward the cedar box. "The children outside the Heartland might ask which country you mean."

For an instant Osra saw the girl she had promoted after the Ford Riots, boots covered in flour, refusing to let cavalry trample a bread queue. Competence had survived. Agreement had not.

"Limited sick exchange," Osra said. "Fifty per day, matched by our wounded prisoners. No general corridor."

Tavan accepted the concession without gratitude. "And bombardment?"

"Military stores, wall towers, river chains. Not ward wells."

"For now?"

"For as long as Maela keeps civilians away from hinge approaches."

That condition let both women hear the threat without writing it down.

The first sick exchange tested the order before noon. Vael's postern released fifty people under a white river banner: fevered children, three women in labor, old men carried on doors, and two wounded soldiers whose uniforms had been cut away. Tavan's inspectors found a knife in a midwife's bag and nearly stopped the column until the woman demonstrated its use by slicing a birthing cord from her roll.

Osra watched from the east bank. Her own prisoners waited opposite, twenty-seven fit enough to walk and twenty-three on litters. Maela had sent exactly fifty, honoring the arithmetic even while forcing Osra to decide whether civilian illness counted against soldiers.

A captain asked which bodies to return so the categories matched.

"All of them," Osra said. "The agreement says fifty people."

The columns crossed between sharpened stakes. A Vael boy on a litter stared at the siege works with an intensity that made every ditch seem indecent. Beside him, a Heartland archer returning from the city gripped his sister's hand after recognizing her among Osra's camp laundresses. For several minutes the ring admitted kinship through its own line.

Then an inspector found a ration estimate sewn inside an old man's sleeve. Tavan brought it to Osra. The figures named ward stores and projected twenty-eight days at the new issue, less than their clerk's estimate.

"Maela sent a spy," Tavan said.

"Maela sent a number she wanted us to believe." Osra examined the stitching. It had been made conspicuous with blue thread. "If we arrest him, the exchange ends. If we accept it, she knows we have seen her claim."

"Is it true?"

"Possibly. That makes it more useful than a poor lie."

Osra let the old man pass and ordered the estimate copied. Mercy, intelligence, and coercion had occupied the same strip of road. She could not separate them cleanly, so she recorded all three.

Aruk arrived near midday with rain running from the edges of his silver tusk caps. He wore Reed scale woven from lacquered cane, no royal badge, and brought two marsh counters who placed a jar of cloudy water on Osra's map.

"From the Lower Nest channels," he said.

Osra did not need to taste it. Salt crusted the rim.

"Ember's movement drove a surge," she said.

"Your surveyors predicted pressure. They did not predict this."

"They predicted a range."

"Then your envoy chose the clean end of it when she bargained for our four thousand."

Aruk's voice remained quiet. Reed councils distrusted shouting because sound carried badly over marsh wind and encouraged spectators to mistake volume for consent.

Osra opened a newer survey. "The surge should recede in nine days."

"Should."

"We will release freshwater from the east canal."

"Heartland gates control that canal."

"I control those gates."

"That difference is why I asked for autonomy."

Tavan shifted away from the table, leaving the bargain to its makers.

Osra named what she could grant: eight hundred water carts, salt-resistant seed from royal stores, fishing rights along the Wheatwater, and immediate recognition of three disputed Reed councils. Aruk listened without removing his caps.

"In exchange?" he asked.

"Hold the southeast ring. Deny Kharza passage if she reaches the city. Send twelve companies to seize Salt Hinge before her coalition arrives."

"You offered marsh autonomy for service against Vael. Salt Hinge was not in our treaty."

"The altered weather makes it part of the same defense."

Aruk touched the water jar. "Changed costs make it a new bargain."

Osra admired the precision and resented having taught it through concealment. "Name yours."

"Reed command remains under Reed speakers. No burning of civilian boats. Survey figures go to our counters before public release. Freshwater moves today, not after my companies march."

"Agreed, except survey figures that expose military routes."

"Then your counters can black out routes under our witness."

"Agreed."

Aruk did not offer his hand. "Six companies for Salt Hinge. The rest hold the ring. If your engineers attempt movement without Reed witnesses, my soldiers stand aside."

Tavan looked sharply at Osra. A subordinate commander would have received an order. Aruk had never been one.

"Six," Osra said. "Under your officers."

"Under our war speakers."

He left with a written canal release, three council recognitions, and more authority than Osra had planned to grant. Bargains made during crisis had a way of surviving it.

Irel Saan did not come in person. Her message arrived in a Rootglass cylinder sealed with orchard resin. The senior gardener reported that Sevrin had taken stolen pollen into the salt desert, that queen-hive workers were striking the hive walls, and that any forced bearing could destroy the remaining migration pattern.

She offered Osra twenty orchard guards and route knowledge through the Sunken Observatory. Her terms required protection for Rootglass, no removal of the queen-hive, and Aeli control over any pollination attempt.

Osra dictated her answer to a Salt Aeli clerk. "Rootglass neutrality recognized. Queen-hive remains under Gardener Saan. Orchard guards retain their own captain. In return, prevent Sevrin Ael from bringing contaminated comb to Salt Hinge."

The clerk paused. "Contaminated?"

"That is the public word."

"Do we know it to be true?"

"We know the comb crossed Ember pressure and preceded ecological disruption."

"That does not establish contamination."

Osra looked at the clerk's shaved filaments and saw another person testing whether precision still mattered inside her pavilion. "Write unverified comb in the sealed terms. Public notices will say unsafe pollen."

By evening, the siege ring's first proclamation waited for her seal. It listed Vael's defiance, offered amnesty to soldiers who left Maela, and described the weather crisis. One figure required her decision.

The survey placed projected Heartland grain loss under an uncontrolled Great Turning at between fourteen and twenty-nine percent, depending on timing. Her herald had written twenty-nine as the expected loss.

Tavan read over her shoulder. "That is the upper bound."

"It remains possible."

"The line calls it expected."

"Fear will not mobilize around a range."

"Truth might."

Osra changed expected to probable and left twenty-nine. One word softened the lie without removing it. She signed the proclamation.

Tavan did not move. "Maela will publish the lower figure."

"Then people will choose which risk they believe."

"They will choose which of us has lied less."

"People under threat choose the number that resembles their graves." Osra sanded the ink. "You have your sick exchange. Prepare it."

After Tavan left, Osra opened the Ash Famine ledger again. She could have burned it. The revised public histories already carried a clean sequence: failed harvest, royal intervention, fixed stars, recovery. No treasonous clerk needed to alter another page.

Instead she wrapped the original ledger in waxed linen, returned it to the cedar box, and pressed her private seal across the lock. She wrote a custody note naming the box, its contents, and the public figure she had changed. The note she hid beneath the false bottom where her brother's silver ration token had rested for forty-two years.

Preservation did not absolve the lie. It ensured the lie had an adversary if she lost.

Before closing the box, she added the day's proclamation beneath the linen. The honest range and the public figure now traveled together. A future court could call that vanity, confession, or insurance against her own ministers. Osra did not choose among them. She only knew that destroying evidence would make her certainty easier, and certainty had already cost too many nameless lines. She locked the box and gave the brass key to Tavan without explanation.

The marshal weighed it in her palm. "What am I guarding?"

"A record I may later order you to surrender."

"Will you?"

"If the realm survives my prevention."

Tavan put the key inside her cuirass. Trust between them had narrowed to custody, but custody could outlast agreement.

Osra summoned Tavan and the salt-road commanders at nightfall. On the map, Vael Tern's lamps burned inside a complete ring. Far west, Hollow Salt showed no lights, only reports of a collapsed court and fugitives carrying clay records.

"Six Reed companies and two engineer cohorts march before dawn," she said. "Irel's guards guide them through the Sunken Observatory. Seize Salt Hinge. Take Caldryn alive if possible. Recover every tablet."

"And Vael?" Tavan asked.

"No food enters. Sick exchange only. Cut the north aqueduct after our cisterns are full."

Tavan's mouth flattened. "That will force the lower wards onto river water."

"It will force Maela to count days honestly."

Rain struck the pavilion roof harder, each drop sent by a hinge moved without Osra's consent. She set one hand over the cedar box and gave the final order.

"Starve the city before the sky starves the realm."

Chapter 13 — The Sunken Observatory

The first star appeared beneath Sevrin's boots.

He stopped halfway down the rope ladder. A blue point burned under the salt crust, distant and clean, as if night had opened below the world. Then another brightened beside it. A hooked line emerged across the darkness until the buried constellation filled the chasm under him.

Above, Hollow Salt reflected noon in a white glare. Below, the buried sky held midnight.

"Move," Kharza called from the ledge. "The ladder dislikes contemplation."

Sevrin descended. His leaf-filaments leaned toward the blue fire despite the rock between them. Every strand along his scalp and forearms lifted with painful recognition. Upper and buried constellations pressed through his body in contrary directions. The sample comb at his chest began to hum.

The coalition entered the Sunken Observatory through a sinkhole Caldryn had found on an old tablet margin. Pell's haulers lowered the Compact tablets, counterweight bars, water, pollen frames, and wounded in separate slings. No animal could take the descent. Every pound had to be justified before hands carried it down.

At the bottom, black mineral glass curved away in terraces. Ancient observers had cut seats into the walls around a lens pool broader than a market square. Its water reflected no lamps. It showed the lower firmament directly: pale constellations moving beneath transparent stone, their light distorted by accumulated pressure. The Deep Hart's antlers bent against the horizon. A chain of cold stars Sevrin knew as the Salt Mother lay crowded behind a red arc that did not belong near it.

A procession had been carved around the pool's rim. Not kings. Teams. Mahr readers knelt with tusks near four separate pillars, none placed above another. Aeli keepers opened hive frames under mirrored light. Vennik crews hung from weighted ropes, their feet braced against opposing walls. Human river delegates carried bowls from seven waters and poured them into a common channel. Time and royal chisels had damaged faces, but the work remained legible in hands, harnesses, and loads.

Sevrin traced one carved hive. Several keepers had shaved filaments like Saan Rel. Others wore leafing growth long enough to braid. Orchard histories claimed Salt Aeli had abandoned sacred service after the first courts. The wall showed them serving without surrendering their own practice.

Caldryn found names beneath the mineral bloom and began reading. Some belonged to families now separated by borders. One Vennik witness bore the Vask house knot, though Pell refused to claim an ancestor from a shared voluntary

name. A Mahr counter came from the drowned eastern reeds. The first court had not gathered pure representatives. It had gathered people with relevant labor and debts.

Coalition witnesses moved quietly along the relief. Refugees recognized grain measures carved beside the river bowls. A Sul Venn observer found an old capped-tusk custom depicted three centuries before her city's treaty. The room changed their posture before Caldryn translated a word. Nobody had been invited as decoration.

Sevrin looked up at the buried constellations. Rootglass teaching described observatories as places where Aeli starwardens interpreted the paired sky for lesser courts. Here interpretation occupied one station among several. The discovery reduced his office and enlarged the work.

The descent itself continued for another hour because supplies jammed at the final chimney. A pulley basket twisted beneath two water casks, trapping a hauler against the wall. Pell stopped every following load rather than cut the basket loose. Vennik climbers traversed the shaft, redistributed forty pounds into shoulder sacks, and lowered the hauler with a splinted ankle. The delay cost daylight through the mirrors, yet it preserved the person needed to rig them.

No pound arrived anonymously. Water carried Tei's chalk mark. Pollen frames carried Sevrin's. Clay tablets bore Pell's four seals. Each ration bundle named the company that had surrendered it. The old court turned logistics into testimony before magic began.

The observatory had sunk unevenly. Northern galleries stood dry above the pool. Southern doors disappeared under brine. Salt Hinge occupied the far wall, a colossal crescent of layered stone held between two natural pillars. Its bearing grooves climbed through galleries and vanished into the crust. Royal masons had fitted blue clamps across older cuts.

Sevrin touched the sample comb. Worker bees moved inside, agitated but alive. They had refused upper pollen at Rootglass. At Ember, they had flown when rain and heat briefly crossed. Here their bodies turned toward the buried light before he opened the case.

"Not yet," he whispered.

Kharza heard. "What do they need?"

"A path between paired patterns. The pool can show it. I need the upper light carried down."

Pell pointed at a row of tarnished mirrors hanging from chains. "Those?"

"Those, cleaned and aligned."

"Excellent. An ancient sacred work requiring rags."

The work divided quickly. Vennik teams freed mirror chains and set portable counterweights beneath the hinge's lower lip. Kharza placed Mahr readers along

the pillars, each listening to a separate stress path rather than echoing her judgment. Caldryn arranged witnesses in four surviving court bays. Refugees from Ashwall, Sul Venn observers, Salt Aeli navigators, and coalition captains each received the cost map copied from the tablets.

Sevrin climbed the lens gallery with Saan Rel. They cleaned salt film from the mirrors using vinegar and felt. One by one, shafts of upper daylight crossed the chamber. The beams struck the pool and seemed to continue below it, spearing toward buried constellations. His leaf-filaments mapped relations faster than thought. Upper Cinder Net paired with a lower rain cluster. Rootglass's absent pollination path curved between the Salt Mother and a dim green pattern beyond the hinge.

The bees knew before he finished.

He opened the sample frame. Thirty-two workers rose in a tight spiral. Their wings scattered points of copper pollen through the daylight beam. They flew downward toward the pool, stopped a finger above its surface, and turned along an invisible road. Sevrin followed their line with chalk on the gallery floor.

Saan caught his wrist. "That path crosses Neris's winter current."

"I see it."

"You saw it three years ago."

The accusation required no raised voice. Sevrin kept his hand on the chalk. "I saw losses. I did not see this chamber."

"You saw enough to tell us."

"Yes."

Below, Pell called for the next mirror angle. Labor continued around his confession.

Sevrin marked the Neris crossing in red rather than conceal it among white lines. "Witness the cost."

"I will witness that you hid it first."

"Do both."

A horn sounded in the upper shaft.

Not theirs.

Kharza ordered shields toward the north gallery. Pell's people locked the counterweight bars but left the lines slack. Caldryn closed the tablet cases. The witnesses withdrew behind the lens pool, carrying the maps rather than abandoning them.

The first arrow struck a mirror and filled the gallery with bright fragments.

Irel Saan entered behind a line of orchard guards in green-glass lamellar. Sevrin had last seen her among Rootglass trunks, holding the queen-hive as though every road beyond the orchard led toward theft. Here she wore a salt veil and carried a

pruning spear. Heartland engineers crowded the shaft behind her. Reed soldiers advanced through a western gallery, lacquered cane shields overlapping.

"Close the comb," Irel called.

The bees circled the broken mirror, confused by scattered light.

Sevrin spread both hands. "Look at their flight."

"I see stolen workers driven against buried pollen."

"They chose the lower path."

"After you starved them of every other path."

A royal engineer raised a crossbow toward the sample frame. Irel knocked the weapon down with her spear.

"The hive material remains under orchard law," she said without looking back.

The engineer cursed. Kharza used the hesitation.

Coalition shields struck the gallery mouth. Mahr soldiers drove the engineers back from the mirrors, not toward the shaft, because blocking retreat would turn a contest for position into slaughter. Reed companies pushed along the western terrace toward the lower counterweights. Their objective lay in the ropes. Cut those, and the coalition could not distribute the Salt Hinge's load.

Pell sent half her haulers to defend the lines and kept half at their stations. "A counterweight abandoned in battle becomes expensive scenery," she shouted.

Sevrin crawled along the lens rail while arrows crossed above him. He gathered the sample frame and tucked it under his coat. Two worker bees clung to his filaments. The rest kept following the paired light, even as boots shattered chalk marks beneath them.

Saan Rel dragged a wounded mirror tender behind a column. Blood soaked the elf's right sleeve. "The upper beam is broken."

"Three beams remain."

"Two. Look."

Smoke poured from the north gallery. Osra's engineers had thrown damp wool onto braziers, not to burn the chamber but to blind the light paths. The bees dropped lower, losing orientation.

Sevrin ran for the chain controls. Irel met him on the narrow bridge above the pool.

Their spears stayed behind them. Their bodies did not.

She caught his coat and forced him against the rail. "If Salt turns now, Rootglass may lose its last leafing."

"If it does not move, the pressure will break this observatory and reach the orchard anyway."

"Your figures do not earn trust because you finally admit them."

“No. The bees earn attention. Watch them.”

A worker stumbled through smoke and landed on Irel's wrist. Copper pollen dusted her skin. The insect turned toward the lower green constellation even without direct light.

A crash from the north gallery broke their standoff. Heartland engineers had reached the first mirror winch. They drove an iron locking spike through its drum, freezing the beam over the wrong buried star. Three bees followed the false line and struck the pool. Their wings flashed once beneath the surface.

Sevrin shoved past Irel. She pursued him, whether to stop him or protect the hive material he could not tell. The bridge ended at a ladder above the contested winch. Coalition archers held the upper rail; royal shields occupied the floor. Neither could shoot without striking mirror tenders.

He climbed down the chain instead.

A soldier grabbed his ankle. Sevrin kicked free, dropped the final six feet, and landed beside the drum. The locking spike had bent under celestial load. Pulling it straight would take tools they did not have. He wrapped both hands around the warm iron while leaf-filaments streamed toward the trapped beam.

Irel landed beside him with greater grace and worse temper. “You will tear your hands.”

“Then turn the drum when it clears.”

She jammed her pruning spear under the spike. Together they levered. An engineer swung a pry bar at Sevrin's head. Irel blocked it with the spear shaft. One of Kharza's captains drove the engineer back, then stopped when Sevrin ordered him not to strike the mirror frame.

The spike came free. The winch spun. Chain tore skin from Sevrin's palms before Irel caught the brake. The beam traveled across the pool, searching. Bees rose from the smoke to follow it.

“Two degrees left,” Sevrin said.

“I can read a mirror scale.”

“Then why are you helping?”

“I am preventing your incompetence from becoming Rootglass's funeral.”

She aligned the beam exactly, then kicked the spike into the brine. For that narrow task they had acted together. The next decision still divided them.

Below the bridge, Reed soldiers captured a counterweight landing. Their war speaker ordered coalition haulers away but forbade his own fighters to cut occupied lines. One Heartland officer countermanded him. A royal sapper swung an axe at the main rope.

The Reed speaker struck the sapper with the flat of his hook. “My treaty says seize. It does not say bury us.”

Conflicting commands opened a gap. Pell's haulers rolled two loose stone weights down the service ramp. The blocks hit shield edges, broke the formation without crushing bodies, and stopped against a drainage curb. Lessa's medics pulled wounded from both uniforms into the dry witness bay. Each rescue reduced somebody's fighting line and enlarged the group with reason to prevent collapse.

For a few breaths the objectives stood exposed. Osra's officers needed intact tablets, hive material, and a locked hinge. Irel needed the pollinators alive. Reed speakers needed control over any cost imposed on their marsh. The coalition needed movement before structural failure. No side wanted the same victory, which made the chamber more dangerous than a simple battle.

Irel stared at the worker on her wrist for one breath. Then she closed her hand around Sevrin's collar again. "One colony does not authorize a region's destruction."

"Nor does one gardener authorize its slow death."

The floor lurched.

Brine burst through the southern doors.

A wall of black water swept across the lowest terrace, taking two royal engineers and a Vennik line tender off their feet. Ropes snapped taut. One portable counterweight toppled, crushed a bench, and dragged its partner toward the pool.

Pell jumped onto the trailing bar. Her small weight changed nothing until three haulers joined her. "Cut the fallen line, not the live one!"

A Reed soldier reached the rope first. He raised his hook.

Kharza's niece Lessa tackled him at the knees. They went into knee-deep brine together. The soldier surfaced without his silver-capped helmet and stared at the medic who had chosen wrestling over a blade. Lessa shoved the correct rope into his hands.

"Cut that or we all drown."

He cut it.

The fallen weight vanished into the pool. The remaining system slammed level. Stone-song rolled through the chamber, deep enough to blur Sevrin's sight.

Kharza staggered against a pillar. Blood appeared beneath the copper around her left tusk. "Load rising from the south. Hinge will jump if it moves without balance."

"We need all three lower bars," Pell called.

"One is gone."

"Then we need its enemy's replacement."

Across the brine, royal engineers had brought their own load bars to lock the hinge. Pell pointed at them as if requesting borrowed cookware.

Tactics dissolved into water and weight. Coalition soldiers fought to hold the

mirror galleries. Reed forces tried to seize the witness bays. Royal engineers defended their bars from the same brine threatening everyone. The pool rose over its stone rim and turned the central floor into a current.

Sevrin saw the paired lights bend. Pressure did not merely distort them now. It pulled the upper beam toward the lower constellation with enough force to ignite pollen in the air. His leaf-filaments shone at the tips.

Pain entered like cold wire.

He released the rail. Tiny burns ran from his wrists to his scalp. The star path had become visible inside his own growth, every filament carrying too much relation between the skies.

Irel caught him before he fell into the pool.

"Close yourself," she said.

"I don't know how."

"Drop the reading."

"If I drop it, the bees lose the path."

"Then let them."

Below them, a royal lock bar cracked. Salt Hinge shifted less than a finger and threw everyone toward the southern wall. A ceiling plate fell into the brine. Behind it, the buried sky showed through naked stone, stars burning close enough to cast shadows.

Nobody could leave the hinge fixed. The chamber had lost that option.

Sevrin pulled the red cost map from his coat and thrust it at Irel. "Neris crosses here. Reedwater here. Rootglass beyond this green line. Help me keep the bees on the narrow arc, or the movement spreads across all three."

"You cannot promise the narrow arc will hold."

"No. I can show you what breaks if it doesn't."

Irel read the marks. She looked toward her orchard guards. Three defended the royal engineers from Kharza's soldiers; two had broken formation to pull drowning witnesses from the current. Her command contained disagreement even before she gave it words.

"Orchard guard," she shouted. "Preserve the hive path. No attack on pollinators or mirror crews. Engineers, bring the west bars to Pell Vask."

The Heartland captain seized her arm. "Our order requires the hinge secured for the regent."

"The hinge is breaking beneath your order."

"Stand down."

Irel struck his hand away. Half her guards followed her toward the mirrors. The rest stayed with the captain, faces hidden behind salt veils. Aeli did not become

one people because an old court had named their practice.

Aruk's Reed war speaker raised his hook above the lower bars. "Our terms forbid movement without Reed witnesses."

Pell, waist-deep in brine, pointed toward the court bays. "Send witnesses."

"You have no Reed seat."

"We have three marsh counters captured at Ember Ford who joined the refugee column yesterday."

"Prisoners do not speak for us."

"No," Kharza called. She had reached the pillar nearest him, one hand clamped around her tusk. "You do. Witness your refusal or witness the cost, but choose before the south load splits this room."

The war speaker looked at the water jar hanging from his belt, cloudy with Lower Nest salt. He sent two soldiers to the court bay. He did not join Kharza. He ordered his people to loan the bars under Reed supervision.

Separate authority, shared danger.

Before the bearing could begin, they had to recover the southern witness bay. Brine had trapped five people behind a fallen screen, including both Reed counters and Caldryn's youngest copyist. The water already reached their chests. The direct stair had vanished under a current strong enough to roll helmets.

Pell proposed a suspended crossing. Her team fixed a mirror chain between pillars and hung cargo loops from it. Kharza rejected the south pillar after hearing a fracture inside. Ral Olt, still an observer rather than her soldier, tested the west support and offered his own reading. Their reports disagreed by a hand's width. They marked both limits and placed the line between them.

Sevrin could contribute only sight. He watched the buried stars through the flooding pool and called each pressure pulse before it lifted the water. Haulers crossed during the intervals. Lessa went first with bandages tied above her head. She reached the copyist, fitted a sling, and sent him across while arrows struck the upper chain.

An orchard guard covered the rescue from Irel's gallery. A coalition bowman covered her in turn. Neither acknowledged the exchange.

The last Reed counter refused the sling until she had pressed her witness mark into Caldryn's wet clay. "My speaker may withdraw our bars," she said through chattering teeth. "He may not erase that I saw the cost."

A pulse lifted the brine. Kharza shouted warning. Sevrin saw the lower Salt Mother brighten and counted the rise aloud. Pell's team hauled the counter clear a heartbeat before the screen collapsed.

Lessa returned with a Heartland engineer she found submerged against the rail. He had stopped breathing. She drained his lungs and worked his chest while both armies watched. When he coughed brine onto her knees, his captain demanded

him back.

“He can choose after he breathes twice without help,” Lessa said.

The engineer chose the royal gallery. Lessa let him go with her blanket around his shoulders. Rescue had not purchased allegiance, and nobody claimed it should.

The recovered counters took their court bay. Caldryn read each affected region from the cost map. Neris: colder current and harbor risk. Reedwater: a short brine retreat followed by uncertain nursery pressure. Heartland: rain across siege roads and reduced late grain warmth. Rootglass: possible opening of a dormant pollen route, with no guarantee of orchard survival. Witnesses repeated the entries until every working group could hear.

Only then did Pell raise her hand for the bars to move.

Pell rebuilt the missing counterweight with royal bars and chains from the mirror gallery. The arrangement looked asymmetrical because equal load did not require equal shapes. Kharza assigned each Mahr reader one pillar and demanded independent reports. Caldryn shouted the emergency clause while witnesses pressed marks into wet field clay. Irel aligned the remaining upper beams. Saan Rel held the Neris cost map where every bay could see it.

Sevrin opened the sample comb fully.

The bees rose through smoke. Irel adjusted a mirror by hand, catching daylight on its broken half. A thin beam struck the pool. Workers followed it to the buried green arc, carrying pollen between skies.

Salt Hinge began to turn.

Not far. One degree, measured by the old groove as stone moved against stone. Yet the observatory made that distance enormous. Buried constellations slid under the pool. Brine climbed the walls, paused, and rushed toward the eastern drains. Above them, daylight changed from white to pearl gray.

The movement tore through Sevrin's leaf-filaments.

Every strand flared. He smelled green wood scorched after rain. Pain erased the chamber, then returned it in fragments: Irel's hand gripping his shoulder, bees spinning in copper light, Kharza screaming a stress count, Pell hanging from a line with her boots off the floor.

He tried to release the path. The path had already burned into him.

His filaments blackened from tip to root. Some fell across his eyes like ash. Others remained attached, carrying no light at all. The twelve-year growth beneath his skin closed around the injury. He understood with a starwarden's precision what that meant. There would be no next leafing. The root beds had cauterized.

He kept the frame open until the last worker crossed.

Then darkness arrived, though lamps still burned.

Irel lowered him to the wet stone. “Sevrin. Look at me.”

"I can see your face."

"Follow the lower green line."

He turned toward where memory placed it. Nothing in his body answered. The constellations had become ordinary light beyond ordinary distance.

"I cannot."

The hinge settled into its new bearing.

A second surge hit the chamber. This one came from above. Rainwater poured down the coalition shaft while brine rose through the royal galleries. Kharza listened once and ordered immediate evacuation by separate routes. No side could cross the central floor without fighting the current and each other.

Irel's divided guard withdrew through the northern shaft with the royal engineers and Reed companies. Before leaving, she gathered three surviving workers into a reed vial. The queen-hive remained far away at Rootglass, still under her custody.

"Your stolen sample has changed the hive's law," she told Sevrin. "It has not changed mine."

"What will?"

"A path that lets Rootglass live."

She climbed out with her wounded.

The coalition took the western drain. Pell's people carried the tablets above water in slings. Lessa bound Kharza's bleeding tusk and Sevrin's burned scalp while walking. Caldren repeated witness names until a clerk had them all.

They reached the salt surface near dawn on Day Twenty. Behind them, part of the Sunken Observatory collapsed into the buried sky. Both armies emerged from different shafts and formed exhausted lines too far apart to resume battle.

Clouds had gathered east of Vael Tern. Wind moved across Hollow Salt carrying moisture away from Osra's siege roads and cold toward the Heartland approaches. Salt Hinge had moved one degree. The siege ring would now have to survive weather it had not provisioned for.

Sevrin stood beneath the altered upper sky. He could see clouds, faces, weapons, and the black rim of the sinkhole. He could no longer see how any star paired with another.

Pell put the recovered sample frame in his hands. Eleven workers remained alive.

He listened to their wings without pretending they restored what had burned away. Then he gave the frame to Saan Rel for safekeeping and began dictating every path he could still remember before memory changed its shape.

Chapter 14 — A Season With Nowhere to Go

Sevrin held the map upside down for half a minute before Saan Rel corrected him.

“The Neris coast lies under your left hand,” she said.

He turned the board. Ordinary ink remained perfectly visible: rivers, orchard councils, tide stations, three generations of corrections. What had vanished lay between the marks. No paired constellation drew his attention from coast to buried sky. No filament tightened at false alignment. The map had become an object instead of a living relation.

Around him, the coalition's weather tent snapped under a cold wind from Salt Hinge. His burned scalp carried a linen dressing. The root beds beneath it felt hot and absent at once. Eleven star-bees worked inside Saan's sample frame near the lamp, their flight unreadable to him except as movement.

“Again,” he said.

Saan placed three transparent sheets over the map. One carried tide measures from before Salt moved. Another held Caldryn's copied cost lines. The third showed reports collected during the retreat from the Sunken Observatory. Sevrin aligned them by nail holes rather than instinct.

Neris appeared first as a widening blue stain.

A one-degree movement had shortened the harbor current by less than a day. That change alone would not flood the coast. The danger came from accumulated pressure and what a full immediate Great Turning would release into the same winter track. Old tide markers predicted water entering the lower wards of Neris and crossing the sea wall at four salt towns.

“Check the scale,” Sevrin said.

Saan did. Tei Vask checked the tablet conversion. A human river surveyor named Hal Crow used a plumb line and arrived at the same contour. Sevrin made them repeat the calculation without his assumptions.

The result remained.

Neris would flood.

They tested the finding against living memory. Saan summoned three coastal caravaners sheltering with the coalition: an elderly rope maker from the lower harbor, a Salt Aeli pilot, and a human well keeper who had left Neris after the third failed hive season. None saw Sevrin's first contour. Pell required them to draw storm water from memory on blank boards.

The rope maker marked the alleys where winter tides backed through drains. The pilot marked an offshore shelf that redirected surge toward the east gate. The well keeper placed the freshwater mouths higher than Sevrin's archive map, because two had been rebuilt after subsidence. Their accounts narrowed one

danger and enlarged another. The eastern wards might gain six hours, but evacuees climbing from the ropewalks would converge on the same stair used to move water uphill.

“Boats?” Sevrin asked.

The pilot shook her head. “A flood current enters against the harbor chain. Boats inside cannot clear until the chain drops. Boats outside cannot enter while it holds.”

“Who controls it?”

“Neris council in peace. The harbor captain during storm warning. Osra's appointee at present.”

Sevrin added a required action to the warning: lower the chain before the projected surge, then reserve upper quays for evacuation rather than grain speculation. The rope maker demanded that hive docks receive equal notice. Rich warehouses had bells; dockside keepers had runners.

They built a time estimate from feet rather than hope. A child or elder climbing from the lowest ropewalk needed two hours to reach cliff shelters in dry weather. Moving hive boxes doubled congestion. Night movement required lamps that the lower wards could not afford. With every public bell, open stair, and upper storehouse available, the threatened district could clear in two days. With resistance from harbor authority, four might not suffice.

Sevrin wrote both estimates. Evidence no longer served as a single number chosen for persuasion.

Not all of it. Precision mattered. The upper harbor, cliff storehouses, and western salt enclave would remain dry. The lower ropewalks, hive docks, poor wards, and three freshwater wells lay inside the projected surge. Sevrin had grown up above the second well. His family home stood on safe stone. The dockside keepers whose losses he had hidden lived below it.

He wrote the threatened wards by name.

Kharza entered while he reached Reedwater. The general had replaced the bloodied copper around her left tusk. Lessa had wound the new strip wider across her jaw, making speech uncomfortable. Kharza looked at the blue Neris stain, then at the hour marks beside Vael Tern.

“How bad?”

“For Neris, a full movement now sends water above the lower sea wall.”

“How many days to evacuate?”

“Unknown.”

“That means you have not counted.”

“That means roads, boats, tide phase, and warning trust change the count. Give me until tonight.”

"Vael may not have until tonight."

She placed Pell's latest courier sheet on the table. Osra had closed the ring, cut incoming food, and begun work near the north aqueduct. Maela's coded marks put ward stores below the optimistic estimate. The city had not yet breached. Hunger already occupied the plan.

Sevrin forced himself back to Reedwater.

The marsh calculation carried different harm. Salt Hinge's single degree had briefly pulled brine from three western channels. A complete movement would send it back along a colder route, holding salt in nursery islands through the seed-reed season. Lower Nest could lose two plantings. Reedwater might retain navigable water and still lose the food grown beside it.

A marsh counter named Vek Venn spread channel cords over the map. Silver caps covered both her tusks. She refused Sevrin's first contour because his old survey treated floating islands as fixed land.

"They migrate every flood year," she said. "Your line drowns empty water and saves farms that moved six miles east."

"Show me."

She reset the cords according to barge records. The threatened area shifted. It grew.

Sevrin copied her revision under her name. "How much freshwater offsets this?"

"More than Osra released. Less than the eastern canal carries if Heartland gates open fully."

"Would Aruk order that?"

"Aruk does not command the gates."

Every map returned to custody.

Vek took Sevrin to the coalition's marsh camp to show what the cords represented. Reed families had built their shelters on narrow sled-barges that could be pulled when channels shifted. Salt from Ember's rain consequence had dried along the runners. Children scraped it into bowls because wasting edible salt offended their elders, even when too much of it had poisoned the water.

At a seed rack, bundles of reed grain hung by district. Lower Nest seed carried blue ties; eastern islands used yellow shell beads. Vek split one Lower Nest stalk. The center had softened into gray paste.

"Freshwater might save the parent beds," she said. "It will not restore seed already spoiled."

"How many households depend on these?"

"Do not ask households until you ask boats. Three families may share one planting barge. A widow may own seed while a council owns the mud bed. Your tables want one owner per loss."

"Then the tables are wrong."

They revised categories in the rain. Planting barges, nursery islands, fishing channels, household stores, council stores, and the labor of towing fresh water each required separate lines. A full movement made some eastern channels easier to navigate while destroying their seed banks. Calling Reedwater a single loser would conceal which councils gained passage and which lost food.

A young counter asked whether the coalition would pay them if Kharza ordered movement anyway. Sevrin could promise no treasury. He wrote obligations instead: Heartland canal release, coalition water carts, Sul Venn seed purchases, priority passage for nursery barges. Vek marked each promise unfunded until Pell assigned actual stores.

That word prevented concern from masquerading as provision.

By afternoon the tent held delegates from regions that had never shared a weather table. Sul Venn observers marked caravan wells. Ashwall refugees identified terraces too damaged to absorb more rain. Salt Aeli navigators corrected currents. Pell assigned two counters to every number, one from a benefiting region and one from a burdened one.

No season had anywhere harmless to go.

Kharza waited through the work, increasingly still. When the last counter left, she closed the tent flap.

"We need Salt Hinge moving farther before Osra locks Crown Hinge," she said.

"Farther now could kill the people we claim to include."

"Doing nothing leaves Vael under siege and the buried pressure under every wall."

"I did not say nothing."

"You said tonight, unknown, repeat, verify. Those words protect an expert from error. They do not protect a city from cavalry."

Sevrin looked at her copper wrap. "You moved Ember under immediate collapse. You saved refugees and spent Reedwater's fresh channels. Would you repeat that choice knowing the cost?"

"Yes."

The answer came without pause.

Vek, still outside the flap, went silent.

Kharza heard her. Shame crossed the general's face but did not change her statement. "I would name the cost and owe it. I would not let the ford fold with people on it while searching for a painless degree."

"This is not Ember Ford. We have time to find a narrower path."

"How much time?"

Sevrin could not see the stars that might have answered. He relied on

instrument marks and Pell's courier intervals. "Days. Not weeks."

"Vael has days. Rootglass lies away from Vael."

"Rootglass Hinge controls the cloud shade and river thaw that shape both forecasts. If its pollen route joins Salt's narrow arc, we may move pressure without sending the whole burden through one coast."

"May."

"Yes. I have done enough harm turning uncertainty into confidence."

Kharza leaned both hands on the table. "And I have done enough harm making delay sound like care while somebody else held the wall. We march toward Vael. If you want Rootglass, find a route that does not cost the army the siege."

"You cannot command an orchard into our road."

"No. I can command our departure. Bring me a choice before it."

She left.

Sevrin sat with the disagreement. Friendship had begun between them not as softness but as an ability to hear what the other refused. Kharza refused delay disguised as innocence. He refused urgency that hid where the water went. Both refusals belonged in the plan. Neither could rule alone.

He added Kharza's position to the map margin in her own terms: Vael's siege clock, Crown access, structural pressure, civilians already consuming reduced stores. A cost map that recorded only climatic injury would become another expert's concealment. Delay also had real, named households attached to it.

Saan opened the sample frame. The eleven workers emerged slowly. Since the observatory, they had ignored upper-sky pollen and clustered along the eastern mesh whenever cold wind arrived. Sevrin could no longer read their celestial orientation, so he asked Saan to describe each turn.

"Three circle the lamp. Five walk the lower edge. Two face east. One grooms."

"Which east?"

"The map's east, not yours."

Her correction carried no cruelty. His own body no longer supplied direction through star relation. He rotated the frame and observed that the same two bees returned to the eastern edge.

"They are following something toward Rootglass," he said.

"Or away from Salt."

"Both can be true."

They tested temperature, lamp angle, mineral dust, and pollen. Only a sliver of green pollen from the Sunken Observatory changed the workers' behavior. The bees lined along a route northeast across Hollow Salt, then curved toward the Rootglass river basin.

Saan found a faded entry in the Compact cost map. It named seasonal resting gardens between Salt Hinge and Rootglass, places later orchard histories omitted. Tei matched the old Vennik route marks to abandoned cisterns used by caravans before royal toll roads shifted south.

A migration corridor had once connected the two hinges.

It did not pass through the heart of Rootglass. It skirted the western orchards, crossed mineral fields now considered barren, and reached a neglected lower gate. If Irel's queen-hive accepted that corridor, pollen could distribute pressure through living stations rather than force it across Neris alone.

"If the gardens survive," Saan said.

"If their wells survive. If the lower gate opens. If Irel listens."

"Your gift for reassurance has not improved."

"It nearly ruined us when it was better."

They left before dusk with six scouts, Vek, Tei, and the sample frame. Kharza gave Sevrin one day to find evidence, not permission. The main coalition began packing eastward toward Vael while his party followed the old cistern marks north.

The first resting garden held only salt grass and a collapsed wall. Bees explored its dry stones without landing. At the second, they found a sealed well under glassy roots. Vennik jacks lifted the cover. Cold air rose carrying the scent of dormant green pollen.

The route between them demanded more than following marks. Salt wind had buried the old caravan cuts, and recent rain turned the basin floors into traps with hard crust over black mud. Tei walked ahead with a weighted probe. Twice the crust failed under it. The party shifted along higher mineral ribs, losing hours but not animals.

At one abandoned cistern, they found signs of people already displaced by the altered season. Six Reed households had dragged nursery barges onto dry ground after brine entered their home channel. An Aeli glassworker from the western orchard had traded them root meal for fish. Neither group intended to join Kharza or Osra. They wanted to know whether the next weather change would make the cistern drinkable.

Sevrin showed them the unfinished map. He marked the well as unknown instead of safe. The glassworker recognized an orchard maintenance cut leading toward Rootglass's lower gate but warned that Irel's council had sealed it after fungal blight thirty years earlier. The Reed elder knew a parallel watercourse omitted from Aeli maps because marsh fishers used it only in flood years.

Two local memories produced a viable route where the archive showed none.

They tested the cistern with silverleaf paper. Salt remained high but falling. Vek left one counter to measure it each dawn. Tei issued the displaced families enough lamp oil for four nights from coalition stores and recorded the debt against the

corridor survey. Discovery consumed provisions. Pell would insist the map carry that cost too.

By the time the party reached the second garden, Sevrin understood that reviving the corridor meant agreements over wells, passage, quarantine, and seed, not merely releasing bees along an ancient line. Rootglass could not own it alone. Neither could a marching army.

Workers entered the well shaft and returned dusted pale green.

Sevrin felt nothing. Saan's filaments curved so sharply toward them that she gasped.

"The pairing continues below the dead garden," she said.

At the third station, fresh boot prints crossed the old route. Orchard guards. Irel had already traveled this way with the queen-hive after leaving the observatory. She had not retreated directly to Rootglass. She had tested the corridor herself.

They followed at distance and found a camp abandoned that morning. A hive stand had pressed four feet into the soil. Wax flakes carried the queen-hive's scent. Beside them, Irel had left a gardener's warning cut into bark: Lower gate blocked. Western wells viable. Do not follow with soldiers.

"She knew we would come," Tei said.

"She knew the bees would," Sevrin answered.

The evidence did not secure her alliance. It established that she had not dismissed the path.

Sevrin used the abandoned stand as a writing table. He prepared two warnings with identical maps.

To Maela and Kharza he wrote that immediate full movement risked flooding the lower Neris wards and salting Reedwater's seed-reed islands. He named the Rootglass migration corridor as the best surviving route for a narrower distribution and stated that Irel had tested it without consenting to coalition control.

To Osra and Aruk he wrote the same forecast, including the projected harm to Heartland grain and the freshwater gate requirements for Reedwater. He did not soften the danger to Neris to win Osra's delay. He did not soften Vael's siege risk to win Kharza's patience.

Vek read both copies. Saan verified the contours. Tei sealed them with separate witness marks.

One courier rode toward the siege ring under Salt Aeli colors. Another followed Kharza's column. A third carried the Rootglass portion to Irel, though her scouts almost certainly watched from the mineral ridges.

Sevrin remained at the hive stand until the workers settled. Stars appeared above Hollow Salt. He saw every point as light and none as a path.

When he returned to Kharza after midnight, he put the verified map in her

hands.

"We do not force a full turn," she said after reading.

"No."

"We reach Vael Tern before its food ends."

"Yes."

"We bring Reedwater, Neris, and Rootglass into the decision, even if some arrive as opponents."

"That is the only route I can defend."

Kharza studied the marked migration corridor, then gave orders to shift the coalition's northern column toward its surviving wells. She had not yielded the siege clock. Sevrin had not yielded the cost.

By dawn their goal had changed. They would not race to complete the Great Turning at the first hinge they could reach. They would carry the Compact tablets, the flood forecast, and the corridor evidence to Crown Hinge with every affected people given a place to answer.

Ahead, the road bent toward Vael Tern. North of it, unseen by Sevrin and visible through the bees, the old migration corridor waited beneath dead gardens for the queen-hive to choose it.

Part III

Chapter 15 — The Long March to Vael Tern

Kharza gave away the first road on the morning they left Hollow Salt.

Three routes crossed the white basin. Her old instinct chose the central causeway, shortest by half a day and broad enough for cavalry. Vek Venn's marsh counters warned that cold from Salt Hinge had softened the crust below it. Tei Vask preferred northern caravan wells. A Sul Venn observer argued for the southern ridge because refugees already occupied the wells to the north.

Every face turned toward Kharza.

"Route council decides," she said. "Vek judges ground, Tei judges water and wagons, refugee delegates judge displacement. I judge enemy contact. We move only when three agree."

A captain from her former imperial command frowned. "And if they divide?"

"Then I choose after all three objections enter the march record."

It sounded slower than command. It prevented her from pretending one mind could feel every load.

They chose the northern route with a diversion around occupied wells. The decision cost four hours and kept thirty water carts from breaking through the softened causeway before scouts found Osra's abandoned stakes beneath the crust.

Thus began eight days toward Vael Tern.

On Day Twenty-Four, cold rain drove across Hollow Salt while upper sunlight remained hard enough to blister skin. Soldiers marched in cloaks with wet cloth beneath their helmets. Kharza's cracked left tusk rang whenever buried pressure shifted. Lessa changed the copper wrap at noon and forbade her to bite through pain.

"Command with your mouth open if you must," her niece said. "Nobody respects you for bleeding into your own stomach."

By sunset they reached a field of salt pinnacles. Wind had exposed bodies from an older caravan disaster, preserved with hands still gripping harness. Caldryn identified royal levy tokens from the last delayed Turning. The army could not bury them in salt rock. Vennik haulers built cairns from broken road markers while Salt Aeli witnesses copied names where tokens remained legible.

Kharza assigned one company and tried to move the column.

The burial dispute widened before it resolved. Salt Aeli navigators wanted the bodies left facing the buried current, a custom for travelers who died without sea. Kiln soldiers proposed firing the tokens in a portable ancestor kiln. Vennik haulers

objected that claiming unknown dead into one house rite could erase families still searching for them.

Caldrin found a solution in the old road law. Unidentified travelers received markers made from the road itself, with every known token copied and carried forward to the next public court. The cairns would belong to place, not ancestry. Individual families could later reclaim names without disturbing the bodies.

Kharza divided the labor by choice. Mahr soldiers moved stone. Salt Aeli witnesses washed tokens. Vennik scribes made paired copies. Human deserters built a drainage lip so the next rain would not open the graves. Refugee children pressed route marks into wet clay plaques.

One token carried only a number and a grain-porter's hook. Kharza remembered porters from the Three Valleys campaign, people counted under wagon strength until dead and under civilians afterward. She pressed the hook into the first plaque herself.

The rites consumed more than two hours because exposed bodies required wrapping. Pell released six lengths of worn tent cloth and recorded them against burial duty rather than medical stores. Nobody objected to the column. Categories could shape whether respect became theft.

When the final cairn closed, the refugee delegates asked Kharza to speak. Her former imperial troops expected a commander's honor. She gave names, occupations where known, and the fact that the old crown had left their deaths unrecorded. She did not call them sacrifices. No cause had asked their consent.

The halt changed the march. Rear companies began reporting roadside graves instead of passing them. Scouts carried clay and charcoal with signal flags. By Vael Ridge, the copied roll held forty-three names and nineteen identifying marks. The army had lost hours and gained a record broad enough to include people outside its banners.

The refugee delegates had forced that change by refusing the original order to move on. Their dead from Ashwall had received hurried trenches because the vanguard approached; these unknown travelers had waited decades. Leaving them exposed would have announced that march time still outweighed unclaimed bodies.

Kharza had looked east, feeling Vael's invisible siege clock, and granted the burial crews the hours they needed. Then she put her own hands to stone. Delegated authority did not free her from labor.

Day Twenty-Five brought heat from below. Mud steamed under cold air. Two draft oxen collapsed. Pell redistributed their loads across twelve carts and slaughtered the animals before fever spoiled the meat. Every company received less than a mouthful. Hides became rain covers; horn became wedges; bone went into Lessa's medical boil. Nothing disappeared merely because grief made inventory indecent.

A messenger from Maela found them after dark. Vael's outer farms had closed. Osra controlled harvest fields and allowed only sick exchanges. Ward stores issued rye by household. The north aqueduct faced attack.

Kharza read the message to the whole camp. She did not remove the line naming uncertainty in Maela's ration count.

On Day Twenty-Six, three Heartland companies appeared along the ridge with blue cloth tied over their spearheads. They had deserted Osra after receiving Sevrin's Neris warning and learning the public grain figure used the upper bound. Their captain offered seven hundred soldiers if Kharza retained their ranks.

"Why did you serve her?" Kharza asked.

"Because my valley survived the Ash Famine by fixing the sky."

"Why leave?"

"Because she told us only our graves counted."

Kharza accepted them under separate companies and appointed no coalition officers over their internal watches. Ral Olt witnessed the terms. The deserters surrendered siege maps but kept their banner furled, neither forgiven nor humiliated.

That night somebody painted queen's dogs on their ration cart. Lessa made the responsible Kiln soldiers clean it. Kharza ordered no loyalty oath. A march taught allegiance through repeated access to food, voice, and danger, or it taught nothing.

The first river rose on Day Twenty-Seven.

Salt Hinge's cold had driven rain into the western hills. The ford Pell expected lay under six feet of brown water. Upstream, an old stone bridge could carry people but not loaded wagons. Downstream, Vennik ferry ruins offered two intact towers and no deck.

Pell took the decision from the route council because weights belonged to her authority. She ran a cable between the towers, hung cargo slings beneath it, and used empty water barrels as floats. Soldiers crossed the bridge in units. Wagons came apart on the western bank, traveled over the river piece by piece, and returned to wheels by morning.

Osra's cavalry attacked while the third grain load hung above the current.

Their objective lay in rope, not bodies. Twenty riders split toward the tower anchors while archers fired oil-wrapped shafts. Kharza gave the defense to the defecting Heartland captain, whose soldiers knew cavalry feints. She kept Kiln troops on the grain bank and did not seize his line when riders broke through.

The captain abandoned twenty yards of ground, drew the cavalry between dismantled wagons, and trapped them behind raised axles. Vek's counters dumped river water over the burning anchor rope. Pell cut one cargo sling so grain, not the main cable, fell into the river.

They lost six sacks, four soldiers, seven attackers, and half a day. The cable held. The defecting company earned trust by preserving food for people who had insulted them the previous night.

On Day Twenty-Eight, they passed fresh graves marked with Vael ward signs. Sick civilians released through Osra's exchange had died on the road after finding surrounding villages stripped of spare food. Coalition medics counted each grave and added the names to Maela's courier roll. Siege policy traveled beyond walls.

Weather reversed again on Day Twenty-Nine. Upper clouds cleared. Buried cold froze yesterday's mud into ridges sharp enough to split hooves. Tei ordered straw wrapped around animals' feet. Cavalry officers complained until Pell showed them the replacement-horse column, which held zero.

Kharza spent the afternoon among rear wagons instead of the vanguard. She heard which axle grease had run out, which new companies drew late rations, and which refugees feared being left outside Vael if the city refused entry. Command maps showed distance. Rear wheels showed whether distance could be crossed.

A fight broke out beside the medical wagons when Kiln soldiers tried to move refugee bedding off a dry cart for arrow bundles. Their sergeant cited battle priority. Nim Vask, who had joined Pell's rear service with evacuation barges dismantled onto wagons, asked him to define battle.

"The part where weapons keep us alive," he said.

"The bedding belongs to fever families. Move it into rain and you create thirty patients. Your arrows then defend a slower column."

The sergeant appealed to Kharza. Her old command would have settled ownership by rank. Instead she called Lessa, Pell, and the refugee cart delegate. Lessa confirmed twelve active fevers. Pell found a grain wagon due to empty by midnight. The delegate offered to shift bedding after the grain issued, provided soldiers supplied lifting labor and a new oilskin.

Kharza approved the agreement and entered the delayed arrow movement in the record under her own authority. If an attack came before midnight, the cost would attach to her decision, not vanish into civilian obstruction.

The sergeant obeyed but remained angry. "A general should decide faster."

"A general did. The decision took long enough to discover what it would damage."

At dusk the grain wagon emptied. Soldiers moved the bedding under dry cover, loaded the arrows, and repaired two refugee cart wheels while they waited. No one called the compromise unity. It functioned.

News worsened. Osra's earthworks reached the north aqueduct. Vael had stopped baking in private ovens to save fuel. Maela kept the inner gates open between wards, but merchant guards demanded preference at storehouses. Pell sent public ration sheets ahead by three couriers so ward captains could compare

siege claims against actual coalition supplies.

Day Thirty brought the second river, divided into five shallow channels across reed flats. Aruk's patrols had removed bridge planks. The Reed war speaker left a tablet on the far bank: Turn back. Your movement harms the marsh you claim to save.

Vek read it twice. "He is not wrong about the harm."

"No," Kharza said. "He is wrong about who may close the answer."

They built reed mats instead of a bridge, spreading wagon load across mud. Marsh families in the column directed the weave. Kiln soldiers cut reeds badly and learned. Salt Aeli scouts found the firmest channels. Crossing took a day without battle. Aruk's patrol watched from distance and reported every wagon toward Vael.

On Day Thirty-One, Rootglass sent no answer.

Sevrin's corridor courier returned with Irel's seal unbroken on the warning packet. Orchard guards had accepted it and refused discussion. The queen-hive remained beyond reach. Kharza could not count Rootglass among allies, yet she kept the northern road open behind the column and assigned two cistern crews to protect corridor wells.

"You are spending people on an undecided orchard," her imperial captain said.

"I am preserving their ability to decide later."

"Osra will use the same road if they choose her."

"Yes."

He waited for a cleaner explanation. None existed.

The army climbed Vael Ridge after sunset. People who had marched eight days wanted to run the last mile, but Kharza held pace until rear wagons cleared the slope. The city appeared gradually: first the dark line of the outer wall, then towers against the river haze, then the camps surrounding it.

Thousands of siege fires burned around Vael Tern.

They formed a red ring from northern aqueduct to southern vineyards. Stone throwers stood against the western sky. Aruk's barge lamps marked the southeast bank. Inside the walls, windows had been blacked out to save oil. Only the citadel beacon remained, small and blue above the Crown Hinge.

The coalition halted beyond artillery range. No cheer rose. The distance they had crossed ended in an army larger than theirs, a city eating its stores, and an ally in Rootglass who had not chosen them.

Rear wagons continued arriving for another hour. Each axle cresting the ridge changed tomorrow's options: grain, bandages, bridge cable, refugee witnesses, the saltwood cases holding old law. Kharza waited until the final slow medical supply cart entered the marked camp before allowing cook fires. An army reached a battlefield only when its slowest necessary burden arrived, and every injured and

exhausted hand beside it.

Kharza listened through her wrapped tusk. Beneath the ridge, stone carried two pressures: siege works above and the buried sky below.

She summoned the route council rather than her captains alone.

"Tomorrow," she said, "we find which road still reaches the city."

Chapter 16 — The Quartermaster's War

Pell began the battle by announcing that they were short eleven thousand meals.

She posted the ration ledger on a wagon board where every company and refugee delegate could read it. Grain on hand, animals fit to haul, bridge cable, lamp oil, medical alcohol, and days remaining stood in black columns. Beneath them she wrote the deficit required to feed Vael's nearest wards for three days.

A Kiln captain called the figure enemy intelligence.

"Osra knows we eat," Pell said. "What she does not know is which carts matter. Secrecy goes there."

From Vael Ridge she could see cavalry dust along every open approach. Osra's riders did not need to defeat seventeen thousand fighters. They needed to burn flour, kill oxen, and force refugees onto soldiers' shares. Pell's objective required getting supplies through the ring without presenting one precious line to attack.

She divided the train into visible lies and hidden truths.

Forty tall wagons received empty barrels, wet hides, and enough stone to leave proper wheel ruts. Soldiers guarded them ostentatiously along the north road. Real grain traveled in fish carts, medical sacks, dismantled barge floats, and sealed night-soil bins no cavalry scout wanted to inspect closely. Nim Vask assigned voluntary-house teams across companies so no ancestry monopolized a route or bore every risk.

Three bridges crossed tributaries outside the siege ring. Pell measured each span herself. Her right hand lacked two fingers, so she tied the plumb line around her wrist and read tension through the scarred palm. The western bridge could carry loaded carts if they crossed singly. The mill bridge could carry empty decoys at speed. The eastern timber span would fail under cavalry if two counterweight pins were withdrawn after the convoy passed.

"Will it fail into houses?" Nim asked.

"Downstream mill yard. Empty since the ring closed."

"Animals?"

"Two stray goats. We relocate them."

Nim put the goats in the route plan. That was why Pell trusted them.

On Day Thirty-Two, cavalry took the decoy.

The false convoy rolled toward the mill bridge under coalition banners. Osra's riders struck from two orchards, arrows burning. Guards abandoned three wagons according to plan and defended the rest badly enough to look desperate. Cavalry captured barrels full of stone while real fish carts crossed west under rain cloth.

Then a decoy driver panicked.

He turned his team off the road and blocked the mill bridge. Riders closed around him. Pell could preserve the deception by leaving him or reveal that the wagons meant nothing.

She signaled the guards back.

Coalition archers returned, pulled the driver from beneath a fallen mule, and surrendered six more decoys to make space. Osra's cavalry saw the light barrels bounce. The lie ended early.

"Now they know," a captain said.

"They know these are false. They do not know where the grain went." Pell marked one driver wounded, one mule dead, six wagons lost. "A plan that requires a frightened teamster to die quietly deserves exposure."

The real convoy reached the west bridge before noon. Pell stationed public counters at both ends. Every sack crossing went onto the board. Refugees saw that soldiers did not receive hidden priority. Soldiers saw the food promised to Vael and understood why their ration shrank.

Cavalry scouts arrived as the last carts crossed. They attacked the bridge weights with long arrows. Pell's tenders lowered water barrels beneath the deck, changing its sway. Mahr shields protected the cable team. Salt Aeli archers used the rain angle rather than competing at range. The convoy escaped with two carts damaged.

Pell withdrew the eastern bridge pins after a smaller medical train crossed. Osra's cavalry reached it at dusk. The lead riders recognized the trap and stopped. Engineers dismounted, replaced one pin, and began a careful crossing instead of charging.

Competent enemies spoiled elegant plans.

Pell revised the campaign that night. Instead of one large deception, she issued six smaller truths that could be mistaken for lies. A pottery train carried actual flour inside clay slip barrels. An empty medical cart traveled with genuine surgeons changing camps. Refugee fishing skiffs carried bridge pins but no food. Scouts who captured any one route would learn something accurate and nothing complete.

She also changed departure times by labor rather than clock. Convoys moved when bread ovens cooled, when river laundresses changed shifts, or when camp goats returned from forage. Osra's observers could count bells. They could not predict a thousand ordinary decisions without entering the camp.

The next cavalry probe struck the pottery train. Drivers overturned the first cart at a narrow lane and smashed barrels into white mud. Riders assumed the cargo lost. Beneath the slip, waxed flour sacks survived. After cavalry withdrew, refugees scraped clay away and recovered all but nineteen meals.

Another patrol captured the surgeons' empty cart. The surgeons treated two injured attackers before being exchanged that evening. Their medical rolls carried

no routes. Osra gained proof that coalition hospitals moved; Pell gained the names of cavalry units operating west of the river.

At the northern culvert, a child noticed royal scouts counting fish skiffs. Nim paid her with lamp oil and asked what else she had seen. She identified a rider who returned at the same hour each dusk. Coalition scouts followed him to a relay stable, then left it untouched. For three nights they fed false convoy timings into his line while the real loads traveled during laundry shifts.

War at this scale rewarded no single clever cart. It rewarded correction. Every failed lie taught the next route. Every person watching from a cook line or washing bank could change the map if officers treated them as observers rather than scenery.

Pell posted an additional column naming information sources. The child chose to sign only as South Bank Washer, and that choice remained hers. Public accounting did not require public vulnerability.

Nim proposed burning the span. Pell refused. Refugees still came from farms inside the ring. They loosened the repaired pin, left the bridge unstable but usable on foot, and moved south.

At camp, the public board drew a crowd. Some accused Pell of spending soldiers to save a decoy driver. Others accused her of risking grain on a bridge rather than feeding the coalition. She answered with numbers until one refugee woman asked who had authorized Pell to choose Vael over camps already hungry.

Pell could have cited Maela's writ and the route council. Instead she looked at the ration ledger and saw another board from twelve years ago.

"I have falsified one of these before," she said.

Nim turned slowly.

Pell told them. During Maela's western campaign, a siege company had run out of food. Pell moved nine hundred meals from a refugee allocation and changed the receiving mark to storm loss. Maela's soldiers held their wall. The refugee camp reduced rations without knowing why. Nine people died during the following fever week.

"You never told me," Nim said.

"I told myself the wall saved more."

"Did it?"

"Yes."

"That answer did not need secrecy."

Pell felt every eye on the missing fingers of her right hand, the old injury people used as proof she had paid for expertise. Those fingers had nothing to do with the ledger. Pain did not settle unrelated debts.

"I hid the transfer because I wanted Maela to trust my solutions," she said. "And

because I did not want the camp to refuse.”

Nim took the chalk from her. “Then no private correction now.”

“We are in a convoy war.”

“Publish totals, destinations, losses, and decision names. Hide routes only until arrival. If a cart disappears, its households learn before officers rewrite it as weather.”

That rule gave Osra information after the fact. It also denied Pell the power to turn failure into a cleaner column.

The crowd adopted it by witness marks. Pell signed first.

Adoption did not end the hearing. A former resident of the camp where nine died asked Pell to name them. She knew only four names. That failure struck harder than accusation. She had recorded the transferred meals to the last sack and let mortality remain a total.

The woman supplied the missing five. Nim wrote each name beneath the confession. One had died of fever before the reduction could affect her. Two had surrendered portions to children. A camp healer believed scarcity weakened the remaining six, but no ledger could assign a clean fraction of cause.

“Then perhaps you did not kill nine,” a soldier said.

Pell faced him. “That uncertainty does not refund the choice. It tells us not to turn people into a number convenient for either condemnation or pardon.”

A Vael refugee wanted her removed. A Vennik hauler argued that nobody else understood the routes. Nim rejected both shortcuts. Expertise could remain in service without becoming immunity.

They set three constraints. Pell retained operational control of supply movement. Two counters outside her house reviewed every allocation within one day. Refugee delegates could halt a transfer from civilian stores until a public hearing, unless immediate attack prevented one; any emergency override carried Pell's name and expired after six hours.

The constraints slowed orders. They also gave others a way to stop her before deaths required confession.

Kharza attended from the edge and did not rescue Pell with endorsement. After the crowd dispersed, she asked, “Can you still move food?”

“Yes.”

“Can you move it under those limits?”

“I will find out.”

“That is more useful than confidence.”

Maela's next courier received the full confession. Pell included no request for forgiveness and no claim that their former intimacy had caused the decision. She had wanted Maela's trust. She had also wanted to be indispensable. Both motives

belonged to her.

At midnight, the ration board showed another consequence. Companies that had demanded secrecy began submitting their own hidden stores before counters discovered them. A Kiln captain disclosed four reserve sacks. Heartland deserters reported cavalry oats fit for porridge. Refugees offered dried roots in exchange for guaranteed return of the cooking kettles. Visibility created inventory where command searches would have created concealment.

Day Thirty-Three tested the promise.

A southern convoy carried grain, fever bark, lamp oil, and two cistern pumps toward a river culvert marked on Maela's oldest maintenance maps. Pell sent it through willow beds under fog. Osra's cavalry did not find it. Reed patrol boats did.

Aruk's soldiers blocked the channel with linked barges. Their speaker offered passage for medical goods but claimed grain under siege authority. Pell's escort refused. Neither side fired while families hid among the willows.

Pell went forward in a skiff with the public ledger held over her head.

"The grain feeds Vael," she said.

"The city defies our treaty ally."

"The people eating it did not sign Maela's refusal."

"The marsh people losing seed did not order your hinge movement."

Pell showed the Reedwater debt lines, including unfunded obligations. "We published what we owe."

"Paper does not freshen channels."

"No. Eight water carts already turned east do."

The speaker had received reports of only six. Pell produced route seals for eight. He allowed one grain barge and all medical goods through, took two grain barges into Reed custody, and released the civilian skiffs.

It counted as a bargain until Heartland cavalry arrived on the southern bank.

They attacked both groups. Reed archers answered. Coalition escorts cut tow lines. In the confusion, one grain barge grounded beneath burning arrows. Pell ordered the crew off and watched three days of flour become a low white fire. Another captured barge escaped east with Reed boats. The final grain barge and medical skiffs entered the lower river.

The lost convoy had not been one event. One barge burned, one changed custody under negotiation, one arrived. Pell wrote each result separately and sent copies to every camp before sleep.

Critics used the report immediately. Kiln soldiers demanded she classify the Reed seizure as theft. Marsh refugees called it partial repayment. Heartland deserters asked why medicine had received priority over grain. Pell answered in public until her voice failed.

Transparency did not create agreement. It prevented her from choosing which disagreement existed.

On Day Thirty-Four, Nim found the submerged route.

The old map showed a waste culvert outside Vael's southern wall. River shift had buried its mouth beneath ten feet of water. Nim's barge crews sounded the bank and found dressed stone behind silt. The passage sloped toward an abandoned cistern inside the city.

Too narrow for wagons. Wide enough for people, sealed sacks, tablet cases, and pump parts.

The route still needed proof. Pell sent no swimmer until teams mapped every hazard from the outer mouth to the first air pocket. River workers lowered a weighted rope along the drowned masonry. Twenty-six feet inward, the roof dropped. Forty-two feet farther, a side current pulled toward an iron grate. Beyond that lay an air bell large enough for three people, then a second submerged run.

Nim selected swimmers by current experience, not military rank. Two came from Reed fishing families now opposed to Aruk's alliance. One was a Salt Aeli wreck diver. A human sewer mason knew Vael's stone but admitted he panicked underwater. He served on the rope team instead.

They practiced in an open inlet with sacks equal to tablet-case weight. Pell joined once and struck the roof because darkness made her misjudge depth. Her missing fingers could not close securely around the guide rope, so Nim rigged a wrist loop she could release by twisting. Accommodation entered the route plan beside water timing.

The first swimmer reached the air bell and found royal scratch marks under the mineral film. Vael maintenance crews had sealed the passage after a fever outbreak, not structural collapse. The iron grate ahead could open from inside. Jorren would need to find its wheel.

During the second test, the side current caught a flour sack and pinned it against the grate. The escort could not free it without exhausting their air. They cut the tether and surfaced. One hundred meals stayed underwater until low flow, when hook teams recovered eighty-two. Pell recorded eighteen spoiled in a test before anyone called the loss training expense.

"Why publish failed practice?" a route captain asked.

"Because future swimmers should know which current tries to kill them."

Nim marked three rope knots before the pull, added a breakaway tether, and moved cargo beneath rather than beside each swimmer. The next sack crossed cleanly.

A hostile scout nearly found them at dusk. Refugee fishers continued casting nets over the work site while Vennik teams submerged tools under reed mats. When cavalry questioned them, an old fisher complained for ten minutes about

army horses muddying spawning shallows. The scouts left with two purchased carp and no route.

Concealment succeeded because ordinary work remained credible, not because civilians vanished from the operation. Pell paid the fishers at the public rate and listed their names under restricted witness marks.

Pell tested the current with weighted corks. Water flowed inward at dusk when Vael's lower sluices opened, outward before dawn. A strike group could enter during the inward pull if Maela opened the cistern gate. The same route could expose the city if Osra discovered it.

They needed contact.

Pell built a message cylinder around a blue river lamp and sent a Vennik swimmer through the first submerged arch. The swimmer returned forty minutes later with Maela's reply scratched into wax: Cistern accessible. Jorren has the inner map. Send food before soldiers.

Pell read the line twice. Maela still knew which order would anger officers and save civilians.

They packed the first inward loads: fever bark, water filters, flour sealed in waxskin, and copies of the ration ledger. Compact tablets would follow with Pell's strike group after the route proved stable. Counterweight teams hid the remaining supplies in three river depressions rather than one depot.

Priority went through public counters. Fever bark served crowded lower wards before military infirmaries because contagion ignored rank. Water filters went to cistern mouths serving the largest households. Flour parcels carried colored cords so ward captains could report destination without opening waxskin underwater. Pump parts traveled last in the first wave; losing food to preserve equipment would repeat Pell's old habit in a new shape.

A Vael reply requested lamp oil for the citadel. Pell cut the amount in half and reassigned the rest to ward shelters. She wrote her name beside the change and sent the request back with the delivery. Maela could countermand it after seeing the cost, not before civilians knew the oil existed.

Swimmers carried no weapons beyond belt knives needed to cut lines. A fighter drowning in a narrow culvert could block every load behind them. The first soldiers would enter only after food teams established the route and Jorren secured both grates.

At sunset, the first sealed sacks vanished beneath the cistern water. Forty minutes later a blue lamp flashed twice from a drain slit inside Vael Tern.

Food had crossed the ring.

Pell posted the delivery count, the burned grain, the Reed-held barge, and her old falsification on the same public board. Then she marked the submerged cistern route in a private ledger shared with Nim, Kharza, and Maela.

Authority had not come from keeping the cleanest secret. It came from letting people see what her choices cost, then trusting them to keep following the routes that still worked.

Chapter 17 — Through the Cistern Gate

Maela turned the iron wheel while three wards waited for water.

The abandoned cistern had not served Vael Tern in twenty-eight years. Fever moss stained its walls. Silt buried the lower steps. Jorren and six engineers had cleared the inner grate by lantern light while ward captains rationed every remaining bucket above.

“Again,” Jorren said.

Maela leaned into the wheel. Rust broke. River water surged through the submerged culvert and rose to her knees. A blue lamp appeared beneath the surface, followed by a swimmer towing flour.

Food came before soldiers.

For two hours, Vael crews hauled waxskin sacks from the black water: flour, fever bark, filters, pump parts, public ration sheets. Each carried colored cords naming its destination. Lower wards received the first loads. Citadel clerks protested until Maela showed them Pell's signed reduction of palace lamp oil.

Distribution began inside the cistern so no ward could intercept another's share on the stairs. Blue cords went to river families, red to western shelters, uncolored double knots to fever wards. Two counters cut every seal together and weighed water gain before accepting flour. One sack had leaked enough to lose a quarter of its contents. The deficit entered the board before anyone carried it away.

People gathered above the rail. A mother recognized her district cord and wept without making a sound. Soldiers stared at fever bark as if it were treasure because sickness had removed more watch hours than arrows. Pump parts drew no cheers, though they would make the remaining water usable. Maela watched attention gather around immediate hunger and reminded herself that unseen maintenance still required protection.

A merchant factor attempted to purchase six flour sacks for later distribution. Ward captains expelled him from the cistern. Under old law his storehouse contracts carried priority. Under siege rules, public destination cords outranked private debt. Maela signed the seizure and required the factor's name on the board beside hers.

The first outgoing group assembled before the swimmers finished. Twelve fever patients rejected by Osra's daily exchange, four pregnant women, seven children with lung sickness, and six carers waited under blankets. Jorren objected that the return flow had not been tested with frightened civilians.

“Then test it with volunteers before dawn,” Maela said. “Nobody enters submerged water tonight.”

They moved the patients into the emptied cistern keeper's rooms instead. Supplies created shelter by vacating storage space. Every arrival altered more

than a ration total.

"Honor the allocation," she said.

The seventh swimmer brought Pell.

The Vennik quartermaster emerged gasping, wrist loop still tied to the guide rope, black hair pasted over her large eyes. Two missing fingers on her right hand had not kept her from crossing; they had changed the harness. Maela noticed that before the months between them.

"You took the water route," Maela said.

"You left the road occupied."

Their embrace lasted one breath and belonged to survival, not settlement.

Pell's strike group followed: twenty swimmers, thirty fighters, eight counterweight workers, Caldryn, and two tablet cases wrapped in inflated skins. The Compact tablets crossed last among essential loads, after medicine and before weapons. Witnesses checked all four seals inside the cistern.

Maela touched neither case. "Open them in the lower council hall."

"Publicly," Caldryn said.

"As publicly as siege permits."

"That phrase has hidden much."

"Then count the people I exclude."

They did. One royal guard for security. No merchant delegates until ward captains had seats. No crown clerk without a Vennik counter beside them. Caldryn accepted the conditions.

Jorren closed the grate after the final swimmer. "The route gives us a bridgehead outside the ring."

"And gives Osra a road in if she finds it," Maela said.

He spread a wet map across an empty water bench. The cistern gate connected to three flood tunnels. One rose beneath the river ward. One reached a lower Crown Hinge passage sealed by royal order. The third ended near the south wall foundations. Supplies could enter. Civilians could leave in small numbers. Enemy sappers could reverse the same path.

Pell studied flow marks. "We install two breakaway grates, not one lock. Inner grate stays under Vael control. Outer obstruction stays under my river teams. Either side can close without trapping swimmers between."

"You are creating separate authority over one route," Maela said.

"Yes. Practice accepting it."

Old affection made the irritation precise.

In the lower council hall, Caldryn placed the Compact tablets on bread tables because every ceremonial table had become a ration station. Clay showed four

scripts and royal erasures. Ward captains leaned close. Mahr residents read hearth marks. Urban Aeli corrected one translation. Vennik pulley workers recognized old weight knots. The discovery entered the city through ordinary expertise rather than proclamation.

Caldrin read the four equal-practice clause in every surviving script. Each version named labor differently. Mahr marks emphasized hearth plurality. Aeli branches described living transfer rather than ownership of bees. Vennik knots tied authority to measured counterload. River TERNIC required witnesses from places receiving benefit and places carrying harm.

A noble asked which version ruled when meanings differed.

"None alone," Caldrin said. "Difference requires another hearing."

The answer angered people trained to seek one seal. It relieved those accustomed to being mistranslated.

Maela ordered her six years of denied hinge petitions brought from the citadel. Clerks stacked them beside the original tablets. Mahr miners had requested pressure readings after foundation cracks. Urban Aeli keepers had asked to compare failing hives. Vennik bridge houses had offered to weigh Crown chains. Her own refusals cited public order and royal custody.

A miner named Hadr Olt held up a petition carrying Maela's signature. "My sister died when the east cellar folded."

"I denied your inspection."

"You denied our standing. The inspection happened after she died."

No siege necessity could absorb that answer. Maela entered the death and refusal into the public record. She offered Hadr a place among the lower-court witnesses. He accepted without forgiving her.

The first cost map circulated through the hall. Ward delegates added current siege burdens: water shortage, fever concentration, ration cuts, exposed foundations. Pell insisted that military urgency enter beside climatic damage so delayed action could not masquerade as neutral. Caldrin accepted modern entries on fresh clay rather than carving them into the originals.

Copies began at once. Children from the scriptorium pressed damp sheets over tablet marks. Potters prepared cheap clay versions for every ward. Scribes translated into trade language, then read translations back to native readers. Exact authority remained disputed, but concealment no longer depended on possession of nine heavy tablets.

Maela assigned mixed guard to the originals: one ward officer, one Vennik counterweight worker, one Mahr resident elected by hearth delegates, and one Aeli hive keeper. Her royal guard held no sole key.

"Your seal can still open the lower gate," Hadr said.

"Yes."

“For how long?”

Maela touched the metal beneath her cuirass. “Until I can alter access without surrendering the city to whoever reaches it first.”

He disliked the answer. She recorded that too.

Pell stood beside Maela without touching her. “Before we discuss the tablets, I sent you another account.”

“The old ration ledger.”

“You read it?”

“I read nine names and four you did not know.”

Pell flinched. “You know now.”

“I know I benefited.” Maela remembered that western wall and the soldiers who had eaten. “You changed the ledger. I never asked which camp lost food because success arrived.”

“That does not split my choice in half.”

“No. It adds mine beside it.”

The council waited. Their former intimacy could not become a private room while public harm sat on the table.

Maela told them she had rewarded Pell after the campaign without auditing the storm-loss entry. Pell described the new review constraints. Ward captains demanded the same rules inside Vael. Merchant councillors objected that open deficits would cause panic.

“Hunger already knows itself,” Pell said. “Only officials require paper to be surprised.”

They adopted public daily store figures and named emergency overrides. Maela surrendered her right to requisition ward food without two counters. The decision reduced speed. It also stopped the citadel from eating first by habit.

At dusk, Jorren led Maela through the flood tunnels. He marked niches where children could rest during evacuation, ladders needing repair, and turns too narrow for litters. The submerged section allowed strong swimmers only. To move civilians, engineers would need to lower the cistern level and build air chambers.

“How many per tide?” Maela asked.

“Two hundred if uninjured. Eighty with children and litters. More invites drowning.”

“Start with sick exchange overflow.”

“We need this route for supplies.”

“We need people alive to use supplies.”

He revised the schedule: incoming loads at dusk, outgoing civilians before dawn. Every person leaving reduced mouths and defenders' families, but also risked

exposure. Scouts would spread false culvert marks along two other banks.

At the south branch, Jorren found fresh grit below the wall. Someone outside had sounded the stone.

“Osra?” Maela asked.

“Could be old settlement. Could be engineers.”

“Treat it as discovery.”

They installed a listening post and prepared clay plugs that could flood the branch without drowning the main route. The cistern gate became relief and vulnerability in the same hour.

Before returning above, Maela joined the evacuation test. Jorren selected eight healthy volunteers whose bodies reflected different problems: a strong swimmer, two elders, a parent with a child-sized bundle, a soldier with a splinted arm, a Vennik worker shorter than the air-bell handholds, and Maela in armor without weapons.

They lowered the cistern level by opening the river sluice. The first submerged run shortened, but the current strengthened at the grate. Jorren sent them in pairs along the guide rope. Maela entered behind the elder named Sella Crow.

Dark water closed over her. Stone grazed her cuirass. Sella's feet stopped ahead when panic locked her hands around the rope. Maela could not speak underwater or push without risking both of them. She pressed the elder's ankle twice, the signal for air ahead. Sella moved.

They surfaced in the bell. The Vennik volunteer could breathe comfortably, while Maela had to crouch because the roof sloped. The child bundle floated too high and blocked one adult from drawing breath. Jorren marked a lower sling position. The splinted soldier could not manage the grate turn with one arm. A rope lever solved it after two attempts.

The second run proved worse. Silt reduced visibility to nothing. The elder arrived exhausted. Maela's wet armor doubled effort and scraped the narrow turn.

“No armored guards in civilian groups,” Jorren said when they surfaced outside. “One swimmer per five evacuees. Rest in the bell. Litters cannot pass until we widen the inner throat.”

Sella coughed river water and corrected him. “One per three elders. Your count assumes fear improves after the first drowning place.”

Jorren changed it.

The test reduced projected flow to eighty only under trained escorts, fewer with frail evacuees. Maela ordered no public promise above sixty until the route completed a full civilian tide. The lower figure disappointed ward captains. It might keep them from sending more people than air pockets could hold.

Engineers began widening the inner throat by hand, using cloth to catch every stone chip before it entered the current. Each inch required an hour. Siege logistics

offered no miraculous hidden road, only another place where labor bought capacity slowly.

When Maela returned above, bells summoned her to the throne hall.

The council had arranged Ordan's plain iron circlet on a ration cloth. Four nobles, two guild heads, and a frightened priest waited beside it. Outside, stone throwers struck the western wall at measured intervals.

"Vael requires a crowned sovereign," Lord Pellan said. "The troops need lawful continuity."

"I am Crown Marshal. They have command."

"Command does not answer Osra's claim."

"The city has eaten boiled leather in two wards. You propose spending oil on a coronation."

"A brief rite."

"No rite remains brief after witnesses, bells, guards, vestments, and bread."

The priest lowered his eyes. "Tradition requires distribution to the poor."

"Then distribute the food and omit me."

Pellan's face reddened. "Without a crowned heir, the Compact tablets may be used to abolish all royal authority."

Maela looked at the royal bearing seal beneath her cuirass. It still opened rooms no ward captain could enter. She had not yet decided what to do with it. She knew what not to spend tonight.

"Good law should survive people reading its original," she said. "If my authority depends on clay staying hidden, it deserves a siege."

The councillors pressed. A coronation might rally defenders. It might split Osra's Heartland troops. It might make foreign captains recognize orders. Each benefit carried a cost the speakers treated as ceremonial dust.

Ward representatives arrived before Maela answered. News of the circlet had spread faster than flour. Hadr Olt came from the tablet hall, still carrying clay on his hands. Sella Crow arrived wrapped in a cistern blanket after the evacuation test. A baker from the western wall brought the day's fuel count.

Lord Pellan protested that succession belonged to the royal council.

"Then why ask our children to defend it?" Sella said.

The baker placed two cold oven stones on the cloth beside the circlet. "We extinguished forty ovens. If bells ring for a crown, people will think bread follows. It does not."

A palace guard argued that defenders needed a face above faction. Hadr answered that he would defend Maela's command because she had opened the tablets, not because Ordan's metal touched her head. An urban Aeli captain said some soldiers might indeed rally to a crowned heir, while others would see

confirmation that every promise of shared custody ended at the same throne.

Maela made the council list effects as Pell listed stores. Possible Heartland defections. Possible Mahr withdrawals. Guard hours. Public bread expectations. Legal claim against Osra. Delay to cistern works. No column produced a simple total.

The priest confessed that an abbreviated rite could omit feast and vestments but not the royal vow of sole hinge guardianship. The old words required the sovereign to keep Crown Hinge from all unlicensed hands.

"Can you change the vow?" Maela asked.

"Not without a crowned sovereign's authority."

"Then the rite requires me to promise what the Compact tablets dispute."

Pellan called the contradiction temporary. Caldryn, arriving at the hall door, called it the purpose.

A stone struck the wall. Dust crossed Ordan's circlet. Maela saw who had been left outside the supposed necessity: people whose fuel, dead, petitions, and labor would purchase her symbol. Refusal would not settle monarchy. It would prevent hunger from settling it by exhaustion.

Pell entered carrying the ration board. "Circlet banquet baseline, even reduced: eight hundred loaves, twelve oil jars, forty guard shifts, six hours of hall labor."

"Those figures assume a full court," Pellan said.

"They assume your written requirements."

"We can waive them."

"Then you admit the crown exists without them."

Maela almost smiled. Former lovers remembered where each other kept knives.

She lifted the circlet from the cloth. For a moment the hall inhaled. Then she placed it in an empty flour chest and closed the lid.

"No coronation while the ring holds," she said. "No food, oil, or guard hour spent converting defense into inheritance. Address me as Crown Marshal."

A western impact shook dust from the rafters. Nobody mistook the changed condition.

Below, Caldryn began reading the tablets to ward delegates. Pell's swimmers prepared the second tide. Jorren posted guards at both grates and gave each authority to flood its own side if captured.

Maela revised the defense plan around the new route. The cistern would supply lower wards, evacuate those unable to survive the siege, and carry a small strike group between city and coalition. No mass sortie would expose it. Two false tunnels would receive visible guards. Engineers would prepare the real branch for collapse if Osra entered.

Near midnight, Pell joined her beside the cistern water.

"You put the circlet in a flour chest," Pell said.

"It was empty."

"That part troubles me more."

Maela wanted to ask whether they had changed enough to begin again. The question would turn siege survival into leverage. She let it wait.

"I am sorry I benefited from the lie," she said.

"I am sorry I made you useful to my excuse."

Neither apology restored the dead. Both altered what they could conceal next.

A guide rope tightened in the water. Another food load entered. On the outer bank, Pell's people held one end. Inside Vael Tern, Maela's crews held the other. Between them the submerged passage remained open, carrying relief through a gate that either side might have to destroy.

By dawn the coalition possessed an internal bridgehead, the Compact tablets rested under mixed guard inside the city, and every defender knew that their newest road could also become the breach.

The first civilian tide carried fifty-eight people outward without a drowning. Jorren reduced the next group after one elder reached the air bell in distress. Pell published the lower capacity beside the delivered food. Relief had opened a narrow, dangerous, measurable passage, not an escape large enough for the hungry, frightened, crowded city. No map or promise made it wider. Maela ordered its limits repeated at every ward board, granary door, infirmary, and guard post before hope could turn them into another dangerous public lie.

Chapter 18 — The General of Three Orc Armies

Three Mahr armies arrived at Kharza's command fire and each refused the place she offered.

Kiln House captains stood closest, black-clay banner behind them. Seven hundred imperial Mahr deserters kept their furled Tern standard to the west. A Reed splinter force of nine companies held the riverward edge under silver-capped speaker Vek Rann. They had left Aruk after Osra's canal release arrived late, but they had not joined Kharza.

Kharza set three equal stones around the map.

"No," Vek said. "A place at your fire implies your command."

The imperial captain objected to sitting beside soldiers who had attacked royal convoys. Kiln elders demanded Kharza absorb both forces under emergency field law.

Eleven years earlier, she would have ended the argument by assigning ranks. That method had won the Three Valleys and taught the crown how to use one command against every region.

"Keep your own fires," Kharza said. "We meet here for shared objectives only."

She moved the stones apart.

The immediate objective concerned Vael's relief bridge. Osra held both approaches. Maela could sortie from inside if an outer force reached the river. Kharza's coalition needed Mahr stone readers along the bridge foundations, infantry against siege earthworks, and Reed boats to keep evacuation water open.

Each army wanted a different condition. Kiln captains demanded unified timing. Imperial deserters demanded protection from execution if captured. Vek demanded no command that worsened Reedwater without marsh review.

Kharza wrote all three before offering terms.

Separate banners. Separate internal officers. Shared signals for retreat, civilian passage, and hinge danger. No commander could order another army to burn boats, close evacuation roads, or continue over a reported stone failure. Every force received refusal authority when an order violated its written conditions.

A Kiln elder struck the table. "An army cannot fight if every captain debates."

"Refusal requires a named condition and a public reason," Kharza said. "Not preference."

"And if refusal loses the bridge?"

"The refusing commander answers for that cost. So does the commander who gave the order."

Vek studied her. "You would permit us to leave?"

"I cannot build equal alliance by denying the door."

The imperial captain asked who held final command during attack.

"I coordinate. I do not own your people."

They argued until noon. Refusal signals needed to differ from retreat. Reed horns carried poorly over stone; Kiln drums carried badly across water. Vennik signalers designed paired flags and bells. Every order received an objective, a boundary, and an ending condition.

Before any captain signed, each army held its own council.

The Kiln Houses gathered by hearth delegation. Soldiers placed fired tokens in bowls for commanders they accepted; cracked tokens registered dissent without revealing individual hands. Kharza's oldest captains expected automatic support and received two full bowls of objection. Families from terraces damaged under her former central command demanded that supply officers, not only fighters, hold refusal marks.

Imperial Mahr met by company guilds. Many had lived in human-majority cities for generations and rejected Kiln ancestral rites as irrelevant to their service. They chose officers by written slate and required amnesty terms in court Ternic so Vael officials could not later claim mistranslation. One company remained loyal to the dead king's law while opposing Osra. Another wanted the monarchy abolished. Shared defection had not produced shared politics.

Vek's Reed splinter force convened on moored skiffs. War speakers rotated by channel, and silver-capped elders could recall them after each objective. Three boats voted to return to Aruk. Vek allowed them to leave with weapons and food. Two did. The third stayed after its crew learned Osra's freshwater release had bypassed their nursery island.

Kharza attended each council only when invited. At the Kiln fire she answered for the Three Valleys. At the imperial slate she promised captives would receive ordinary law, not revenge. On the Reed skiffs she listened while families described salt-soft seed. Nobody asked her to summarize Mahr interests because the councils had demonstrated that no such single list existed.

The signed command agreement carried three forms of consent. Fired tokens, company slates, and knotted reed cords hung from the same board without becoming interchangeable. Caldryn copied their meanings for non-Mahr witnesses.

Vennik signalers then ran a field test. A black flag meant objective complete to Kiln troops, but mourning to imperial companies. Reed boats read a lowered silver pennant as safe channel, while land soldiers mistook it for surrender. They replaced colors with shapes: square for hold, split-tail for withdraw, ring for civilian passage. Bells carried the same counts at night.

During the final test, a drummer deliberately gave a false advance. Two captains obeyed from habit. The exercise stopped until both could explain why the written boundary mattered more than familiar command tone. Refusal required practice

before fear.

Lessa arrived to change Kharza's tusk wrap. The medic listened while captains proposed making her chief surgeon over all Mahr companies.

"No," Lessa said.

Kharza held still as copper came away from the crack. "You have field trust."

"I have your name."

"You also have skill."

"Then let skill keep me treating patients. Chief surgeon spends half a day resolving tent claims and becomes proof you promoted kin."

She nominated an imperial Mahr physician and a Reed bone-setter as joint coordinators, with herself leading mobile triage. Kharza accepted before pride turned praise into pressure.

"Your wrap is too tight," Lessa said.

"It was holding."

"It was hiding swelling."

Kharza let her loosen it. The lesson required no military translation.

Aruk requested truce at sunset.

He came to the river island with twelve guards and both silver tusk caps in place. Kharza brought twelve from mixed companies and no banner. Between them, Vael's walls rose over smoke. Osra's siege camps filled the banks.

Aruk set a jar of Reedwater brine on the stone. "Your hinge work did this."

"Yes."

"Your warnings arrived after."

"Yes."

He had expected defense. Its absence did not soften him. "Six councils lost seed beds. Osra opened freshwater gates after bargaining. You sent carts and called debt public."

"We sent eight."

"Eight carts do not replace a season."

"No."

Aruk looked toward Vek's splinter camp. "You are recruiting my army."

"They came under their own speakers."

"You accepted them."

"As separate authority."

"You once hanged officers for less."

"I once taught officers that obedience could erase their people."

Aruk touched one silver cap. "Do not turn regret into a claim over my refusal. I remain with Osra because she signed canal authority the crown denied us for generations."

"She also concealed the surge range."

"And you moved Ember without our witness."

Both charges held.

Aruk opened a reed case and removed copies of his treaty with Osra. Each council recognition bore its own seal. Canal gates would transfer to a marsh authority after the war. Salt fishing rights extended for twelve years. Heartland courts had accepted Reed inheritance law in three disputed settlements. These were not slogans Kharza could dismiss as bribery. They corrected injuries the old crown, including Kharza's campaigns, had enforced.

"What have you offered them?" Aruk asked.

Kharza could name future witness seats and public costs. She could not transfer gates she did not hold. "No sovereignty that depends on my victory."

"Then Osra's paper carries more weight."

"Until she decides emergency requires the gates again."

"Every treaty risks breach. Yours risks never becoming material."

A Reed guard set down two seed bundles. One came from a canal reached by Osra's delayed freshwater. Its center remained firm. The other came from beyond the release. Gray rot filled it. Aruk placed both beside his treaty.

"I serve the councils that received this," he said, touching the sound seed, "and the councils owed this." His finger moved to rot. "Leaving Osra now does not open another gate tonight."

Kharza understood why his army stayed. Understanding did not make the siege lawful.

"Vael's wards are also hungry tonight."

"Yes. Maela can surrender Crown access."

"To a regent who falsified the grain risk."

"To a regent who signed terms your coalition cannot yet fund."

Their conflict did not reduce to truth against ignorance. It concerned which enforceable harm each accepted while preventing another.

Kharza added a proposal: independent Reed counters at any future bearing, canal releases placed under councils before further hinge motion, no demand that Aruk acknowledge her command. In exchange she asked him to open a civilian lane if Vael's wall failed.

"I already negotiated sick passage with Tavan," he said.

"Fifty per day does not answer a breach."

"Nor does your cistern answer a city."

"Then we need both."

Aruk would not promise. He agreed to let Reed counters survey two neutral river islands for emergency landing. The concession created capacity without changing allegiance.

A distant stone thrower discharged. They watched the missile strike Vael's western wall. Dust rose around homes neither controlled.

"My soldiers say your name as if you betrayed the Mahr," Aruk said.

"Mine say yours the same way."

"Correct them."

"I have."

"So have I."

For once they shared an order.

Kharza showed him the written limits. Aruk read every line. He paused at civilian boats and stone-failure refusal.

"Osra agreed to no civilian burning," he said.

"Then your terms match ours there."

"Our terms do not make us allies."

"No."

"Good."

They discussed the bridge. Aruk would defend Osra's southeast bank. Kharza would attempt relief. Neither would target medical barges. Both would mark prisoner channels. If stone-song revealed bridge collapse beneath civilians, either could signal a halt without surrendering position.

"You expect me to honor your bell?" Aruk asked.

"I expect you to hear your own bridge."

His caps damped that hearing by cultural choice. Kharza did not ask him to remove them.

Aruk rolled the terms and returned them unsigned. "I will meet you at the bridge."

"As enemy?"

"As the war decides."

He left with Osra still his ally and no place beneath Kharza's command.

The next two days tested the federation before battle.

A Kiln patrol seized two imperial deserters as suspected spies. Their own captain invoked refusal authority and halted joint scouting. Kharza convened a field hearing. Evidence showed the soldiers had visited relatives in Osra's camp without

permission but carried no maps. They lost scout duty, not freedom. Joint patrols resumed with mixed pairs chosen by each army.

Vek's force refused a trench line that would drain runoff into a refugee hollow. Engineers moved it uphill at the cost of two hours and harder soil. During the delay, cavalry attacked. Imperial troops held the incomplete trench while Reed soldiers evacuated the hollow. The altered line cost six wounded and saved sixty families from flood and horse charge.

A Kiln captain then tried refusal for extra rations. The hearing rejected it because hunger applied across companies and violated no written condition. Refusal did not become a polite form of demand.

Every decision entered a command ledger beside its consequence. Kharza read it nightly. Distributed authority produced more words, more delay, and fewer hidden resentments. It did not produce harmony.

They rehearsed the bridge attack on a field marked with ropes. Pell scaled the river, piers, siege banks, and cistern outlet in paces. Soldiers carried weighted sacks to represent wounded people. Refugee volunteers moved through the model at walking speed while formations tried to protect them.

The first plan failed in nine minutes. Kiln infantry reached the western earthwork and blocked the civilian lane with its reserve. The second failed when imperial deserters pursued a simulated cavalry retreat beyond their objective. The third trapped Vek's boats downstream of a lowered chain.

Kharza did not correct each failure herself. The affected commanders revised their sections while everyone watched. Kiln reserves shifted uphill. Imperial companies tied pursuit authority to a split-tail signal from their own captain. Reed boat crews assigned cutters at both chain towers and retained the right to abandon attack if civilians crowded the channel.

A fourth rehearsal introduced false signals. Vennik bell teams repeated only commands carrying the proper shape flag. A familiar Kiln drumbeat ordered advance from beyond the field; two companies started, remembered the earlier test, and stopped. An officer cursed the hesitation.

"Hesitation saved them from enemy command," Pell said. "Spend it where authentication fails."

The fifth rehearsal introduced a collapsed bridge span. Mahr readers marked danger with white clay. Captains had to choose between objective and withdrawal. One Kiln officer crossed anyway to maintain momentum. Kharza removed him from bridge command, not for refusing caution but for violating the written stone-failure boundary his own hearths had approved.

"Real battle will not resemble ropes," he argued.

"Then honor the few conditions we know become worse in reality."

Lessa tested triage by declaring injuries at random. Commanders repeatedly

used medics as messengers because they stood near every line. She stopped the rehearsal.

“My workers carry patients, not your indecision.”

Dedicated runners replaced them. Joint medical coordination remained with the imperial physician and Reed bone-setter Lessa had nominated. Her refusal improved the plan because she remained free to expose its demands.

Pell added supply endings. Every formation carried water for six hours. When empty, it withdrew unless another force voluntarily transferred stores under counters. No captain could prolong battle by silently taking refugee carts.

The final rehearsal lasted through the planned bridge opening and stopped at relief, not pursuit. Kharza wanted instinct to recognize the objective's end. Victorious armies caused fresh disasters when they mistook movement for permission.

On Day Thirty-Eight, the command table fixed the Four Banners plan.

Kharza's black-clay formation would take the western bridge earthworks. Aruk's Reed silver-cap force remained opposing them on the southeast approach, but Vek's splinter boats would hold civilian water lanes without adopting his banner. Maela's blue-river sortie would open from the cistern district when Pell's signal reached the wall. Rootglass's green-glass guard had not committed; the plan preserved a northern lane if Irel came.

The name described the formations required for full relief, not alliances already secured.

Pell assigned ration limits and bridge weights. Sevrin supplied wind forecasts through Saan's readings. Lessa established triage beyond command fires. Imperial deserters received the dangerous work of dismantling cavalry stakes because they knew Osra's pattern, not as punishment for former service.

Kharza issued no speech about one people. She read each force's objective and refusal condition aloud.

Then she required each commander to repeat another force's terms. Kiln Captain Dorr recited the Reed civilian-water condition. Vek named the imperial prisoner protection. The deserter captain described the Kiln stone-failure limit. None could later claim ignorance of a refusal merely because it came from another army.

Civilian witnesses challenged the plan next. A Vael fisher pointed out that opening the bridge for relief would push siege debris downstream toward the cistern mouth. Pell added boom crews. An Ashwall refugee asked where families outside the walls should go when fighting began. Kharza reserved two ridge lanes and removed an imperial reserve from one, weakening the attack to prevent another trapped convoy.

A Mahr merchant serving Osra's camp crossed under truce to ask whether

coalition lines would accept noncombat defectors. Kiln soldiers called him collaborator. Kharza granted passage under search and public registration. A command federation that recognized military refusal could not deny civilians the same exit from allegiance.

The merchant brought intelligence: Osra had ordered more stakes near the bridge and rotated tired Heartland infantry away from the western bank. Kharza recorded the source without making his admission purchase forgiveness for earlier supply work.

Finally, each army appointed a consequence speaker who did not transmit orders. Their task involved counting when objectives consumed the limits written beside them: water gone, wounded capacity full, civilian lane blocked, foundation song changed. Commanders disliked a voice dedicated to stopping momentum. That discomfort justified the role.

Only after those additions did the three councils press their distinct marks into the plan. Agreement attached to one battle and expired when relief opened. No emergency phrase extended it automatically.

Kiln Houses could halt if the western foundation split. Imperial companies could refuse execution orders against prisoners or defectors. Vek's boats could withdraw from any action closing civilian water. Vael's sortie remained Maela's command. Rootglass, if it came, would answer to Irel.

A young officer asked what made Kharza general if she could not compel them.

"Coordination," she said. "Information. Consequence. If my plan fails, I do not become less responsible because you remained free."

At dusk, Aruk's signal fire appeared across the river. One light, then two: acknowledgment of the medical-barge channel. Not alliance.

A consequence speaker counted the signal before any officer answered. Vek's boats shifted one anchor upstream, preserving the agreed channel without entering Aruk's formation. Kiln archers lowered bows along the marked water. One limited promise had changed positions on both banks while leaving every army's allegiance intact.

Kharza ordered the adjustment entered beside Aruk's name, not hers. Shared restraint deserved accurate custody as much as shared victory.

Kharza answered with the agreed bell. Her cracked tusk vibrated beneath its looser copper wrap. Three Mahr armies prepared around Vael Tern without becoming one army, and the rival across the bridge retained every right to oppose her.

She looked from separate fires to the city wall.

At the bridge Aruk would meet her under his own banner. If he ever crossed to their cause, he would cross as an equal or not at all.

Chapter 19 — The Heir Who Refused the Sky

The councilors had set a coronation stool across the map table.

Maela stopped inside the Hall of Rivers with rain drying on her cuirass and listened to the northward artillery. The interval had narrowed since dawn. Osra's stone-casters struck every fifty breaths now, probing for mortar weakened by hunger and three days of cold rain. Each impact traveled through the floor and made the silver cups tremble beside the stool.

Someone had found blue velvet for its cushion. No one had found bread for the children sleeping beneath the west arcade.

"Move it," Maela said.

Councilor Hadran, whose flour mills had supplied the city before the siege, folded both hands over his belly. Hunger had reduced him without making him smaller in his own imagination. "Your accession requires witnesses. All nine surviving councilors are present. The chaplain waits in the lower court. We may not have another hour when the bells are quiet."

"They are not quiet."

A stone struck the outer wall. Lime dust fell from the ceiling ribs. The river captains at the end of the table glanced up, calculating thickness by habit. Maela counted the delay before the answering horn. South bastion. No breach.

She crossed to the stool and lifted it. One leg caught on a red cord stretched across the campaign map. Pell had marked the city's cistern routes in red, evacuation lanes in yellow, and districts too crowded to move in black. The royal furniture dragged all three colors together.

Maela set it against the wall.

"The king named you," Hadran said. "The army already calls you heir. Osra calls you usurper because you refuse the act that answers her. Take the crown, open Crown Hinge by right, and give the defenders a lawful center."

"A lawful center cannot begin by blocking the only useful map in the room."

The council shifted with the particular impatience of people who had turned fear into procedure. Maela understood it. A crown promised a shape they recognized. Walls failed inward; dynasties continued forward. The old answer offered them a line through chaos, and all it asked was that she stand where Ordan had stood.

She unbuckled her sword belt and laid it along the table's eastern edge. "Where are the public copies?"

A young archive clerk raised an ink-stained hand. "At the Hall of Measures, Crown Marshal. Two hundred and eleven made by noon. More if we can boil glue."

"And the original Compact tablets?"

"In Quartermaster Vask's wagon by the inner quay. Under Vennik guard."

That custody mattered more than velvet. Maela looked at the nine councilors and then at the gallery doors, which remained barred from inside. "Open those."

Hadran's expression hardened. "This is a royal succession council."

"No succession has occurred. Open them."

The door wardens obeyed the office she still held. Noise entered first: boots on stair stone, an argument about ration chits, a baby crying with tireless fury. Then came the people who had waited in the passage. Two Mahr kiln workers carried a Compact copy mounted between laths so wet ink would not smear. An Aeli cooper from the river ward leaned on a cane. Three Vennik bridge crews arrived in tarred aprons. Behind them stood human laundresses, wounded defenders, an old Neris fisher, and six residents elected by the shelter circles that had formed in granaries and bathhouses.

Pell entered last, ducking beneath the displayed copy. Mud striped her coat to the elbows. Her right hand, short two fingers since long before Maela had known her, held a bundle of tally slates against her chest.

"You have a chair problem," Pell said.

"It has been relocated."

"Excellent. We have several bridge problems that resist equal treatment."

A few people laughed, quietly and without relief. Maela felt the old pull toward Pell's voice, toward nights when a dry observation had made duty seem briefly proportionate. She let the feeling pass without asking it to carry either of them.

The archive clerk read the copied clauses aloud. Public bearing required four equal labors. Every region receiving a seasonal benefit must witness the cost imposed elsewhere. No dynasty could close a bearing court to a laboring people whose bodies or lands bore its strain. The language had cuts where later royal copies removed names, yet Caldryn's tablets preserved enough to expose the shape of the theft.

When the reading ended, the Aeli cooper tapped his cane against the floor. "Six years ago my enclave petitioned to inspect the lower pollen channels. Your guards turned us away."

Maela faced him. "I signed that exclusion."

"You did."

No artillery answered for several breaths. That silence pressed harder than an accusation dressed in ceremony.

A Mahr mason named Veka lifted the lath-mounted copy. White dust filled the grooves of her black-clay neck plates. "The Crown called our fault-readers dangerous when they asked to hear the hinge. Now you need General Olt below it. Does refusing a crown change who held the door?"

"No," Maela said. "It changes whether I can pass the same door to an heir."

"Convenient timing."

"Catastrophically late timing."

Hadran pushed back from the table. "We can perform confession after the siege. Vael needs command. The outer wall has lost two stair towers. Osra's sappers have reached the north counterscarp. A divided city cannot survive a full assault."

"Then we should stop dividing it into people whose consent counts and people whose labor counts."

Maela motioned to the campaign map. The shelter delegates came nearer, uncertain whether old rules still forbade them from approaching it. One laundress, a broad human woman with burned forearms, stepped first. Others followed. Their bodies covered the painted estates and noble wards. The map improved at once. They knew which alleys remained passable, which wells had fouled, where handcarts could turn, where a fallen lintel had trapped thirty people in a cellar until Mahr masons cut through from the brewery.

Pell spread her slates beside Maela's sword. "If this room wants legitimacy, it can begin with arithmetic. Sixty thousand two hundred forty people remain inside the outer districts and the inner city. We have grain for eleven reduced days if no storehouse burns. Water lasts longer, provided Osra fails to foul the east intake. Evacuation through the cistern route can move eight hundred people an hour under ideal conditions, which have never once visited my profession."

"Four barges are repaired," a Vennik rigger said.

"Three and a half," Pell corrected. "One possesses aspirations."

The river captains bent over the yellow lines. Hadran tried twice to return to accession, but each attempt found a new obstruction: a collapsed stair, a shortage of mule shoes, an exposed queue outside the southern ovens. Defense reclaimed the room from inheritance one fact at a time.

At last Maela asked, "What must exist before any bearing is authorized?"

Pell studied her. "Cost maps. Not a blessing over estimates made in private. Named districts, named regions, water heights, crop losses, migration lanes, food reserves, and people with the standing to stop a movement at an agreed threshold. Civilian seats, because armies have a professional tendency to call a road empty after moving their own wagons off it."

Councilor Sere, the oldest of the nine, rubbed his scalp. "You propose to put refugees over Crown Hinge."

"Beside it," Pell said. "No one should be over it. That arrangement produced our present weather."

"Who chooses these seats?"

The Neris fisher answered before Maela could. "The people paying each cost. You do not appoint my coast to agree with you."

Voices rose. A river captain objected that siege elections invited Osra's agents.

Veka demanded Mahr refusal authority over any load they could hear breaking stone. The Aeli cooper insisted Rootglass and Neris could not share one representative merely because both were called elf in trade speech. Shelter delegates wanted the right to publish all ration transfers. Hadran warned that merchants would hide stores rather than submit to seizure by a crowd.

Maela let the argument continue. Command had taught her to cut across uncertainty before it infected a line. Six years at Vael had rewarded speed, hierarchy, and doors that opened for her seal. Now she saw how often the appearance of unity had depended on removing anyone likely to disagree.

Another impact shook the hall. This one brought a runner through the gallery, blood along one sleeve where stone chips had cut him.

"North counterscarp taken," he said. "Marshal Roe's engineers are laying mantlets toward Flood Bastion. Captain Taal requests two reserve companies and says the cistern mouth must be cleared of civilians before dark."

Maela returned her sword belt to her waist. "He gets one company from palace reserve and the brewery archers. The second goes to the cistern mouth. Tell Jorren evacuation outranks salvage."

The runner saluted and left.

His report split the room along a new line. Three officers urged an immediate levy from the shelter circles, arguing that anyone able to carry a paving stone could reinforce Flood Bastion. The laundress with burned arms demanded to know who would carry water if the shelters emptied. A river captain proposed abandoning Lantern Ward to shorten the defense. Lantern Ward's elected resident, a boy-faced cobbler named Edris, spread both hands on the map until his fingertips covered six black alleys.

"There are eleven hundred people in those blocks," Edris said. "Four hundred cannot climb. Give us carts and two hours."

"We do not have two hours," the captain replied.

"Then give us one, and put your soldiers on the carts."

Maela could have decided in a breath. The geometry favored withdrawal. Lantern Ward projected beyond the second wall, its tiled roofs exposed to fire arrows and its lanes too narrow for a shield company. Yet Pell's yellow route crossed the district before turning toward the cistern. Abandoning it without moving those eleven hundred would fill the evacuation road with terrified people at the same moment disciplined retreat required it clear.

"One hour," Maela said. "The brewery archers hold the eastern lane after they deliver the reserve company. Every empty military cart reports to Edris. Anyone who can walk leaves first, carrying water. The bedbound move under guard. At the hour bell, defenders collapse the tile sheds across the northern lane and withdraw."

Edris did not thank her. "Who checks the houses?"

"Your circle names search pairs. Each pair takes one soldier."

The captain started to object, then saw that Maela had given civilians authority over the search while keeping soldiers responsible for its protection. He scratched the change onto his slate. The decision consumed seven minutes. It also meant no officer could later report Lantern Ward empty merely because his patrol had failed to look behind cellar doors.

As messengers carried the order away, voices gathered in the gallery below. A palace lieutenant had shown the Compact copy to his company. Half had sworn they served Ordan's named heir and demanded a coronation before taking the north reserve post. The other half said their oath bound them to Vael rather than a bloodline. Their quarrel blocked a stair needed by stretcher crews.

Maela found the lieutenant at the gallery turn, surrounded by soldiers with drawn faces and clean spearheads. Hunger had made rituals precious to them. They wanted a sovereign who could make their losses belong to a story older than Osra's siege.

"You swore to defend the city under its lawful command," Maela told them. "I remain that command while the council recognizes my office. If any soldier needs my ancestry to carry a stretcher, leave your spear here. The shelter circles require hands. If you can serve Vael without choosing its grandchildren's ruler tonight, take the north stair."

One veteran laid down his spear. Shame colored his cheeks, but he went toward the stretcher crews as ordered. The rest filed north. No cheer followed them. Their morale had not mended. It had changed its object.

When Maela returned to the hall, Edris had already marked Lantern Ward's search pairs beside Pell's route. Defense reclaimed the room from inheritance one accountable name at a time.

"There," Hadran said. "You decide, and we obey. Give that reality its proper name."

Maela looked toward the bronze doors at the rear of the hall. Beyond them, stairs descended to the exclusive court. The royal bearing seal hung at her neck under her cuirass, a disk of pale riverstone in a cage of gold. Ordan had placed it in her hand when illness made stairs impossible for him. She remembered his apology. Not for the locked court, only for the weight.

"Come below," she said.

The chaplain waited on the first landing with a narrow crown wrapped in blue cloth. He had brought oil, a bowl, and the genealogical roll. His assistants occupied the width of the stair. Behind them, the lower bronze door showed four shallow depressions around its frame. Three had been filled with royal plaster generations ago. Only the human handprint remained open.

Maela stopped before it. The crowd packed the stair above her. Pell stood one step back, not at Maela's side as lover or subordinate, but close enough to see every motion.

"Your Majesty," the chaplain began.

"Crown Marshal."

"The city may not understand a distinction made during bombardment."

"Then say it more than once."

She drew out the royal bearing seal.

Its weight had always seemed modest. A guard could wear more metal in buckles. Yet doors throughout Vael answered the stone. Archive locks released. Council chambers admitted. The lower court recognized one bearer while refusing fault-readers, hive keepers, counterweight houses, and the citizens whose fields received whatever season emerged. Maela had used that convenience long after she understood its injustice because every crisis arrived with reasons to postpone a different law.

Veka spoke from the stair. "If you destroy it, can the court open?"

"The door may jam shut."

"Can your smiths cut it?"

"Eventually."

"Then the question concerns time, not holiness."

That drew a sharper laugh. The chaplain flinched. Maela almost smiled.

Pell set her tally slates down. From an apron loop she removed a bridge pin, square-headed and thick as Maela's thumb. "River brass," she said. "Ugly, durable, and already implicated in public transport."

Maela placed the disk on the stair. Hadran pushed down through the crowd.

"Wait. Break the dynasty after we survive it. Osra can claim the city has fallen into mob law. Every wavering company beyond these walls will hear that Ordan's heir smashed her own right while enemy ladders rose."

"They will hear that I remain Crown Marshal. They will receive orders bearing my military authority. They will also hear that Crown Hinge no longer belongs to my children, should I ever have them."

"Words cannot create shared custody."

"No. People must do that. The words prevent me from forbidding them to begin."

Maela took Pell's bridge pin. One blow chipped the gold cage. A second bent it away from the riverstone. The third split the royal bearing seal along a pale fault she had never noticed.

Nothing thundered. No hidden sanction struck her hand. Two halves lay on old stone, unequal in size and equally useless.

The chaplain lowered the wrapped crown. From above came a sound like wind gathering through reeds. It resolved into voices, first uncertain, then steady enough to reach the gallery. Crown Marshal. Crown Marshal. Not queen.

Maela returned the pin to Pell. "Leave the halves on the council table. Publicly."

"I will inventory them as two pieces of failed access policy."

"Use smaller handwriting."

They carried both halves upstairs. Hadran did not leave. He removed the coronation stool from against the wall and gave it to an attendant, who took it into the gallery. That small surrender mattered because everyone saw him make it.

During the next hour, the Hall of Rivers built a defense charter under bombardment. Maela retained authority over walls, sorties, and evacuation orders as Crown Marshal. District circles gained seats over shelter movement and ration publication. Vennik houses received direct control of load limits on bridges and barges. Mahr fault-readers could order a local withdrawal when stone-song crossed a witnessed danger threshold. Aeli delegates could halt pollen-bearing work that threatened an unmapped orchard or coast. No group received power alone. Every refusal required a stated reason entered beside a cost map, open for challenge after immediate danger passed.

It did not produce harmony. Two councilors resigned. A palace company threatened to follow them until Jorren sent word that any soldier with leisure for succession politics could carry cistern stretchers. Merchants protested inventory access. One shelter delegate accused Pell of protecting military grain; Pell answered by opening the army ledger first.

At dusk the north wall bells began a continuous warning. Osra's mantlets had reached Flood Bastion. Maela issued reserve positions, ordered every nonessential cart toward the cistern route, and assigned the palace kitchens to public control. People moved faster because they had argued over the route themselves. Others moved slower because debate carried cost. Neither fact resembled the obedience of a coronation.

Before leaving for the wall, Maela returned to the bronze lower door.

Smiths had chipped out the old plaster from the three blocked handprints. The work exposed darker stone beneath, worn smooth by palms from eight centuries ago. Veka placed her hand in the Mahr hollow. Pell used her left hand in the Vennik mark. The Aeli cooper pressed long fingers into the third. Maela took the remaining human place without seal or title.

Four bodies leaned.

The door resisted, gave a finger's width, then opened on bronze pivots that had not moved for generations. Cool air rose from Crown Hinge. It carried wet mineral scent, dust, and a low vibration Maela felt through her boots rather than heard.

No guard barred the stairs. Laundresses entered behind councilors. Masons

followed captains. Refugees carried lamps down to the court from which their costs had once been excluded.

Maela waited at the threshold until every ordinary witness who wished to descend had passed her. Then she turned toward the north wall, still heir to a dead king, still responsible for a living city, and queen of nothing at all.

Chapter 20 — The Breaking of Vael Tern

Pell knew the full assault had begun when every plumb weight in the cistern yard kicked east at once.

The bronze weights struck their frames. Mules screamed between the capstans. A row of water jars toppled from the intake wall before the sound arrived, a single blow from Osra's stone-casters that seemed to flatten the dawn against Vael Tern.

"Reset every line," Pell shouted. "Do not trust a hook you did not touch after that strike."

Vennik riggers moved among the frames with chalk and mallets. Some wore bridge-house knots at their collars; others belonged to no house Pell knew. Hunger had sharpened their faces, but their hands checked pins in the proper order. Load first, anchor second, route third. Panic changed none of those.

Above the yard, continuous horns called from the outer wall. Three long notes marked artillery. Two rising notes marked infantry advancing under mantlets. A broken pulse from Flood Bastion meant sappers had reached its foot.

Nim Vask stood atop an evacuation barge with a sounding pole in one hand and the original Compact tablets packed in a tarred chest behind them. "East channel rose another palm."

"Can you clear the culvert?"

"If the roof stays where roofs generally perform best."

"Your optimism sickens me."

"Inherited defect."

Pell looked at the board nailed beside the cistern gate. The first count on it came from the siege registry: 61,400 residents and 8,600 refugees within the outer walls. Seventy thousand bodies, each of whom required space, water, and time. During the past days, barges and submerged carts had taken 9,760 through the old water road. Another 4,440 needed to clear before the gate shut if they were to reach the planned 14,200 evacuated before a breach.

That would leave 55,800 inside.

No chant could make those figures noble. Pell had forbidden the copyists to round them.

A messenger slid down the yard stair, missed the final tread, and struck both knees. "Quartermaster. Crown Marshal says the north reserve has engaged. General Olt's western companies are attacking Osra's cavalry screen outside the river road. Captain Taal requests the next barge leave half loaded so it can return before the intake drops."

"No half loads," Nim said.

Pell agreed. A barge moved at the speed of its draft and the tunnel current, not

at the speed of an officer's hope. Underloading would save minutes outward and waste a full return passage. "Tell Jorren the next barge carries capacity. Two hundred seated, thirty stretchers, no household chests. His scouts choose the walking column."

"He says Flood Bastion may not hold until noon."

"Then he should avoid scheduling the breach before our return tide."

The messenger stared.

"That means go."

At the outer river arch, the first enemy arrows rattled against overhead shutters. Osra's cavalry had found a firing angle across the south embankment. Pell ordered wet hides raised over the boarding lane and sent two counterweight crews to change the draw on the shutter frames. Every crew she moved from the gate slowed the barges. Every crew she left exposed became a body nobody else could replace.

The board changed to 9,960.

A second artillery strike hit close enough to crack the cistern plaster. Water sheeted from a new seam and ran across Pell's boots. She tasted lime in the air. On the upper landing, defenders dragged three wounded archers down from the wall, one with a shaft through his cheek. Lessa Olt met them beside the pump house and pointed without ceremony: walking wounded to the brewery tunnel, chest wounds to her tables, dead against the blue tiles where stretcher crews would not stumble.

"General Olt?" Pell asked.

"Alive," Lessa said. "Her tusk heard the sapper galleries through the west abutment. She has been singing warning lines since midnight. The copper wrap is cutting her gum."

"Can you stop her?"

"Would you like to stop counting loads?"

"No."

"Then respect equivalent stupidity."

A roar from above drowned the horns. Pell watched a ripple cross the cistern pool. Mortar fragments fell through a ventilation grate, followed by daylight where no daylight had belonged.

Flood Bastion's lower horn ceased.

Pell climbed to the wall because the load board no longer told her what would fall on it next.

The stair opened beneath a wooden gallery packed with reserve spears. Through a split in the parapet she saw Osra's assault spread across the northern ground. Heartland infantry advanced behind layered mantlets roofed in wet oxhide.

Engineers rolled two timber towers along roads made from doors stripped from evacuated farms. Stone-casters worked from the orchard terraces, their arms dropping in sequence so one missile remained in flight whenever another struck. Tavan Roe had not wasted ammunition on terror. She had cut the wall into separated commands.

Along the west, Kharza's black-clay banners pressed toward the river road. Her federation held three distinct lines rather than one merged army. Kiln troops used ceramic shields against the cavalry archers. Imperial Mahr defectors carried long city pikes. A Reed splinter company moved through drainage cuts where horses could not follow. They aimed for the siege stores and the road to the cistern mouth, not for Osra's command pavilion.

A signal disk flashed from the Kiln line, three white turns followed by red. Pell knew the code because she had written it into the Four Banners plan: road blocked, wagons available, civilian route possible if the obstruction came down. Between Kharza's force and Vael stood a siege barricade made from chained supply carts. Osra's cavalry waited behind it. If the coalition broke through, evacuees from West Sluice could march beyond bow range rather than crowding the downstream quay.

Pell took a mirror from the wall station and answered with the route code. West Sluice active. Capacity constrained. Do not pursue cavalry.

The Mahr disk repeated her final command. Kharza had accepted it.

Below the west parapet, Vennik bridge crews prepared two counterweight baskets on chains salvaged from the river boom. Their plan required dropping the baskets from Vael's wall to drag apart the enemy barricade. Each basket carried broken paving stone and weighed enough to crush the crews if a brake failed. Pell checked the anchor bolts with her thumb. One shifted in wet mortar.

"Replace that pair," she told the crew chief.

"No spare bolts."

"Then run the back line through the butcher's chimney."

"Chimney leans."

"Toward Osra's army. A considerate defect."

They fed hawser across the roof while arrows struck sparks from the parapet. Two Kiln shield files advanced outside, closing the last ground to the barricade. Pell waited until cavalry committed toward them. Then she chopped her hand down.

The bridge crews released both baskets.

Stone loads plunged outside the wall. Chains snapped tight across the siege carts. The suspect anchor tore loose, but the back line caught around the butcher's chimney. Brickwork leaned farther and held. Below, two chained carts rolled sideways. A gap opened just wide enough for six Mahr abreast.

Kharza's Kiln troops did not charge through it. They braced shields and let the

cavalry enter the narrowed ground first. Imperial pikes struck from behind their shoulders. Reed fighters came out of the drainage cuts at the horses' flank, silver caps bright in the smoke. The cavalry recoiled, fouling its own barricade. Kharza's second line moved on the wagon teams.

Osra's engineers turned a stone-caster toward the west wall.

Pell saw its throwing arm lower. "Clear the anchors!"

Crews cut free the chains and ran. The missile crossed the river road like a dark moon. It hit the butcher's chimney, drove brick through the roof, and tore one basket line away. Three riggers disappeared beneath the collapse. Pell reached the nearest, a human apprentice with both ankles pinned. She and the crew chief levered roofing off him while another impact showered them with tile.

Outside, the freed supply wagons rolled toward Kharza's lines. The road did not open. Heartland infantry formed beyond the cavalry and drove the Mahr back from the gap. Yet six grain carts and two medical wagons escaped west. More important, Osra had turned artillery away from Flood Bastion for two precious casts.

Pell flashed a final message: take wagons, break contact.

Kharza's disk answered once. The federation withdrew by distinct routes, each formation covering another without surrendering its banner. Pell watched the Reed splinter fighters vanish into the drains last. Kharza had not won the road. She had forced Osra to spend cavalry, infantry, and stone on holding it, and she had carried away stores intended for the assault.

That kind of defeat could feed people. Pell entered eight recovered wagons on the wall slate and three missing riggers beneath them. She refused to let one figure erase the other.

Outside the east arch, Vael defenders dropped hooked stones onto sapper mantlets. The enemy answered with clay pots that burst into greasy smoke. Wind drove it back against the city.

"Quartermaster!" Jorren called.

He crouched below the parapet with a blood-dark bandage around his thigh. He had tied it high and kept moving, which told Pell the wound hurt badly enough to frighten him. His scouts carried no matching shield patterns; they had taken whatever remained in store.

"Your barge leaves full," Pell said before he could speak.

"Good. The north road ends in half an hour. Flood Bastion's footing has separated from the curtain wall. We can hold the upper stones, but when the lower chamber goes, it takes the gate stairs."

"Evacuation pace requires four more barge cycles."

"You have two through the cistern. Move the walking columns through West Sluice after that."

"West Sluice has no counterweight brake."

Jorren pointed to the river chain. "Take one from the palace bell."

Pell almost objected that the bell frame could not bear a side draw. Then she followed his sight line. The bell itself provided the missing mass. Forty years of ceremonies had hung three tons of bronze above a city that presently needed a brake more than a voice.

"I require eighty laborers and every length of hawser in the council hall," she said.

"You get forty soldiers and the coronation ropes."

"There was no coronation."

"Then the ropes are rested."

A stone missile struck the timber gallery two bays away. Planks broke upward. One reserve soldier vanished in a burst of splinters; another hung through the floor by one leg. Pell crawled beneath the rail as the gallery tilted. Jorren cut the trapped soldier's belt and hauled her free. The outer end of the gallery fell against the wall, opening a gap where three enemy ladders rose through smoke.

Vael's spears met them. The fight compressed into hands, ladder rails, and the effort to keep footing on boards slick with rain. Pell had no weapon except a brass tally punch. She used it on the wrist of a Heartland soldier who reached over the parapet, then stamped his fingers until he fell. Jorren drove a broken spear down between ladder rungs.

"Go build your brake," he said.

Pell went.

By the time she reached the palace bell, councilors and shelter workers had already stripped the coronation ropes from their chests. Blue and white cords lay across the square beside tarred river hawser. Maela stood on the bell platform in a plain helm, assigning the reserve by district rather than rank. No crown. The north wind pulled her cloak toward the wall.

"Flood Bastion is separating," Pell said. "Jorren gives the cistern two more cycles. I need the bell as West Sluice brake."

Maela looked up once. "Take it."

Temple attendants protested when Vennik climbers cut the ceremonial lashings. Pell gave them work coiling the ropes. Forty soldiers lowered the bell until its bronze lip hovered over the paving. Counterweight crews built a timber cradle from the abandoned coronation dais and four council benches. Nobody asked whether furniture remembered its old purpose.

The ground shook again. Hairline cracks raced across the square toward the lower court.

Kharza came through the west passage with twelve Mahr soldiers carrying two

wounded between shield poles. Blood ran down the copper around her left tusk. The crack from Ember Ford had widened enough to show a dark line almost to the root. Each distant impact made her jaw flinch.

"West abutment will hold," Kharza said. Her speech blurred around the injured tusk. "North will not. Two galleries beneath Flood Bastion have joined. When Roe burns their props, the collapse runs south along the drain course."

"How far?" Maela asked.

"Past the outer wall gate. Possibly to the cistern stair."

Lessa arrived behind her and seized Kharza's chin. "You are done singing."

"I can still hear."

"So can I when you grind the split wider. Hearing does not make the act intelligent."

Kharza's eyes found Pell. "How many out?"

"Ten thousand three hundred sixty."

"Too few."

"Your contribution has been noted."

The bell settled into its cradle. Pell threaded the main hawser through the crown loop, around two basalt posts, and down toward West Sluice. Her missing fingers made the wet rope difficult to grip. A young Mahr mason braced it against her palm without comment. Together they reeved the final line.

Maela sent Kharza to command the inner-wall withdrawal. Kharza refused until Lessa cut away the copper wrap and bound her jaw with leather, muffling stone-song and speech together. The general left furious, which kept her moving.

At the cistern, the next barge took two hundred seated civilians and thirty stretchers. An Aeli baker tried to give his place to a sack of flour. Nim threw the sack aboard and kept him in the seat, solving the argument by capacity. Children wore wax tablets around their necks with names and destination marks. Shelter searchers checked each against district lists.

Count: 10,590.

The barge entered the submerged arch. Teams walked the tow ropes along ledges cut under black water. Overhead, the city sustained another series of blows.

Pell stationed herself at West Sluice. The sluice had once carried floodwater beneath the southern curtain. Its outer mouth opened downstream of Osra's main lines, but a steep run made uncontrolled descent fatal. With the palace bell rigged as drag weight, shallow evacuation skiffs could lower through one at a time. The first carried sixty walkers and no luggage. When the brake line tightened, the dais timbers groaned.

"Hold three turns!" Pell called.

Riggers locked the hawser around basalt. The bell lifted a finger's width from its

cradle. The skiff descended without striking either wall.

A second followed. Then a third.

The assault reached the outer gate while the fourth loaded. Heartland infantry poured through smoke beneath the gatehouse arch, using shield roofs against stones thrown from above. Vael defenders dropped the portcullis. It stopped halfway when fractured masonry blocked its groove. Men and women fought beneath the iron teeth.

Jorren's signal runner arrived without Jorren. "Captain says last cistern barge now. After it leaves, he seals the upper stair."

"His withdrawal route?"

"Gate gallery to the brewery tunnel."

Pell knew that route crossed the predicted collapse. "Tell him west stairs only."

"He says west stairs are carrying Lantern Ward."

"Then tell him to leave before the final column."

The runner's face answered. Jorren had already chosen where he stood in the queue.

Pell gripped the child's slate hanging at her own neck, the running total scratched and corrected until its surface resembled cracked ice. She wanted to go to the gate. She wanted to drag Jorren away by his injured leg. Neither desire altered the brake ratio.

Count: 11,830.

Smoke entered West Sluice. Enemy archers had reached roofs along the northern market and were firing toward the loading lanes. Maela sent the brewery archers to answer. Their arrows crossed over civilians crouched beneath wet hides.

A skiff jammed when a floating roof beam turned broadside in the channel. Sixty people halted under open sky. Pell shifted the bell line to lift the skiff's stern, then sent two swimmers with hooked poles. One swimmer took an arrow through the shoulder. The other broke the beam loose. Lessa's assistants hauled both out while the brake crews lowered the skiff.

Count: 12,070.

At midday, Flood Bastion lifted.

The stone did not fall at first. A hundred paces of wall rose on a bed of smoke and pulverized mortar as Osra's sappers burned the gallery props beneath it. For one suspended breath Pell saw daylight under the foundation. Then the bastion folded inward. Towers split. The curtain wall dragged the gatehouse with it. Thousands of tons of stone struck the north districts and sent a cloud across Vael that turned noon brown.

The shock snapped West Sluice's forward post.

Hawser tore through the brake crew. Pell hit the paving on her left shoulder. The

palace bell rolled in its cradle, crushing one timber and trapping a Vennik rigger beneath the other. Downstream, the loaded skiff accelerated toward the bend.

Pell crawled to the loose line. Her right hand could not close around it. She wrapped the hawser across her back and thrust her left arm through a loop.

"Second anchor!" she yelled.

Nim reached her first. Together they hauled the line toward an intact basalt post while workers levered the bell. A Mahr soldier shoved his shield through the crown loop as a temporary pin. The shield bent. The line caught.

The skiff struck the bend sideways, hard enough to throw people from benches, but it did not overturn.

Under the collapsed cradle, the trapped rigger made no sound. Pell touched their throat, found nothing, and ordered the body moved clear of the line. Grief had to wait somewhere it would not obstruct transport.

The north district vanished behind dust. Bells from three inner towers called retreat. Another horn continued at the cistern gate, one steady note that should have ended.

Jorren.

Pell ran toward it with Nim shouting after her.

Broken masonry blocked the direct stair. She climbed through a bathhouse whose upper rooms had collapsed into steaming pools. Defenders came south carrying wounded, shields, water buckets, and children found during the Lantern Ward search. Osra's infantry moved behind them through the breach in disciplined blocks. Tavan's officers directed the advance toward the surface Crown Hinge approach and the inner river gates rather than allowing a sack. That restraint made the attack more dangerous. It possessed an objective.

At the cistern gallery, Jorren held a crank that kept the flood gate raised.

A stone beam had fallen across his legs. Blood soaked the channel beneath him. Six civilians crawled under the gate while two scouts tried to lever the beam. Beyond them, the final barge waited in the tunnel current.

"Leave it," Jorren said when he saw Pell.

"An offensively poor order."

"Crank drops if I let go. Gate pins sheared."

Pell examined the housing. The right bearing had split. Without the crank's pressure, the iron gate would fall into the barge roof and block the tunnel. She could brace it with a counterweight if she had twenty minutes, two beams, and a crew not being shot at.

She had a broken spear, one intact pulley, and perhaps two minutes.

"Tie the crank," Pell told the scouts.

"Line slips off," Jorren said. His voice had thinned. "Tried twice."

A child crawled beneath the opening. Jorren's arms shook, and the gate descended a thumb before he forced it back.

Pell set the intact pulley against the cracked housing. Her missing fingers could not hold the pin square. One scout held it while she drove it with her tally punch. Enemy shouts entered the bathhouse behind them.

"Last barge has four hundred sixty," Jorren said. "That makes your number."

"I know arithmetic."

"You also lie when frightened."

The remark struck too close to the old ration ledger, to nine people shifted into hunger because Pell had hidden scarcity behind a corrected total. She met his eyes. "Four hundred sixty makes 14,200. The number will be published with your name and every person we fail to carry."

"Leave my name off the glorious part."

"There is no glorious column."

"Good."

The pulley seated. Pell ran line through it and around the beam, creating enough advantage for the scouts to lift one edge. Jorren tried to pull free. His face emptied of color. The beam moved no farther. Rubble had pinned him below the knees, and enemy boots sounded on the stair.

"Take the scouts," he said.

Pell looked at the crank, the gate, the barge roof sliding beneath it. No arrangement let him release his hands.

One scout began to protest. Jorren ordered him through in the flat voice of a captain. The man obeyed crying.

Pell put her left hand over Jorren's on the crank. "I can stay."

"You have fifty-five thousand eight hundred loads left."

"People."

"Then count them as people. Go."

An arrow struck the stone beside his head. Pell ducked, seized the final scout, and crawled beneath the gate as the barge moved. Behind her, Jorren held the crank. He held it while enemy soldiers reached the gallery. He held until the stern cleared.

The gate fell.

Iron hit water with a sound deeper than the battle. The tunnel went dark.

No one on the barge spoke. Pell sat among four hundred sixty civilians and listened to the gate scrape along its broken bearing behind them. Her tally slate had cracked in the fall. She fitted the pieces together and wrote the final total across both.

14,200 evacuated.

When the barge emerged at the downstream quay, she gave the slate to Nim. "Keep this with the tablets. If the city falls, the count does not."

"You are returning."

"Fifty-five thousand eight hundred."

Nim closed their hand over the slate. "I heard him."

Pell climbed the west maintenance stair with the surviving scouts. By then Osra controlled the outer wall, Flood Bastion, the outer river gates, and the broad surface approach leading toward Crown Hinge. Vael's defenders had withdrawn behind the inner districts. Kharza's coalition remained outside the breach, cut from the city by cavalry and falling stone. Her black-clay banners moved west under pressure. The copper binding on her left tusk had failed; Lessa led her away with blood dark across both their collars.

Maela waited at the lower-court door, holding it open for wounded defenders and civilians. Dust had turned her blue cloak gray.

"Jorren?" she asked.

Pell shook her head once.

Maela shut her eyes. Artillery struck again before grief could take a fuller shape.

"Osra's vanguard reaches the citadel court within the hour," Maela said. "We cannot hold the surface approach."

"Below, then."

They sent district messengers through the inner streets with orders to shelter rather than rush the lower stairs. The hinge chambers could hold command, healers, and only a fraction of the population. A stampede would kill people Osra's assault had not reached. Pell hated the choice. She entered it in the ledger anyway.

Crown Hinge's bronze doors closed on a column of survivors. Above them, Vael Tern's outer wall belonged to Osra. The cistern route lay sealed by Jorren's body and the iron gate he had kept raised. Beyond the buried stone, 55,800 civilians remained trapped among the inner districts.

Pell descended last, carrying no crown, no victory, and one blank slate she did not yet know how to fill.

Chapter 21 — Under the Crown Hinge

Kharza heard Jorren's death in the way Pell counted bandages.

"Thirty-six clean. Twelve boiled and drying. Nine for chest packing. Four reserved for the hinge team."

Pell knelt beside the lower court's dry fountain, sorting linen with her left hand while her right rested against her ribs. Dust whitened her slate-gray skin. She had written no name beside the empty place in her inventory, but each number came out clipped, stripped of the dry irritation that usually made scarcity answerable.

Kharza stood beneath the first arch and let Lessa tighten the leather around her jaw. The binding muted vibration through her left tusk. It did not stop pain. Every step of Osra's troops across the upper court traveled down the Crown Hinge and found the split in the tusk like a chisel entering a seam.

"If you sing again tonight," Lessa said, "I will pack your mouth with wool and assign two children to watch you."

"Children need sleep."

"Then behave more sensibly than they do."

Around them, the survivors of the retreat made a refuge out of a sacred court. Vael defenders lay beneath murals of seven river cities. Aeli healers shaved ruined cloth from burns. Mahr soldiers stacked ceramic shields into privacy screens. Vennik crews hung lamps from old bearing hooks and marked every step where the floor had lifted. Humans from Lantern Ward ladled water without asking which banner a cup belonged to.

Maela moved among the pallets in a gray cloak, still giving wall orders through runners because no one else held the whole defense map. Her face changed when she reached the scout captain's surviving pair. One scout gave her Jorren's knife and reported the last words he had heard. Maela listened without touching the weapon. Then she assigned both scouts to sleep before taking another post.

Grief had no place large enough to lie down. It stood beside every job.

From overhead came three muffled blows. Osra's engineers were clearing the surface approach. Dust sifted into the fountain basin. Refugees looked up, though thirty paces of hinge stone separated them from the assault.

Kharza felt the next pressure through both tusks.

Two notes.

She gripped the arch. For a moment Ashwall returned: refugees outside a ration line, stone rising under their feet, the Deep Hart pressing its shape through foundations built to carry only an upper sky. The outwork had sung in two pitches before it folded upward. She had believed the second note came from a fracture reflecting itself.

Here the lower note arrived first. A higher answer followed half a breath later.

"General?" Sevrin asked.

He stood near the fountain with a white film covering the places where leaf-filaments had burned from his temples. His eyes still saw the court, but no living thread connected that sight to constellations. He carried a brass pollen frame like a blind person's staff, tapping joints and listening to the grains trapped inside.

Kharza raised one hand for quiet. The court obeyed unevenly. Wounded people breathed. Water dripped. Above, iron scraped across stone.

Again: low pressure from beneath, then a thinner reply from somewhere west.

"Paired," she said through the jaw binding. "Not echo. Two load paths."

Sevrin angled his head. "How far apart?"

"Farther than the chamber."

Pell rose slowly. Pain tightened her mouth. "This court has two counterweight galleries on the royal plan. North and south."

"Royal plans omit useful populations," Maela said. "They may omit useful walls."

A palace mason brought three copied floor sheets from the archive alcove. The sheets showed Crown Hinge as one immense crescent below the citadel, with bearing chambers clustered along its inner curve. Kharza laid her palm on the floor. The first note ran across the crescent. The answer did not. It traveled downward at an angle no surface room could occupy.

"There," she said, pointing beyond the drawn foundation. "A road or gallery leaves the west bearing."

"Toward solid crust," the mason objected.

"Toward what your plan calls solid crust."

Pell had already begun checking wall joints. The lower court's western mural depicted the Inversion: two constellations separated by a band of black stone, with laborers standing upright on both sides of the band. Royal plaster covered part of the scene. Veka, the Mahr mason who had witnessed Maela break the seal, chipped at its edge with a healer's blunt knife.

Beneath the plaster, a row of small figures walked under the lower constellation.

"Not decoration," Sevrin said. He touched the pollen frame to the mural. Grains inside shifted toward the hidden figures. "Buried pollen pulls west and down."

Maela assigned twelve rested soldiers to guard the refuge, then led a smaller party through the western arch: Kharza, Pell, Sevrin, Lessa, Veka, and two Vennik riggers. No one argued over ancestry or rank. The people capable of reading the problem went.

The arch ended at a bronze grille thick with mineral scale. Royal records named it a drainage screen. No water had touched the dust behind it for centuries. Veka found hinge pins rather than pipe fittings. Pell inserted her bridge punch, worked

the lower pin free, and swore when her injured shoulder failed on the second.

Kharza took the bar. The motion pulled against her jaw. She used her weight instead of her tusks. Bronze yielded with a shriek.

Beyond lay a descending gallery wide enough for two counterweight sledges. Grooves ran along the floor. Each groove split at regular intervals into a shallow fan, then rejoined. Wear had polished the stone along both edges, forward and back.

Pell crouched beside the nearest split. "Sledges traveled down."

"And returned," one rigger said.

"Frequently. Look at the inner lip. A load dragged outward would not polish that face."

They followed the track. The air cooled until breath showed. Lamps revealed old knots of rope turned black and hard with mineral deposits. At every seventh pace, a number had been carved in four scripts. Royal masons had cut lines through three of them, but the depth preserved their shapes.

Sevrin traced an Aeli mark without pretending he could read its celestial sheen. "Measure of arc."

"How much?" Maela asked.

"One degree. Repeated."

The required words seemed too small for the distance beneath them. Kharza had watched Ember Hinge move that far and change rain across Varkesh. Here the same measure appeared not as an accident wrested from battle, but as a worker's mark repeated along a road.

At the gallery's end, the hinge root entered a chasm.

The buried sky shone below.

No roof enclosed it. Darkness curved away into impossible distance, pierced by constellations bright enough to throw shadows upward. The Deep Hart's antlers lay across the lower vault, each star veiled by drifting mineral cloud. Farther west, a river of blue points bent under the world. Between the gallery and that inverted firmament, a stone causeway descended along the hinge root until it vanished behind a luminous ridge.

Kharza's stomach tightened. Her body knew down from weight and up from breath, yet the lower stars asked both senses to renegotiate.

Pell gripped a handrail. "There are anchor sockets."

Square cuts lined the causeway, each matched by a worn circle on the opposite side. Portable counterweights could travel that road in stages. The old laborers had not merely reached the hinge from above. They had crossed its underside.

A narrow platform clung to the causeway's first bend. Bronze rails surrounded a stone table cut with channels. Pell went first on a safety line, testing each slab

before shifting her weight. Veka followed with one tusk exposed. Maela ordered the two soldiers to remain at the gallery mouth so a single collapse would not take every witness.

Sevrin crossed third. Without star-sight he kept one palm on the inner rail and asked Pell to describe every change in the lower constellation. He did not hide the care required. The loss at Salt Hinge had not made him helpless, but it had removed the private certainty on which his old authority relied.

Kharza watched from the gallery until the leather binding warmed with her restrained jaw. Sending others into a load path offended every habit she had once mistaken for duty. Veka glanced back only once.

"Your refusal authority works at a surprising distance," the mason called.

"I can revoke it."

"Then it would not be authority."

Pell reached the platform and brushed mineral dust from the stone table. Four recessed bowls occupied its corners. Between them, a set of straight lines crossed arcs divided into small units. Someone had driven a royal chisel through the inscriptions, yet the blows had struck shallow. Oblique lamplight revealed characters beneath the damage.

"Read what survives," Maela said.

Veka sounded the table with a knuckle. "Mahr line says the stress must answer from both roots before release."

Sevrin bent close to the Aeli arc. "This marks pollen drift before movement, then pollen drift after return. Not a completed exchange. A comparison."

Pell found a Vennik notation beneath the eastern bowl. "Load down, load reduced, load back. It gives ratios for every one-degree interval."

The hyphenated measure had come from a laborer's hand, not a royal tutor. Kharza felt anger move through her with unusual calm. Generations of court teaching had declared partial movement an emergency failure. Here, workers had recorded it as ordinary practice, with return loads and comparison marks precise enough for apprentices.

Maela examined the human river-city line. "Witness before advance. Witness after reversal. Each city records its own water mark."

"A cost map on stone," Pell said.

No one answered with triumph. The table could have belonged to a time when lower pressure differed, ropes remained fresh, and all four hinges answered together. An old instruction did not guarantee a present act.

A crack sounded under the platform.

Pell froze. Veka dropped to one knee and pressed her uncapped tusk to the slab. The causeway's inner edge shed a fan of chips into the sky below. They fell toward

the Deep Hart until darkness swallowed them.

"Outer bracket shifted," Veka said. "Weight inward. Slowly."

Kharza seized the safety line. Maela braced behind her. Sevrin moved only when Pell told him the path lay clear. He crossed first, one hand following the rail. Veka backed after him while keeping contact with the slab. Pell stayed at the table long enough to press wet cloth into the chiseled Vennik ratios, making a dark rubbing she could copy later.

"Leave it," Kharza said.

"This is leaving it efficiently."

The platform dipped another finger. Pell lunged for the gallery. Kharza and Maela hauled the line, dragging her across as the outer bracket pulled free. Half the platform rotated away from the hinge root. The stone table remained caught on its inner rail, tilted toward the lower stars but still legible.

Pell lay on the gallery floor and looked back at the hanging record. "We now possess a practical demonstration that ancient infrastructure also fails."

"Enter that prominently," Sevrin said.

Maela helped Pell sit. "We have instruction, wear, and a dangerous road. Nothing more."

Kharza listened to the two load paths answering the shifted platform. The paired notes changed in opposite directions. Added weight deepened the lower line; relieved weight sharpened the return. The relation offered information no single pitch could carry.

That, too, belonged in the test. Not proof of safety. A way to know when the stone began to refuse.

Lessa blocked Kharza from stepping onto the causeway. "Your tusk has contributed enough blood to public knowledge."

"I only need to hear the first span."

"No."

"Refusal authority," Pell said quietly. "You gave it to her."

The words hurt more cleanly than the tusk. Kharza stepped back. Command that mattered had to survive inconvenience to herself.

Veka took the forward place instead. She removed the clay guard from one tusk and pressed its tip to the handrail. "Two tracks," she said. "The causeway bears toward us and away."

Sevrin knelt beside a patch of pale growth in a socket. Without star-sight, he used a knife to lift one filament into his pollen frame. The trapped grains moved, first toward the Deep Hart, then toward a dim cluster behind them.

"Paired constellations again," he said. "One below the causeway's forward face, one behind Crown Hinge. The laborers may have aligned to both."

Maela studied the returning polish. "The court taught a single complete motion. Ordan's tutors described anything less as uncontrolled failure."

"Ember disproved part of that," Kharza said.

"Ember moved," Sevrin replied. "It did not move back."

That distinction held them silent.

Pell walked the gallery with a measuring cord. She counted fan-shaped splits, anchor sockets, and scars where old brake teeth had bitten the floor. Each fan covered the same narrow arc. Some scars pointed down the causeway. Others faced back toward the court.

"These are not construction marks," she said. "Builders do not polish return faces after placing a permanent load. Counterweight teams worked both directions."

"Could a retreating sledge make them?" Maela asked.

"Once, perhaps. Not this often. Look at the wear marks. Deep bite forward, shallow bite back, repeated at each arc measure. They advanced under full load and reversed under less."

Kharza listened through the intact right tusk. The low note came from Crown Hinge's weight against the causeway. Its higher partner trembled through a return line under the court. At Ashwall she had mistaken two structures answering each other for one wall breaking twice.

"We need a test," she said.

Lessa made a disgusted sound.

"Not a bearing," Kharza added. "A transfer between brake teeth. Enough to learn whether the second note answers."

Pell evaluated the nearest sledge frame. Its wood had rotted away, leaving stone runners and bronze eyes. The portable counterweights brought below during the retreat could supply a small trial load. Moving it across one fan would shift less mass than the bell Pell had used at West Sluice. Yet Crown Hinge multiplied every load through the roots of the city. Small did not mean harmless.

They returned to the lower court for a public decision.

Maela refused to authorize the test in the gallery alone. She called the provisional civilian seats from the previous day's charter, the surviving wall captains, Veka, Sevrin, Pell, and the healers responsible for people sheltering over the second load path. Kharza described what she heard. Pell drew the scars. Sevrin explained the paired pollen pull and named what remained unknown.

"No claim of safety," he said. "We have evidence of use, not proof that present pressure allows it."

A Lantern Ward delegate asked, "What happens if the old brake breaks?"

"The trial load runs six paces down the gallery," Pell answered. "It may strike the

second stop hard enough to crack the western refuge floor."

"Clear that floor first."

The order came not from Maela but from the people sleeping there. They moved their pallets, carried wounded neighbors east, and demanded chalk marks showing the danger line. When the space stood empty, Maela authorized one transfer with three conditions: no stone-song through Kharza's injured tusk, no pollen release, and immediate cutaway if either gallery note rose.

Pell built the trial from two water casks, shield fragments, and a portable counterweight frame. The load weighed less than a cavalry horse. Four Vennik riggers tied separate brake lines so no single failure controlled it. Veka read the forward path. Kharza stood by the return wall with her right tusk against a bronze hook. Sevrin held the pollen frame between both directions.

"First tooth," Pell called.

The riggers eased the frame down the polished groove. Stone runners crossed the beginning of a fan.

Crown Hinge answered with its low note. The court lamps dimmed as dust shook from their wicks.

"Hold," Kharza said.

The frame stopped.

A breath later, the higher note traveled back through the western floor. Not an echo. It carried less force and a distinct rhythm, exactly as the wear had promised.

Sevrin's pollen shifted toward the lower stars.

"Return it," Maela ordered.

Pell reversed the ropes. The frame resisted. The riggers leaned together, boots slipping on dust. For one terrible moment the load continued down despite them. Kharza heard the low note deepen.

"Cut forward line!"

A rigger severed it. Released tension snapped against the grille. Pell's return rope caught around the portable frame, and the load climbed back across the fan until its runner struck the starting tooth.

The higher note sounded first this time. The lower answer followed.

Nothing cracked. That proved only that the trial had not broken this chamber.

Pell sat on the floor, breathing hard. "Reversed across one brake interval."

"With a load too small to move the bearing," Sevrin said.

"Yes."

Maela looked toward the hidden road. "To prove more, someone must take counterweights onto the causeway and measure the hinge from below."

Above them, Osra's soldiers hammered at the sealed upper doors. The rhythm

had become organized. They would enter the lower court eventually.

Kharza studied the refuge: wounded enemies treated side by side, citizen delegates guarding a test line, Pell grieving through arithmetic, Maela holding authority without claiming a throne. Defeat had driven them under the structure they had fought to reach. It had also placed them beside an older route no royal plan admitted.

"Small party," Kharza said. "Pell leads the weights. Sevrin reads the pollen. Maela carries public authority. Veka reads stone in my place."

"And you?" Maela asked.

Kharza touched the leather over her cracked left tusk. "I hold the court and make Osra pay for each stair."

Lessa approved by saying nothing.

At dawn, the first expedition lamps moved onto the causeway. Their light descended toward the buried sky, along paired tracks worn by workers who had once carried the heavens forward and back one degree at a time.

Part IV

Chapter 22 — The Road Across the Buried Sky

Pell lowered the first counterweight sledge onto a road that had stars beneath it.

Four Vennik riggers eased the brake ropes while Veka Olt walked backward along the hinge root, one uncapped tusk touching the bronze rail. The sledge carried eight basalt blocks, two water casks, a coil of river hawser, food for three days, and every measuring pin Pell had recovered from Vael's bridge stores. It weighed slightly less than two draft mules and had no opinion about the direction in which it hung.

Pell envied it.

Below the causeway, the buried sky curved through luminous dark. The Deep Hart stretched along the lower vault, its points connected by veils of amber mineral cloud. A blue constellation Pell did not know seemed to pour uphill into the western distance. Dust fell from Crown Hinge and became a faint rain toward those stars.

"Brake three," she called.

The riggers locked the line around a stone tooth. The sledge stopped at the first fan-shaped split. Its rear runner lifted, settled, and remained on the road.

Maela stepped onto the causeway behind Sevrin. She wore no royal insignia. Chalk arrows marked both sleeves, a precaution Pell had added after watching three soldiers vomit at their first sight of the inverted firmament. Sevrin carried two pollen frames and a folded copy of the cost map. The burned skin at his temples remained smooth. He asked Veka to name every change in stone pitch and asked Maela to describe every change in starlight.

Six soldiers completed the party, two human defenders, two Mahr fault-readers chosen by Kharza, and two Vennik riggers from houses other than Vask. Twelve people total. More bodies might have fought better. More food, water, and rope would have left no capacity for the test weights.

At the gallery mouth, Kharza stood with her jaw bound. "Three days," she said around the leather. "After that I close the western arch if Osra enters the court."

"You will leave before closure," Maela said.

Kharza looked at her until the instruction became a request rather than an order. "I will use my refusal authority."

Lessa gave Pell a packet of willow bark and salt. "For balance sickness. Do not let Maela stand after she says she can. Humans lie about dizziness because their pride lacks a useful organ."

"Vennik never do that."

"Of course not."

Above them, Osra's hammers struck the upper bronze doors. The defenders had braced those doors with rubble and the abandoned coronation stool. Each impact traveled through the road.

Pell released the brake. Their expedition descended.

The first six spans followed Crown Hinge's inner curve. Ancient lamps hung empty in wall niches. Mineral growth covered the counterweight teeth, forcing riggers to clean each stop before trusting it. By the ninth span, the gallery roof fell away. Only the causeway remained, a carved ledge along dark stone with the lower firmament visible from both sides.

They tied themselves in pairs.

Pell paired with Maela because neither commented on the choice. Their rope measured twelve paces. Long enough to permit work, short enough that one fall would make the other person's decision immediate.

"This resembles our courtship," Pell said while checking Maela's knot.

"I remember fewer basalt blocks."

"You attended different evenings."

Sevrin smiled without turning. The humor lasted only until they reached the broken span.

Thirty paces of causeway had collapsed. A lower maintenance rib crossed beneath the gap, narrow as a roof beam and canted toward the stars. Anchor sockets survived on both sides. The old route had used a suspended counterweight bridge, but its timbers and ropes had vanished.

Pell inventoried what they possessed. River hawser could cross the gap twice. Bronze pins could anchor the lines. Sledge runners could become bridge rails if she dismantled one frame. Doing so would leave only one sledge for the demonstration and force them to abandon half the supplies on return.

"We need two frames to balance the bearing station," a rigger said.

"We need one frame to reach it," Pell replied.

Maela studied the lower rib. "Can people cross first and rebuild from the far side?"

"People, yes. The weights, no."

Veka pressed her tusk to the near anchor. "The rib carries. It dislikes the center."

"How specifically?"

"Enough to object. Not enough to vote."

Pell sent the lightest rigger across on hands and knees with a guide line. Every movement produced a faint note through the stone. Sevrin monitored pollen drift, which angled toward the Deep Hart when the rigger reached the rib's center.

Maela recorded the change by touch marks cut into a wax slate. No observation remained private.

They built a cradle under the surviving sledge. Two hawsers took its weight from above while the lower rib guided its runners. Everyone except Pell and Veka crossed first. Pell controlled the forward brake; Veka called stone stress. The sledge hung over the buried sky.

Halfway across, one ancient anchor rotated in its socket.

"Stop," Veka said.

Pell stopped breathing with the ropes. The sledge swayed beneath the gap. Basalt blocks knocked against one another.

A Mahr soldier on the far side drove a fresh pin into a secondary socket. Maela redirected the guide line without waiting for rank to organize the hands around her. Sevrin called the pollen angle. When the second line took strain, the old anchor tore free and fell through amber cloud.

The new pin held.

They brought the sledge up on the far side. Pell sat against it until her inner ears agreed that stone beneath her still counted as ground. She ate willow bark before Lessa's warning could become relevant.

The causeway bent away from Crown Hinge after the gap. No handrail survived there. Old rope holes marked the inner wall, but mineral frost had widened several until Pell could fit her wrist inside. She rejected them and spent one bronze pin per twelve paces. At that rate, the supply would not reach the bearing station.

A buried weather front solved nothing.

Silver cloud climbed from the blue constellation below and struck the hinge root without wind. Light moved through stone. Every loose metal fitting began to hum. The forward sledge tried to slide sideways across a level road as celestial pressure pulled at its basalt load.

"Down!" Veka shouted.

The party clipped harnesses to the new pins. Pell threw both sledge brakes and watched the first pin bow outward. A soldier caught the rear line around his waist before it tore free. Sevrin's pollen frames brightened inside their wrappings.

"Which direction?" Pell called.

His Aeli assistant opened one cover by a finger. "Toward the road's outer edge. Fast."

"Move living weight inward. Blocks outward."

People crawled against the hinge wall. Riggers shifted two basalt blocks to the exposed runner. The cloud's pull took the stone rather than the frame, forcing that runner down. Pell hated using loss as ballast, but a block could fall without leaving a family on either side of the war.

Pressure increased. One outer strap snapped. The basalt blocks slid together, struck the runner, and cracked it.

Pell cut both lashings.

The blocks left the causeway. Their release slammed the sledge inward, trapping her boot between frame and wall. Maela braced the frame while a Vennik rigger worked Pell free. Pain flashed up her ankle. She could move every toe. The test mattered because later she would have to stand on it.

Silver cloud streamed past for six hundred breaths. Sevrin counted by touching knots along a cord. Veka reported the stone pitch at each hundred. Maela recorded which anchors bent and which held. Even sheltering became evidence if witnesses refused to call it mere endurance.

When the pressure passed, three bronze pins had failed and one sledge runner required splinting. They possessed too little hardware for the station brakes unless they recovered material. Pell sent teams back to the broken span, where the abandoned ancient anchor had left a bronze collar in the rock. It took half a day to cut free. From that collar they forged six rough pins on a charcoal pan, hammering them against the sledge bed.

The delay consumed water. Maela reduced every person's ration equally until Veka objected that larger Mahr bodies doing loaded work required more. Pell revised the shares by exertion instead of ancestry or rank. Sevrin surrendered none of his own portion, explaining that pollen judgment degraded with dehydration before thirst felt severe. Expertise included naming when sacrifice became sabotage.

By night they had repaired the runner and replaced the failed anchors. Pell marked the silver front on the cost map, including two lost blocks, one strained ankle, reduced water, and six hundred breaths during which the road could not be crossed. A future bearing plan would need weather intervals, not merely degrees.

They slept clipped to the inner wall. Buried stars moved below their eyelids even after every lamp went dark.

On Day 44, they reached the first lower bearing station.

Four stone arches met around an open circle. Each arch faced a different hinge direction. Channels in the floor held fossil pollen, bits of old counterweight chain, Mahr listening cups, and human witness marks showing river heights. The sky lay below the circle through a shaft without a bottom Pell could see. Along its rim, twelve broad divisions each contained twelve smaller cuts.

"Not for a full exchange," Maela said.

"No," Pell answered. "For stopping."

The station joined Crown Hinge to a return bearing deep in the root. Two counterweight beds faced each other. Moving the loaded sledge into the forward bed would relieve pressure from Crown's west shoulder. Shifting the empty frame

into the return bed could pull that pressure back. The geometry matched the scars under the lower court, scaled across a much larger arc.

A royal mason had smashed the return-bed brake. Pell found its bronze teeth scattered in a drainage channel. She and the riggers rebuilt six teeth, enough to cover one measure and reverse it. Veka listened at every anchor. Sevrin placed one pollen frame toward the lower sky and one toward Crown Hinge. Maela read aloud the witness limits agreed below: halt for a sharp rise in either stone pitch, pollen reversal beyond one division, water loss from either cask greater than one hand, or balance sickness affecting two people.

"We have no coast height," Sevrin said.

"No Rootglass hive response," Maela added.

"No Ember or Salt teams in position," Veka said.

Pell looked at the rebuilt brake. "Therefore one measure out, one measure back. No farther."

They spent the rest of the day rehearsing release without a live load. Each person knew which rope to cut, which tooth to lock, and who could call a stop. Any one of the four labor groups could halt the test for immediate bodily danger. Resuming required all four. It took longer than a command from one mouth. That delay belonged to the structure, not to inefficiency.

During the night, buried starlight changed color. The Deep Hart faded behind a current of silver cloud. Cold moved upward through the shaft and glazed the brake ropes. Pell woke every hour to inspect them. Sevrin remained beside the pollen frames, unable to read their glow without assistance. He asked each waking guard for a description and recorded differences in raised marks he could later follow.

Near dawn, Maela said, "You have not slept."

"Neither have you."

"I am not controlling the brake."

"No. You merely represent fifty-five thousand eight hundred trapped people and several regions threatened by our mistakes. Restful work."

Maela sat beside her. Silence gathered without turning comfortable.

"Jorren disliked memorial speeches," Maela said.

"He requested omission from the glorious column."

"Did you promise?"

"I told him no such column exists."

Maela rubbed a thumb over the chalk arrow on her left sleeve. "Good."

Pell wanted to take her hand. The rope between them, coiled nearby, already represented as much trust as either could responsibly carry. She offered willow bark instead. Maela took it.

They began at first buried dawn.

Veka and the second Mahr listener occupied opposite arches. Sevrin's frames stood in the pollen channels with one Aeli assistant describing color and movement. Maela took the river-city witness mark. Pell and three Vennik riggers staffed the brakes. Soldiers waited beyond the cut lines with axes and wet cloth.

"Forward load to first tooth," Pell said.

The sledge moved into the bed. Crown Hinge's low note entered the station through the western arch.

"Stone holds," Veka reported.

Pollen rose from the lower frame in a pale spiral. Sevrin listened to the assistant's description and placed two fingers on the raised scale.

"Drift within first division."

Maela watched water tremble in the casks. "No loss."

"Second tooth."

Riggers eased the sledge deeper. The station tilted no more than a ship crossing another vessel's wake. Far above, beyond miles of stone, Crown Hinge began to accept the changed load.

At the third tooth, Pell felt pressure close around her ears. One rigger staggered. She called hold before he fell.

The Mahr listeners compared notes. Pollen drift remained inside the agreed division. Maela ordered the dizzy rigger replaced and recorded the bodily cost. He protested until Pell pointed at the written limits. Rules became meaningless if pride could overrule them.

They advanced again.

At the sixth tooth, a sound passed through the lower vault. Not thunder. Every visible point of the Deep Hart shifted by the width of a fingernail. Amber cloud streamed sideways. The forward pollen frame opened into light.

"One degree," Sevrin said.

Crown Hinge had moved.

Pell locked the brake. Nobody cheered. The station groaned through all four arches, and hair lifted on Maela's arms. Water climbed the inner side of both casks against weight.

"Lower note rising," Veka warned.

"Pollen at limit," Sevrin said.

Maela stared toward the causeway. "The road is turning."

It had not moved. Pell saw that at once. Yet Maela stepped as if the floor had rotated beneath her. She reached for the west arch and caught empty air.

Pell crossed the witness line, seized her harness, and lowered her to the stone. "Eyes closed. Name my hands."

"Your left at my shoulder. Right on the buckle."

"Which way lies Crown?"

Maela pointed toward the lower sky.

Temporary disorientation counted as one person affected, not two, but the water had violated its limit and Veka's note continued to rise. Three stop conditions.

"Reverse," Maela said from the floor.

Pell confirmed each labor. Veka: reverse. Sevrin: reverse. Maela pressed her palm to the river-city mark: reverse. Pell released the return brake.

The empty frame moved into its bed while crews hauled the loaded sledge back tooth by tooth. The first pull achieved nothing. Pressure held the forward runners against bronze.

"Increase return load," Pell ordered.

Soldiers transferred two basalt blocks to the empty frame. That reduced the hands available on the rope. Pell took a position with them. Her right hand slipped once; she caught the line against her wrist and leaned with her full weight.

The sledge came back one tooth.

Crown Hinge answered from above. The star points shifted toward their former marks.

At tooth four, frost broke from the ropes in sharp flakes. A brake pin bent. One rigger drove Pell's tally punch through the secondary eye, sacrificing the tool to hold the load.

"Pollen returning," Sevrin called.

"Stone pitch falling," Veka answered.

Maela remained seated with her eyes closed, speaking every witness observation onto the wax record. Her voice stayed steady even when she named her own failure to orient.

Tooth two. Tooth one.

The loaded sledge returned to its start bed. Pell locked both lines. Across the lower sky, the Deep Hart's points settled on their first chalk alignments.

Sevrin's assistant inspected the frames. "Forward pollen folded back. Lower frame matches the starting angle."

Veka listened along both arches. "Paired notes restored."

Water dropped to level inside the casks. Some had spilled, less than two fingers. Pell measured it rather than deciding the amount looked small.

"Reversed," she said.

The one-degree movement had gone out and returned. The station still stood. Their bodies carried the cost: one rigger vomiting beside the arch, Maela unable to point toward Crown for the next hour, Pell's ears ringing, Veka bleeding lightly

where stone-song had split the skin around her uncapped tusk. Safe did not mean harmless. It meant limits had been stated, witnessed, and obeyed before harm became catastrophe.

By midday Maela could follow the chalk arrows correctly. Pell made her repeat the route six times before allowing her to stand without a guide rope. The disorientation eased, but its warning remained in every record.

They copied measurements onto wax, cloth, and skin. Pell scratched the six brake ratios along her forearm in case water destroyed the other copies. Sevrin sealed lower pollen in a brass tube for Irel. Veka carried paired pitch intervals in a Mahr cadence she repeated at every stop.

The return crossing took a day because the broken span had worsened. They abandoned one sledge frame and all but one basalt block. Soldiers carried Maela across the narrow rib on a safety line despite her objections. No one used the successful test to excuse carelessness.

Osra's troops had entered the upper lower-court stair when the expedition reached Crown Hinge. Kharza's defenders held them behind a wall of broken benches. Refugees crowded the western refuge, ready to retreat farther if the court failed.

Pell handed Maela's wax record to the civilian seats. Sevrin displayed the pollen tube. Veka sang the outward pitch and its returned answer. Pell laid her scratched forearm beside the cost map.

"One degree moved," she said. "One degree reversed. We know the required load, the brake sequence, the stone limits, the pollen limit, and the first bodily costs. We do not know what happens at Rootglass or along Neris unless their witnesses and labor join us."

A shelter delegate read the figures twice. "What do we call a plan that stops before it takes too much?"

Pell looked at the six brake teeth, each one a decision rather than a failure to complete the old command.

"A staged Turning," she said.

For the first time, the phrase named measured proof instead of hope. Runners carried it upward through the refuge with the limits attached.

Chapter 23 — Where the Star-Bees Returned

Sevrin found the first dead orchard by smell.

Rootglass trees had once given off a mineral sweetness before dawn, sap rising through translucent roots while star-bees warmed inside clay hives. Now rot lay under the cold air. Branches clattered without leaves. Salt from the displaced marsh tides crusted the irrigation cuts three days' journey inland.

He stood at the edge of the terrace and waited for someone else to describe the light.

"Cloud shade from the north," said Evi, the Aeli apprentice who had crossed the buried road with him. "Upper stars faint. Rootglass under the soil has a green seam, but it breaks near the lower channel."

Sevrin touched the brass tube inside his coat. Buried-sky pollen clicked softly against its seal.

"Be precise about the break."

Evi counted tree rows and named the direction using orchard markers rather than constellations. Sevrin followed her account across the terrace. Before Salt Hinge, he would have read every influence directly through his leaf-filaments. The loss had removed speed, not responsibility. He asked twice as many questions and accepted that answers arrived through other people's senses.

Irel's guards met them at the ninth terrace. Green-glass plates covered their shoulders. Half were Aeli gardeners; the rest included human orchard tenants and Vennik irrigation workers whose livelihoods belonged to Rootglass without granting them seats on its old council. Bows remained lowered but strung.

"You brought six people and a tube," Captain Ruunel said. "Osra's riders brought six hundred. Which threat should concern us first?"

"The one already in your roots," Sevrin answered.

Ruunel looked at the smooth scars on his temples. Pity entered her face before discipline removed it. "Irel will hear you. She promises nothing."

They walked beneath branch nets toward the surviving inner orchard. Star-bees moved nowhere. Empty clay hives hung among trees whose leaves had turned the gray of old metal. Workers painted root wounds with lime. Children carried water in paired cups because single heavy buckets cracked the glassy soil.

At the council house, Irel Saan had removed every carved shutter from its windows. Nothing obstructed sight lines to the terraces. She sat at a long workbench with the queen-hive under her left hand.

The hive resembled a wide clay jar wrapped in root fiber. Warmth pulsed through its wall. Irel had hidden it through the Sunken Observatory fighting and carried it back after Salt Hinge moved. Her leaf-filaments spread silver around her

head, healthy enough to catch the faint upper pattern. She did not rise for Sevrin.

"You have brought lower pollen into my orchard," she said.

"Sealed."

"Pressure does not respect brass indefinitely."

"Neither does a dying hive."

Irel's fingers tightened on the root-fiber wrap. "You lost the right to diagnose what I protected."

Sevrin accepted the blow. "I did."

The council expected argument. He gave them the figures instead.

Three years earlier, Neris shipping orchards had lost eight queen lines under the fixed sky. Rootglass had lost twenty-three. Sevrin had combined the totals in the guild report and blamed salt mites, fearing that a regional split would cost both enclaves Crown support. Neris obtained shade cloth and new comb. Rootglass received inspection teams that found fault with local pruning.

"I concealed the unequal loss," he said. "My silence helped turn your damage into incompetence."

A gardener across the table cursed him. Another asked how many Rootglass children had missed leafing because relief went to Neris. Sevrin did not know. He said so.

Irel watched him without satisfaction. "Why tell us now?"

"Because any plan requiring your trust must begin with the reason you should withhold it."

He placed copies of the lower-station measurements on the bench. Evi described the proof while Sevrin answered technical questions. One degree outward. One degree reversed. Pollen response measured on both paths. Water displacement recorded. Bodily injuries named. Limits that had stopped the test before pressure rose farther.

"A staged Turning," Irel said, tasting the new phrase as if it might contain poison.

"A bounded possibility. Not a promise that Rootglass survives."

"Osra promises it survives if no one turns anything."

"Your dead western terraces give her answer."

Irel carried the queen-hive to a window. "And the Neris flood map gives yours. Movement kills somewhere."

"Then both places must witness each stage and stop it when the mapped cost crosses the agreed line."

"You ask me to place the last viable queen under a court assembled during siege."

"No. I ask you to test what she chooses."

Sevrin set the brass tube beside the hive.

The council moved to the migration terrace at noon. Irel chose the site: a narrow corridor between living inner trees and a western block written off after salt burn. Irrigation crews opened two channels, one carrying clean spring water and one carrying the brackish pulse that had followed Salt Hinge's movement. Children and nonessential workers left the area. Guard teams took roofs and root trenches. Osra's riders still camped beyond the northern ridge under a truce negotiated when Irel had supported fixed custody.

Evi laid white cloth over the rootglass. Any pollen movement would show as color. Irel placed three empty worker combs along the corridor. Sevrin opened his instrument cases without touching the queen-hive.

"You release her," he said.

"You interpret the lower pollen," Irel replied.

Their opposed skills had caused years of conflict. Irel could read the hive's immediate health through upper-star leafing. Sevrin understood paired migration and coastal weather. Neither could perform the other's labor now, and that incapacity protected the test from private certainty.

Irel unwrapped the hive.

Worker bees emerged first, ordinary-sized and dark except for flecks of pale dust along their legs. They circled the mouth but refused the upper-pollen comb. The queen remained inside. A low agitation moved through the jar.

Sevrin broke the brass seal.

Buried-sky pollen held no brilliance he could see. Evi described it as amber with a blue edge, the colors of the Deep Hart cloud and the unknown river constellation beneath Crown Hinge. Sevrin used a bone spoon to place one measured grain on each of two western combs.

The worker bees stopped circling.

One landed on the first grain. Its abdomen lowered. Others followed until the cloth seemed to gather a small dark tide. They carried the pollen toward the hive, touched antennae at its mouth, and returned to the corridor.

Inside the clay jar, the queen moved.

Irel inhaled sharply. Her leaf-filaments lifted despite the still air. "She reads the lower pair."

"Does she accept it?"

"Wait."

The queen emerged into noon.

She had not grown monstrous or divine. She remained a thumb-length insect with a heavy abdomen and one damaged wing. Workers supported her across the

root-fiber lip. At the first western comb, she touched buried-sky pollen and began the slow abdomen movement that marked a chosen lay site.

Evi laughed once, then covered her mouth.

Irel did not laugh. Tears stood along her lower lids. "The corridor reaches her."

A horn sounded from the northern ridge.

Green-glass guards turned toward the council house. Two signal flags rose above the trees: Osra's white grain sheaf and Irel's old truce mark. Captain Ruunel watched through a tube.

"Envoy party," she said. "Thirty riders. Two wagons."

"Too many for an envoy," Irel replied.

Another horn answered from the western terraces. Smoke lifted behind the dead orchard.

Osra's agents had waited for the hive to open.

The first arrows carried clay bulbs rather than iron heads. They broke among the outer trees and released oil. Riders came down the irrigation lanes while hidden teams ignited the western block, driving heat toward the migration terrace. Their objective did not require holding Rootglass. Fire could kill the exposed queen and destroy evidence that threatened Osra's fixed-sky claim.

Irel closed the queen-hive wrap. "Inner vault."

"Smoke follows the channel," Sevrin said. "Move her east and you cross the upper-pollen rows. She may reject the comb and leave the workers exposed."

"Fire comes from west."

"Which means they expect east."

Ruunel confirmed riders moving behind the council house.

Irel looked at the brackish channel, the living inner trees, and the lower-pollen comb where the queen remained. "Down through the root drains."

"Water will take her."

"Not if you reverse the clean channel."

Sevrin understood. Rootglass irrigation operated through paired cups cut into the mineral soil. Opening one lowered pressure in the other. If crews reversed the spring gate, flow would pull smoke west while exposing a dry maintenance tunnel beneath the migration terrace.

"Your roots will take salt," he said.

"Western block already has. Name the cost and move."

Irel assigned guards to delay the riders without pursuing. Sevrin ran with irrigation workers to the spring gate. He could not read the blue sheen that showed pressure through rootglass, so Evi called the line as he turned the wheel.

"Two marks. Three. Hold."

Smoke flattened, then moved toward the western channel. Salt water surged into the sacrificed block. Living trees along its edge shed leaves in a single gray wave.

At the terrace, workers lowered the queen-hive into the maintenance tunnel on a sling. Irel descended beside it. Sevrin followed with the buried-sky pollen and both frames. Above them, arrows struck rootglass with bell-like cracks.

The tunnel offered crawling height. Clay pipes crossed between tree roots that glowed faintly through stone. Workers passed the hive hand to hand. No single person carried it far enough to claim custody through rescue.

A blast closed the passage behind them. Oil had reached a dry root pocket. Heat chased air through the tunnel. Bees poured from the hive mouth and gathered on its cool underside.

"Forward fork blocked," a worker called.

Two routes remained. The north drain led under the riders. The south line emerged in a nursery where two hundred young trees grew under shade cloth.

Irel touched the soil. Her filaments leaned north. "Upper-star pressure opens the rider line."

Sevrin lifted a pollen frame. Evi, coughing beside him, described grains pulling south.

"The lower pair opens toward the nursery," he said.

"Fire follows us there."

"Only if the clean channel continues west. Close it after we pass the branch. Flood the tunnel behind us."

"That sends brackish water into the nursery."

"For less than one hundred breaths."

Irel made the decision. "South. Ruunel, tell the gate crews: close on our third rope tug, reopen at one hundred."

The line moved. Sevrin crawled ahead, counting branch joints by touch. Behind him, Irel kept one hand on the queen-hive and one on living roots. Their knowledge pulled in different directions and created a route neither would have chosen alone.

At the third rope tug, water struck the tunnel.

It came cold and salted, filling the passage to Sevrin's elbows. Burning oil hissed behind them. Workers lifted the hive over their heads. Bees covered their wrists without stinging. Sevrin lost his pollen tube, caught it against a pipe with his forearm, and shoved it into Irel's free hand.

The south grate appeared as a pale square. Guards broke it outward. The party emerged beneath nursery shade cloth while brackish water spread ankle-deep among young roots.

"Count," Irel ordered.

Sevrin counted one hundred breaths. At eighty, several saplings darkened. At ninety-four, the flow slowed. At one hundred, clean water returned from the spring gate and pushed the salt back.

The nursery lived. Some leaves would fall. The cost remained visible.

Battle continued above for less than an hour.

Ruunel had divided the inner orchard into irrigation squares before the riders reached it. Each square possessed two gates and one raised glass walk. Her defenders withdrew along those walks, forcing mounted troops into channels too narrow to turn. Human tenants used pruning hooks to pull riders from saddles. Vennik water crews opened gates behind them, leaving horses knee-deep in mud without drowning either animals or soldiers.

Osra's agents still held the council house and the northern pump. Their oil wagons waited on high ground. If they reached the spring wheel, they could send fire along the clean channel and burn every inner terrace at once.

Irel saw the threat through her leaf-filaments. Upper starlight reflected from oil skins beyond the shade cloth. Sevrin could not see that pattern. He asked Evi for the rider count, Ruunel for the available routes, and the irrigation workers for channel capacity.

"Northern pump has a stone overflow," one worker said. "Open it and the terrace floods."

"Including the nursery," Irel replied.

"Not if we use the old root cistern," Sevrin said. "The fixed-sky repairs sealed its western mouth, but lower pollen pulled toward it in the tunnel."

Irel understood the implication. "You want to open a buried channel under armed riders."

"I want their horses standing on a roof instead of ground."

The root cistern had not carried water for forty years. Its glass cover might collapse under pressure and kill everyone above. Irel sent a warning horn before she accepted the risk. Ruunel's guards withdrew from the northern pump in deliberate disorder, inviting pursuit. The riders took it.

Sevrin and three workers crawled to the sealed western mouth beneath the nursery. Old mineral mortar filled the gate. He found its edges by touch while Evi described the pollen glow. They drove pruning wedges into the seam. On the terrace overhead, hooves struck glass.

"Again," Sevrin said.

The workers swung mallets. Mortar cracked. Brackish water from the temporary flood pushed against the far side.

Irel called through the speaking pipe. "Oil team moving south. Twenty breaths."

The third blow freed the gate.

Water entered the root cistern and lifted decades of silt. The roof did not collapse at once. Its panels flexed, turning the riders' footing into a wavering mirror. Horses shied. Ruunel's archers shot oil jars rather than bodies, spilling fuel into water before the fire teams could light it.

One agent reached the spring wheel with a torch. Irel crossed the glass walk alone, silver filaments streaming behind her. She carried no bow. Instead she cut the shade-cloth release. A weighted sheet dropped between the torch and the channel, smothering its flame. The agent struck her with the handle. Irel fell against the wheel but held the cloth rope until guards arrived.

At the cistern mouth, the roof began to split.

"Out," Sevrin ordered.

A young worker stayed to close the gate. Continued flooding would undermine the living terrace. Sevrin went back, seized the worker's belt, and pulled her clear as the first glass panel collapsed. Water and two riderless horses fell into the cistern. The remaining troops scattered toward the northern ridge.

Ruunel could have closed the retreat. She left one irrigation square dry and announced it by horn. Soldiers who dropped fire pots received passage. Most did. A Heartland officer tried to ignite the nursery while withdrawing; an Aeli guard from Irel's own faction shot the torch from his hand and then accepted his surrender.

The fighting ended without pursuit. Rootglass needed every able body for fire lines and injured trees. Human orchard tenants captured two fire teams. One team consisted of Heartland soldiers under written orders from Tavan's deputy; another included Aeli workers whose families depended on Osra's grain guarantee. Irel forbade revenge killings. She took their testimony and locked the oil wagons under mixed guard.

Afterward, the cost map gained another square: northern root cistern broken open, two horses injured but alive, one glass walk destroyed, Irel bruised across the shoulder, one young worker pulled from collapse. The tactical success had preserved the spring wheel by sacrificing old storage and another piece of orchard floor.

When the smoke thinned, the western block had burned to black ribs. Eleven guards and workers were dead. Thirty-two carried wounds. The queen-hive remained warm.

At dusk, Irel reopened it in the nursery. Workers flew first to the buried-pollen comb. The queen followed and settled beneath a young tree whose roots still held a faint amber trace.

"Buried-sky pollen," Irel told the assembled council. "Accepted by the surviving queen. The corridor can function under a bounded bearing. It also costs one western block and salt injury to this nursery under today's attack. Both enter the record."

Sevrin gave the council his concealed Neris figures, signed without guild

privilege. Irel added written safeguards: physical custody remained with Rootglass until a public bearing court ratified shared terms; access required Irel plus an Aeli witness from outside her faction; any pollen release required published migration and water maps; Rootglass could call a pause with one other delegation, never alone.

"You will not hold the hinge alone," Sevrin said.

"Neither will you."

"Agreed."

Irel pressed her seal into the document. Sevrin signed only as witness, not starwarden. Ruunel added the orchard guard. A Vennik irrigator and a human tenant signed for workers the old council had excluded.

The queen-hive stayed beneath Irel's hand. Its future access entered shared custody through the safeguards, pending the court that would bind every delegation. Rootglass Hinge opened its lower galleries to mixed teams. Green-glass guards packed for Vael.

Before dawn, Irel gave Sevrin one living comb wrapped in nursery cloth. "You carry evidence. I carry the queen."

"And if either of us fails?"

"The other tells the truth about the cost."

They left the burned terraces together, not reconciled, not subordinate, and carrying the fourth labor toward war.

Chapter 24 — The Bridge of Four Banners

Kharza put her good tusk against the relief bridge and heard three hundred civilians trying not to breathe.

They lay below the deck on evacuation barges, hidden beneath wet reed mats while Osra's archers watched both banks. Children had cloth tied over their mouths. Wounded adults held the barges against the piers with padded hooks. The old bridge carried their shelter through its stone footings: a quick, frightened vibration beneath the heavier song of armed feet.

Above, the west half belonged to Kharza's federation. The east half belonged to Aruk Venn.

Between them rose a broken lifting span chained in the open position. Vael Tern stood beyond Aruk's Reed lines, outer districts smoking behind the breached wall. Maela's blue-river signals waited at the inner quay. To the north, green-glass flashes marked Irel's orchard guard approaching along the flood embankment.

Four banners had been assigned to the plan. Only one had reached the bridge.

Kharza lifted her tusk from the parapet. The leather around her cracked left side tasted of blood each time she breathed. Lessa had packed the split with resin and wrapped the jaw again. Singing through it could drive the crack to the root. She would listen through the right and trust other fault-readers with the rest.

"Load report," she said.

Veka stood at the first pier with two younger Mahr. "Western arch holds. Center pier takes uneven pressure from the raised span. Barges touching underneath add little weight, but their hooks pull against the current."

Pell's bridge crews had fixed counterweight baskets to the lifting chains. If they lowered the span, Kharza's fighters could cross. If Osra's engineers released their upstream boom, timber and fire barges would strike the hidden evacuees before the span settled.

"Enemy?" Kharza asked.

A Kiln scout pointed. "Four thousand Reed began this war under Aruk. Losses and detachments leave near three thousand here. Heartland archers behind them. Incendiary crews at the upper quay."

Aruk's silver-cap banner hung over the eastern tower. Its polished circles flashed whenever smoke opened. He had promised to meet Kharza at the bridge. Neither of them had promised what meeting would produce.

Kharza called her commanders beneath the black-clay banner. Kiln House speakers, imperial defectors, and the Reed splinter captain stood in a half circle. She repeated the objective: lower the span, open a relief route, protect the barges, do not pursue a retreat beyond the eastern tower.

"Any commander may refuse an order that loads the bridge beyond Veka's mark or exposes the barges to fire," she said. "Name the reason and offer another action if time permits."

The imperial captain frowned toward Aruk's tower. "If Reed troops break, we should finish them."

"No. We need their river knowledge and we need the route. Revenge offers neither."

"They drowned our west camp."

"Enter that cost after the battle. Do not add a city to it."

Pell raised a red flag from the counterweight station. Ready.

Kharza gave the advance.

Ceramic shields moved onto the deck in overlapping rows. Heartland arrows struck black clay and burst into chips. Imperial pikes followed at half length because the bridge allowed no full formation. Reed splinter fighters climbed below the parapets, using repair ledges their cousins across the river knew equally well.

Aruk did not contest the first thirty paces. He let Kharza's line enter the narrow center, then opened sluice gates in the eastern tower.

River water surged through channels cut beneath the deck. The old bridge rolled sideways by a hand. Fighters lost footing. One counterweight basket swung into its frame and cracked a timber upright.

"Hold shields!" Kharza shouted.

Veka called from the pier. "Center pressure rising. Two notes."

Aruk had turned the bridge itself into a weapon without striking the civilian barges. Kharza recognized the restraint and the danger. His people understood marsh crossings as load and current, not merely ground.

She signaled the Reed splinter captain.

The splinter fighters dropped from repair ledges onto the west sluice wheel. Aruk's defenders met them below the deck. Kinship produced no hesitation. They fought over handles in water to the waist, one group protecting Osra's line because autonomy had been promised, the other attacking because fire orders had broken their confederacy's conditions.

Pell's crews released the first basket. Stone descended; the lifting span lowered a fraction. Enemy engineers cut one secondary chain. It whipped across the deck, killing two imperial pikers and tearing a shield from Kharza's hand.

The raised span stopped halfway.

Its western hinge pin had twisted under the cut chain. Pell waved two yellow flags from the counterweight station: mechanical obstruction, ten minutes if the deck stayed clear. Ten minutes on an exposed bridge could consume a company.

Kharza ordered the Kiln line into the bridge alcoves. Imperial pikes angled over

them, points covering the narrow center without adding feet to it. The maneuver yielded ground Aruk could have taken. He did not advance. Instead his front ranks locked shields at the east rise and waited for the bridge to choose a side.

Below, one evacuation barge drifted out of alignment.

A padded hook had slipped from the north pier. Current turned the bow across the arch. If it rotated farther, the barge would emerge into Heartland bow range. Nim climbed onto its roof and tried to reset the hook, but the line fell short by two arm lengths.

Kharza pointed to the Reed splinter captain. "Can your swimmers reach it?"

"They can. The center pressure sings above Veka's limit. Putting people in the water adds no deck load."

"Do it."

The captain refused. "Archers have the angle. Give us shield cover from the upper ledge first."

Kharza swallowed the instant command that rose in her. The reason held. She redirected six ceramic shields to the north parapet. That weakened her approach line and opened a gap Imperial soldiers had to cover. Only after the shields overlapped did four Reed swimmers enter the current.

Aruk saw them.

He raised one hand. His archers lowered bows along the water angle. Heartland archers behind them did not. Their first volley struck the bridge piers and one swimmer's upper arm. She rolled, surfaced, and kept hold of the line between her teeth.

Kharza sent slingers against the Heartland position. Aruk's officers protested when stones passed over Reed shields. He moved his front rank half a pace east, widening the target. The act protected civilians without joining Kharza. Every allegiance still carried edges.

Swimmers reached the barge. Nim threw down a tow line. Two took it around the north pier while another cut the tangled hook. The wounded swimmer braced against the hull, blood dispersing in the current.

On deck, Pell's crews crawled beneath the lifting chain. They carried wedges instead of weapons. A Heartland skirmisher climbed over the eastern parapet and ran toward them. An imperial piker stepped from Kharza's line to intercept, placing his weight on the raised span.

"Back!" Veka shouted.

The piker ignored her. He killed the skirmisher and took another step.

Stone cracked below.

Kharza reached him, caught the rear of his cuirass, and dragged him off the center boards as a seam opened where his foot had landed. "When the fault-reader

refuses your weight, she commands the ground beneath you."

"He would have killed the crews."

"Then throw your spear next time."

The soldier looked toward Veka and offered a stiff apology. She pointed him to the south alcove without accepting or rejecting it.

Under the span, riggers hammered the bent pin free. The chain dropped half a link and trapped one worker's sleeve. Pell cut cloth away with her teeth and passed in a smaller wedge. Her injured shoulder kept her from swinging a mallet overhead, so a human wall mason struck while she called angle changes. Vennik expertise directed; another body's strength supplied what injury denied.

The barge straightened below. Civilians hauled the swimmers onto its roof. The wounded orc pressed a wet mat around her own arm and took the hook line again.

At the east tower, Osra's officer ordered another volley. Aruk stepped in front of his archers. Kharza could not hear the words across the bridge, but she saw the argument travel through Reed ranks. Some bows stayed down. Others rose toward her line.

Pell's first yellow flag vanished. One remained.

A siege stone came from the north terrace without warning. It struck the western approach behind Kharza's main formation. Ceramic shields, bodies, and paving lifted together. The blast did not break the bridge, but retreat compressed toward the deck.

Kharza turned and shouted, "Hold west of the load mark!"

Fear drove soldiers forward anyway. The imperial captain planted his pikes across the approach, barring his own allies from safety. Kiln speakers opened side lanes into the river warehouses. People moved off the bridge rather than onto it. Distributed commands prevented a crush that Kharza could not have stopped from the center.

Smoke revealed the casualty hollow. Lessa crawled into it with medics while stones still fell. Kharza wanted to go back. Her job held at the center until the pin cleared. She remained, hating the discipline she had once imposed on others and now imposed on herself.

Pell raised a green flag.

The twisted pin came free. Counterweight crews took up the chain one careful hand at a time. The span lowered another pace, enough that a fighter could climb its slope without adding a leap to every step.

Aruk advanced then.

Not with his whole line. He came alone for the first ten paces, making clear that the meeting belonged to two commanders rather than a rush against workers. His long marsh spear rested across one shoulder. Silver covered both tusks.

Kharza handed command of the western load mark to Veka. If Kharza fell, the bridge objective would continue without waiting for vengeance.

Kharza climbed onto its slanted boards. Arrows passed over the low edge and struck higher as she ascended. She used a dead soldier's shield until three shafts split it. Ahead, Aruk came down from the eastern tower with a long marsh spear and silver caps on both tusks.

They met where the lifting span peaked.

Aruk thrust for her injured side. Kharza turned enough that the spear grazed the leather wrap. Pain flashed white. She caught the shaft under her arm and drove her shoulder into his chest. He yielded one step, planted, and used the bridge's roll to throw her off balance.

Neither fought like the trade songs imagined orcs fought. No roaring, no test of brute strength. Aruk used reach and current timing. Kharza read board stress and weight transfer. Each tried to place the other where the bridge would decide.

"Osra has lost the city outer wall already," Kharza said between strikes. "What remains of her promise?"

"A marsh treaty with a seal," Aruk answered. "You offer councils that change when armies need roads."

"Then hold us to writing."

"After you cross over our bodies?"

He swept her ankle. Kharza fell to one knee. Her cracked tusk struck the shield rim. Resin broke inside the split. She tasted blood.

Aruk stopped the spear point one finger from her throat.

A white grain-sheaf signal rose from Osra's upper quay.

Three red lamps followed.

Aruk looked past Kharza. His soldiers on the eastern bank hesitated. The signal repeated: burn all craft beneath the bridge. No exception for evacuation marks.

Nim's hidden barges began to move. Wet reed mats slipped from one bow, exposing wounded civilians.

Kharza saw Aruk understand the order. "Your condition was no civilian burning."

"I know my condition."

"Then choose it."

He could have killed her first. The spear remained steady. Kharza did not reach for her knife. A decision made under her blade would make him subordinate to force, and he would never accept that place.

Upstream, Osra's incendiary crews pushed six tarred barges into the current. Fire teams waited with arrows. The floating boom opened.

Aruk lowered his spear.

He pulled the silver cap from his right tusk.

Bare mineral veining met the bridge's song. His face changed. Through cultural choice he had damped that resonance for decades, refusing upland claims that stone hearing defined Mahr worth. Removing one silver cap did not undo that choice. It let him hear this particular bridge.

The civilian vibration reached him first. Then came the center pier, cracked by the lifting strain. Last came the six fire barges striking current upstream.

"The bridge fails if they hit," Aruk said.

"Yes."

He turned toward his banner crew. "Reed condition invoked. Refuse incendiary order. Take the upper quay."

Half his nearest soldiers moved immediately. Others remained frozen between Osra's written treaty and their war speaker. A Heartland officer shouted that refusal constituted treason. Aruk struck the officer's sword aside without harming him.

"The Confederacy named its limit before we marched," Aruk called. "No civilian burning. Those who keep that law, with me. Those who choose Osra, withdraw from the bridge."

The Reed line split.

Some companies lowered spears and backed toward Vael. Two held position under their captains. Most turned on the incendiary crews. Silver-cap shields advanced along the upper quay while Heartland archers pivoted in confusion.

Kharza rose. "Your command remains yours."

"Keep it that way."

Aruk ran east to lead his people.

The fire barges entered bow range. Reed archers shot the tow ropes on the first pair. One grounded against the north bank and ignited harmless mud. Another rotated broadside, blocking the third. The remaining three came on.

Pell signaled that the lifting chain could not lower while the center pier carried combat. Kharza ordered her forward ranks back ten paces. An imperial captain refused, pointing to Aruk's exposed rear.

"Reason?" Kharza demanded.

"We can take the tower now."

"That violates the objective. Withdraw."

He held her gaze, then obeyed. Distributed refusal did not remove command. It made its reasons visible.

With the center load reduced, Pell released both counterweight baskets. The lifting span descended. Broken chain dragged across planks, throwing sparks. Veka and her fault-readers sang a low corrective note through the west pier. Kharza

heard but did not join; her injured tusk had begun pulsing with every syllable she spoke.

The first fire barge reached the bridge.

Nim's evacuation crews cast padded hooks around its prow. Civilians below the deck hauled alongside Vennik riggers above, turning the burning hull away from the central pier. Flames crossed the wet reed mats. A child passed water buckets between two wounded adults. Nobody waited for rescue to become passive.

The barge struck the south arch. Stone held. Fire climbed its outer face.

A second tarred craft followed. Reed fighters on the quay dropped a sluice gate before it arrived. The diverted current caught the barge and drove it into Osra's own empty siege wharf.

The third came under the nearly lowered span.

Aruk reached the east wheel and released a flood pulse. Pell saw his intent. She raised one counterweight basket, lifting the span just enough for current to pass below. The fire barge shot through without touching the civilians and emerged downstream, where Nim's empty towboat guided it onto a gravel spit.

For one breath, the bridge belonged to water rather than either army.

Then Maela's blue-river banner appeared above the eastern tower.

Her sortie came through a tannery lane from Vael's inner districts. Defenders carried short shields suited to streets, not fields. Shelter workers rolled carts behind them with water and stretchers. They struck Heartland archers from the city side, opening space for Aruk's refusal companies at the quay.

Osra's loyal Reed captains could have trapped Maela against the tower. One withdrew instead. Another joined Aruk after seeing civilians under the bridge. The third attacked and lost the wheel room in close fighting. Their choices remained separate.

From the north embankment, green-glass armor flashed.

Irel's orchard guard arrived with Sevrin walking beside the living-comb cart. They did not charge the bridge. Aeli archers took the flood dike and shot the ropes of Osra's remaining oil wagons. Orchard tenants opened a drainage cut that flooded the approach behind Heartland reinforcements. The guard secured the north abutment, keeping the relief route from closing as soon as it opened.

Pell dropped a green flag.

The lifting span settled onto its stone rest.

Kharza's black-clay formation crossed first, shields outward rather than leveled against Aruk. His Reed silver-cap banner joined from the quay, still under his command. Rootglass green glass came down from the dike. Maela's blue river flew above the eastern tower.

Four banners stood on the same bridge.

No cheer could erase the bodies on its planks or the fire along the south arch. Kharza ordered lanes left open for healers and evacuation traffic. Pell's crews inspected every chain before allowing supply wagons across. Veka limited the bridge to one company or two wagons at a time. Each commander accepted the restriction.

Aruk returned with soot across his face and one tusk bare. He held the removed silver cap in his palm.

"My treaty with Osra ends on her breach of the no-burning condition," he said. "Reed forces join the bearing action under their own banner. We claim equal marsh authority, separate ration accounting, and one seat in every decision that changes salt or flood."

"Agreed as terms for emergency alliance," Kharza said. "Final terms require public court."

"And if the court refuses?"

"You keep your army and your refusal."

Aruk extended his bare right hand. Kharza clasped it. Neither knelt.

Behind them, relief wagons began crossing into Vael. Evacuation barges emerged from under the deck and moved toward the downstream quay. The route opened slowly, under a load limit, while Osra's fractured companies withdrew toward Crown Hinge.

Kharza looked at the four banners and felt no desire to place one above the rest. The bridge carried them because each remained distinct enough to bear its own weight.

Chapter 25 — The Bearing Court

Maela opened the bearing court in a warehouse whose roof had burned away.

Morning showed through black rafters. Rain fell on the center aisle and ran between benches made from barge planks. Beyond the missing east wall, the relief bridge carried food into Vael under Pell's load limits. Wounded soldiers occupied the dry loft. Prisoners from three armies received water beside them.

No palace door could close this room.

Maela stood at a chalked square rather than a dais. The broken royal seal remained on the council table across the city, beyond enemy lines. She wore the plain blue cloak of Crown Marshal and kept one hand on a witness rail polished by dock labor.

"This court has authority for the emergency bearing only," she said. "It cannot appoint a dynasty, settle every marsh border, or excuse any crime committed during the siege. It can decide whether and how we redistribute present sky pressure, and who may stop us when the cost exceeds what we have named."

People filled the warehouse and the riverbank outside. Mahr Kiln speakers sat apart from Reed delegates. Rootglass gardeners shared a bench with Neris sailors who expected flood from the same movement the orchards needed. Vennik bridge houses yielded front seats to evacuation workers. Vael shelter circles, Heartland deserters, coast towns, human river wards, and refugees sent witnesses. Caldryn's copied clauses hung in four scripts from the rafters.

Pell brought the cost map on sailcloth.

It covered the wet floor from wall to wall. Blue thread marked Neris water rise. White clay showed salt movement through Reedwater. Amber dust traced heat relief across Varkesh. Green glass marked the Rootglass migration corridor. Black counters represented Vael's remaining trapped population and the routes by which they might shelter during each bearing.

"Every benefit gets a loser," said a capped-tusk observer from Sul Venn. "Name them before anyone names victory."

Pell began with Varkesh. Ember pressure would ease if the lower Deep Hart moved farther into exchange, bringing steadier highland rain. Heartland grain warmth would weaken as the Cinder Net shifted. Families already living on reduced siege rations could lose a late harvest.

A Heartland farmer stood from the prisoner section. "How much?"

"First estimate: one part in twelve under the proposed arc," Pell said. "Confidence low because royal surveyors destroyed two field series."

"Then say low confidence in the law."

Nim Vask wrote it into the rule text.

Reedwater came next. Salt Hinge's present position threatened nursery pools if pressure rose without controlled drainage. Aruk named marsh channels that must open before the second action. A Reed fisher challenged him on three settlements omitted from his army map. Aruk added them publicly and assigned his own reserve barges to carry their young and nets.

Rootglass required lower pollen to keep the migration corridor alive. Neris required time to move harbor families above the third-stage flood line. Sevrin read the old concealed figures before anyone could use his expertise without its history. Irel read the orchard losses and the safeguards agreed at Rootglass. Neither asked forgiveness from the other.

Witnesses then tested the map against lives its symbols had compressed.

A Reed woman named Hessa carried a nursery basket to the chalk square. No child lay inside. White salt furred its woven base. She turned it over on the sailcloth beside Aruk's marsh channels.

"We moved eggs from South Mirr when the first hinge shifted," she said. "Your army map says the settlement can take another hand of water. It cannot. The reed beds uprooted. If salinity crosses Pell's fifth mark, there is no return route for spawning fish. Do not write crop loss. Write nursery loss, and write that recovery takes three summers if it comes."

Nim replaced the term. Aruk moved the pause line below Pell's fifth mark and assigned two additional barges. Hessa did not thank him. Her testimony had purchased less risk, not generosity.

A Heartland miller came next under prisoner guard. His left ear had burned away at Vael's breach. He placed a handful of weeviled grain on the Cinder Net sector.

"One part in twelve assumes our southern stores remain dry," he said. "They do not. Reed cavalry cut the mill road before they joined you. Osra's requisition took seed grain from three districts. Shift warmth at the wrong week and your estimate doubles."

"What warning shows that week?" Pell asked.

"Red mold under the husk. It appears two days before the heads bend."

The court added field inspections before the second action and reserved relief wagons from the recovered siege stores. Several Vael residents protested sending grain outward while inner districts remained hungry.

Maela called a shelter delegate rather than answering herself.

Edris of Lantern Ward stood with mortar dust still in his hair. "We have fifty-five thousand eight hundred people who did not fit through the cistern route," he said. "That fact does not turn every sack beyond our walls into ours. But no stage advances if Crown's lower refuge cracks or Osra drives civilians onto the hinge approach. We need shelter counts at every bell."

The map gained black counters at six refuge districts. Each counter required a human runner and a second witness from another people, preventing a military commander from reporting a threatened district empty for convenience.

From Neris, a Salt Aeli navigator named Seli brought tide cords knotted by harbor mothers. She challenged Sevrin's blue flood line because it treated stone quays and floating homes alike. Floating homes rose with water but broke when moorings reached full stretch. Stone-cellar residents drowned sooner, often without boats.

"Three different thresholds," Seli said. "One coast cannot be one line."

Sevrin redrew it as braided thread. Irel asked whether buried-sky pollen might change the current before height increased. Seli did not know. That uncertainty entered as a requirement for live reports rather than a guessed answer.

A Varkesh terrace worker objected to the phrase highland rain benefit. "Rain on cracked ash becomes a slide," he said. "We need slower water before we need more water. Open the old kiln channels before first action."

Kharza assigned Kiln companies to drainage instead of assault reserve. The decision reduced troops available at Crown Hinge. Nobody called the exchange free.

Last came a displaced family from the farms outside Vael. Osra had cleared their village for siege earthworks; coalition cavalry had later taken their surviving mules. The mother asked which delegation represented people whose field no longer belonged to any functioning region.

The court had no prepared seat.

Maela felt the old temptation to promise inclusion later, after urgency passed. That delay had built every locked door beneath Crown Hinge.

"Refugee witnesses choose one rotating cost recorder now," she said. "Not under the river-city delegation. Beside all four, with authority to challenge any map that treats displaced people as belonging to the land that expelled them."

The family selected an older human midwife from the riverbank crowd. A Mahr refugee and an Aeli tenant joined her as alternates. They received their own slate and space at the witness rail.

By the time testimony ended, the sailcloth had become harder to read and more accurate. New threads crossed old colors. Objects weighed its corners: salt basket, damaged grain, tide cords, a refugee's mule bell. The plan lost elegance with every person it admitted.

At midday, the court divided into four bearing delegations.

Kharza Olt and Aruk Venn represented Mahr labor, each retaining separate political authority. Sevrin Ael and Irel Saan represented Aeli pollen work and its contested regions. Pell and Nim Vask represented Vennik counterweight labor, bridges, and evacuation. Maela took the river-city place with one rotating delegate

each from Vael, Neris, and the Tern Heartland.

A Salt Aeli navigator objected. "One coast voice rotates while two orchard keepers remain fixed."

"Then Neris chooses who rotates and may replace them between actions," Maela said. "The emergency structure will not become permanent by habit."

"Who controls the queen-hive?" asked a Rootglass tenant.

Irel set the wrapped clay hive on a four-handled cradle. "I retain care of the queen. Access now requires my hand, Sevrin or another public Aeli witness, a Vennik load record, and the river-city cost mark. No one carries her alone."

Sevrin placed his living comb beside it. Shared custody entered physical practice when Pell, Nim, a Neris witness, and a Rootglass worker sealed the cradle latches together.

The court turned to the plan.

Four actions would exchange twelve degrees across the hinges. Each action covered three degrees, but every degree retained its own brake interval. Crown coordinated; Ember, Salt, and Rootglass answered through separate teams. No hinge could advance after another group called a stop until the relevant cost map had been read again.

"That sounds like four chances for an army to interfere," a Vael captain said.

"It also gives civilians four chances not to drown," Pell answered.

The first action would relieve Crown pressure enough to prevent the lower chambers from folding into Vael. The second would open the Rootglass pollen corridor while Reed teams adjusted salinity gates. The third carried the Neris danger. Coastal bells, harbor heights, and evacuation barges would report before any advance. The fourth would settle the twelve-degree exchange only after every hinge answered inside its limit.

A Neris sailor laid a wet knotted cord across the map. "Our pause threshold: water reaches the seventh harbor knot, two tide stairs over present height, or three evacuation bells fail to answer. Any one condition stops the third action."

Irel added Rootglass limits: queen agitation beyond the marked pattern, pollen folding away from both paired constellations, or breakage in the nursery corridor.

Aruk named salinity and child-transport thresholds for Reedwater. Kharza named paired stone pitches that signaled an unstable load. Pell named brake heat, rope stretch, and inner-ear injuries among counterweight crews. Maela entered Vael's shelter capacity and structural movement in Crown Hinge.

"Who may pause?" Caldryn asked.

The old Compact had given each equal bearer a veto. Royal copies had erased all but human command. Restoring a single absolute refusal to each group now risked allowing one captured delegate or factional leader to halt every action for private advantage.

Debate lasted two hours.

Kharza favored one-labor refusal for immediate bodily danger. Aruk demanded protection against Kharza's former habit of calling every tactical delay disobedience. Irel insisted that ecological injury could appear before human instruments confirmed it. Pell warned that any rule requiring consultation during a snapped line would kill riggers.

They agreed on two forms.

Any labor crew could stop its local work immediately for direct danger. Resuming required all four delegations at that hinge. A strategic pause across the entire bearing required two delegations plus a published cost map showing a threshold crossed. No single delegation held an indefinite veto alone. No commander could punish a lawful stop during the emergency action.

Nim read the clauses aloud. Shelter delegates repeated them from the riverbank so the crowd beyond the warehouse could hear.

Then Kharza rose.

Her left tusk remained wrapped in leather darkened by old blood. The black-clay banner hung behind her. Soldiers across the warehouse still called her General, a title that had gathered three armies and could gather them again around one mouth.

"I relinquish sole command of the bearing assault," she said. "Military actions remain under their separate banners. Hinge labor answers to the four delegations and the witnessed limits. I command the Kiln formation until the emergency court closes, not Aruk's Reed force, not Irel's guard, not Vael's sortie."

Aruk stood beside her without taking her title. "The Reed Confederacy accepts coordinated objectives under this court. We do not swear to General Olt."

"Recorded," Nim said.

Maela felt part of the room loosen. Not trust. A load transferred into several supports.

Ratification used no crown seal. Each delegation pressed tools into wet clay: Kharza and Aruk placed opposite tusk-cap edges; Sevrin and Irel marked a comb frame; Pell and Nim used counterweight pins; Maela and the rotating human delegates pressed the river-depth rod. Refugees, coast witnesses, marsh settlements, Heartland prisoners, and Vael shelters signed the cost map itself.

The last question concerned Osra.

Maela wrote the surrender offer in plain language. Osra could stand down the upper court, release all hinge workers and civilians, preserve her right to public defense, and enter mixed custody pending trial. Her soldiers would receive food and safe disarmament. No office, marriage, or secret exile formed part of the terms.

Tavan Roe received the document under a white flag at the Crown approach.

She returned an hour later with Osra's answer written across the bottom.

The Queen-Regent recognized no court assembled by rebels under military occupation. She would accept Maela's coronation, Mahr and Aeli advisory seats, and a delayed survey after the Heartland harvest. She would not surrender royal command of Crown Hinge.

Tavan handed the page to Maela. "She also ordered me to prepare the upper lock."

"Will you?"

"I command until her order targets the civilians sheltering below. After that, I decide in the moment."

It was not defection. It was a limit.

Maela placed Osra's refusal beside the ratified map. Outside, four banners moved toward their assigned approaches. The queen-hive cradle left under shared hands. Counterweight wagons crossed the bridge. Neris bells began passing the evacuation signal coastward.

The bearing court had not made peace. It had made the coming danger lawful enough to stop.

Chapter 26 — The Great Turning

Maela entered Crown Hinge through the door her ancestor had built for servants.

It opened behind the upper court's west brace, too narrow for shields and half flooded by a broken bath conduit. Pell went first with a counterweight pin between her teeth. Maela followed on hands and knees, sword scraping stone, while Vael's river company waited in darkness behind her.

Beyond the wall, Osra's soldiers braced the royal doors against assault from the public court. The servants' passage bypassed them. It also opened beneath an iron stair guarded by two engineers.

Pell struck the first behind the knee with her pin. Maela caught the second before he could ring the alarm bell. She put him against the wall and felt him stop resisting when three more blue-river soldiers emerged from the conduit.

"Drop your hammer," she said. "You receive quarter."

He did.

At dawn, four banners moved against one objective: open Crown Hinge long enough for four witnessed actions. Kharza's black-clay troops held the lower western galleries. Aruk's silver-cap companies took the river stair and protected evacuation signals. Irel's green-glass guard escorted the queen-hive cradle toward the pollen court. Maela's blue-river sortie aimed for the upper lock. No formation commanded another. Pell and Nim directed counterweight labor through every line.

Osra held the upper court with Heartland infantry, engineers, and Tavan Roe's remaining siege companies. Three royal lock bars crossed the bearing shaft. If engaged together, they could force Crown to accept one command without the outer hinges. The shortcut had preserved fixed seasons before by sending unmatched strain outward. Under present pressure, a full royal lock might shear Vael's foundations and bury the lower court.

Maela reached the stair landing and signaled attack.

River soldiers climbed. Engineers rolled barrels down at them. Pell kicked open a drain gate; water caught the first barrel and turned it sideways. The second broke against it. Soldiers used both as cover, advancing one landing while arrows struck the iron treads.

From the public court came Kharza's horn. First brace engaged.

Maela took the upper landing. A Heartland captain met her with a hooked sword, driving for the gap beneath her cuirass. She caught the hook on her crossguard and used the narrow stair to deny him reach. He yielded only after Maela's soldiers reached the platform behind her. Several defenders dropped weapons. Others withdrew toward Tavan's central line.

The upper court opened around Crown Hinge's shaft. Rings of dark stone descended farther than torchlight. Three brace towers rose around it, each linked by bronze walks. Royal mosaics showed human rulers laying hands on a simplified sky while the other laborers stood below carrying tools. Fresh barricades blocked the pollen court and counterweight galleries.

Tavan waited at the central bridge in siege armor stained with mortar. "Crown Marshal."

"Marshal Roe. Order withdrawal and safe disarmament. The bearing court offers food, treatment, and public trial."

"The Queen-Regent rejects its authority."

"Do you?"

Tavan looked toward the lower refuge. A new royal order hung from her belt. Maela could see the grain-sheaf wax.

"My troops hold the bridge," Tavan said. "Yours have families under it. Advance and the shaft becomes a grave."

"Your engineers know the same."

The first assault halted. Battle noise continued in surrounding galleries, but neither line entered the central bridge. Maela used the pause to bring civilian witnesses through the servants' passage. Edris from Lantern Ward came with a black refuge counter. Seli of Neris carried harbor cords. Hessa brought the salt-stiff nursery basket. They took places behind cover, present where royal bearing had once admitted only command.

Osra's voice carried from the eastern tower. "Tavan, clear the pollen court. Burn the hive if they enter."

The order found every soldier on the bridge.

Tavan closed her eyes. "There are civilians behind that barricade. Rootglass prisoners."

"Then move them."

"No route remains."

"The hinge cannot pass to rebels. Execute the order."

Tavan drew the royal message from her belt and broke its wax in her fist. She turned to the officers beside her. "I will not burn the pollen court. Units choosing lawful surrender cross west with weapons grounded. Units remaining under the Queen-Regent withdraw east. No fire."

One officer stabbed her below the shoulder plate.

Maela's soldiers surged. Tavan caught the attacker's wrist, but blood darkened her sleeve. Heartland companies split across the bridge. Some struck their former comrades. Others threw down weapons. Pell crawled under the railing and pulled the fire-release chain free before anyone could use it.

Maela reached Tavan as the marshal sagged. "You are under mixed guard."

"Captured?"

"Alive."

"I have had worse mornings."

Healers carried Tavan west. Her refusal collapsed the central defense without erasing the battles she had directed. Maela sent her written orders with two witnesses.

Second brace engaged, Aruk's horn reported.

That left the north brace and pollen court under Osra's control. Maela divided the river company rather than driving everyone toward the royal wheel. One file followed Edris to the refuge stair, where Heartland soldiers had begun forcing civilians upward as cover. Another joined Irel's guard at the pollen barricade. Maela kept twenty soldiers for the counterweight gallery.

"Twenty does not take a brace tower," her captain warned.

"Twenty prevents its engineers from locking Pell out. We do not need the tower if the labor holds."

The gallery ran behind a screen of carved kings. Defenders had knocked holes through the royal faces for arrow slits. Pell sent two Vennik riggers beneath the screen with flat boards over their backs. Arrows struck wood while they crawled to the first weight bed. Maela's soldiers advanced in pairs, one shield high, one low.

At the third royal face, boiling mash poured from above. It had come from Vael's seized kitchens, food turned into a weapon while inner districts starved. The low shield caught most of it. Two soldiers screamed where it entered their boots. Maela ordered the pair carried back and saw that the spilled mash already cooled into edible paste along the floor.

"Save what has not touched blood," she told Edris.

He stared at her.

"There are hungry shelters. Use clean buckets."

The absurd labor began under arrows. Refugee workers scraped food from protected corners while soldiers held the screen. War contained no material too humble to matter.

Pell's crawling riggers reached the bed and removed its retaining pins. The unloaded frame rolled across the gallery, struck the carved screen from behind, and broke two kings off at the knees. Maela's company went through the opening.

Engineers defended their ropes with axes. One Vennik worker fighting for Osra cut a brake line and shouted that royal stores had fed her house through three failed winters. Pell answered that surrender preserved her right to testify. The worker dropped her axe only after Maela's captain swore the terms in front of Edris.

They took the gallery with six wounded and three dead. Osra's engineers lost four dead; eleven surrendered. Pell immediately mixed both crews according to skill. Former enemies began replacing the brake line they had fought over.

The north brace remained.

Aruk's Reed fighters approached it through a flooded stair. Kharza's Kiln troops occupied a dry gallery on the other side. A royal gate separated them. Neither commander could hear the other clearly through Crown Hinge, but their runners met at Maela's position and laid out competing plans. Kharza proposed cutting the gate pins from dry stone. Aruk proposed raising water until buoyancy lifted the gate.

"Cutting takes thirty minutes," Kharza's runner said.

"Raising risks the refuge drain," said Aruk's.

Maela asked the local fault-readers and water crews. Veka's assistant reported weakened lintels above the dry side. A Reed sluice keeper said one hand of water would lift the gate without reaching the refuge, provided a downstream screen opened first.

"Aruk's plan with a witnessed water mark," Maela decided. "Kharza's troops clear the lintel fall line and secure the raised gate."

The runners departed without needing either command absorbed into the other.

Water rose through the stair. The royal gate shuddered, floated a finger, and jammed on mineral scale. Reed swimmers passed lines beneath it. Kiln soldiers hauled from the dry side. When the lower edge lifted high enough, Kharza crawled through first despite Lessa's shouted objection. Aruk entered from the opposite stair. Together their troops seized the north brace wheel.

Third horn. Brace ready.

At the pollen court, resistance worsened.

Osra's guards had driven Rootglass prisoners into the outer chamber and tied their wrists to hive racks. Archers waited behind them. Irel refused a shot through her own workers. She sent green-glass climbers along ceiling irrigation pipes instead. Sevrin stayed below with the living comb, using descriptions from two apprentices to identify where upper-star light entered the court.

"Close the eastern shutters," he said. "Open the lower pollen vents."

A captured gardener protested that the lower vents had been sealed under royal order.

"Then unseal them."

Workers broke plaster with counterweight hammers. Buried pollen rose in pale dust from Crown's lower channels. The queen stirred inside her clay hive. Worker bees slipped through the cradle wrap and flew toward the ceiling pipes.

The swarm did not attack. It followed pollen over the prisoners, making their

outlines visible through dust. Irel's climbers could see the empty spaces between bodies. They dropped on the archers there.

Fighting spread through the hive racks. Maela arrived as a guard dragged one bound prisoner toward an open shaft. She crossed the chamber, caught his belt, and put her sword against the joint of his mail. He released the prisoner. Another guard shot at Maela; an orchard tenant blocked the arrow with a clay hive lid.

Sevrin called locations from the apprentices' reports without pretending he could see the pollen himself. Irel changed shutter angles from above. Their opposed knowledge turned the chamber's light into a map. Rootglass prisoners ducked when lower pollen brightened around hostile movement.

The final defenders surrendered when the queen-hive workers gathered on the bearing channels rather than dying in sealed air.

Irel cut the prisoners free before touching the queen. Sevrin ordered every opened vent measured. The battle had altered pollen flow; using old ratios would convert rescue into a hidden error. A Neris witness and a Rootglass worker recorded the new current together.

Only then did they carry the queen-hive toward Crown's center.

Across the upper court, Maela could now trace the whole assault by labor rather than conquered ground. Kharza and Aruk held three brace approaches. Pell possessed the counterweight beds. Irel and Sevrin held the pollen court. Civilian witnesses had reached every station. Osra still controlled the east royal lock, and that single control could endanger all the rest.

The queen-hive cradle reached Crown's center under Irel, Sevrin, a Rootglass worker, and a Neris witness. Bees stirred beneath the wrap. Sevrin kept one hand on a guide cord and one on the living comb.

Pell opened the counterweight gallery. "All stations report ready except east royal lock."

Osra stood there.

The Queen-Regent wore no battle armor, only a dark grain-clerk's coat over mail. Her gray hair had come loose. Two royal engineers held the final lock bar while four guards protected the wheel. Behind her, a painted Cinder Net covered the wall in gold leaf.

"You built a court while my army held this city together against four invasions," Osra said.

Maela crossed the central bridge. "Your army broke its wall."

"To keep a power you do not understand from being turned by grievance."

"We measured it. We set limits. You were offered a seat to answer them publicly."

"I remember the Ash Famine. Public hunger does not pause for beautiful procedure."

"Neither do drowned children."

Osra put both hands on the royal wheel. "Then history will judge which deaths I prevented."

She ordered the full lock.

Engineers drove the bar before Maela's archers could reach them. Bronze entered Crown Hinge with a blow that shook every tower. The other two lock bars dropped through hidden linkages. Royal mosaics split along their grout. The shaft's stone rings began moving as one.

Not forward through the planned first action. Inward, toward a fixed command that forced every outer hinge to conform.

Pell fell against the gallery wall. "She has coupled the braces. Cut east linkage!"

Vael soldiers attacked across the bridge. Osra's guards held long enough for the wheel to descend one turn. Crown Hinge groaned. Through the open roof, the upper Cinder Net brightened at morning, visible where no constellation should show in daylight.

Below, Kharza's horn gave two broken notes. Stone danger.

Maela had one path to Osra and another to the east linkage. She sent soldiers after the Queen-Regent and went with Pell toward the coupling.

The linkage ran inside a bronze sleeve thick as a tree trunk. Pell found its inspection mouth and drove in two opposing pins. Neither stopped the rotation.

"Need relief from outer braces," she said. "Begin first action or Crown tears the pins out."

Maela looked to the witness rail. All four delegations had representatives present or connected by signal. Mahr: Kharza and Aruk below. Aeli: Sevrin and Irel in the pollen court. Vennik: Pell at the coupling, Nim at the western weights. River-city: Maela, Seli, Edris, and a Heartland miller under the open court.

The cost map lay stretched across the west walk.

"First action," Maela called. "Three degrees, one interval at a time. Local stops hold."

Clay horns carried the order below. Signal towers relayed it across Vael, then outward by mirror, river flag, and pollen lamps. At Ember Hinge, Kiln teams opened the old drainage channels. At Salt, Reed crews adjusted salinity gates. Rootglass workers prepared the migration corridor.

Kharza and Aruk sounded Crown's paired roots from different galleries. One sang through volcanic-glass tusk veining; the other listened with one silver cap removed and answered in the cadence of marsh pilings. Their notes did not merge. Each identified a separate stress, and Pell balanced between them.

Counterweight beds took load.

First degree.

Crown Hinge shifted against Osra's lock. Gold leaf fell from the Cinder Net mural. Under Maela's boots, stone moved west, though the bridge remained aligned.

Second degree.

The royal linkage heated around Pell's pins. She packed it with wet cloth and called for more return weight. Nim's crews rolled recovered siege stone into the western beds.

Third degree.

The first action settled. Horns answered from Ember, Salt, and Rootglass. Vael's refuge counters remained inside limits. Heartland field watchers reported no red mold. The full lock had stopped tightening, but it remained engaged.

Osra retreated to the east wheel with six guards. She pulled on it again.

"Second action," Maela ordered after all four delegations consented.

Rootglass opened the queen-hive cradle. Irel lifted the clay jar while Sevrin released measured buried-sky pollen along the paired channel. Workers carried both living comb and lower pollen through opposite arches. Bees entered the court in a dark ribbon, ordinary wings moving celestial influence from one alignment to another.

Aruk's river horns reported marsh gates open. Kharza's listeners gave a stable first pitch.

Fourth degree.

Pressure drove Maela to one knee. East seemed to change places with the shaft for a breath. She checked the chalk on her sleeve and stood.

Fifth degree.

Heartland soldiers still loyal to Osra attacked the western counterweight bed. Edris and shelter workers pulled wounded riggers clear while Vael defenders held the gallery mouth. Pell did not leave the brake. She sent a reserve team through a lower maintenance cut, adding load while arrows struck the frames.

Sixth degree.

A lock bar cracked. One end dropped across the central bridge, separating Maela from Osra. Crown Hinge settled into its second action with all three outer answers inside limits.

Nobody rested. The third action carried the Neris flood line.

Seli tied her harbor cord to the witness rail. Signal runners waited beside four bells. The first reports arrived from the coast by relay mirrors: tide climbing within forecast, floating-home moorings sound, cellar evacuation incomplete in the south ward.

"No advance until south answers," Seli said.

Osra's remaining archers used the delay. They shot into the pollen court from the east tower. Green-glass guards raised shields over the queen-hive. One arrow

broke the living-comb frame. Sevrin gathered exposed comb with bare hands while bees crawled across his sleeves.

Maela sent a river company across the fallen lock bar. Its curved surface offered no rail. Three soldiers fell into the lower walk before the rest secured ropes. Osra's guards withdrew toward the royal wheel.

The south Neris bell answered.

"Third action authorized," Seli called.

Seventh degree.

Water rose in both Crown casks. Reedwater reported salinity below the first threshold. Rootglass pollen held its corridor.

Eighth degree.

A Neris mirror flashed red. Seventh harbor knot.

Seli rang the pause bell. Irel struck the Aeli stop plate with her palm. Two delegations. Pell locked the counterweights before Maela spoke.

The hinge halted eight degrees into the exchange, one degree short of the third action's end.

Osra's archers kept shooting. The royal linkage strained against the stopped beds. Crown stone gave a sound like mountains grinding their teeth.

A Vael captain shouted, "We cannot hold here. Finish the degree."

"Pause threshold crossed," Maela said.

"The lock will kill us."

"Then we fight while Neris moves."

She sent every available runner to accelerate the coastal relay. Aruk ordered two Reed reserve barges away from Vael despite the battle, assigning them to Neris cellar evacuation. Pell bled pressure into return beds without advancing the bearing. Kharza and Veka changed their stone-song from movement cadence to holding cadence. Irel returned the queen to the cradle so agitation would not spread through the hive.

Twenty minutes became forty. The east linkage split another layer of bronze. Maela's soldiers reached the royal wheel and lost it twice. Osra fought without a sword, ordering brace positions from the painted map and refusing every demand to surrender.

At fifty-three minutes, the second coastal bell failed to answer.

Seli did not release the pause. "Three evacuation bells must answer."

Maela backed her publicly. The decision might bury them. It also showed the coast that its threshold meant more than a promise made when convenient.

A runner came from the lower refuge. Osra's soldiers had broken into the west shelter. Kharza diverted one Kiln company from Crown's defense, weakening her

own position to protect civilians. Aruk sent a Reed company with them under separate command.

After sixty-seven minutes, Neris reported the south cellars clear. Reed barges had taken the last families from the floating-home lane. Three bells answered.

Seli inspected the tide cord. Water had stopped below the eighth knot.

"Resume," she said.

Irel confirmed. Pell confirmed. Kharza and Aruk answered from the roots. Maela put her hand on the river-city mark.

Ninth degree.

The third action settled.

Osra's lock began to fail.

Its east bar did not release. It bent downward into the shaft, catching one stone ring while the others advanced. The mismatched load tore the royal wheel from its base. Guards scattered. Osra clung to the wheel chain, preventing the bar from dropping deeper.

"Fourth action now," Pell said. "If we wait, the bar welds in place."

Maela checked the court. Neris remained inside its renewed threshold. Rootglass queen agitation had eased. Reed salinity held. Vael refuge counters reported the western shelter secure. All four delegations authorized.

Tenth degree.

The world lost direction.

Maela saw the east tower, the shaft, Pell at the brake, and the blue chalk on her sleeve. None occupied east, down, near, or far in the private map inside her body. She stepped toward Pell and struck the witness rail instead. Her stomach rose as if she had fallen.

"Maela," Pell called. "Stay on the rail."

Maela gripped it. "Tell me where the river mark lies."

"Two hands left of yours."

Left still meant something through muscle. She found the mark.

Eleventh degree.

Sky-shear drove through Crown Hinge. Pell's counterweight crews staggered as inner ears failed. Veka dropped unconscious below. Kharza could no longer sing through her injured tusk; Aruk removed his second silver cap and carried the holding cadence while she struck its rhythm into stone with a mallet. Their two methods shared the load without making either commander lesser.

Irel opened the queen-hive again. Star-bees rose through broken mosaics into upper daylight, carrying buried pollen. Sevrin called their movement from other people's descriptions, then adjusted the living comb so the swarm crossed both

channels.

The bent lock bar slipped.

Pell shouted a cutaway order. One counterweight rope parted before the crew reached it. A loaded bed ran toward the shaft, dragging two riggers. Maela could not tell where they moved. She followed Pell's voice along the rail and caught the cutaway lever with both hands.

"Pull toward me," Pell said.

Maela pulled. The lever resisted. A second pair of hands closed beside hers.

Osra had crossed the broken bridge.

"The royal return pawl," Osra said. "Below the lever. Kick twice, then pull."

Maela could not find below. "Guide my boot."

Osra seized her ankle and placed it against bronze. Maela kicked. Once. Twice. The pawl released. Together they hauled the cutaway lever.

The runaway bed separated from its stone load. Riggers fell clear. Basalt blocks entered the shaft and vanished toward the buried sky. Crown Hinge lurched, but the return beds caught what remained.

"Twelfth degree," Pell called.

The final action moved.

All four hinges answered. Kharza's struck rhythm came through the west root. Aruk's bare tusks carried the Reed cadence beside it. Queen-hive workers crossed the pollen court in two streams. Vennik brakes locked at the witnessed mark. Maela kept one hand on the river-city seal while direction vanished from her for good.

Upper daylight darkened. Through the broken roof, the Cinder Net slid twelve degrees from its fixed place. Far below, the Deep Hart moved into a new arc. Rain began somewhere beyond Vael. Along Neris, water stopped below the eighth knot. Rootglass pollen held. Reed salinity rose, then steadied under the mapped limit.

The royal lock split along all three bars.

Osra let go of Maela's ankle. Mixed guards surrounded her: one Kiln soldier, one Reed fighter, one Rootglass guard, and one Vael defender. She looked toward the shaft as if she could still command its direction.

"Queen-Regent Osra Dane," Maela said, holding the rail. "You are under public custody. You will live to answer the record."

Osra did not resist.

Across the upper court, soldiers lowered weapons as reports carried the same fact through every gallery. The siege had ended. Immediate pressure receded from Vael's foundations. Outer lands gained movement and new costs rather than rescue from all scarcity.

Maela could no longer point toward the relief bridge, the river, or the room

where Pell stood. Pell placed a guide cord in her hand.

"Three steps left," Pell said.

Maela followed the voice. Each step required an instruction her body once supplied without thought. A river soldier tied knots into the guide cord for the nearest exits. Maela learned the first one before she reached Pell. Around them, witnesses continued reading costs aloud rather than celebrating over unfinished casualty lists. Behind her, twelve degrees of changed sky rested on four hinges and no dynasty's exclusive word.

Chapter 27 — The Queen-Regent's Trial

Osra spent the first morning after defeat copying names from wet paper.

Mixed guards sat at either end of the relief table: a Kiln soldier with a chipped clay gorget, a Rootglass archer whose left arm rested in a sling, a Vennik barge worker, and a human defender from Vael's south ward. They did not speak to her unless she misread a line. Her title appeared nowhere on the work slate.

Outside the warehouse, burial carts crossed the relief bridge under strict load limits. Army kitchens served anyone in the queue. Heartland soldiers ate beside families they had starved. Sometimes a person recognized a uniform and left hungry rather than stand near it. The kitchens recorded that refusal as a cost, not ingratitude.

Osra copied a scout's name, unit, district, and condition. Missing. She copied the next. Wounded, found at east brace. The next. Dead at Flood Bastion.

Administrative calm came easily to her. That fact no longer offered comfort.

On Day 52, the public tribunal began in the same roofless warehouse that had held the bearing court. No throne faced the benches. Osra sat at floor level behind a rail with Tavan Roe at a separate table. Tavan's wounded shoulder remained bound, and a guard helped her stand whenever the court required it.

Brother Caldryn placed two ledgers beneath clear oilcloth.

One carried smoke damage from the royal archive and Ordan's private mark on its spine. Osra had preserved it through four relocations, two palace purges, and the siege. Its pages recorded the Ash Famine forty-two years earlier: grain weights, district deaths, locked warehouses, river ice, and the names of officials who had ordered seed stores ground into flour.

The second ledger looked cleaner. Osra's clerks had prepared it during the siege.

Caldryn opened both to the same table.

"Original Heartland reserve transferred to outer regions during the fixed period," he read. "Twenty-seven parts in one hundred. Public copy: nineteen. Original Varkesh deaths linked to pressure relocations: listed by district. Public copy: category removed. Reed nursery loss: three columns. Public copy: folded into storm damage."

A clerk projected the entries onto a whitewashed wall. Every subtraction appeared large enough for the crowd to read.

The presiding panel contained one member from each bearing delegation and three civilian recorders chosen by lot. Maela attended from a marked chair with guide cords tied between rail, exit, and witness place. Pell sat elsewhere, under no obligation to serve as her direction. Kharza appeared without general's command

staff. Sevrin read ordinary ink copies and asked witnesses to describe only the star-path evidence his lost leafing could no longer perceive.

"Did you order the changes?" asked Hessa of Reedwater.

"Yes," Osra said.

"Name the document."

Osra looked at the cleaner volume. "A falsified ledger."

The words entered the record in four scripts.

"Why preserve the original?" Hessa asked.

"Because its figures remained necessary for policy."

Anger moved through the warehouse.

"Necessary for you," Hessa said. "Unavailable to the people paying them."

"Yes."

Osra did not ask the court to confuse admission with repair.

Over the next eighteen days, the trial moved between accusation and relief accounting. Witnesses testified in the morning. In the afternoon, all able prisoners copied lists, packed grain, or cleared safe stone under guard. Osra worked wherever assignment placed her. She learned to distinguish bridge mortar from hinge stone and failed repeatedly. Veka sent her to wash measuring rods instead.

Tavan testified on Day 56.

She described the siege objectives, the order to seize Crown Hinge, and every instruction she had obeyed before the pollen-court fire command. She did not portray herself as secretly opposed. She had placed artillery against Flood Bastion. She had approved sapper galleries. She had known civilians used the cistern route and judged the military objective sufficient.

"When did you decide the Queen-Regent's authority ended?" the panel asked.

"Too late," Tavan said. "Specifically, when she ordered me to burn a chamber containing prisoners and the surviving hive. I had accepted starvation and breach as war. I would not accept fire without a military distinction."

Osra listened from behind the rail. Tavan had warned her before the siege assault that civilians would carry the cost. Osra remembered answering with supply forecasts, as though precision transformed coercion into weather.

A Rootglass guard asked Tavan whether Osra had ordered the orchard attack.

The captured field orders bore a deputy's hand, but the policy of destroying unauthorized hinge evidence came from Osra's council. Tavan placed those orders in the chain without inventing a signature that did not exist.

"Responsibility does not require false proof," she said.

The court entered both facts.

On Day 59, Pell presented Jorren Taal's scout log.

Nim had recovered its wax leaves from the last evacuation barge. The final pages listed gate times, district counts, and individual decisions. Jorren named the Lantern Ward search pairs who checked cellars. He named the scouts who crawled under the gate. He recorded the final four hundred sixty civilians aboard his barge. He did not name how he held the crank.

"His request concerned the glorious column," Pell said. "There isn't one. The record names who got out and who did not."

Osra asked permission to read the last page. Pell carried it to the rail but did not place it in Osra's hands.

Jorren had written one sentence about the attacking force: disciplined movement toward the hinge approach, no general sack before the breach. Osra had considered that restraint evidence of mercy. Beside the sentence, Pell had entered the civilian bodies recovered from collapsed districts.

A tactic could show restraint compared with something worse and still serve a criminal objective.

Survivors followed.

The first came from Flood Bastion. Vela Or, a human mason, had supervised mortar repairs before the siege and spent the breach beneath a stair with her leg pinned. She brought a piece of outer-wall foundation wrapped in cloth. Sapper fire had glazed one face.

"We reported the lower gallery voids before the full assault," she said. "Three copies went out. One to Crown Marshal Ruun. One to siege lines under white flag. One stayed in the wall office."

The panel asked Osra whether she had received the warning.

"Tavan's morning packet included it."

"What did you do?"

"Approved the breach plan."

Vela set the stone on the record table. "Then enter that we told you where civilians sheltered. Do not let anyone call the collapse unforeseeable because engineers used fire underground."

Caldrin attached the warning copy to the assault order. Tavan requested that her approval mark appear beside Osra's. Vela insisted Maela's decision to keep defenders at Flood Bastion also remain. The record accepted all three.

Next, a Vennik rigger named Savo described West Sluice. Their house had supported Osra before the siege because Heartland contracts kept caravan bridges funded. During the breach, the palace bell brake crushed Savo's adopted daughter beneath its cradle.

"Quartermaster Vask chose the bell," Savo said. "I agreed to the cradle. Osra's assault caused the shock. The old timber failed. Which person killed my child?"

No panel member answered quickly.

Pell stood from her separate bench. "I made the load decision. The cradle inspection had six minutes. I accepted green wood from the coronation platform."

Osra felt the room lean toward a single verdict and resist it.

Savo looked from Pell to her. "I do not ask for one name. I ask whether the new rules will let workers refuse green wood when a city is dying."

Nim read the emergency clause protecting local load refusals. The longer tribunal added Savo's question to permanent bridge law. Loss entered governance without dissolving individual responsibility.

A Reed camp cook testified after them. Mevi had marched under Aruk because Osra's treaty promised marsh autonomy and salt relief. She described feeding soldiers while officers concealed nursery losses from them. When the incendiary order reached the bridge, her cooking crews had already filled clay bulbs with oil.

"We did not shoot them," Mevi said. "We still made them."

Hessa asked why.

"Because the order came as bridge denial, not civilian burning. Words shifted the people under the deck out of view."

Osra recognized the method. She had approved that phrase. Bridge denial sounded bounded, strategic, clean. The hidden barges turned it into attempted killing without requiring the paper to say children.

"Who chose those words?" Hessa asked.

"I did," Osra said.

Mevi faced her. "Did you know the barges held evacuees?"

"Scouts reported heat and movement below the deck. They did not confirm the count."

"You ordered fire before confirming."

"Yes."

The cook's testimony joined Aruk's refusal signal and the captured incendiary instructions.

From Rootglass came a prisoner freed in the pollen court. Taen Saan had served Irel's conservative council and had once argued that Sevrin should be barred from every hive. Osra's troops detained him when he objected to burning their retreat route. They tied him to a rack as cover.

Taen did not credit the coalition with moral purity. "Irel withheld evidence from tenant workers. Sevrin hid Neris figures. Osra used both failures to make royal protection seem like the only stable choice. Then her guards used our bodies to preserve that choice."

He presented the arrow that had passed through his sleeve while Irel's climbers entered. Its fletching carried a Heartland unit mark. The archer who loosed it had

died. Taen asked that the record name the unit and not invent motive for a dead person.

Osra had spent years turning incomplete information into justification for central control. Taen demanded the opposite discipline: record what could be proven, preserve uncertainty, and still judge the command structure that placed archers behind prisoners.

A Heartland widow spoke on Day 61. Unlike most witnesses, she began by defending Osra.

Her district had survived two failed harvests because fixed Cinder Net warmth kept winter grain alive. Royal reserve schedules had delivered flour when local merchants withheld it. Her husband and eldest daughter joined Osra's army willingly. Both died at Vael.

"If you had turned the sky years ago, would my younger children have eaten?" she asked the panel.

No witness could answer with certainty.

She pointed at the outer-region columns. "These losses matter. So do lives the fixed season saved. If you write her as a ruler who wanted only power, you falsify another ledger."

Seli agreed. "The warning belongs in the record."

Then the widow faced Osra. "Why did you change the numbers? If the danger spoke for itself, why hide who paid for our grain?"

Osra considered every old reason: preventing regional panic, keeping barges moving, preserving one authority during famine risk, stopping rival councils from turning figures into secession. Each reason described an intended effect. None answered the moral question.

"Because consent might have produced an answer I could not control," she said.

The widow wept without forgiving her.

In afternoon labor, guards assigned Osra to copy that exchange. She wrote the woman's defense first, then the accusation, then her own answer. Rain blurred one line. The Kiln guard made her start the page again rather than decide the damaged words remained readable enough.

Another day's testimony came from the displaced hinge villages. Families had received relocation orders marked temporary. Years later, royal farms occupied their terraces. One Mahr potter described his kiln taken apart because its stone-song interfered with survey instruments. An Aeli laborer described pruning records seized under security law. A human village head admitted she had helped choose which neighboring families lost carts first.

Caldrin built a chain of custody for each decree. Some bore Osra's mark. Others came from provincial officials exceeding broad authority. The panel separated them rather than making Osra responsible for every theft committed under her

policy. It also asked whether she punished any official after reports arrived.

She had punished two for stealing tax grain. None for removing hinge witnesses.

The distinction showed what her administration had valued.

By the end of the survivor sessions, the evidence tables held objects beside paper: glazed foundation stone, a broken brake pin, salt-stiff basket fibers, hive-rack rope, a child's name tablet, and grain from a protected Heartland district. Osra had once trusted figures because objects could provoke sympathy beyond proportion. Now every object carried a figure her summaries had reduced, and every figure belonged to a material consequence someone could touch.

Edris testified about the delayed Lantern Ward withdrawal and people lost when Flood Bastion collapsed. A Heartland camp medic testified that Osra's ration rules favored fit soldiers after the siege road closed. An Aeli worker from the orchard fire team explained why she accepted grain guarantees for her family and why she surrendered after seeing the queen choose lower pollen. A Mahr soldier from Kharza's old imperial command described villages relocated from hinge faults under Osra's earlier decrees.

Not every witness blamed Osra for every death. One Vael defender said Maela had chosen to hold an outer wall after evacuation capacity failed. A Reed captain blamed Aruk for joining the siege in exchange for autonomy. Rootglass tenants named Irel's former cooperation. Pell entered her own old ration falsification into the governance record. The court refused a simple tale in which one guilty ruler made everyone else innocent.

That refusal left Osra with nowhere to hide inside exaggeration.

On Day 63, the panel asked about the Ash Famine.

Osra described being sixteen when cold reached the grain districts. Her mother boiled leather bindings from account books. People broke warehouse doors and found seed stores already spoiled. Local councils issued conflicting orders. River towns kept barges tied while villages upriver starved. When warmth returned, officials destroyed death lists to keep tax claims alive.

"I learned that delay kills," Osra said. "I learned that fragmented authority can turn food into a border weapon. The fixed Cinder Net gave the Heartland seasons it could plan. I believed another uncontrolled exchange would repeat the famine on a larger field."

Seli of Neris asked, "Was that warning false?"

"No. Your coast water rose during the third action."

"And the pause?"

"It prevented deaths."

"Would your royal command have paused?"

Osra looked toward the oilcloth-covered ledgers. "No."

The court allowed the distinction to remain. Her warning had substance. A full uncontrolled exchange could have flooded Neris, salted Reedwater, damaged Rootglass, and reduced Heartland grain. The danger did not authorize falsifying who already suffered, starving Vael into surrender, executing surveyors, or reserving all consent to one dynasty.

"Why did you help release the return pawl?" Maela asked.

Osra could have described it as proof that she always intended preservation. That would have turned one necessary act into a lie about every choice preceding it.

"Because the bar would have torn Crown Hinge," she said. "Because you could not find it after sky-shear took your direction. Because I knew the royal fitting. I had already lost command. Help no longer threatened my custody because my custody had failed."

Maela received the answer without gratitude or contempt. "Recorded."

By Day 68, the missing lists had narrowed. Four hundred twenty people unaccounted for after the breach had been traced through barge rolls, hospital transfers, burial records, and families sheltering under changed names. Some entered the civilian-death count. Others entered the survivor registry. No separate missing number remained to disguise either.

The military dead across both sides totaled 6,840.

Civilian dead totaled 1,130.

The panel read each figure once, then began reading names. The work continued through sunset and into the next morning. Categories included Mahr, Aeli, Vennik, human, unknown, soldier, camp worker, prisoner, resident, and refugee, but no category replaced a name when one could be found.

Osra listened to all of them.

On Day 70, the panel issued an interim sentence. The longer tribunal would still hear forced relocation, surveyor executions, district seizure, siege starvation, and orchard policy. Until then, Osra lost every office, military authority, estate command, and private access to state records. Mixed guards would supervise her public labor. She would copy the original and altered ledgers side by side for distribution, assist grain restitution records, and answer witnesses without controlling the order of questions.

One Vael man shouted for execution. A Heartland widow shouted that the court had humiliated the person who saved her district from famine. Guards removed neither until both finished speaking.

Osra stood when instructed. "I understand the sentence."

Understanding did not mean she accepted every judgment. Part of her still counted the harvests preserved under the fixed sky and imagined the dead a chaotic exchange might have made. That part would not vanish because she had

lost. The tribunal required something harder than inward conversion. It required records others could inspect and power she no longer possessed.

After adjournment, Maela signed the order by guiding her hand along a raised rule. Aruk and Kharza signed separately. Irel pressed the shared-hive mark. Pell and Nim marked the counterweight pin. No signature stood above the others.

Outside, emergency military offices began transferring food, bridge, and shelter decisions to mixed councils. Disputes started before the first meeting ended. Heartland delegates demanded planting priority. Vael shelters demanded stone. Reedwater asked for barges already promised to Neris. Governance arrived not as quiet, but as conflict forced into a room with a public ledger.

A guard returned Osra to the copying table.

She opened the original Ash Famine volume and set a clean sheet beside it. This time the outer-region columns remained visible. When rain spotted the page through the open roof, she waited for it to dry rather than closing the book on the figures.

Chapter 28 — When Both Skies Had Dawn

One year later, Kharza argued with a rain channel.

Water came down the repaired Varkesh terrace in a clear, orderly sheet and struck the new spill stones exactly where the cost map predicted. Then it jumped the third lip, cut across a bean row, and began carrying black soil toward the lower kiln road.

"Close south gate," Kharza called.

A terrace worker ignored the title used by visiting clerks and obeyed the emergency mark instead. Two people dropped a ceramic gate into the channel. Flow divided toward empty ash beds. Mahr children packed the break with clay while a human surveyor recorded water height. Nobody waited for Kharza to sing the stone.

Her left tusk appreciated the restraint.

The crack still ran from the lower curve toward the root, dark beneath a fitted copper brace. Cold made it ache. Rain vibrated through it like a second pulse. Lessa had designed the brace to open along one edge, allowing Kharza to hear enough stone-song for ordinary work without taking a bearing load. She had also stamped NO HEROICS across the inner plate.

"The third lip needs widening," said the terrace worker.

"It passed inspection last month."

"Last month had less water."

Kharza entered the failure on her delegate slate. The new compact required local conditions to defeat old approval without anyone pretending the approval had never made sense. Repairs would cost kiln clay promised to Vael. She marked the conflict for public decision.

Varkesh no longer cracked under constant buried heat. Rain had returned in intervals, enough to plant upper terraces abandoned during the fixed years. It also loosened ash slopes and brought molds older growers did not recognize. Two villages argued over a reservoir built where neither remembered a stream. Every benefit arrived with work attached.

At midday, the road caravan left for Vael Tern.

Kharza traveled without command staff. Her black-clay badge read Delegate Olt, elected for a two-year term by Varkesh hearth councils and removable after any public petition reached the required names. Two former soldiers served as road guards. Three terrace workers carried the drainage objection. A family from Ashwall rode in the rear wagon with stones recovered from the outwork's ruins for the Vael memorial.

The journey crossed land altered by twelve degrees of sky.

Heartland grain stood shorter under the shifted Cinder Net. Relief cooperatives had replaced part of the lost harvest with marsh millet and Varkesh beans. Some farmers cursed the compact at every toll. Others had discovered that cooler nights reduced blight. Royal estates divided during restitution now carried boundary stakes in three colors, each disputed.

Along Reedwater, new salt gates shone among the reeds. Aruk's councils had moved nursery beds farther inland and converted two drowned fields to fish channels. South Mirr still had no spawning return. Hessa's empty basket hung in the local court as a warning against calling adaptation recovery.

Aruk met the caravan at a flood quay. Both silver caps covered his tusks again.

"Your terrace water exceeds the first forecast," he said instead of greeting her.

"Your northern salinity report omits two tenant pools."

"They filed after the deadline."

"Salt did not."

He showed his tusks in a brief smile. Their political rivalry had survived alliance, which reassured Kharza more than affection would have. Aruk joined the caravan under the silver-cap banner. His guards remained Reed Confederacy soldiers, never hers.

Rootglass sent Irel, Sevrin, and a cart of living comb.

The orchards had changed. Western terraces remained black after the fire. The nursery had lost a third of its young trees to salt injury over the winter. Elsewhere, buried-sky pollen produced thick leaves with blue undersides and fruit that ripened later. Whether those trees would live through another twelve-year cycle remained unknown.

Sevrin stepped down from the cart using a guide rope marked with pollen samples. No filaments had returned at his temples. They never would. He no longer answered to Starwarden.

"Describe the clouds," he asked Kharza.

"Low over Reedwater. Broken west. Bright line toward Vael."

"Any amber under the west edge?"

"None I can see."

An apprentice beside him gave a more exact color account. Sevrin combined both descriptions with the queen-hive's morning pattern. Loss had changed his practice from solitary reading into a public chain of observations. It had not softened his anger when reports arrived late.

Irel kept physical care of the queen within Rootglass's public apiary, but the cradle latches required shared marks before travel. A Neris witness, a Vennik keeper, and a Mahr pollen worker rode with her. Rootglass had not surrendered its knowledge. It had opened custody around it.

Vael Tern appeared on the fifth morning.

Reconstruction had made the city less symmetrical. The north wall used black Varkesh brick, pale Heartland limestone, and panels of green rootglass that flexed when buried pressure rose. Old royal builders would have hidden the joins beneath white plaster. New masons left every material exposed and stamped each contributing district into the mortar.

The relief bridge carried two separate lanes. Supply wagons used the center under posted weights. Pedestrians and handcarts used timber galleries bolted to the outer arches. Nim's bridge council had refused merchants' requests for priority tolls, then accepted a timed grain lane after Heartland farmers proved that waiting spoiled seed. Compromise had produced a schedule nobody admired and everyone could inspect.

At the west weigh house, Kharza found her terrace dispute waiting for her.

Vael's repair council requested the same kiln clay needed to widen Varkesh's third channel lip. A blue-river mason displayed drawings of an inner shelter arch still supported by temporary beams. The Varkesh workers displayed a jar of soil carried from the washed bean row.

"If our arch waits," the mason said, "two hundred residents remain in winter tents."

"If our lip waits," replied the terrace worker, "the next rain takes planting soil from six families."

Kharza possessed no authority to allocate either supply alone. A year earlier she would have weighed military importance, chosen, and called speed a virtue. As delegate, she called a temporary cost session at the weigh house.

Pell arrived with transport figures. Four clay wagons stood loaded outside Varkesh. Moving them all to Vael required draft teams scheduled for Rootglass hive transport. Splitting the shipment would repair neither structure fully.

A Vennik kiln builder proposed a third option: fire hollow arch blocks in Varkesh using less clay, send those to Vael, and use the saved material for the spill lip. The blocks would demand two weeks and Heartland charcoal.

"Our southern district already lost warmth," a Heartland delegate said. "Charcoal cutting strips windbreaks."

The discussion expanded instead of resolving. Rootglass offered dead firewood from burned western terraces, but transporting it risked carrying salt mites. Sevrin required heat treatment first. Reed barges could move treated wood upriver if Vael supplied iron gate fittings.

By noon, five regions owned a piece of one rain-channel repair.

"This is intolerably slow," the blue-river mason said.

"Yes," Pell replied. "We should compare it with rebuilding the arch after stealing the soil from someone else."

They agreed on treated Rootglass wood, Reed transport, hollow Varkesh blocks, and temporary shelter reinforcement from reusable siege timbers. Kharza signed only the Varkesh share. Aruk signed river carriage. Vael's council took responsibility for iron. The plan could still fail at three routes, but failure would arrive in named places rather than vanish inside a royal order.

Lessa found Kharza outside the weigh house.

She had refused every offer of a court medical title and now managed a cross-banner clinic near the breach. Her staff included former siege medics, orchard healers, and two Heartland physicians who had treated Osra's cavalry. A ceramic plate covered one side of the clinic where artillery had opened the old wall.

"Open," Lessa said, tapping Kharza's jaw.

"I have a bearing in three hours."

"Then waste less time objecting."

Kharza unlatched the copper brace. Lessa inspected the crack with a small mirror. No new split showed. The root remained sensitive and always would.

Across the clinic, sky-shear patients practiced balance on painted lines. Vennik riggers learned to work seated. A Mahr fault-reader with both tusks capped trained apprentices to interpret mallet vibration. Human patients with disrupted direction followed textured cords between rooms. Maela had helped design the paths but did not own them.

"Your election petition has passed half the removal threshold," Lessa said while replacing the brace.

Kharza held still. "For the Heartland grain agreement?"

"For giving Reedwater too many barges, depending which tavern you ask."

"Will you sign?"

"If you make the next bearing report sound like a victory speech."

Kharza believed her. Public office had not reconciled the Kiln Houses around her past. Veterans of the Three Valleys still opposed her. Families saved at Ashwall supported her more warmly than she trusted. Election changed the means by which conflict reached her; it did not erase the conflict.

Near the archive yard, Osra worked beneath guard at a long public table. Her hair had gone almost white over the year. She copied outer-region columns from the original ledger while petitioners waited to challenge omissions. The longer tribunal had begun hearing relocation cases and had issued no final term.

Osra saw Kharza but did not call to her. Kharza did not approach. Survival had given them time for judgment without requiring intimacy.

Tavan supervised no soldiers. After treatment and testimony, she worked with a prisoner-restitution team mapping stores seized during the siege. Some Vael

residents refused her presence. Others valued her knowledge of where the army had sent grain. Mixed guards kept both truths from becoming a private settlement.

At the former council square, children played around the broken halves of the royal bearing seal. Clear boxes protected the pieces beside an inscription naming what they had opened and whom they had excluded. No one had repaired them.

The city had not turned ruin into purity. Merchants profited from rebuilding. Former officers sought seats on district councils. Refugees argued over whether return orders protected them or cleared valuable rooms for old owners. Yet every argument Kharza passed occurred beside posted figures, named custodians, and a place to file refusal.

The outer wall still gaped at Flood Bastion. Rebuilders had stabilized its edges and left the central breach open around a memorial path. Names of 6,840 military dead and 1,130 civilian dead covered fired-clay tiles along both sides, grouped by recovery place rather than army. Jorren Taal's tile stood beside the cistern-gate count, with no glorious column anywhere.

Kharza placed Ashwall stone beneath the names of refugees who died later in the siege. Other visitors left seed, bridge pins, hive clay, silver wire, ration chits, and pieces of damaged household doors.

Maela waited at the end of the path with one hand on a blue guide rail.

Directional blindness had not altered her eyes. She looked directly at Kharza and could not point toward Crown Hinge without touching the raised city map at her belt. Vael had marked public floors with textures: river grooves toward quays, round studs toward shelters, paired lines toward hinge courts. Visitors learned the system because making Maela navigate alone would have turned accommodation into private burden.

"Delegate Olt," Maela said.

"Crown Marshal."

Maela kept the office under an elected city charter with fixed review dates. She commanded the walls and no hinge. Her blue cloak carried no dynastic mark.

Pell approached from the bridge office wearing a brass badge that read Master of Bearings. She and Maela greeted each other with care rather than performance. Their hands touched, separated, then found each other again after Pell asked, "Guide?"

"For the east stair," Maela said.

Pell offered her left elbow. They walked together until the stair ended. At the landing, their offices led in different directions. Maela used the raised wall line; Pell went toward the counterweight yard. Nothing in their affection promised that either would surrender work or uncertainty.

They had begun sharing supper twice each week, when duty allowed and neither mistook a missed meal for rejection. Pell kept her rooms above the bridge office.

Maela kept hers within the marshal's court, mapped by textured cords she could change without asking anyone's leave. Some nights they slept together. Other nights old command habits turned conversation into an argument and sent them home separately.

"Tomorrow?" Pell asked at the landing.

Maela considered rather than performing confidence. "Ask me after the bearing."

"A dangerously reasonable answer."

They parted smiling, with no witness required to turn the moment into settlement.

The first scheduled rotation began at noon.

A year of the new compact had produced amendments, failures, and three threatened withdrawals. Heartland delegates wanted the movement delayed until after grain heading. Neris wanted earlier rotation before storm season. Rootglass requested less pollen release. Reedwater demanded more drainage labor from the cities benefiting from millet shipments. Varkesh brought the failed third channel lip.

The bearing court met in the repaired lower hall with every door open.

Four delegations retained the emergency structure but rotated their people. Kharza and Aruk held Mahr seats for this action. Sevrin and Irel represented Aeli labor, with apprentices empowered to contradict their readings. Pell and Nim represented Vennik counterweights. Maela sat with rotating Vael, Neris, and Heartland delegates. Refugee cost recorders remained beside all four.

No single delegation possessed an indefinite veto. Any crew could stop for direct danger. Two delegations and a public threshold could pause the whole bearing.

The cost map had grown too large for one sailcloth. Panels covered the walls. Varkesh channels linked by amber cord to Heartland mold reports. Reed salinity cups stood beside Neris tide knots. Rootglass comb patterns faced Vael foundation gauges. Remote southern observers had sent questions about whether their own stone formations belonged to the same sky network; the court recorded the inquiry without allowing it to delay today's bounded work.

Pell called the load sequence.

Counterweight teams inspected ropes in public. Her right hand still lacked the two fingers lost before the war. She had redesigned several grips so workers with similar injuries could lock lines using wrist and palm. The change served more people than its origin.

Kharza and Aruk took separate listening stations. She opened her copper brace. He removed one silver cap. Neither action carried purity. Kharza's exposed crack limited what she could hear. Aruk's damped tusk expressed a Reed choice he resumed after each bearing.

Irel set the queen-hive cradle between paired pollen channels. Sevrin stood beside two apprentices, asking them to describe the living comb before he offered interpretation. Maela placed her hand on the river-city witness mark and tied a guide cord to her belt.

Outside, residents crowded public galleries. Heartland opponents carried signs demanding grain delay. Reed delegates displayed nursery maps. Children from Vael and Varkesh sat along the floor studs, arguing about which visible constellation resembled a cooking pot.

"Authorize one degree," said the court recorder.

Each delegation answered.

Weights entered the forward beds.

Crown Hinge sang through Kharza's good tusk. The repaired stone no longer offered the crushing double note of Ashwall, but two load paths remained distinct. Aruk called the marsh-root pitch. Kharza called the Varkesh return. Pell adjusted between them.

Star-bees left the cradle and crossed the lower pollen channel. Irel reported queen agitation within the first mark. Sevrin's apprentices described blue-amber dust along worker legs. Neris mirrors signaled tide within limit.

Half a degree.

Varkesh's third channel lip failed again. A terrace signal arrived by relay mirror, yellow over black. Water entered the empty ash bed as planned. The local crew did not call a stop because no soil or dwelling crossed the threshold. Kharza entered repair priority without pretending the failure did not count.

Three-quarters.

A Heartland field reported red mold under the husk. The farmer's delegation requested hold. Pell locked the beds before the request reached Maela. Inspectors compared samples. Mold affected one low field already damaged by flood, not the district-wide threshold. The Heartland delegate withdrew the hold and demanded relief grain entered anyway.

The court approved the relief after argument.

"Resume," Maela said when every labor confirmed.

Final brake teeth moved.

One degree settled across four hinges.

No tower fell. No coast alarm crossed its eighth knot. Rootglass bees returned to the living comb. Reed salinity rose by one marked line and stopped. Heartland lost warmth at the edge of the forecast. Varkesh rain shifted toward the repaired channels.

The public galleries applauded, protested, and began disputing the next schedule before workers had finished locking the return beds.

Kharza closed her tusk brace. Pain remained. So did the capacity to hear stone without obeying it alone.

At evening, the delegations climbed to the hinge chasm. Maela used Pell's voice and the paired floor lines. Sevrin walked with apprentices describing color. Aruk wore his cap again. Irel carried one empty comb rather than the queen. They stood among survivors, opponents, children, and workers while the exchanged constellation sectors reached the horizon of the lower vault.

Upper dawn entered through the open roof in a band of gold. Beneath the chasm, the buried sky brightened blue around the Deep Hart. For several breaths, both skies held dawn.

Kharza listened to the stone carry two lights through one world. Around her, custodians argued over the cost of the next degree, and every door remained open.